THE ZEN OF GUITAR

BYRON NEMETH



UNDERSTANDING GUITAR THRU DIRECT INTUITION

VOLUME FOUR

THE ZEN OF GUITAR

UNDERSTANDING GUITAR THRU DIRECT INTUITION

V O L U M E F O U R

"MUSIC SPEAKS WHAT WORDS CANNOT,
AND THE GUITAR IS HOW IT SINGS."

WELCOME TO THE NEXT CHAPTER OF YOUR JOURNEY. THIS BOOK ISN'T ABOUT MEMORIZING RULES; IT'S ABOUT LEARNING TO LISTEN TO YOUR EARS, YOUR INSTINCTS AND THE MUSIC THAT'S ALREADY INSIDE YOU.

WHETHER THIS IS YOUR FIRST VOLUME OR YOUR FOURTH, WHETHER YOU PICKED UP THE GUITAR LAST WEEK OR DECADES AGO, THE FRETBOARD IS WAITING TO BE EXPLORED. EVERY PAGE IS DESIGNED TO HELP YOU SEE IT, HEAR IT AND FEEL IT, UNTIL PLAYING BECOMES SECOND NATURE.

TRUST WHAT YOU HEAR, FOLLOW WHAT YOU FEEL, AND LET THE GUITAR TAKE YOU SOMEWHERE NEW.

Byron

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VOLUME FOUR

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DEDICATION

TO MY PARENTS, MARIA AND PAUL NEMETH, WHOSE LOVE AND BELIEF IN ME MADE EVERY STEP OF THIS JOURNEY POSSIBLE, AND TO MY STUDENTS, PAST, PRESENT AND FUTURE: THIS BOOK IS FOR YOU.

MAY IT SPARK YOUR CREATIVITY, SHARPEN YOUR EAR AND OPEN THE DOOR TO A DEEPER, MORE PERSONAL CONNECTION WITH MUSIC.

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HOW TO READ THE DIAGRAMS

Every diagram in this book uses the same visual language.
Learn these symbols once, and every page will read like a map of the fretboard.



Red square
The root note of the key or mode, marked with a finger number or the letter R.



Red circle
A sharp or flat note, shown with both enharmonic names (Guitar Fretboard Notes).



Blue circle
The “blue” note (♭5) on blues pages, or an open string on the fretboard notes page.



Numbered circle
The fretting finger: 1 index, 2 middle, 3 ring, 4 pinky.



Black circle with interval
The note's interval from the root (Δ3 major 3rd, ♭7 minor 7th, and so on).

Yellow circle
A highlighted note: the altered note (Coltrane M6) or the scale formula notes.



Grey circle
The full mode shown underneath a highlighted formula.



Yellow SLIDE UP bar
Slide the same finger along the string to connect one block to the next.



Blue and black numbers
On tab pages, blue numbers are fingers and black numbers are frets.



Green numbers
Fret numbers under each fretboard diagram.

Light grey dots
The fret-marker inlays on your guitar (3, 5, 7, 9, 12 and so on).



Colored brackets
The fret range of each block on a full-neck map.

Reading the fretboard

Horizontal fretboards are drawn like tablature: the high e string is on top and the low E string is on the bottom. Vertical block diagrams are drawn as if the guitar is standing up in front of you: the low E string is on the left and the frets go down the page.

Your Weekly Practice Plan

How to turn the PRACTICE lines in this book into a routine

Almost every page in this book ends with a line marked PRACTICE. Each one is a single, specific job. This page shows how to fit those jobs into a week, so that you always know what to play when you pick up the guitar. Thirty focused minutes a day beats three hours on a Sunday.

A 30-minute session

Minutes	Block	What to do
5	**Warm up**	Slow scale notes, then bends and vibrato (pages 70–71)
10	**This week's page**	One page from the plan below, with a metronome
5	**Review**	Last week's page, at last week's tempo
10	**Play**	Improvise over a drone or backing track, or play a piece

A week that covers the whole book

Day	Focus	Pages
1	**Chords and rhythm**	22–35
2	**Pentatonic and blues scales, the 12-bar blues**	38–45
3	**Harmonic minor, melodic minor and the exotic scales**	46–53
4	**Arpeggios, tapping and sweep picking**	56–68
5	**Technique and expression**	70–75
6	**Modes, modal pentatonics and color association**	78–119
7	**Rest, or play for fun: "I Don't Mind" and its solo**	120–123

Stay on one page of each day's section until it is comfortable, then move to the next page of that section.

Six rules that make practice work

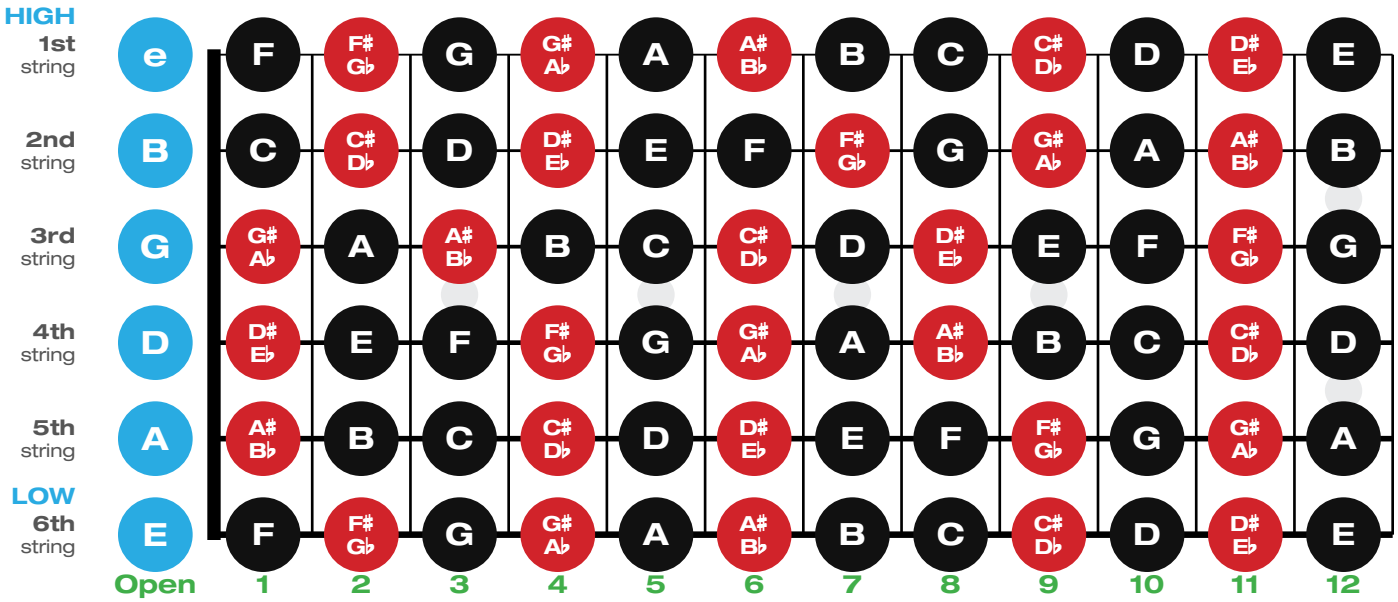
1. **One new thing a week.**
   Learn one block, one shape or one lick properly before you add another.
2. **Use a metronome.**
   Start at 60 BPM. Raise the tempo four clicks only after three clean passes in a row.
3. **Slow is fast.**
   A mistake means the tempo is too high. Drop back until it is clean, then climb again.
4. **Say it out loud.**
   Name the notes, chords and scale degrees as you play them. It doubles what you remember.
5. **Use it the same day.**
   Play the new material over a drone or a backing track before you put the guitar down.
6. **Keep a log.**
   Write the date, the page and the tempo. Small numbers going up are the best motivation there is.

PRACTICE: Tonight: choose the page for Day 1, set the metronome to 60 and write the first line of your log.

Guitar Fretboard Notes

Natural notes: **C D E F G A B** • Sharp / Flat notes: **C♯/D♭ D♯/E♭ F♯/G♭ G♯/A♭ A♯/B♭**

Black circles = natural notes • **Red circles** = sharp / flat notes • **Blue circles** = open strings



At the 12th fret every string starts over one octave higher, so frets 13–24 repeat frets 1–12.

The 12 Notes of the Musical Alphabet

Each step is one fret (a half step). There is no sharp or flat between E–F and B–C.



E to F and B to C are natural half steps (marked ½)

What Is Enharmonic Spelling?

Enharmonic notes are two names for the exact same pitch. F♯ and G♭ are played at the same fret, sound identical and are the same key on a piano. That is why every red circle on this page shows both names: the sharp name on top and the flat name underneath.

Which name you use depends on the musical situation, not on the sound:

- **Going up, usually sharps.** Climbing from F to G, the note in between is spelled F♯.
- **Going down, usually flats.** Falling from G to F, the same note is spelled G♭.
- **Follow the key.** Sharp keys (G, D, A, E, B) use sharps. Flat keys (F, B♭, E♭, A♭) use flats.
- **One letter per scale step.** D major is D E F♯ G A B C♯. Calling F♯ "G♭" would use G twice.

Rarer enharmonics exist too: E♯ sounds the same as F, and C♭ the same as B.

PRACTICE: Name every note on one string at a time, out loud, from the open string to the 12th fret and back.

Intervals on the Fretboard

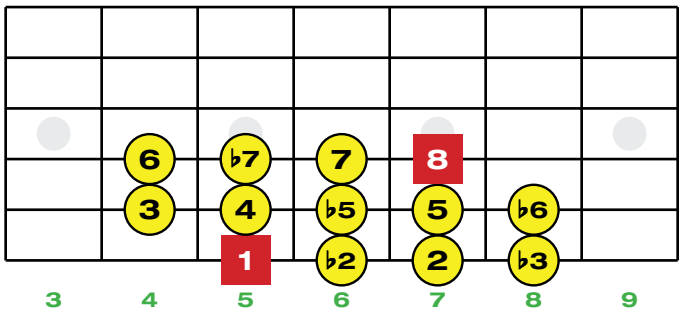
The distance between two notes, and the shape it makes under your fingers

An interval is the distance from one note to another, counted in half steps: one fret each. Every scale formula, chord and arpeggio in this book is a set of intervals measured from a root. Learn how each one sounds and where it sits, and the formulas turn from numbers into shapes.

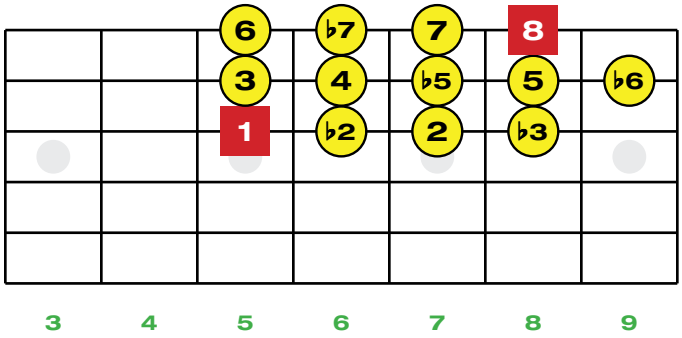
Frets	Interval	In a formula	From A	Sound
1	**Minor 2nd**	♭2	A to B♭	tense, dark
2	**Major 2nd**	2	A to B	one whole step
3	**Minor 3rd**	♭3	A to C	sad: the minor sound
4	**Major 3rd**	3	A to C♯	happy: the major sound
5	**Perfect 4th**	4	A to D	open, suspended
6	**Tritone**	♯4 or ♭5	A to E♭	restless: the blue note
7	**Perfect 5th**	5	A to E	strong: the power chord
8	**Minor 6th**	♭6	A to F	bittersweet
9	**Major 6th**	6	A to F♯	warm, bright
10	**Minor 7th**	♭7	A to G	bluesy
11	**Major 7th**	7	A to G♯	dreamy, yearning
12	**Octave**	8	A to A	the same note, higher

A formula such as 1 ♭3 4 5 ♭7 (the minor pentatonic, page 38) is simply a list of these intervals above the root.

From a root on the 6th string



From a root on the 3rd string



The shape on the left is the same from any root on the 6th or 5th string. Between the G and B strings everything shifts up one fret, because that pair of strings is tuned a major 3rd apart instead of a 4th: compare where the 3 sits in the two diagrams.

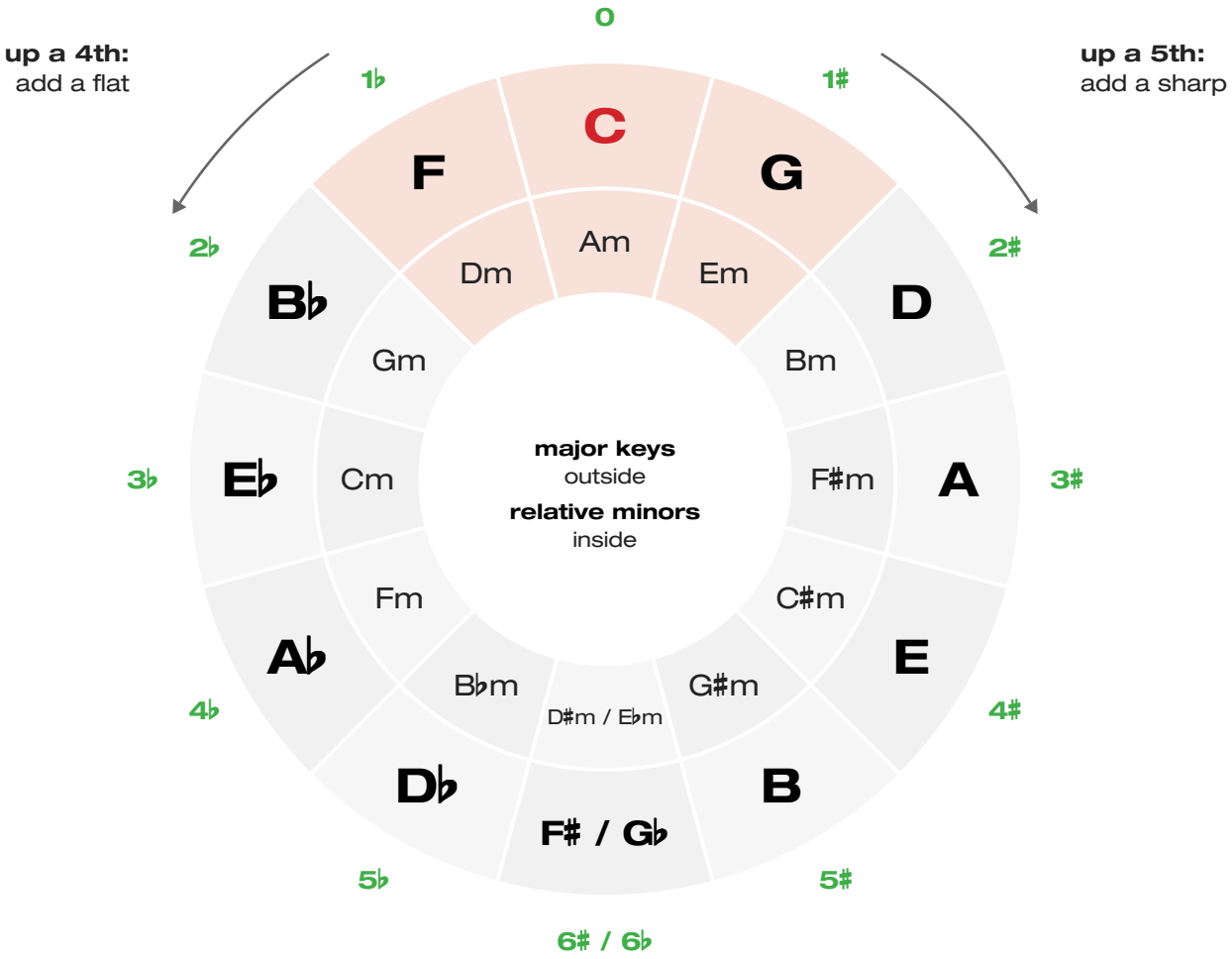
Four shapes to know by heart: the 4th is on the next string at the same fret. The 5th is on the next string, two frets up: the power chord. The major 3rd is on the next string, one fret back. The octave is two strings over and two frets up.

PRACTICE: Pick any note on the 6th string and play each interval above it in turn, saying its name and singing it before you play it.

The Circle of Fifths

All twelve keys on one wheel

Move clockwise and each key is a 5th higher than the last, with one more sharp or one flat fewer. Move counter-clockwise and each key is a 4th higher, with one more flat or one sharp fewer. Inside every major key sits its relative minor, which shares the same key signature.



The numbers around the wheel are the sharps or flats in each key signature.

Four things the wheel tells you

- **The chords of a key.** Take any key and its two neighbors: in C they are F, C and G, the IV, I and V chords. The minors inside them, Dm, Am and Em, are the ii, vi and iii. The shaded keys show the family of C major.
- **Key signatures.** Sharps arrive in the order F C G D A E B, and flats in the reverse order, B E A D G C F.
- **Strong chord movement.** Counter-clockwise, each chord pulls to the next: D to G to C is the II-V-I of page 30, and A, D, G, C, F, B♭ is the cycle of fourths used on page 29.
- **Closely related keys.** Neighbors on the wheel differ by one note, so songs slip easily from one to the next.

PRACTICE: Say the wheel aloud clockwise from C, then counter-clockwise, then name the relative minor of every major key.

MUSICAL NOTATION



Musical Notation

The Value of Reading Musical Notation

The ability to read musical notation is an indispensable skill for musicians of any and all levels and styles. It serves as a universal language that conveys the intricacies of music theory, performance, and composition.

Here are five key points illustrating its value:

1. Understanding Harmonic Structures
Musical notation provides a clear representation of harmonic progressions and relationships. By reading sheet music, musicians can identify chord structures, inversions, and voice leading. This understanding allows for deeper analysis of pieces, fosters a deeper appreciation for compositional techniques, and enhances the ability to create arrangements or adapt to various styles.

2. Mastering Rhythm and Timing
Notation precisely conveys rhythm, meter, and tempo. Complex time signatures, syncopation, and polyrhythms can be visually decoded, allowing musicians to internalize intricate rhythmic patterns. This skill is crucial for ensemble playing, where timing and synchronization are paramount to delivering a cohesive performance, and allows musicians to better execute music with precision.

3. Improved Musical Communication
Reading notation bridges gaps between musicians of different backgrounds. It facilitates efficient rehearsal processes by offering a standardized format for sharing ideas. Whether in classical ensembles, jazz bands, or studio settings, reading notation ensures all performers can access and interpret the same musical roadmap, improving the overall clarity of rehearsals and performances.

4. Unlocking Historical and Contemporary Repertoire
Musical notation grants access to centuries of repertoire, from Baroque fugues to modern orchestral scores. It also allows musicians to engage with contemporary works that rely on extended techniques and unconventional symbols, broadening their artistic horizons and enabling performers to bring historical and modern compositions to life with greater authenticity.

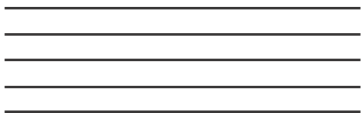
5. Enhancing Composition and Improvisation
Understanding notation strengthens compositional skills by providing a deep framework to document and refine musical ideas. It also empowers improvisers to visualize scales, modes, and harmonic possibilities, making real-time creative decisions more informed and effective. This level of notation fluency allows composers to communicate their ideas clearly while providing performers with the tools to interpret and bring those ideas to life.

Ultimately, reading musical notation is a gateway to a richer, more versatile musicianship, fostering technical mastery, creativity, and collaboration, and ensuring that musicians can not only perform but also contribute to the ever-evolving world of music.

Musical Notation

The Staff

The staff forms the foundational framework of written music, providing a visual representation for musical notes. It consists of five horizontal lines, with four intervening spaces. Each line and space serves as a position for the musical notes, offering a systematic way to notate pitch. A basic staff, without additional markings or embellishments, is shown as a simple grid.

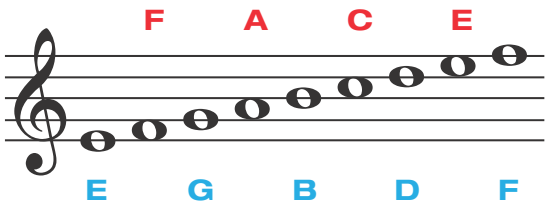


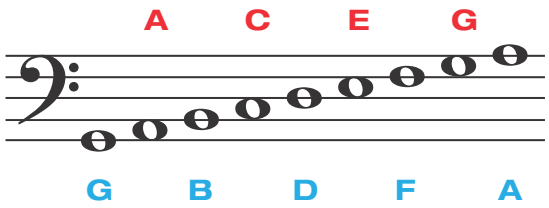
Clefs

The treble clef, seen here, is symbolized by a curving ornate sign on the left of the staff. This clef, often referred to as the G clef, designates the staff for higher pitches. The treble clef spirals around the second line from the bottom, identifying it as G. Guitar music is written in the treble clef and sounds one octave lower than written.

The notes on this staff begin at E on the lowest line, progressing through the musical alphabet: E, F, G, A, B, C, D, E, and ending with F on the top line. Common mnemonics such as “Every Good Boy Does Fine” help reinforce the names of the lines, while the spaces, spelling “FACE,” are easy to remember from bottom to top.
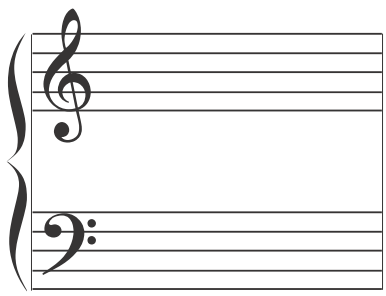
The bass clef, or F clef, appears on the far left of the staff. This clef’s symbol identifies the fourth line from the bottom as F, and it works within the same musical alphabet as the treble clef. The lines of the bass clef read G, B, D, F, A, from bottom to top (with the mnemonic “Good Boys Don’t Fight Anyone”), while the spaces read A, C, E, G (acronym: “All Cows Eat Grass”).





The Grand Staff

The grand staff emerges when both the treble and bass clefs are joined by a brace on the left side. This combination significantly expands the range of pitches that can be notated, making it particularly suitable for instruments with wide pitch ranges, like the piano.



Musical Notation

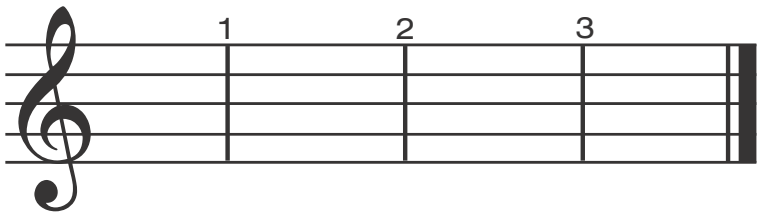
Measures

The vertical lines dividing the staff into segments are called barlines, and the segments between them are called measures. These delineate musical time and help organize rhythms into manageable sections. The time signature, located at the beginning of a piece, dictates how many beats each measure contains. A double barline marks the end of a section, and a thicker final barline marks the end of a piece. Measures may also be numbered for easier navigation, with the first being labeled as measure one, the second as measure two, and so on.

Notes

Musical pitches are designated by letter names from A to G, and this sequence repeats indefinitely. The pitches increase in pitch as you move upwards on the staff, with each higher note representing a progressively sharper or higher frequency. The placement of each note on the staff corresponds to a specific pitch depending on the clef used, as the clef determines the reference point for the note names.

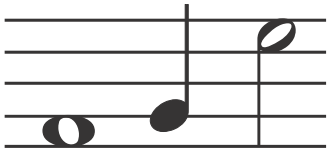
Notes are visually represented by ovals placed on the lines or in the spaces of the staff, with the note head indicating the pitch. The higher a note is on the staff, the higher its pitch, which is reflected by the increased vertical placement of the note relative to the staff's lines and spaces.



Notes Written on the Staff

Notes are positioned either directly on the lines or within the spaces between them. If a note lies above the middle line of the staff, its stem will extend downward from the left side; if below, the stem extends upward from the right. Notes positioned on the middle line generally have their stems pointing down unless adjacent notes with flags cause them to point upward.

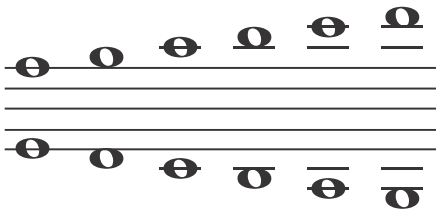
Typically, note stems span a range of one octave, or eight lines and spaces, which helps in visually organizing the notes in a clear, consistent manner. When two separate melodies are written on the same staff, the direction of note stems differentiates the melodies—one having stems pointed upwards and the other downwards, allowing performers to quickly identify which voice or melody each note belongs to. This system ensures clarity and readability, particularly when multiple voices or instrumental parts are notated on a single staff.



Musical Notation

Ledger Lines

Ledger lines extend beyond the normal five lines of the staff, providing a means to notate notes that lie higher or lower than those accommodated by the standard staff. These lines follow the same alphabetical order as the staff itself. They can be seen as additional lines for the note sequence. The stems of notes written on ledger lines continue to extend upwards or downwards toward the center line.

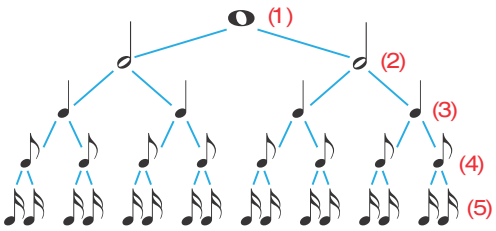


Note Durations

Every note carries a specific duration, indicating how long it should be held. The precise length of the note depends on the tempo and time signature of the piece, but general relationships between note values remain constant.

At the top of the hierarchy is the whole note (1):

(2) Half notes are worth half as much
(3) Quarter notes half of that
(4) Eighth notes half again
(5) Sixteenth notes half again; shorter values, such as thirty-second notes, also exist.
Eighth and sixteenth notes often appear with flags or beams; when grouped, the flags are replaced by beams: one beam for eighth notes, two for sixteenths.





Dotted Notes

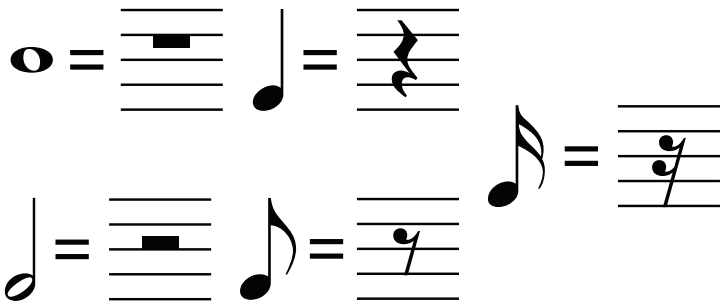
A dot beside a note increases its duration by half of its original value. For instance, a half note typically lasts for two beats in 4/4 time. When a dot is added, it extends the note's duration by one additional beat, totaling three beats. In addition to dots, ties are another means of properly lengthening note durations. A tie links two notes of the same pitch, effectively merging them into a single sustained note.



Musical Notation

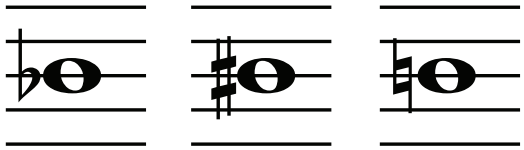
Rests

Rests indicate silence in music. Like notes, rests have specific durations that correlate with their note equivalents. The value of a rest mirrors that of the corresponding note—there are whole rests, half rests, quarter rests, and so forth. Rests are always placed in the same vertical position on the staff, regardless of the pitch, as they do not correspond to any particular note or frequency. This consistent placement ensures clarity in rhythmic notation, helping performers understand the timing and duration of silence within a piece of music.
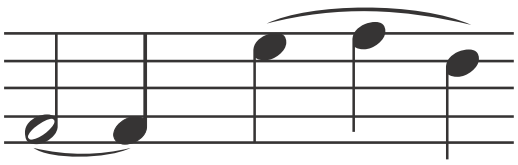


Accidentals

Accidentals alter the pitch of a note by raising or lowering it by a half step. These changes persist throughout the measure in which they occur, affecting all subsequent occurrences of the note in the same octave unless altered again. The sharps or flats placed right after the clef form the key signature, providing the framework for the tonal center of the music. Flats, marked with the flat sign (♭), lower the pitch by a half step, while sharps, marked with the sharp sign (♯), raise the pitch by a half step. Natural signs cancel previous accidentals, returning the note to its natural pitch for the remainder of the measure.



Ties and Slurs

Ties and slurs are curved lines that connect notes. A tie links two notes of the same pitch, creating one continuous sound, allowing the note to be sustained over both durations without rearticulation. A slur, however, connects notes of differing pitches and indicates that they should be played smoothly and without separation, creating a flowing legato effect. This suggests a seamless transition from one note to the next, with no breaks in the sound, enhancing musical expression and phrasing.

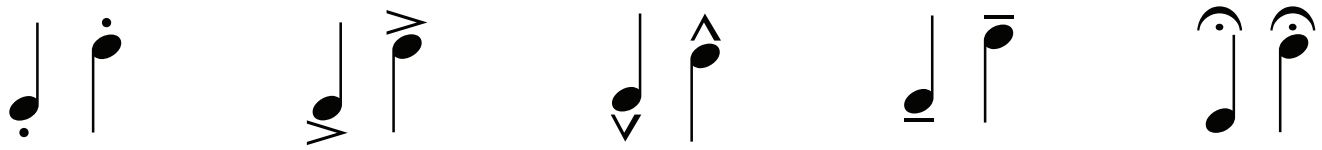


Musical Notation

Articulation

Articulation marks indicate how individual notes should be played.

- Staccato: The note should be short and detached.
- Accent: Play the note with greater emphasis or force.
- Marcato: An even stronger accent, making the note more forceful than an accent.
- Tenuto: Hold the note for its full value without allowing it to decay prematurely.
- Fermata: Sustain the note for longer than its usual duration, typically doubling the length or until a conductor signals to stop.



Dynamics

Dynamics convey the intensity with which music should be played.

These markings provide expressive depth to a performance.

- Pianissimo (pp): Very soft.
- Piano (p): Soft.
- Mezzo piano (mp): Moderately soft.
- Mezzo forte (mf): Moderately loud.
- Forte (f): Loud.
- Fortissimo (ff): Very loud.
- Sforzando (sfz): A sudden, forceful accent on a note or phrase.
- Crescendo (cresc.): Gradually become louder.
- Decrescendo (decresc.), diminuendo (dim.): Gradually become softer.

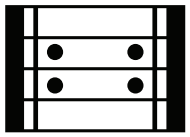


Musical Notation

Repeats

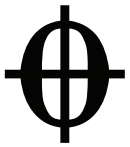
Repeat signs instruct musicians to go back to the earlier point in the music and repeat the passage. This is marked by a pair of dots, placed at the beginning and end of the section to be repeated, signaling the start and end points of the repetition. Often, first, second, or third endings are included to indicate alternate sections played after a repeat, providing variety and structure within the music, allowing the composer to create contrasting sections without writing out the entire passage again.

Dal Segno is a repeat instruction that directs musicians to return to a specific sign in the music, often indicated by the Dal Segno symbol, which is placed somewhere in the score. This may be followed by further instructions like al fine (to the end) or al coda (to the coda), signaling how the repetition should proceed and where the performer should end or transition to the next section of the piece, helping to guide the musical form and ensure the correct execution of the desired structure.







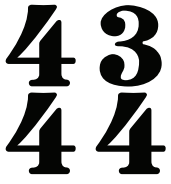


Time Signatures

Time signatures indicate the meter of a piece, dictating how many beats occur in each measure and which type of note receives the beat. The top number tells how many beats per measure, while the bottom number specifies the note value that receives the beat, providing a framework for how the music unfolds rhythmically.

For example, in 4/4 time, there are four beats per measure, with each beat represented by a quarter note. In 3/4 time, there are three beats per measure, with each beat still being a quarter note. In 6/8 time, there are six eighth notes per measure, usually felt as two beats of three eighth notes each.

The pulse (or beat) is the underlying rhythmic foundation of music. It is the beat we feel and often clap to, giving structure to the music. Identifying the pulse involves finding the strongest beat and tapping along with it. Listen carefully to the bass line or rhythm section—they typically emphasize the pulse and guide your sense of meter, helping to anchor the entire musical performance in a consistent, repetitive rhythm.



The Six Vocal Categories

Voices

The overwhelming majority of human vocal expressions can be classified into six primary vocal categories divided into three distinct classifications for female voices and three for male voices. For females, these categories are traditionally defined as soprano, mezzo-soprano, and alto, each representing a unique tonal timbre. For males, the classifications are customarily tenor, baritone, and bass, distinguished by their characteristic pitch ranges and vocal resonance.

The practice of voice classification serves as a systematic framework to analyze and categorize the vast spectrum of vocal ranges, while simultaneously highlighting the nuanced qualities and unique attributes inherent to each range. Understanding your vocal range, which is the span between the lowest and highest notes you can sing comfortably, is foundational. Once it is properly identified, you can delve into the descriptions provided below to accurately determine the vocal category that best aligns with your natural abilities.

1. Soprano

Soprano is the highest female vocal type. A typical soprano has a range from C4 to C6. In the lower and upper extremes, some sopranos can extend down to B3 or up to G6.

2. Mezzo-Soprano

Mezzo-Soprano is the middle-range vocal type for females. It's also the most common female voice classification. A typical mezzo-soprano has a range from A3 to A5. In the lower and upper extremes, some mezzo-sopranos can extend down to G3 or up to C6.

3. Alto

Contralto (Alto) is the lowest female vocal type. A typical alto has a range from F3 to F5. In the lower and upper extremes, some contraltos can extend down to D3 or up to A5. However, the range of a true contralto is rare for females.

4. Tenor

Tenor is the highest male vocal type. A typical tenor has a range from C3 to C5. In the lower and upper extremes, some tenors can extend down to B2 or up to F5.

5. Baritone

Baritone is the middle-range vocal type for males. It's also the most common male voice classification. A typical baritone has a range from G2 to G4. In the lower and upper extremes, some baritones can extend down to F2 or up to C5.

6. Bass

Bass is the lowest male vocal type. A typical bass has a range from E2 to E4. In the lower and upper extremes, a bass voice can extend down to C2 or up to G4.




Phoenix, AZ • Club Red
Blackstar

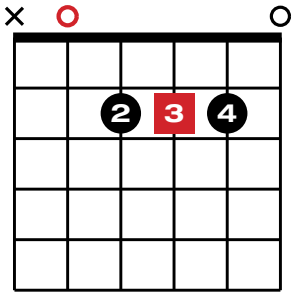
ESSENTIAL CHORDS



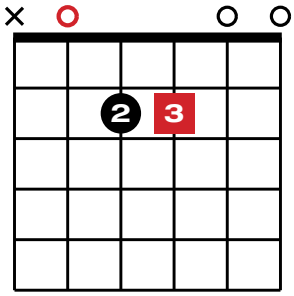
Essential Beginner Guitar Chords

Red squares mark the root · Numbers are fingers · x = don't play · o = open string (red o = open root)

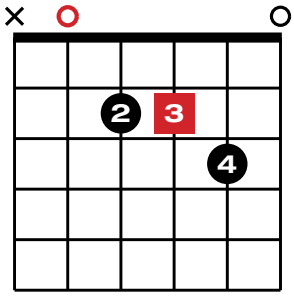
A



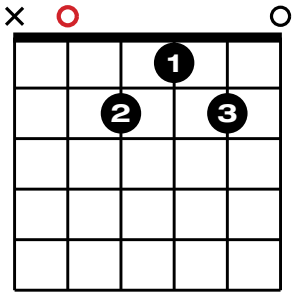
Asus2



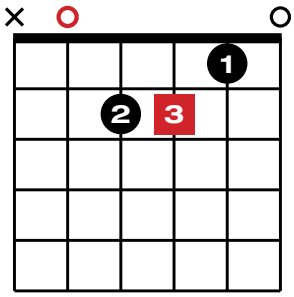
Asus4



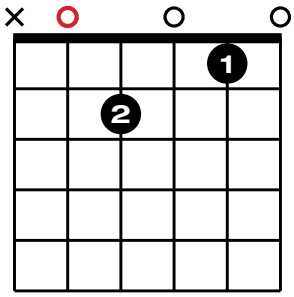
Amaj7



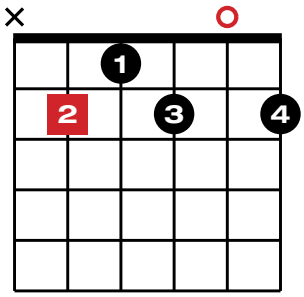
Am



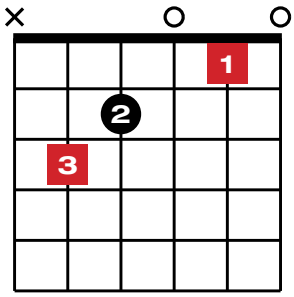
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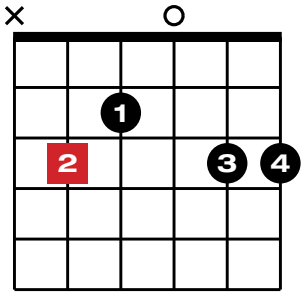
B7



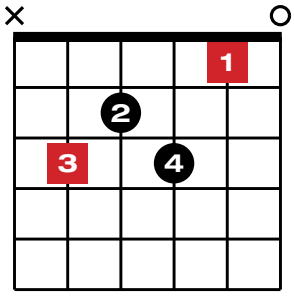
C



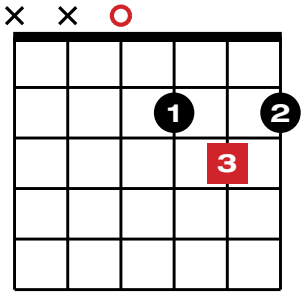
Cadd9



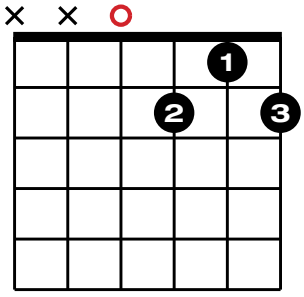
C7



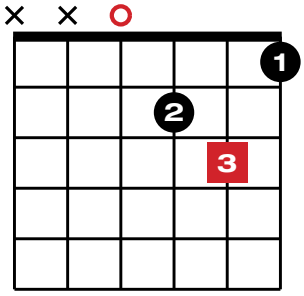
D



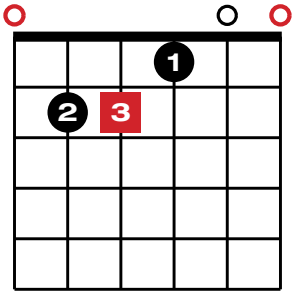
D7



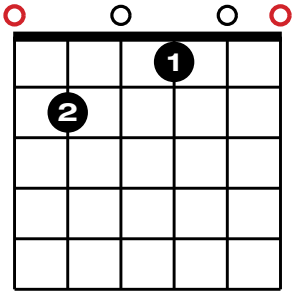
Dm



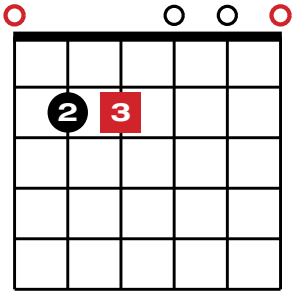
E



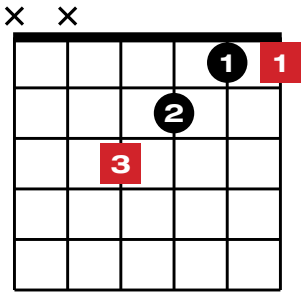
E7



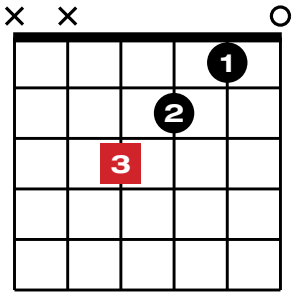
Em



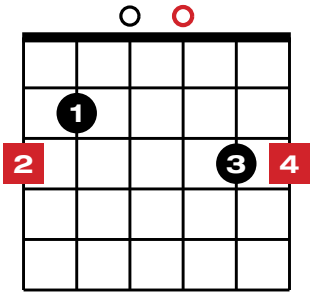
F



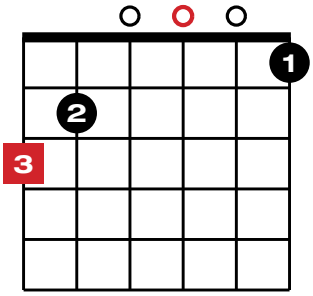
Fmaj7



G



G7



PRACTICE: Switch between two chords for one minute at a time, keeping your strumming hand moving steadily.

How to Use the Magic Chord Guide

Every key, and every chord you need to accompany a song

The Magic Chord Accompaniment Guide on the next two pages puts the most useful chords of every major key in one place. Each row is one key, with its key signature at the left. Read across the row and you have everything you need to play a song in that key.

1 Find your key

Find the row that matches the key of the song. The key signature shows its sharps or flats, so you can also find the key from the written music.

2 Play the three principal chords: I · IV · V7

These three chords are the backbone of thousands of songs. In C major they are C, F and G7. Play I – IV – V7 – I and you have a complete progression.

3 Switch to the relative minor: vi · ii · III7

Every major key shares its notes with a minor key, its relative minor. In C major that is A minor, and its chords are Am, Dm and E7. Play vi – ii – III7 – vi for the minor-key sound. The G♯ in E7 comes from A harmonic minor and gives it a strong pull back to Am.

4 Add color with the alternate chords (Part 2)

Swap a plain chord for a richer one: C6 in place of C, F6 in place of F, Am6 or Dm6 for the minor chords. Use Cdim7 or Caug as passing chords to glide from one chord to the next.

5 Read the diagrams

Red squares mark each chord's root, the numbers are your fingers, x means don't play that string, o means play it open, and a label like 5fr shows the starting fret.

Try these in C major

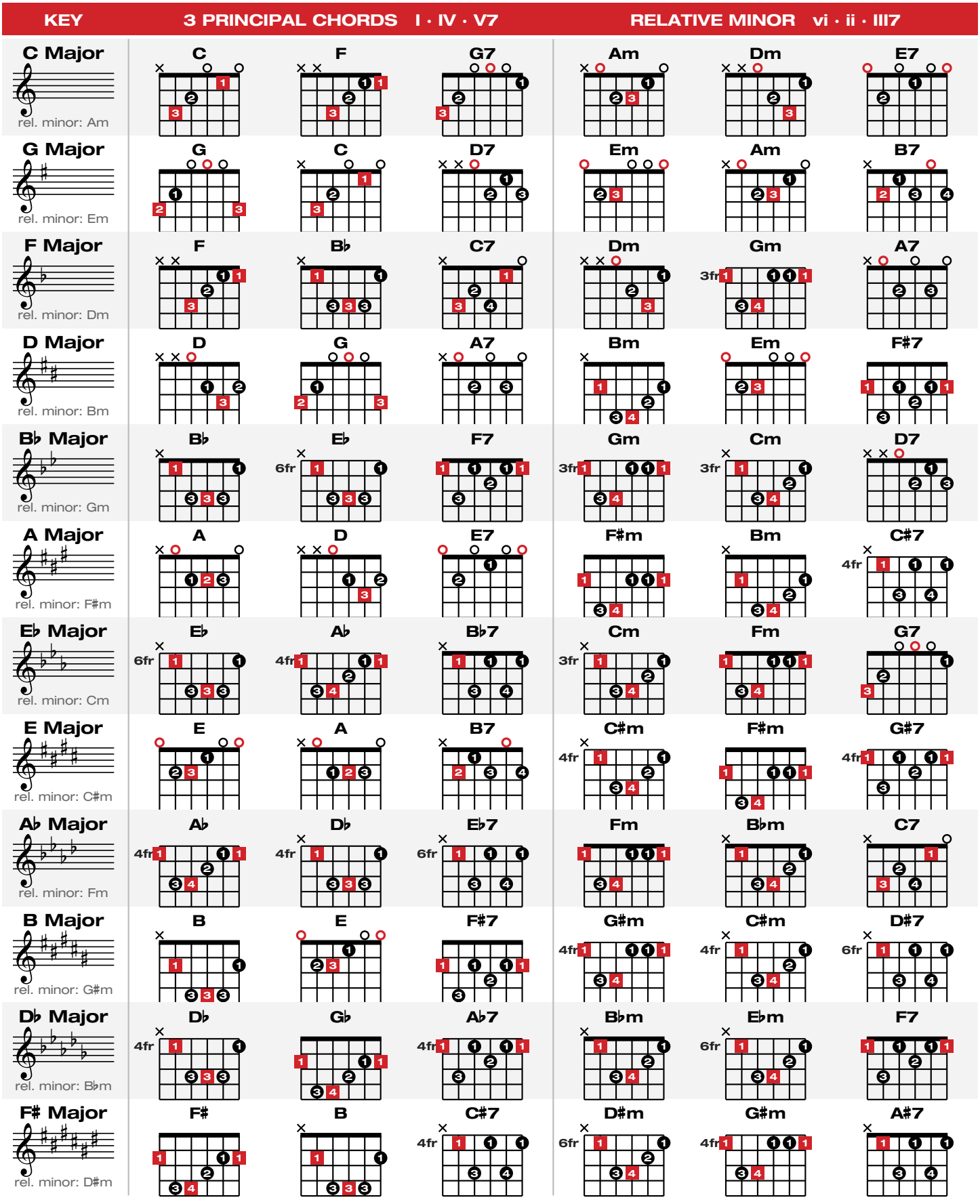
Major:	**C – Am – F – G7 – C**
Minor:	**Am – Dm – E7 – Am**
With color:	**C – C6 – F6 – Cdim7 – G7 – C**

PRACTICE: Pick one key each week. Play I – IV – V7 – I, then vi – ii – III7 – vi, then swap in the alternate chords.

Magic Chord Accompaniment Guide

Part 1 · The Principal and Relative Minor Chords of Every Key

Red squares mark the chord's root · Numbers are fingers · x = don't play · o = open string · 5fr = starting fret



PRACTICE: Pick a key and loop I-vi-ii-V7 (C-Am-Dm-G7), four beats per chord, then play the same progression in every key.

Magic Chord Accompaniment Guide

Part 2 · Alternate Chords to Color Every Key

Red squares mark the chord's root · Numbers are fingers · x = don't play · o = open string · 5fr = starting fret

KEY	ALTERNATE CHORDS I6 · I dim7 · I aug · IV6 · vi m6 · ii m6					
C Major rel. minor: Am	C6 / Am	Cdim7	Caug	F6	Am6	Dm6
G Major rel. minor: Em	G6 / Em7	Gdim7	Gaug	C6	Em6	Am6
F Major rel. minor: Dm	F6 / Dm	Fdim7	Faug	B♭6	Dm6	Gm6
D Major rel. minor: Bm	D6 / Bm7	Ddim7	Daug	G6	Bm6	Em6
B♭ Major rel. minor: Gm	B♭6 / Gm7	B♭dim7	B♭aug	E♭6	Gm6	Cm6
A Major rel. minor: F♯m	A6 / F♯m7	Adim7	Aaug	D6	F♯m6	Bm6
E♭ Major rel. minor: Cm	E♭6 / Cm7	E♭dim7	E♭aug	A♭6	Cm6	Fm6
E Major rel. minor: C♯m	E6 / C♯m7	Edim7	Eaug	A6	C♯m6	F♯m6
A♭ Major rel. minor: Fm	A♭6 / Fm7	A♭dim7	A♭aug	D♭6	Fm6	B♭m6
B Major rel. minor: G♯m	B6 / G♯m7	Bdim7	Baug	E6	G♯m6	C♯m6
D♭ Major rel. minor: B♭m	D♭6 / B♭m7	D♭dim7	D♭aug	G♭6	B♭m6	E♭m6
F♯ Major rel. minor: D♯m	F♯6 / D♯m7	F♯dim7	F♯aug	B6	D♯m6	G♯m6

PRACTICE: Swap an alternate chord in for its principal chord (C6 for C, Dm6 for Dm) and listen to how the color changes.

The Nashville Number System

Write a song as numbers and play it in any key

In Nashville recording studios the chord chart is written in numbers instead of letters. Each chord is named by its place in the key, so one chart works in every key: when the singer wants the song higher or lower, nobody rewrites a thing. The idea goes back to about 1957, when Neal Matthews of the Jordanaires began writing the group's vocal parts as numbers. In the early 1960s Charlie McCoy and the session players brought it to the whole band.

The seven chords of a key, by number

in the key of C

I	ii	iii	IV	V	vi	vii°
1	**2–**	**3–**	**4**	**5**	**6–**	**7°**
C	**Dm**	**Em**	**F**	**G**	**Am**	**B°**

The small grey labels are the Roman numerals used elsewhere in this book: I is 1, ii is 2–, vii° is 7°.

The symbols

every example is in the key of C

4	A number alone is a major chord, one bar long. In C, 4 is F.	**2–**	A dash after the number makes it minor. In C, 2– is Dm.	**5^{7}**	A 7th or other extension is small and raised: 5 with a 7 is G7.
7°	A small circle makes the chord diminished. In C, 7° is B°.	**♭7**	A flat or sharp in front is a chord from outside the key. In C, ♭7 is B♭.	**1/3**	A slash sets the bass note: 1/3 is C with E, the 3, in the bass.
4 5	Numbers underlined together share one bar, two beats each.	**1**	A diamond: play the chord once and let it ring.	**5**	A push: play the chord an eighth note before the bar line.

Reading a number chart

one line of four bars at a time, chords in the key of G below

1	2	3	4
1 **G**	**5** **D**	**6–** **Em**	**4** **C**

5	6	7	8
1 **G**	**5** **D**	**4 5** **C D**	**1** **G**

Change key without rewriting

bars 1 to 4 of the chart in four more keys

Chart	1	5	6–	4
Key of C	C	G	Am	F
Key of A	A	E	F♯m	D
Key of E	E	B	C♯m	A
Key of D	D	A	Bm	G

The Nashville Number System has no official rulebook. Every player agrees on the numbers, but the small symbols (a dash or "m" for minor, how a split bar or a push is marked) vary from band to band. This book uses the most common forms; whatever a chart looks like, the numbers mean the same thing.

PRACTICE: Write a song you know as numbers, then play it from your chart in three different keys.

Nashville Numbers in Every Key

The seven chords of all twelve major keys, and how minor-key songs are charted

Read across a row for the seven chords of a key. Read down a column for the same number in every key. The keys in red, C, A, G, E and D, are the open-string keys of the guitar, the CAGED keys of page 33.

Key	1 I	2– ii	3– iii	4 IV	5 V	6– vi	7° vii°
C	C	Dm	Em	F	G	Am	B°
G	G	Am	Bm	C	D	Em	F♯°
D	D	Em	F♯m	G	A	Bm	C♯°
A	A	Bm	C♯m	D	E	F♯m	G♯°
E	E	F♯m	G♯m	A	B	C♯m	D♯°
B	B	C♯m	D♯m	E	F♯	G♯m	A♯°
F♯	F♯	G♯m	A♯m	B	C♯	D♯m	E♯°
F	F	Gm	Am	B♭	C	Dm	E°
B♭	B♭	Cm	Dm	E♭	F	Gm	A°
E♭	E♭	Fm	Gm	A♭	B♭	Cm	D°
A♭	A♭	B♭m	Cm	D♭	E♭	Fm	G°
D♭	D♭	E♭m	Fm	G♭	A♭	B♭m	C°

Sharp keys first, then flat keys, each one step further round the circle of fifths of page 10.

Minor-key songs are charted in their relative major. A song in A minor is written in the key of C, so its home chord, Am, is 6– and Dm is 2–. When a chart starts and ends on 6–, the song is in a minor key. Some players count from the minor chord instead (Am = 1–), so check which way a chart is written.

For example: **Am 6–** **Dm 2–** **E7 3⁷** **Am 6–**

"I Don't Mind" in numbers

the chords of page 120, charted in C, the relative major of A minor

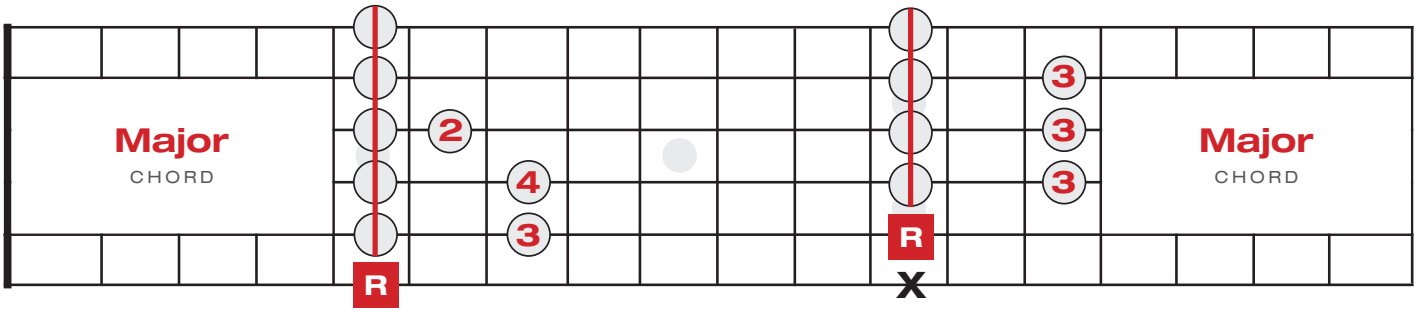
1 **6–⁷** Am7	2 **2–⁷** Dm7	3 **6–⁷** Am7	4 **6–⁶** Am6
5 **2–⁷** Dm7	6 **4^maj7** Fmaj7	7 **6–⁹** Am9	8 **♭6^7♯5** A♭7♯5
9 **4^maj7** Fmaj7	10 **2–⁹** Dm9	11 **6–⁷** Am7	12 **♭6^7♯5** A♭7♯5
13 **2–⁹** Dm9	14 **3^7♯9** E7♯9		

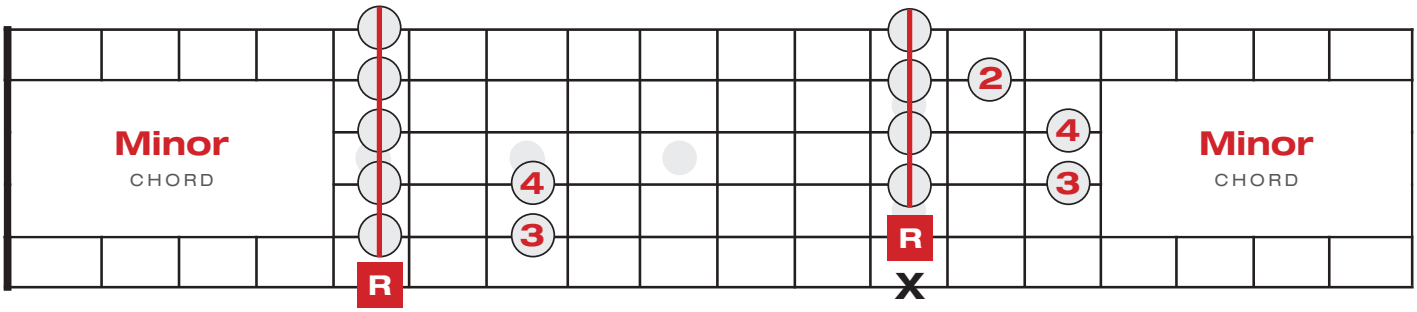
Two chords step outside the key of C. The root of A♭7♯5 is not in the key, so it is written ♭6. E7♯9 is a major 3 where the key has 3–. All the others are numbered straight from the key.

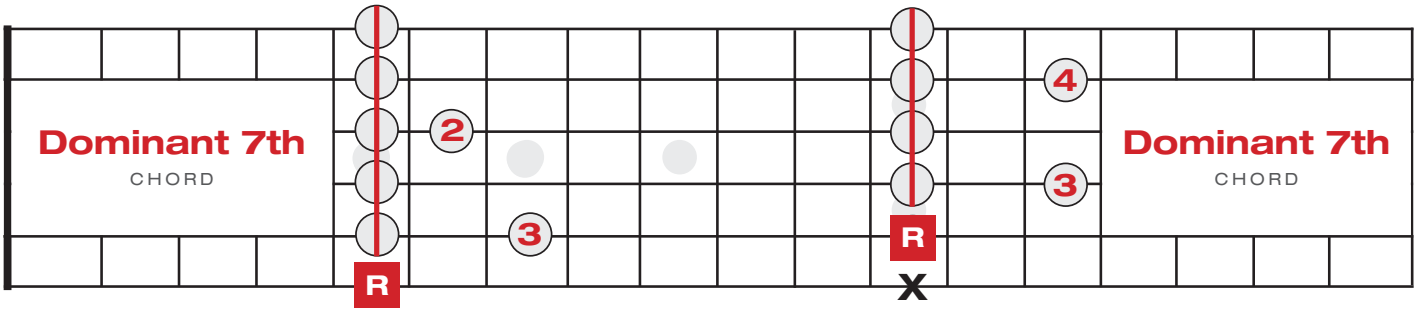
PRACTICE: Pick a key a day. Play its seven chords calling out the numbers, then play 1 4 5 1 and 6– 2– 3 6– in that key.

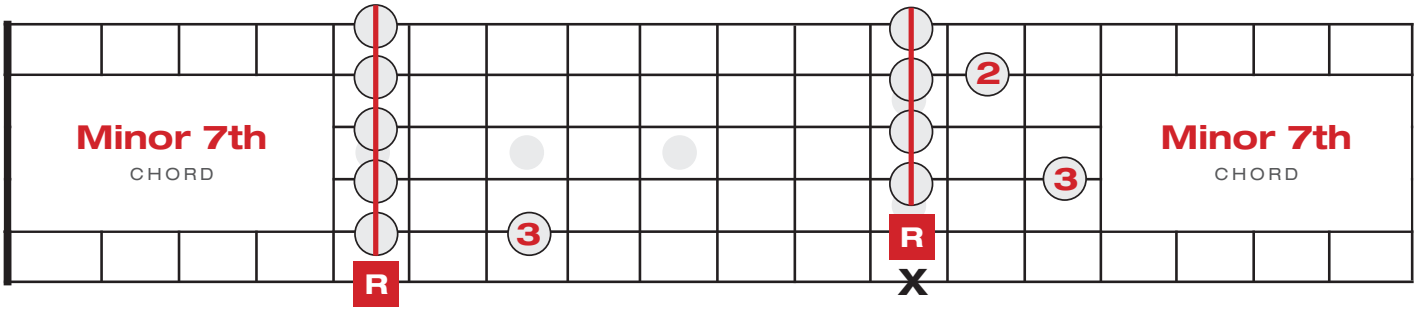
Movable Barre Chord Shapes

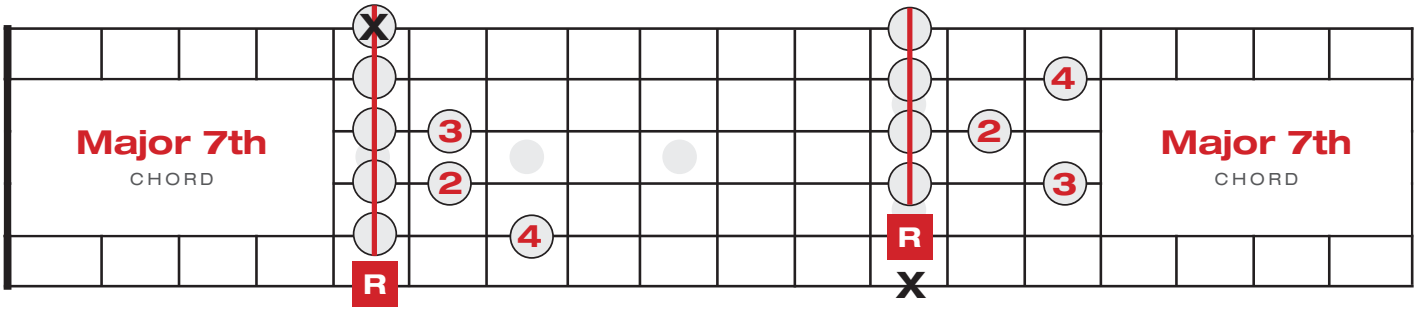
These movable barre chord shapes are a fundamental tool for guitarists seeking versatility. Barre chords are effectively creating movable frameworks for chord voicings in any key.







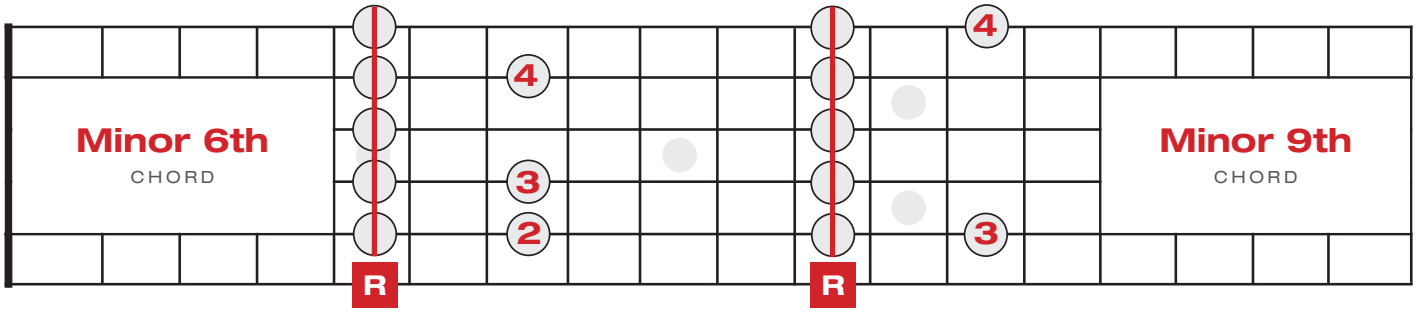


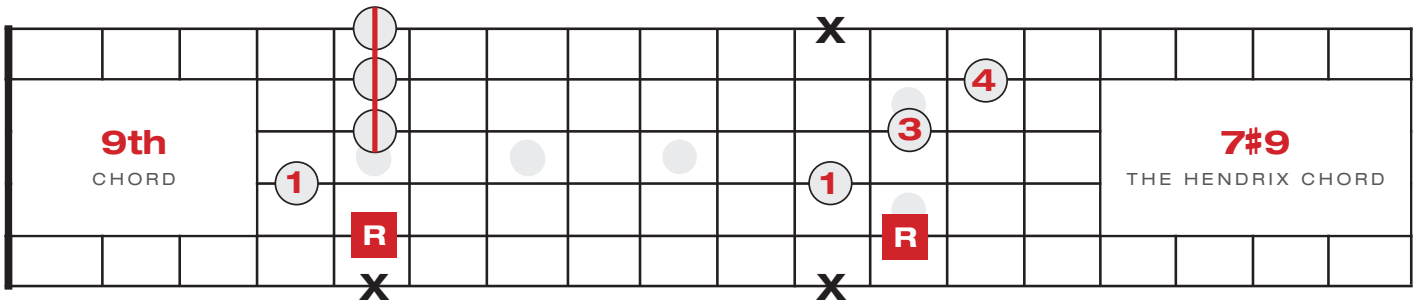


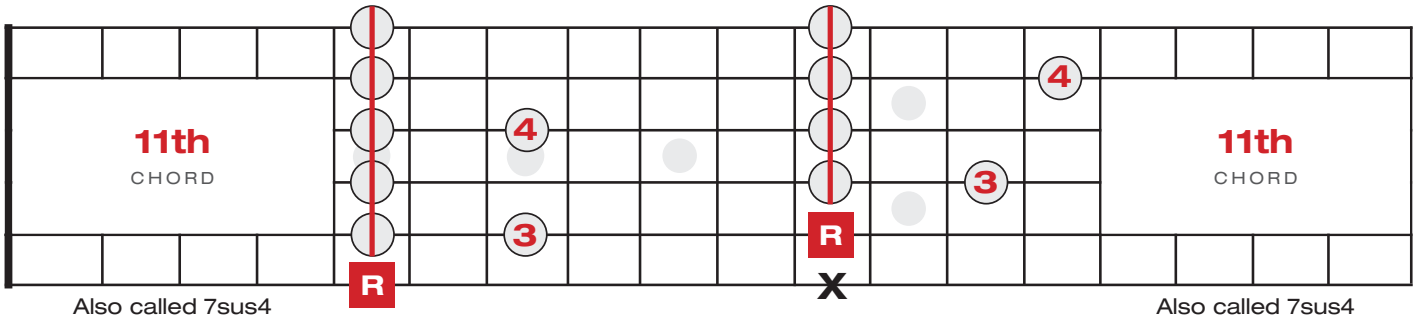
PRACTICE: Move each shape to all 12 roots on the low E and A strings, naming every chord out loud as you play it.

Movable Barre Chord Shapes

These movable barre chord shapes are a fundamental tool for guitarists seeking versatility. Barre chords are effectively creating movable frameworks for chord voicings in any key.

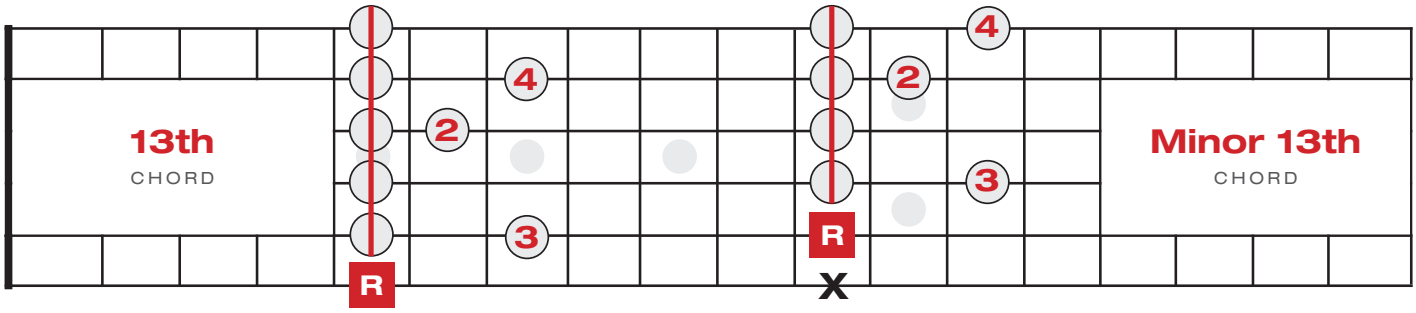


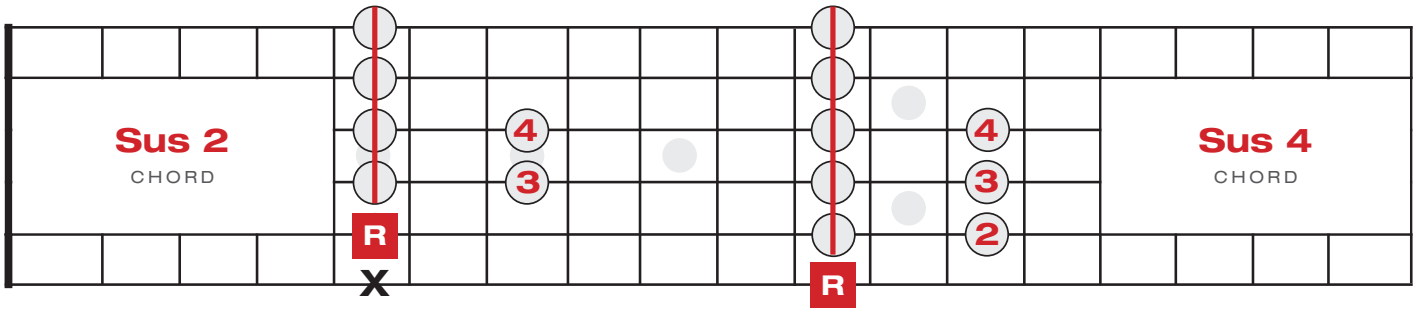




Also called 7sus4

Also called 7sus4





PRACTICE: Pick one shape a day and play it through the cycle of fourths: A, D, G, C, F, B♭, E♭, and so on.

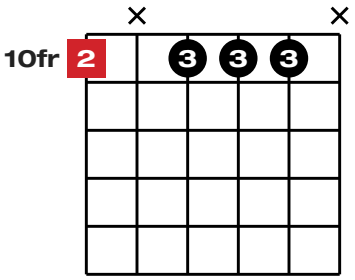
II - V - I

C MAJOR - A MINOR & SECONDARY DOMINANT

The II-V-I progression is one of the most common and essential chord progressions in Western music, particularly in jazz. Adding a secondary dominant enriches the harmonic color and creates stronger movement towards the resolution.

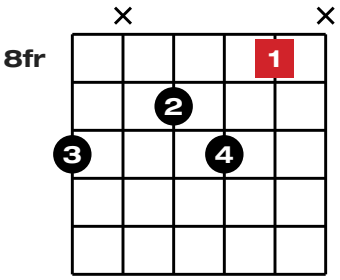
II-V-I · C MAJOR – A MINOR & SECONDARY DOMINANT

Dm7



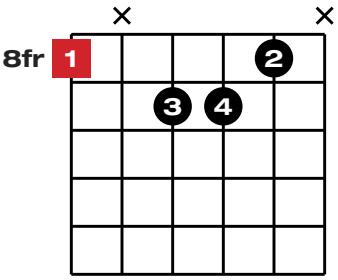
II

G7



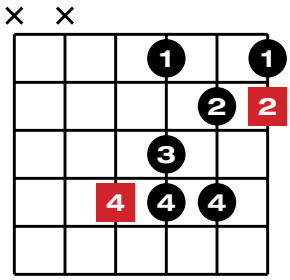
V

Cmaj7



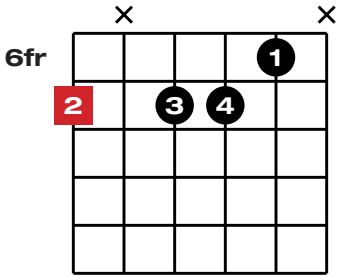
I

C Major Scale



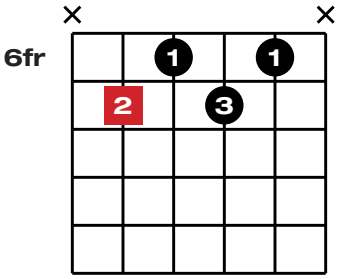
MAJOR

Bm7♭5



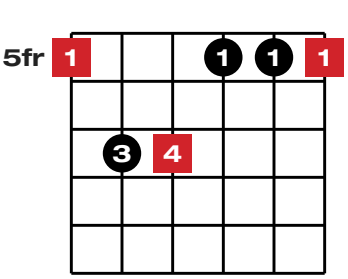
II

E7♭9



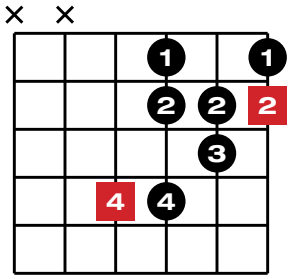
V

Am



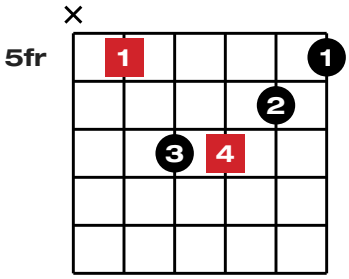
I

A Harmonic Minor

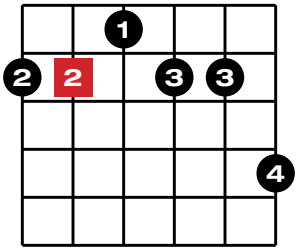


MINOR

Dm



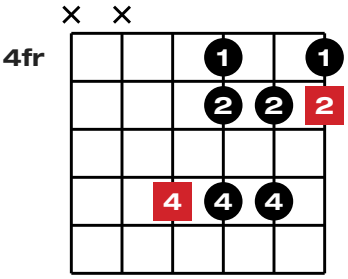
D13



SEC. DOM.

V of V: resolves to G7

A Melodic Minor



SCALE

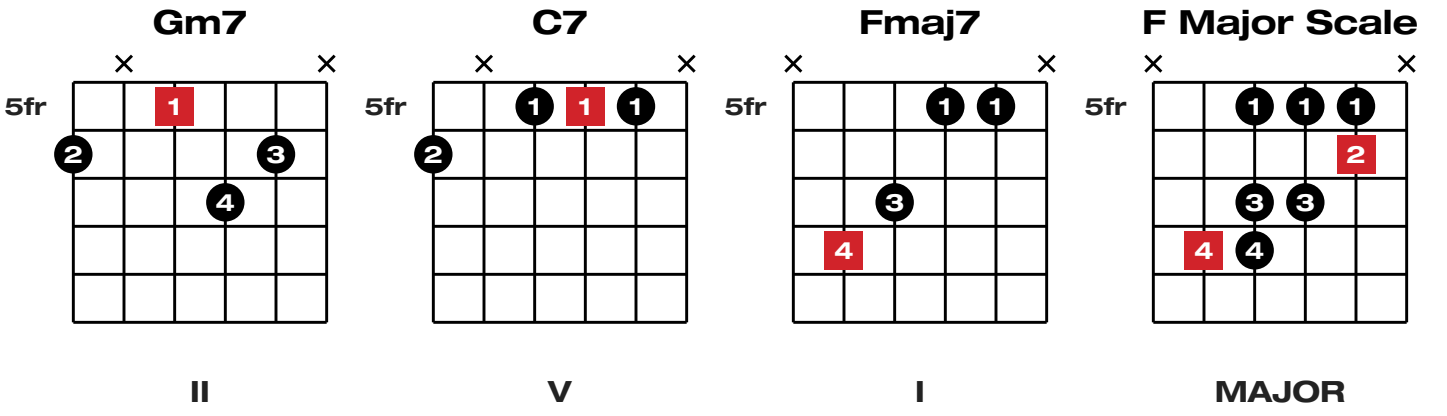
PRACTICE: Loop the progression at 70 BPM, then solo over it and target a chord tone on every chord change.

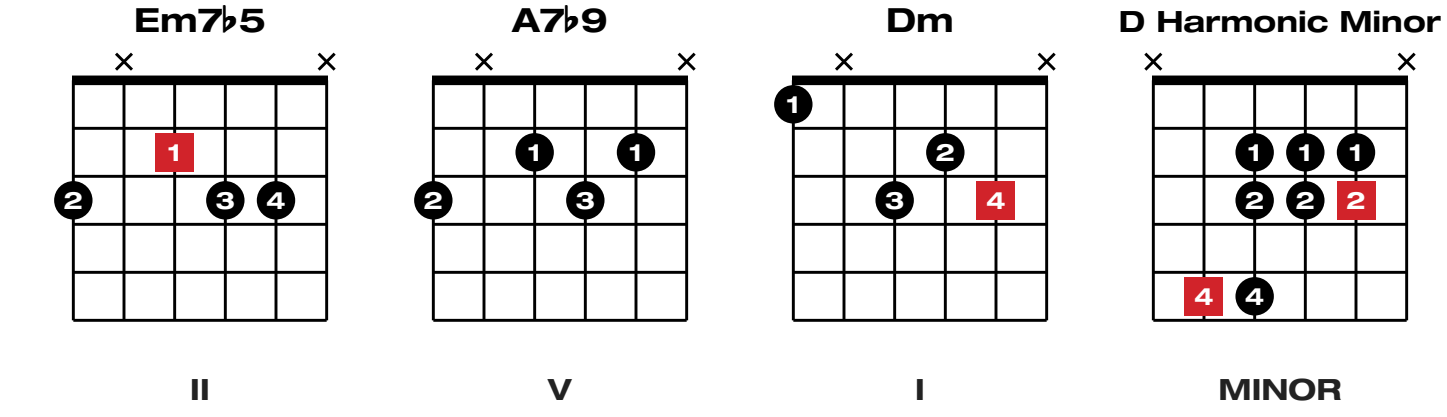
II - V - I

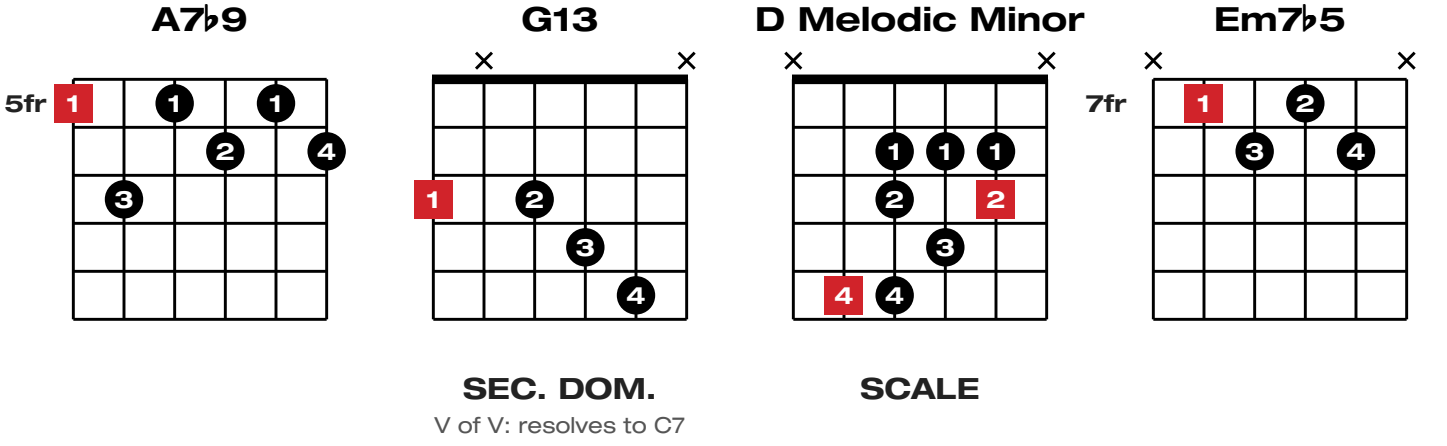
F MAJOR - D MINOR & SECONDARY DOMINANT

The II-V-I progression is one of the most common and essential chord progressions in Western music, particularly in jazz. Adding a secondary dominant enriches the harmonic color and creates stronger movement towards the resolution.

II-V-I · F MAJOR – D MINOR & SECONDARY DOMINANT







PRACTICE: Loop the progression at 70 BPM, then solo over it and target a chord tone on every chord change.

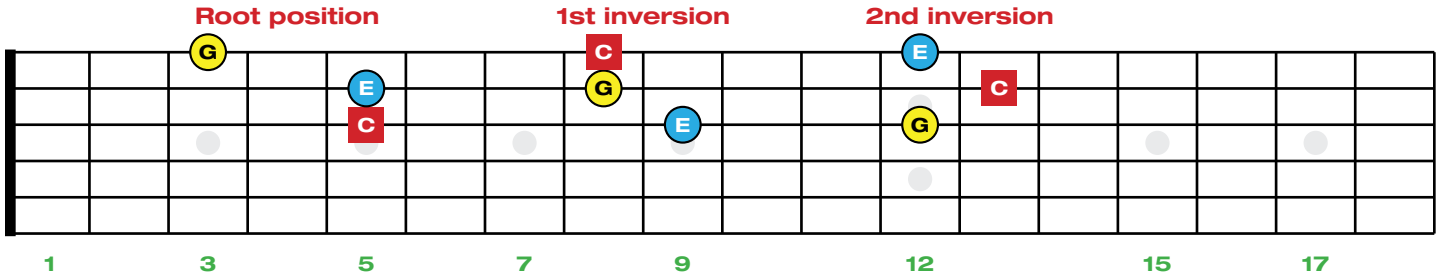
Triads & Inversions

Three-note chords on three strings: small shapes with a big sound

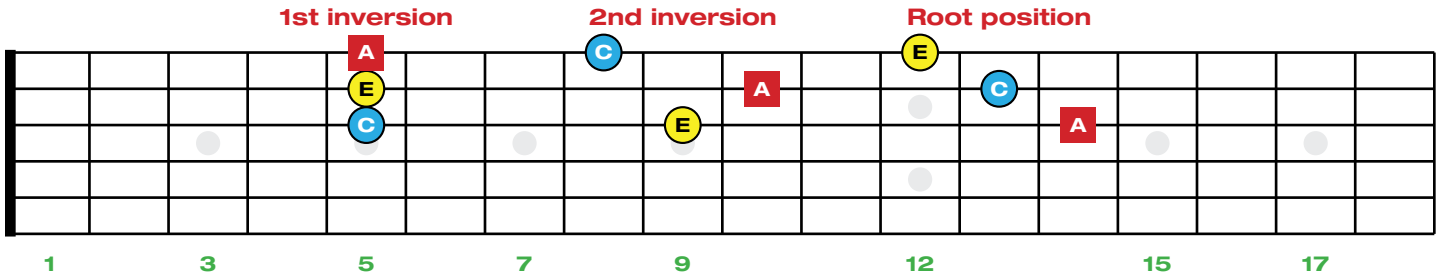
A triad is the root, 3rd and 5th of a chord. An inversion is the same three notes with a different one at the bottom. On any three neighboring strings a triad has three shapes that between them cover the neck. Use them for rhythm parts that cut through a band and for solos that follow the chords. The map on pages 34–35 shows every major and minor triad on all four string sets.

Red squares = the root • Blue circles = the 3rd • Yellow circles = the 5th • The lowest note names the inversion

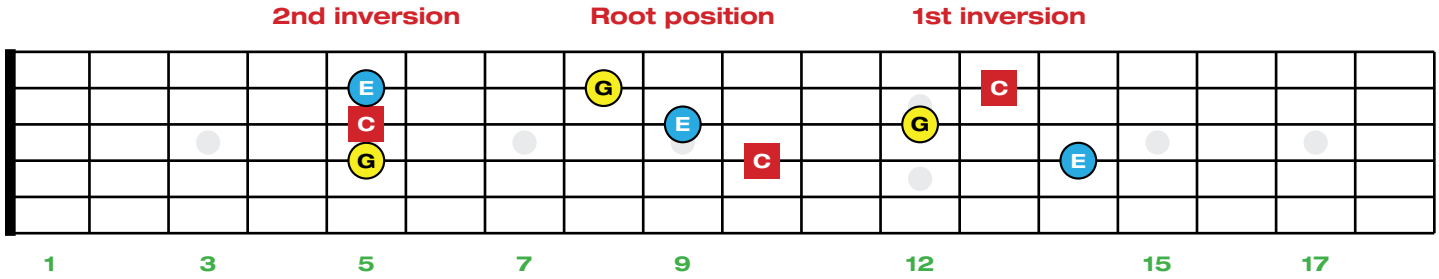
C major on the G, B and E strings



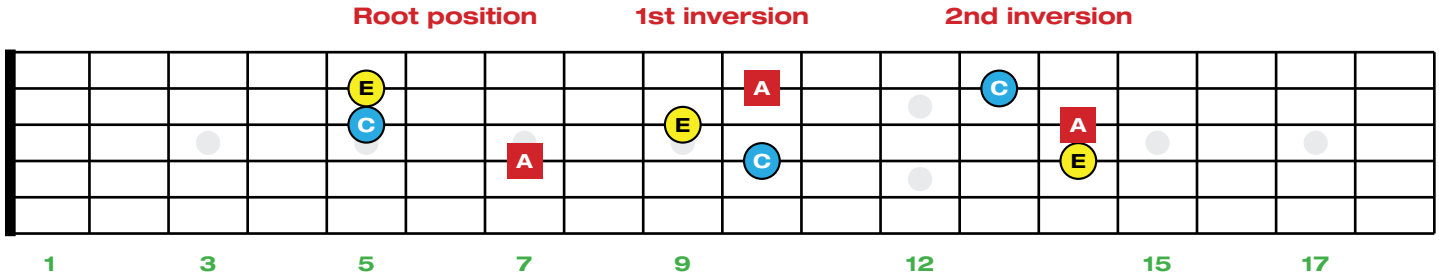
A minor on the G, B and E strings

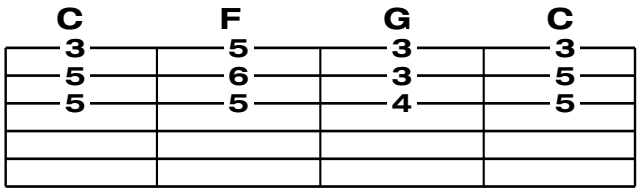


C major on the D, G and B strings



A minor on the D, G and B strings





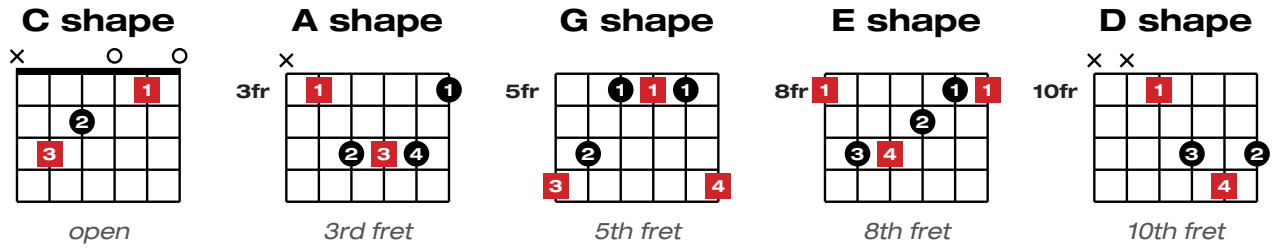
Three chords in one place. C in root position, F in 2nd inversion and G in 1st inversion all sit between the 3rd and 6th frets. No note moves more than three frets, and from C to F and from G back to C one note does not move at all. That smooth motion is why inversions sound so good.

PRACTICE: Play the three shapes of one triad up and down a string set, naming each inversion, then do the same from a new root.

The CAGED System

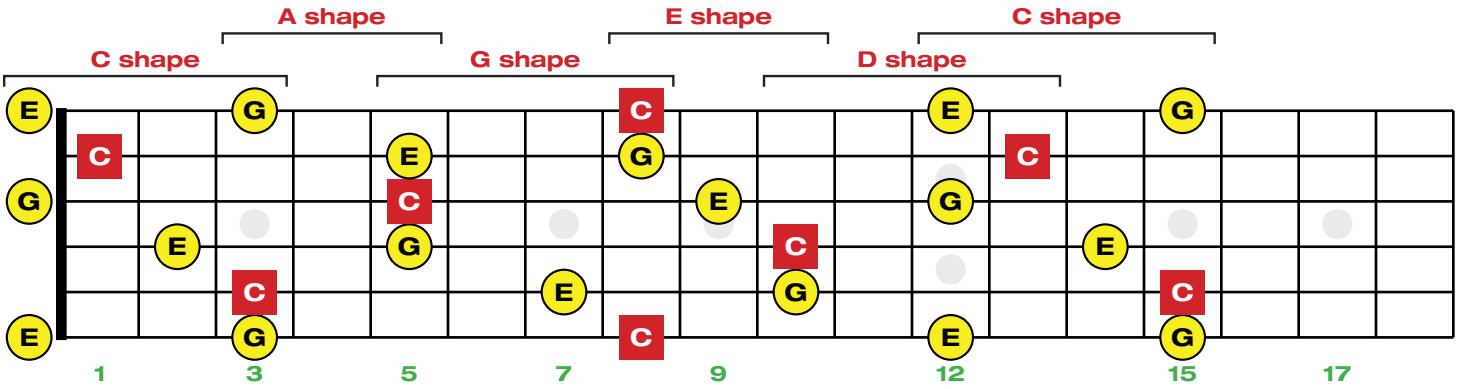
Five open-chord shapes that map any chord across the whole neck

The open chords C, A, G, E and D from page 22 are movable shapes in disguise. Put a finger or a barre where the nut used to be and each one can be played anywhere. Laid end to end they spell CAGED, and together they show one chord in five places. Here is C major.



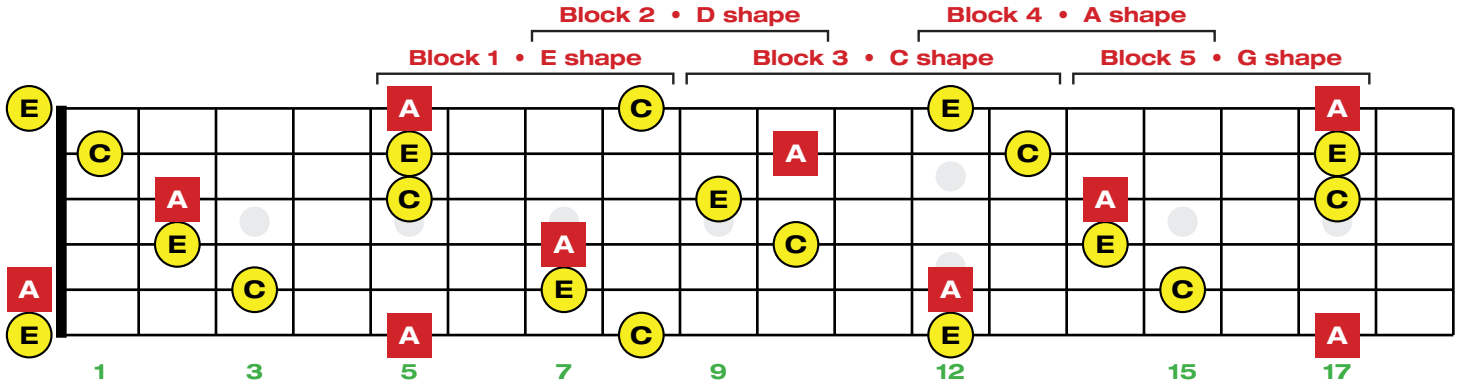
C major along the neck

C = root • E = 3rd • G = 5th



A minor along the neck

A = root • C = ♭3rd • E = 5th



- **Neighbors share notes.** The top of each shape is the bottom of the next, so the five shapes link into one unbroken map.
- **Any chord, anywhere.** Slide the whole map two frets higher and it shows D major. Lower every E to E♭ and it shows C minor.
- **Scales live in the same five places.** The minor shapes above are the homes of the five pentatonic blocks on page 38.
- **Use it when you solo.** Find the nearest chord shape and you have found the root, 3rd and 5th to aim for.

PRACTICE: Play C major in all five shapes, low to high and back, then take another chord from the Magic Chord Guide through all five.

Triad Map: Major

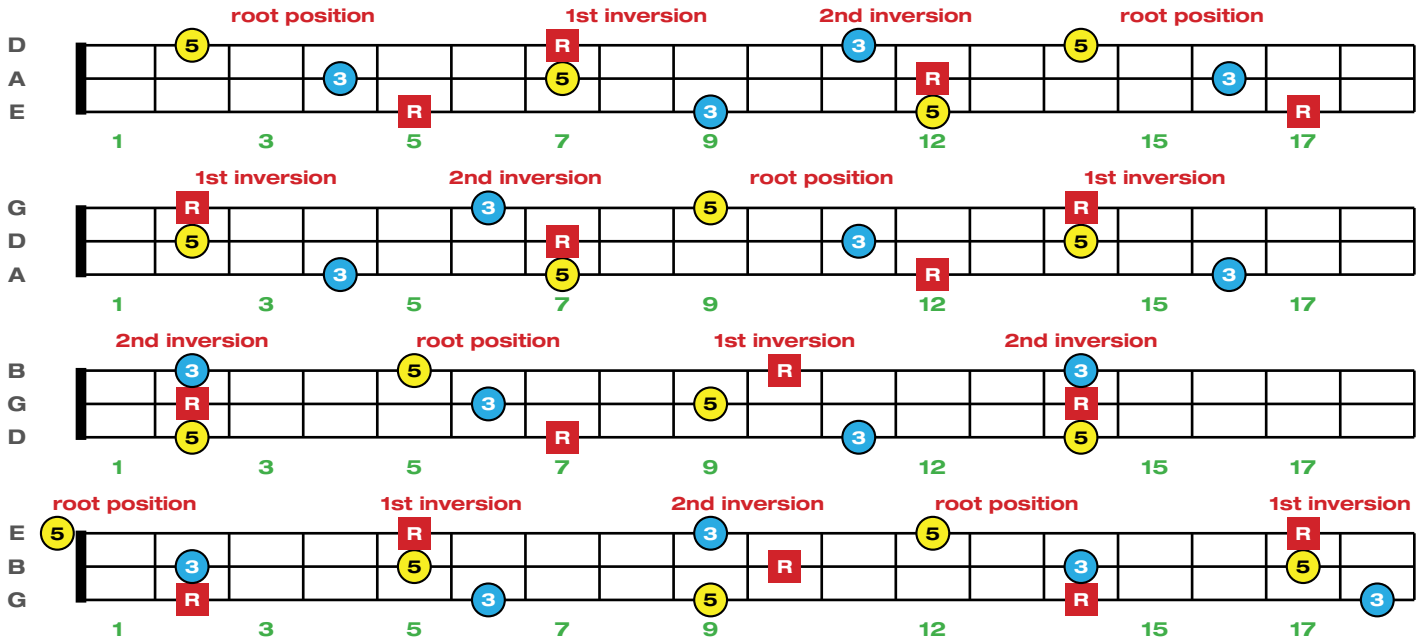
Every A major triad on all four string sets, up the neck and across it

Every A major triad on all four groups of three strings. Each note is named by its job in the chord, so the shapes work for any major chord: slide the whole map until R sits on the root you need.

Red square R = the root • Blue circle 3 = the 3rd • Yellow circle 5 = the 5th • The lowest note names the inversion

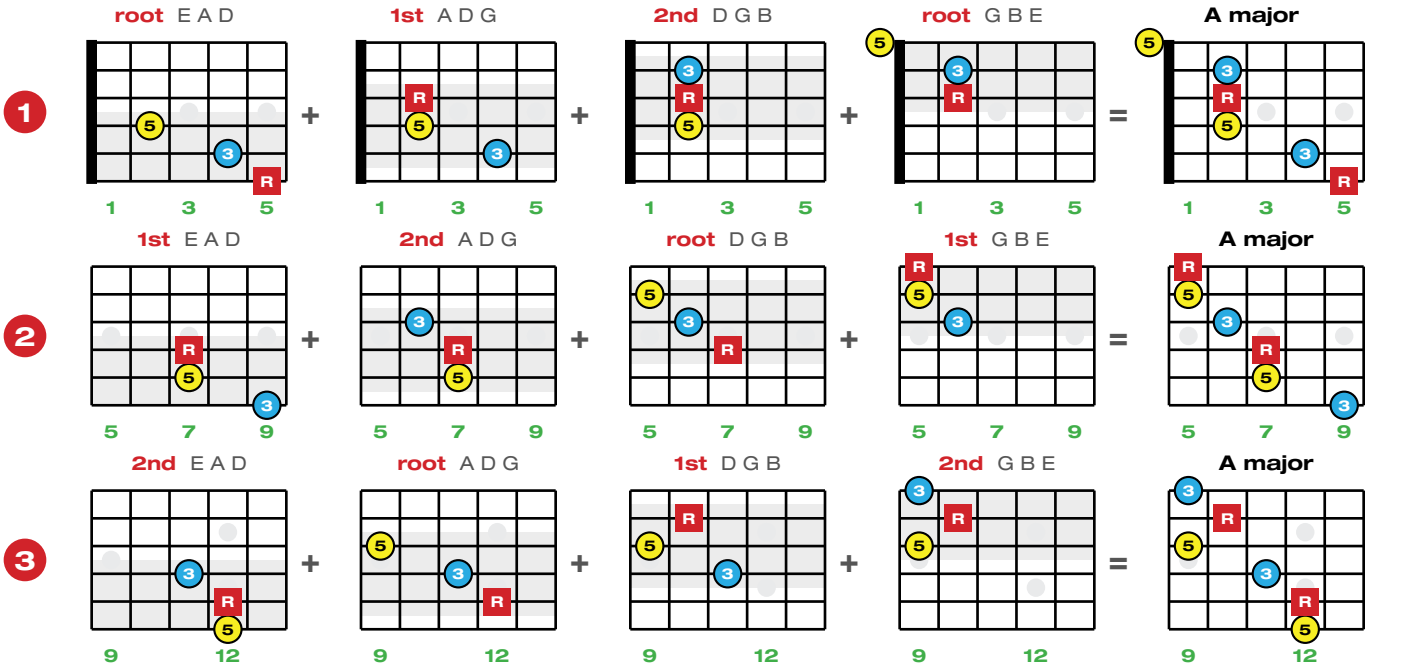
Up and down the neck

one strip for each group of three strings



Across the neck: four triads make one chord

grey band = the triad's three strings



Reading the map. Along every strip the shapes climb in the same order: root position, 1st inversion, 2nd inversion, then root position again 12 frets higher. Across the neck, neighboring string sets share two notes, so the four triads in each row lock into one full chord. Five strings of each chord are a shape from page 33: the G shape (row 1), the E shape (row 2) and the C shape (row 3).

PRACTICE: Play one strip up the neck and back, saying root, 1st, 2nd as you go, then the next strip. Then move the map to D and E.

Triad Map: Minor

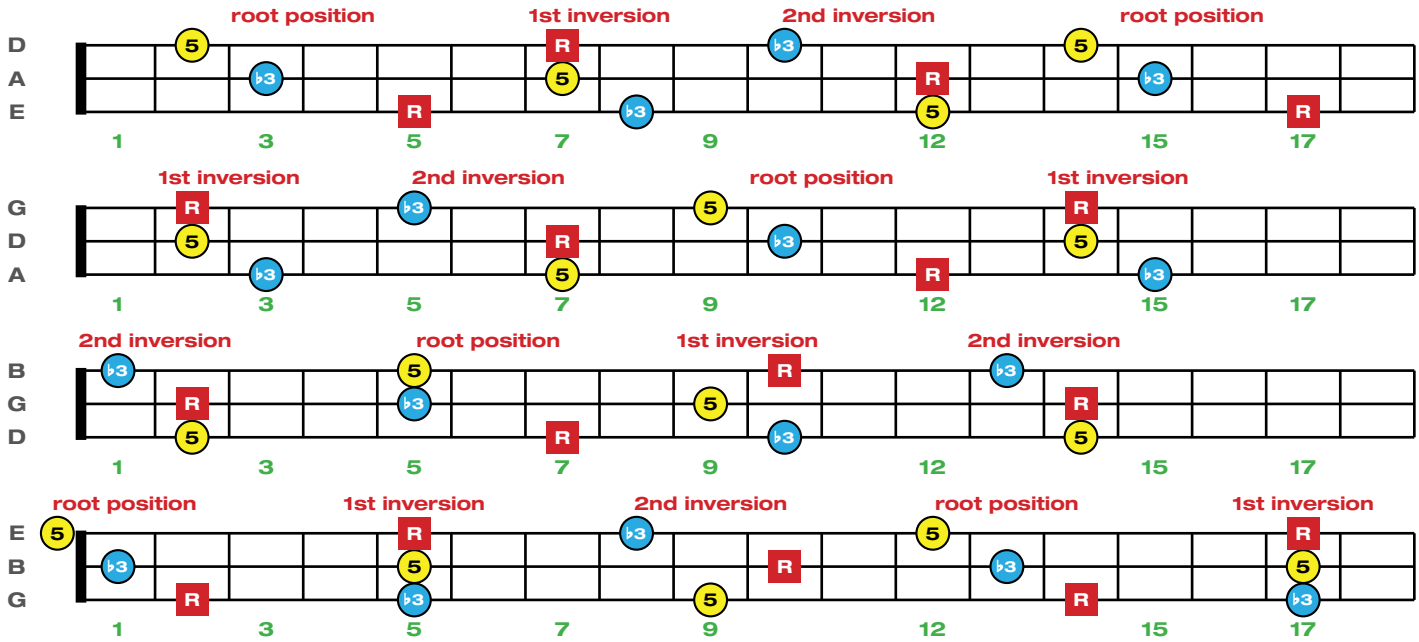
Every A minor triad on all four string sets: the major map with one note lowered

A minor triad is a major triad with its 3rd lowered one fret. Compare this page with the facing one: every R and every 5 stays exactly where it was, and only the blue notes move, from 3 down to ♭3.

Red square R = the root • Blue circle ♭3 = the flat 3rd • Yellow circle 5 = the 5th • The lowest note names the inversion

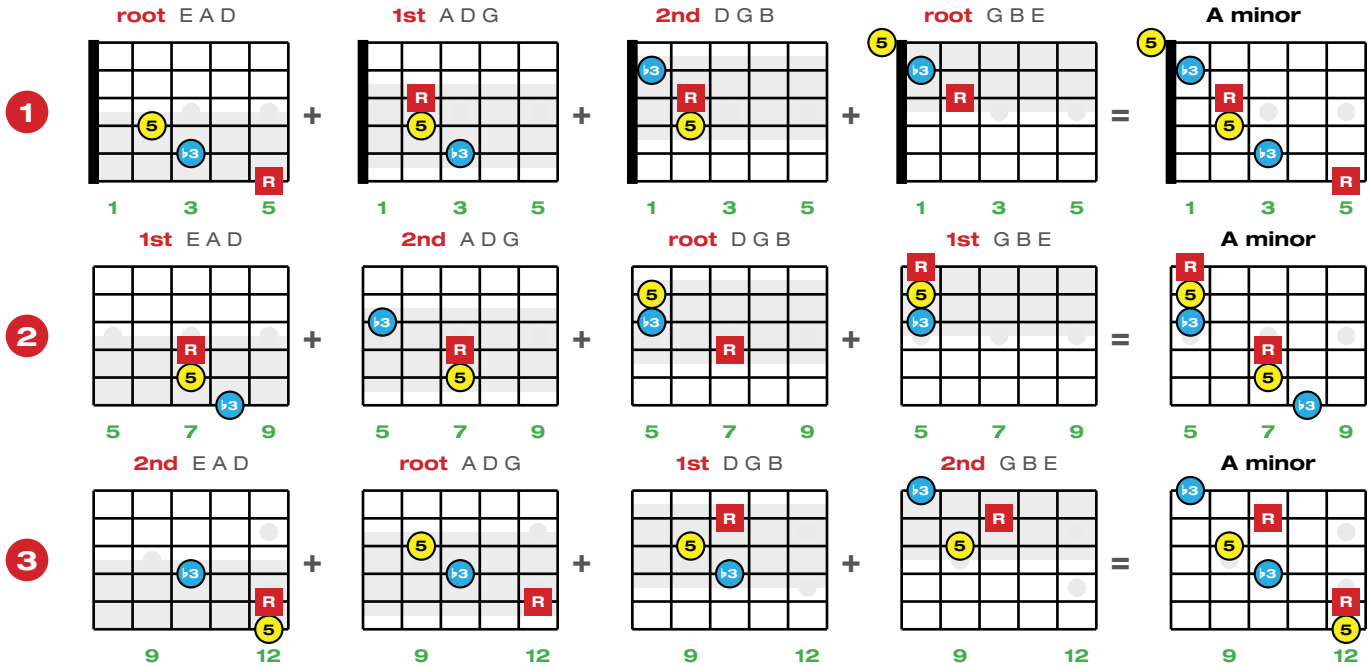
Up and down the neck

one strip for each group of three strings



Across the neck: four triads make one chord

grey band = the triad's three strings



Reading the map. The shapes, their order up the neck and the way they stack are the same as on the major page; only the 3rd has moved. Lower the blue note of any major shape one fret and it becomes minor; raise it and it turns major again. Five strings of each full chord are the minor forms of the G, E and C shapes.

PRACTICE: Play each major shape, then lower its blue note one fret to make it minor, and back again, on all four strips.


Phoenix, AZ • BLK Live
Marshall
Marshall
Blackstar
Marshall
Marshall
BYRON
HEMETH

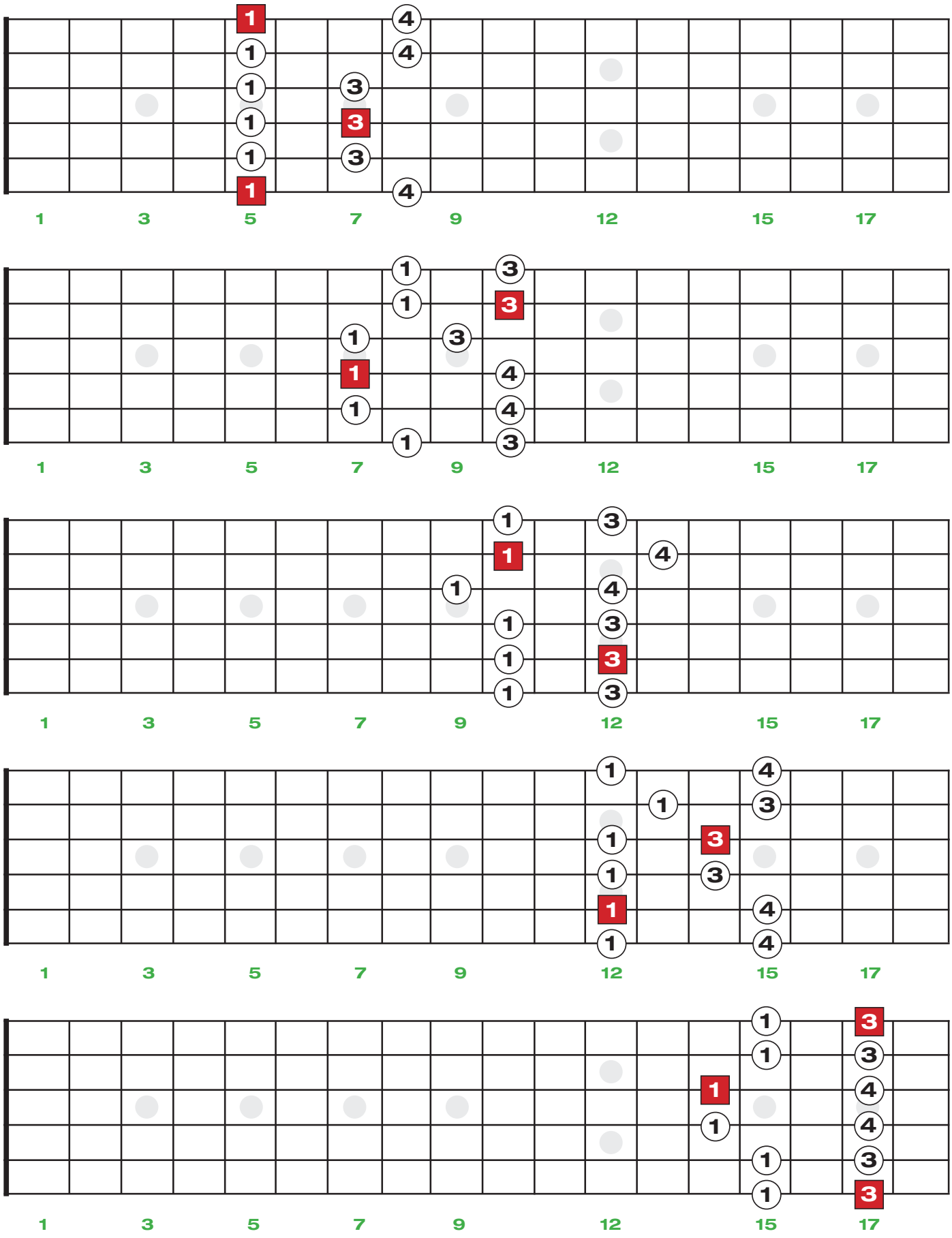
ESSENTIAL SCALES



A Minor Pentatonic Scale

A Minor Pentatonic Notes: A C D E G • Minor Pentatonic Scale Formula: 1 ♭3 4 5 ♭7

The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key

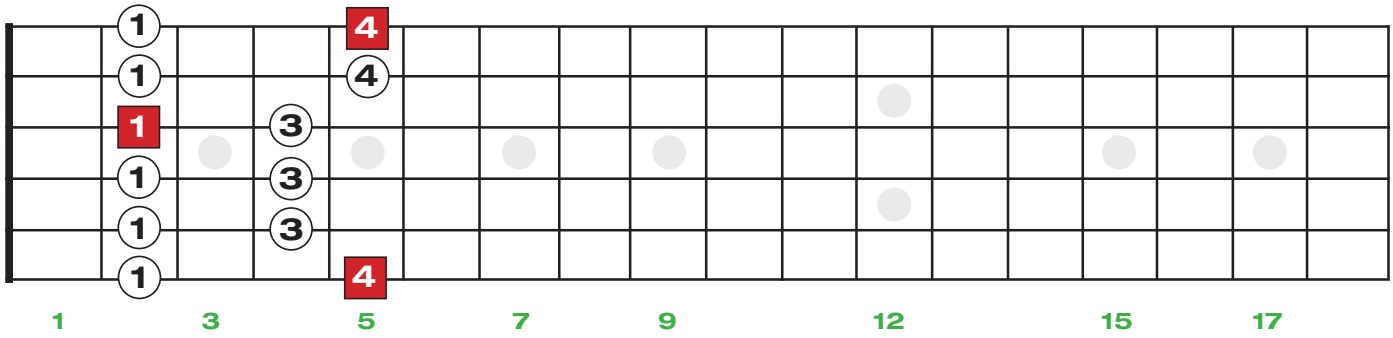


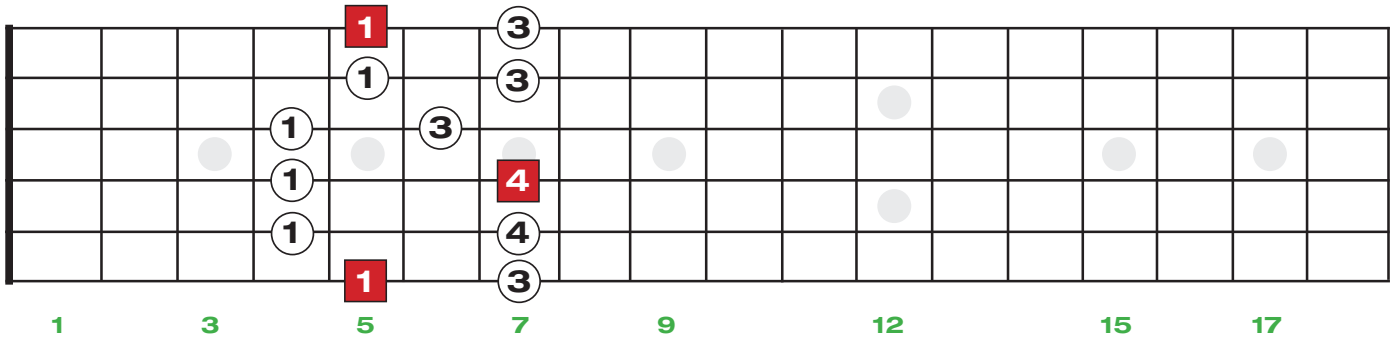
PRACTICE: Learn one block per week. Play it up and down at 60 BPM, then improvise over an A minor backing track using only that block.

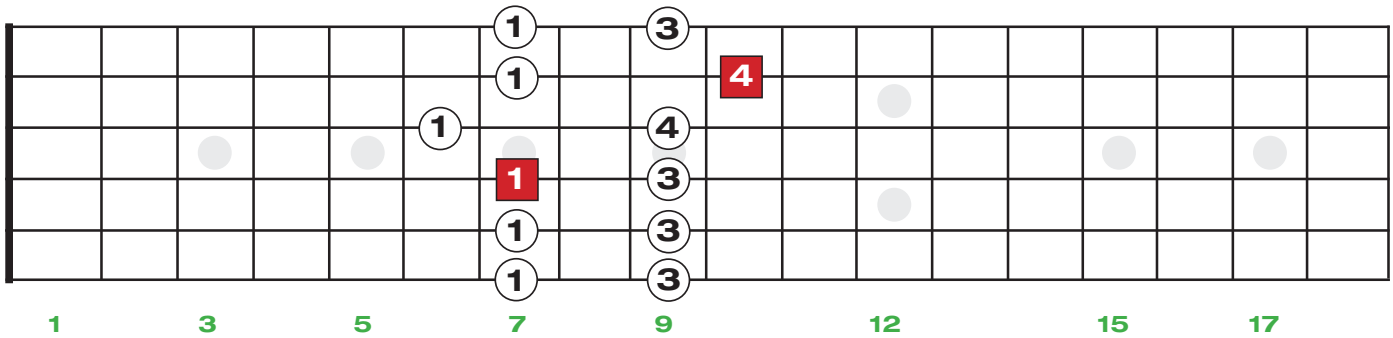
A Major Pentatonic Scale

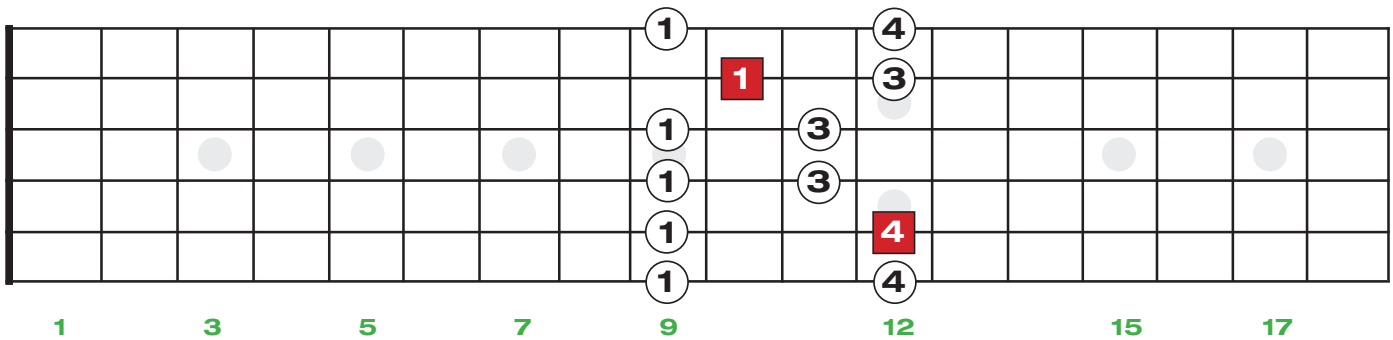
A Major Pentatonic Notes: A B C♯ E F♯ • Major Pentatonic Scale Formula: 1 2 3 5 6

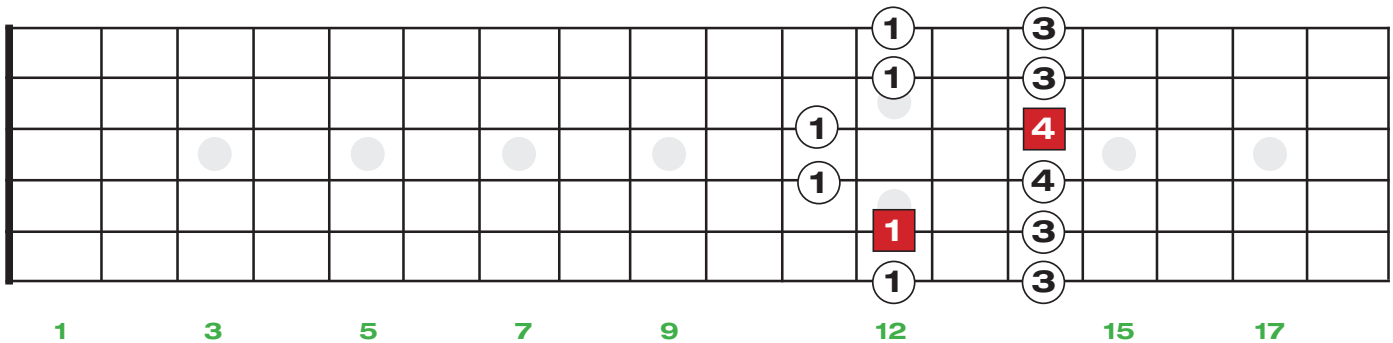
The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key









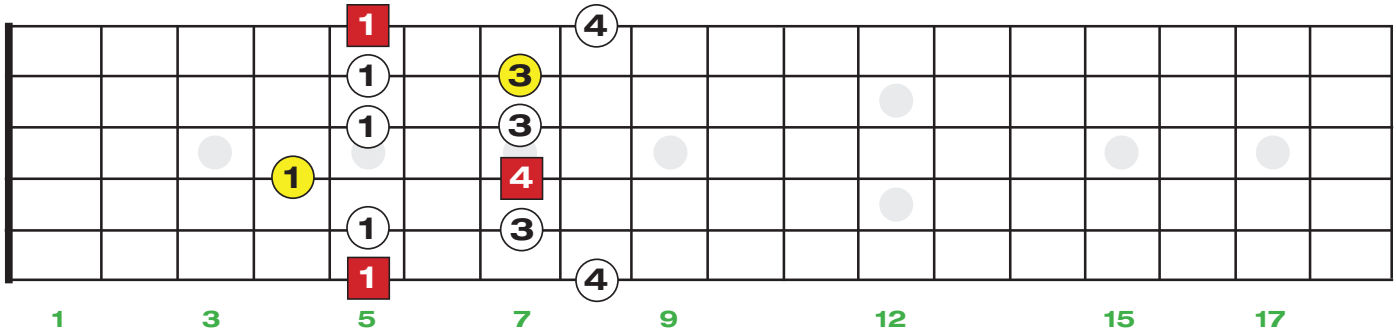


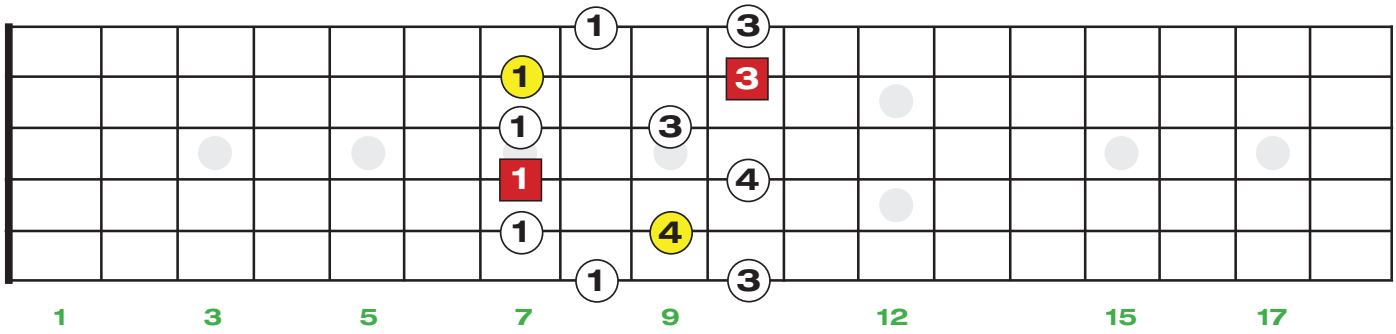
PRACTICE: Play each block over an A major drone. These are the same shapes as F♯ minor pentatonic, with a new root.

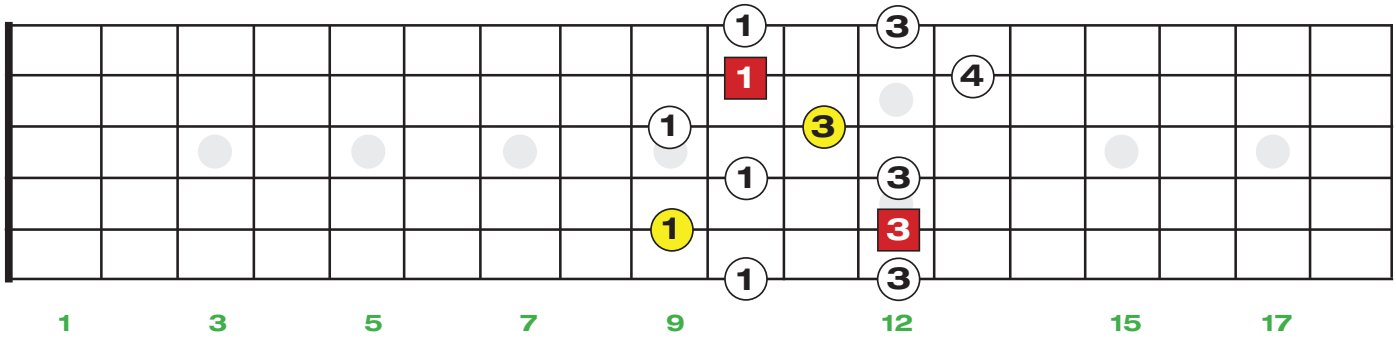
The “John Coltrane” Pentatonic Scale

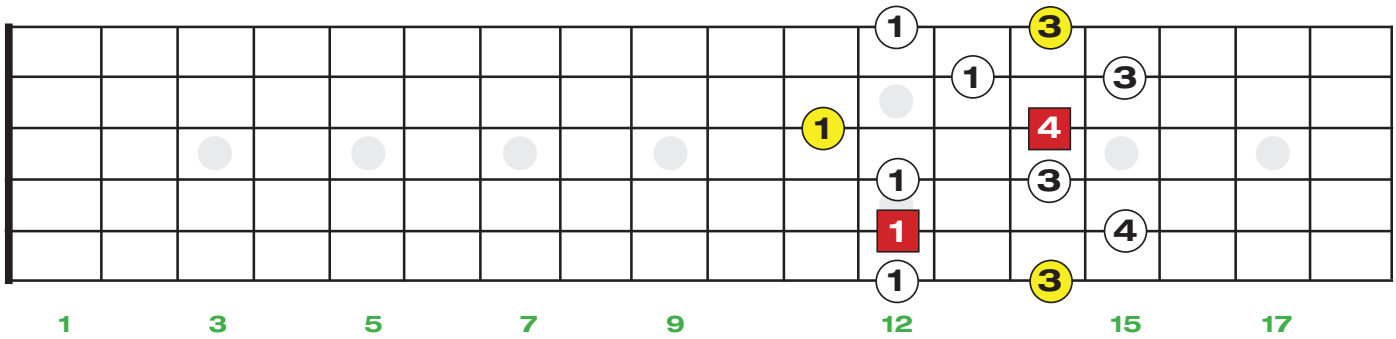
A “Coltrane” Notes: A C D E F♯ • Minor 6 Pentatonic Scale Formula: 1 ♭3 4 5 M6

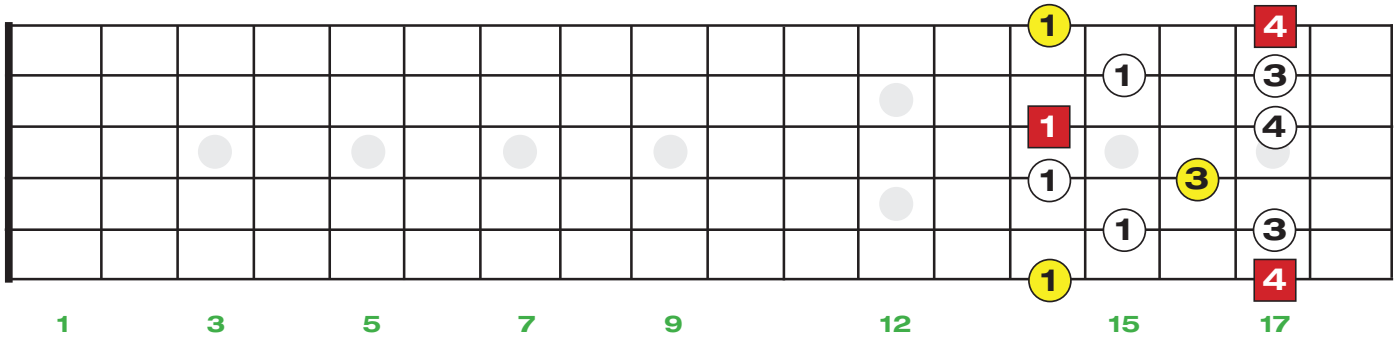
Altered Am Pentatonic replacing G(♭7) with the Major 6th(F♯) YELLOW CIRCLE. Red boxes indicate root note.









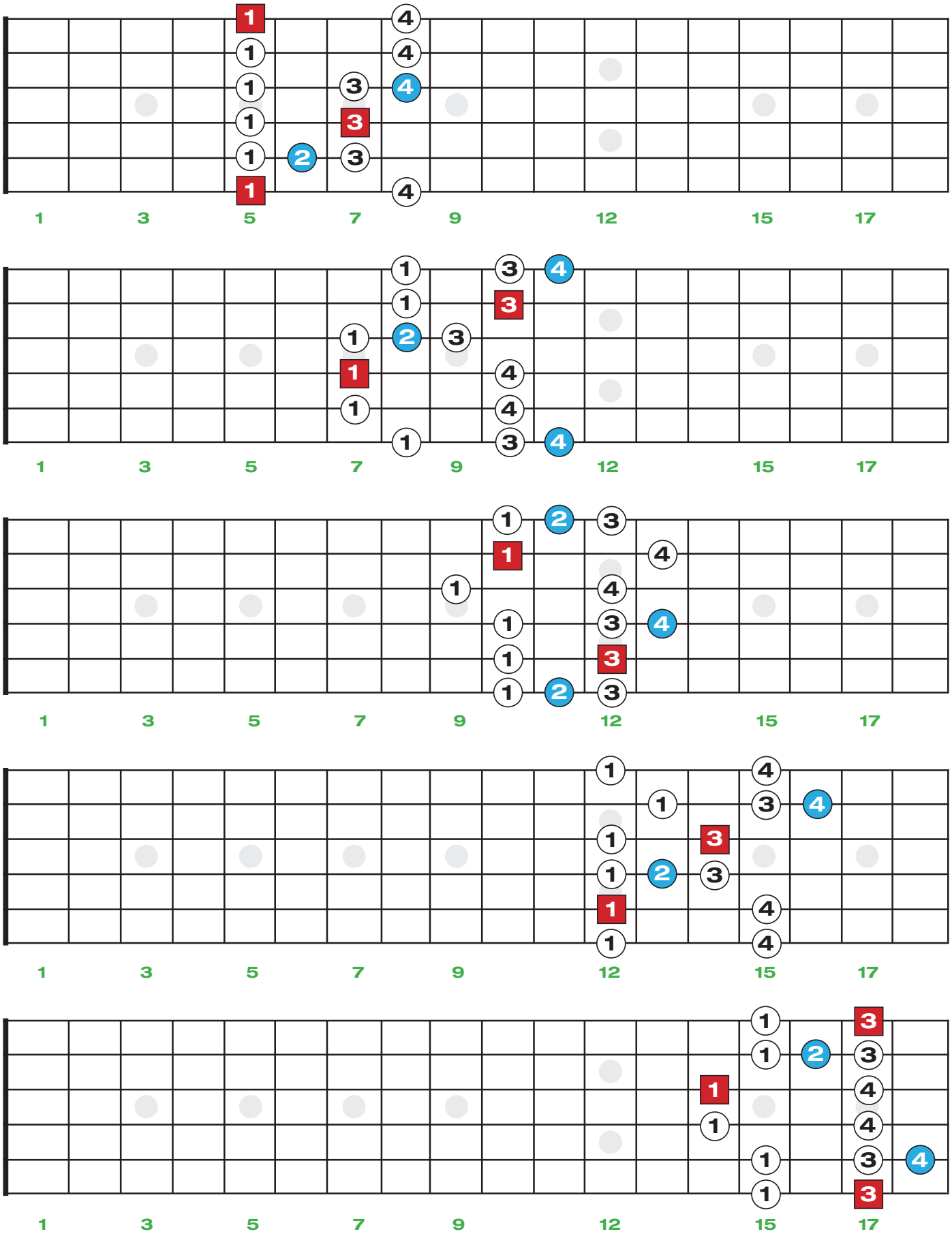


PRACTICE: Alternate between A minor pentatonic and this Coltrane version over an Am7 vamp to hear how the M6 (F♯) brightens the sound.

A Blues Scale

A Blues Notes: A C D E♭ E G • A Blues Scale Formula: 1 ♭3 4 ♭5 5 ♭7

The red square boxes are the root note of the key • The blue circle is the "Blue" note

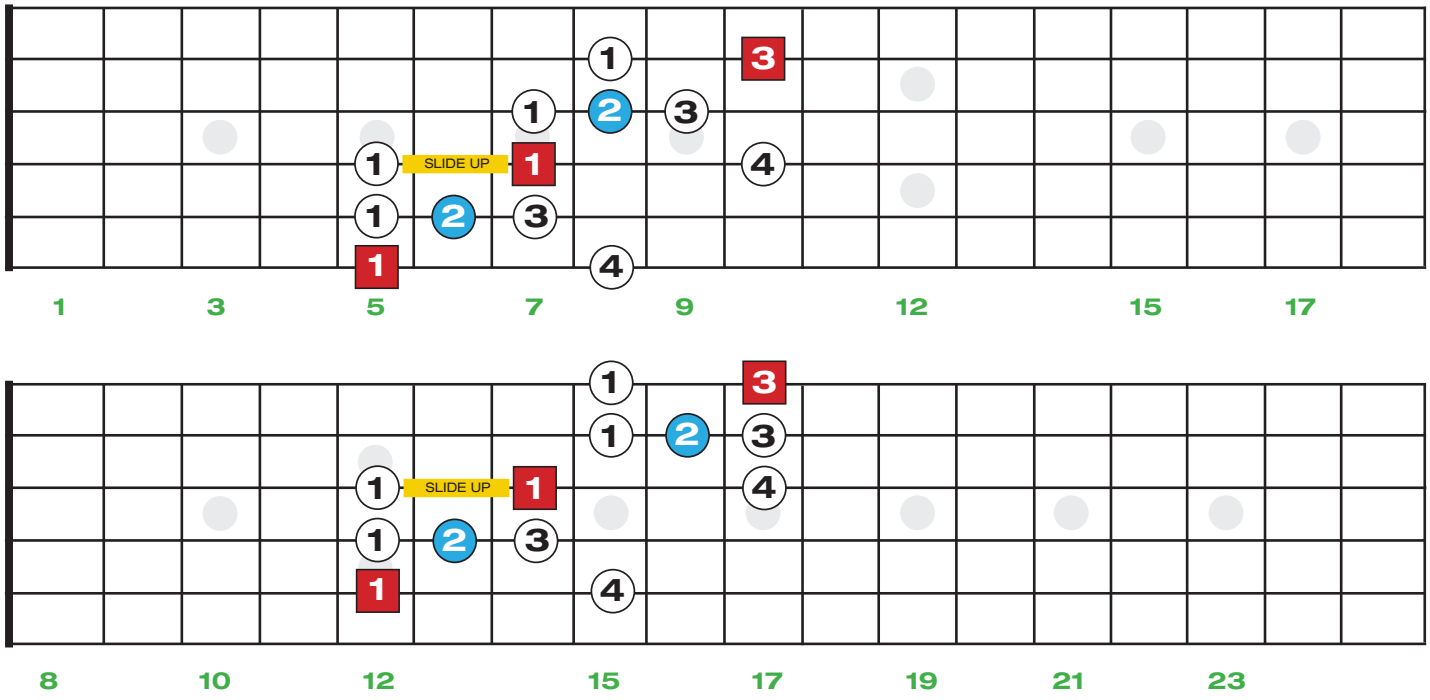


PRACTICE: Play each block up and down at 60 BPM, then slide or bend into the blue note (♭5) and listen to its tension resolve.

A Minor Blues Scale Connection Sequences

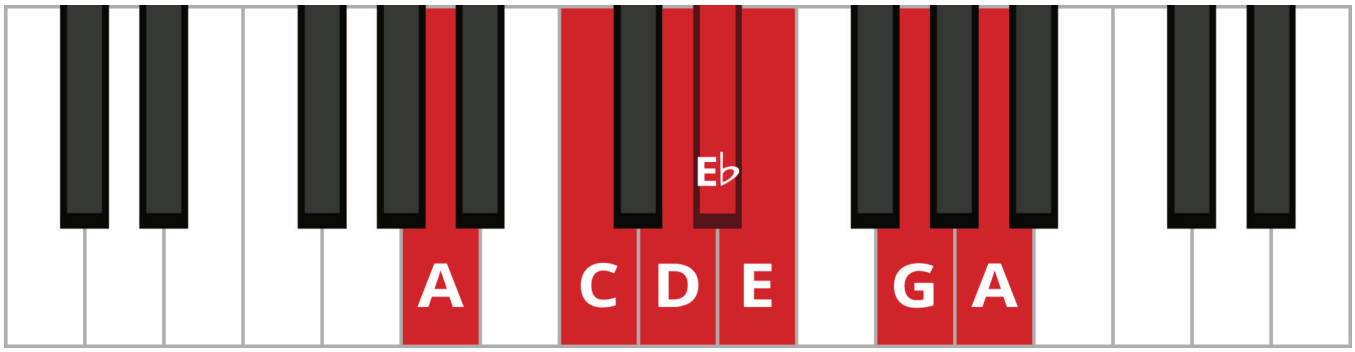
A Blues Notes: A C D E♭ E G • A Blues Scale Formula: 1 ♭3 4 ♭5 5 ♭7

The red square boxes are the root note of the key • The blue circle is the "Blue" note



A MINOR BLUES SCALE

The A Minor Blues Scale is built on this formula: 1, ♭3, 4, ♭5, 5, ♭7.



A MINOR PENTATONIC SCALE

The A Minor Pentatonic Scale is built on this formula: 1, ♭3, 4, 5, ♭7.



PRACTICE: Play each connection slowly and make the slide land in time on the root. Loop it until the shift feels effortless.

A Minor Blues Scale Connection Sequences

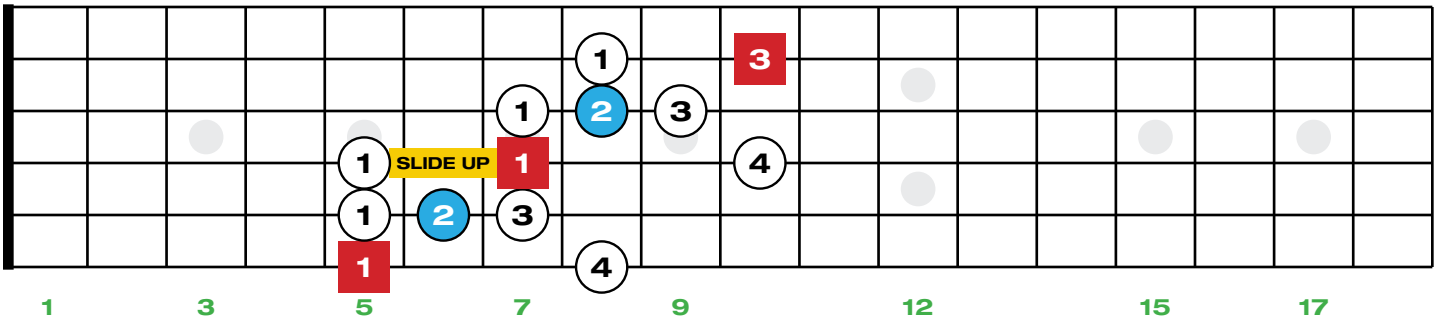
A Blues Notes: A C D E♭ E G • A Blues Scale Formula: 1 ♭3 4 ♭5 5 ♭7

The red square boxes are the root note of the key • The blue circle is the “Blue” note

Numbers show the fretting finger • **SLIDE UP** = slide the 1st finger from ♭7 (G) up to the root (A) to connect the blocks

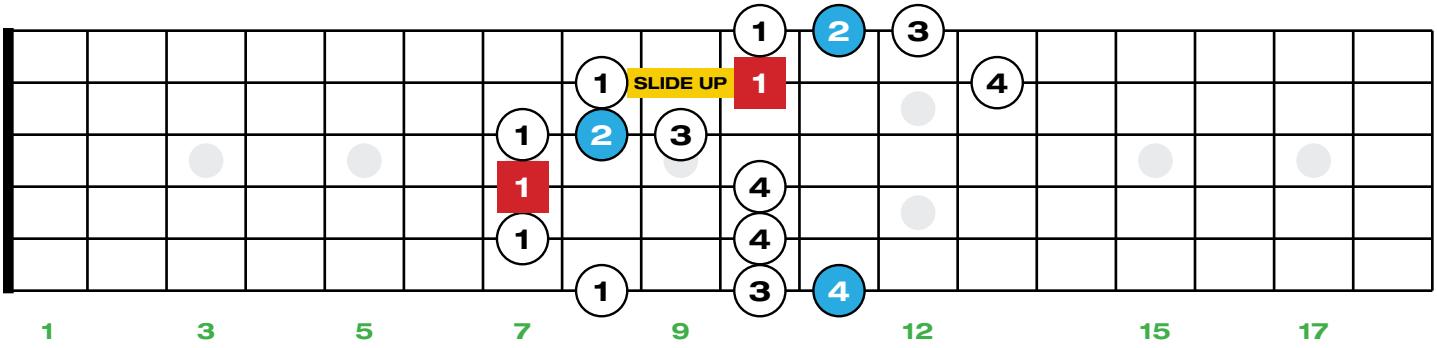
Block 1 → Block 2

Slide on the D string, fret 5 → 7 (G → A)



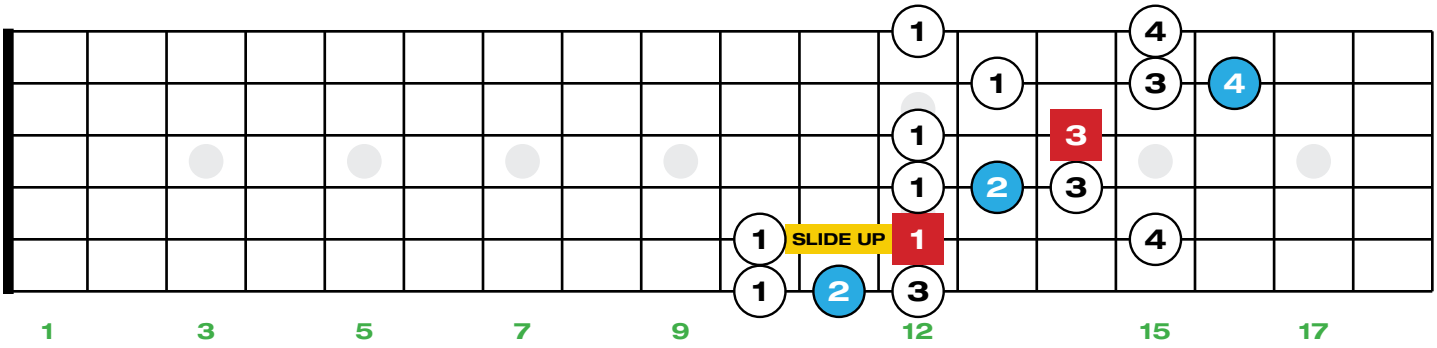
Block 2 → Block 3

Slide on the B string, fret 8 → 10 (G → A)



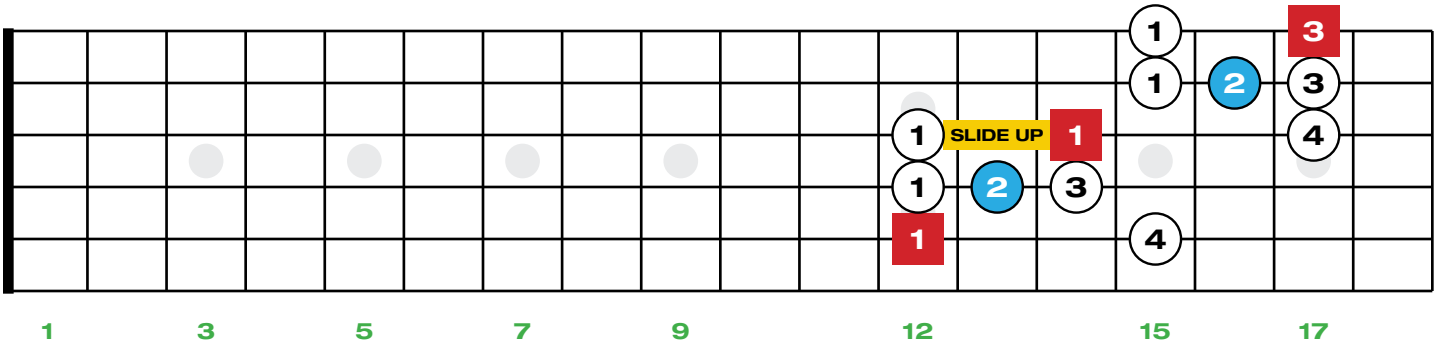
Block 3 → Block 4

Slide on the A string, fret 10 → 12 (G → A)



Block 4 → Block 5

Slide on the G string, fret 12 → 14 (G → A)

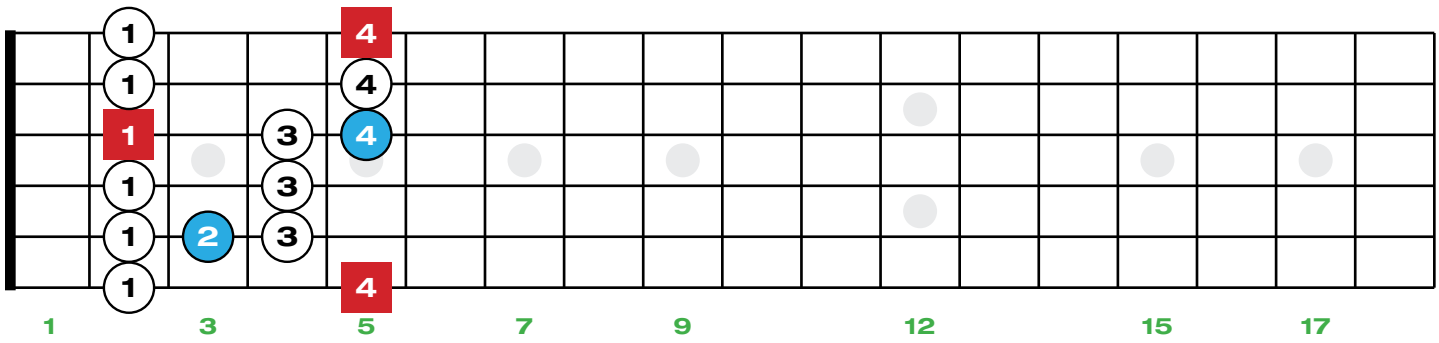


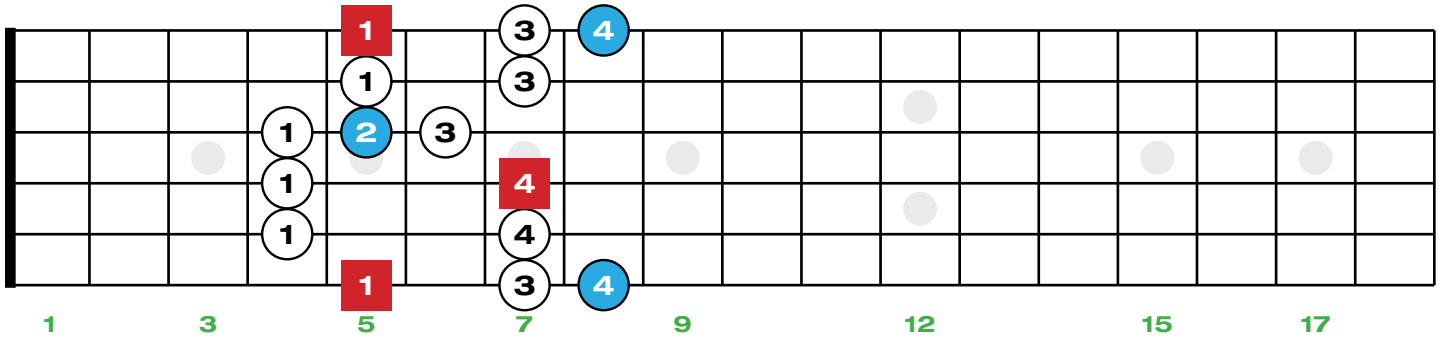
PRACTICE: Master one connection at a time, then chain all four to travel from Block 1 to Block 5 without stopping.

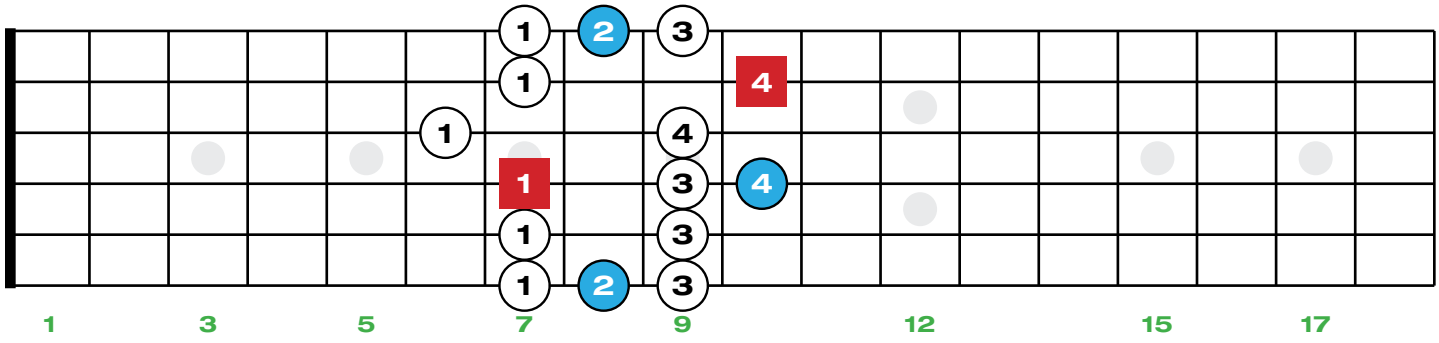
A Major Blues Scale

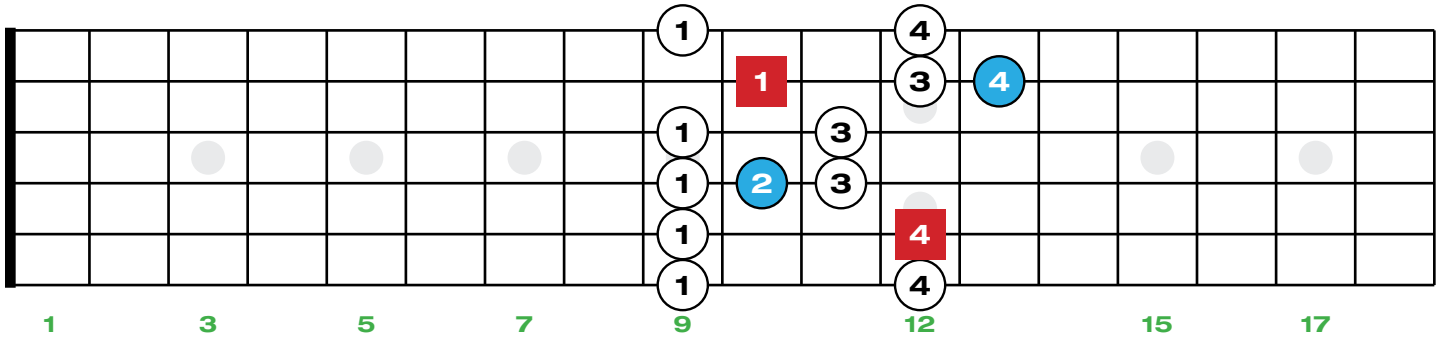
A Major Blues Notes: A B C C♯ E F♯ • Major Blues Scale Formula: 1 2 ♭3 3 5 6

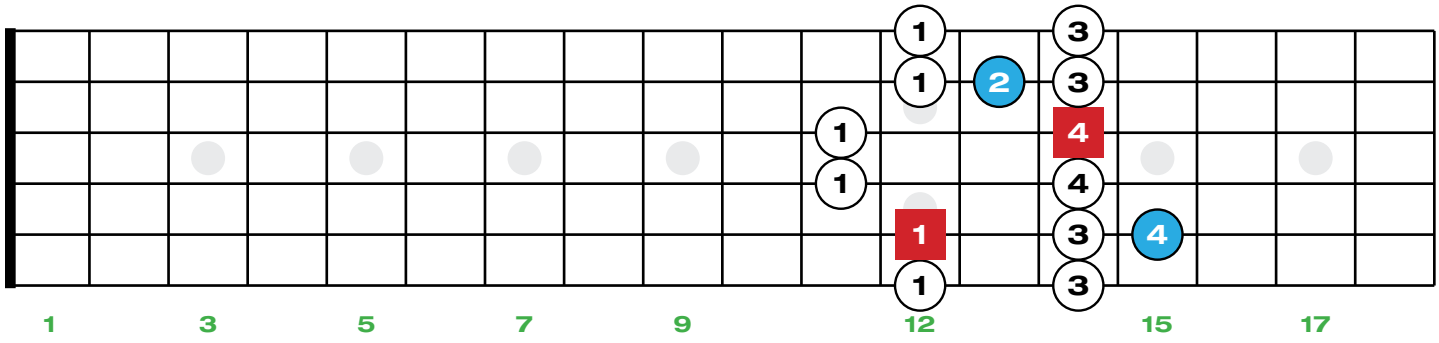
The red square boxes are the root note of the key • The blue circle is the "Blue" note











PRACTICE: The same five shapes as the A blues scale on page 41, three frets lower. Over an A7 vamp, slide the blue note C up to C♯.

The 12-Bar Blues

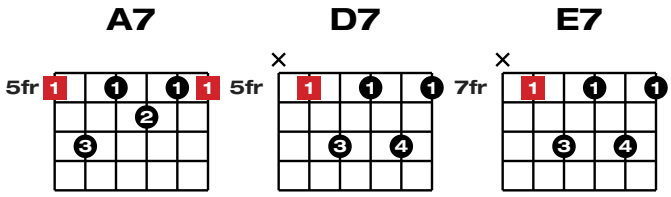
Three chords, twelve bars: the form behind blues, rock and roll and much of rock

A blues chorus is twelve bars long and uses the I, IV and V chords of the key, all played as dominant 7th chords. In the key of A they are A7, D7 and E7. Learn the form until you can feel where you are without counting.

1 **A7** I7 / / / /	2 **A7** I7 / / / /	3 **A7** I7 / / / /	4 **A7** I7 / / / /
5 **D7** IV7 / / / /	6 **D7** IV7 / / / /	7 **A7** I7 / / / /	8 **A7** I7 / / / /
9 **E7** V7 / / / /	10 **D7** IV7 / / / /	11 **A7** I7 / / / /	12 **E7** V7 / / / /

Quick change: many blues tunes move to D7 in bar 2 and return to A7 in bar 3. Bar 12 is the **turnaround**: the E7 pulls you back to bar 1 for the next chorus.

The three chords



D7 and E7 are one shape, two frets apart. Red squares mark each root.

What to solo with

Over the whole form: the A minor pentatonic (page 38) and the A blues scale (page 41).

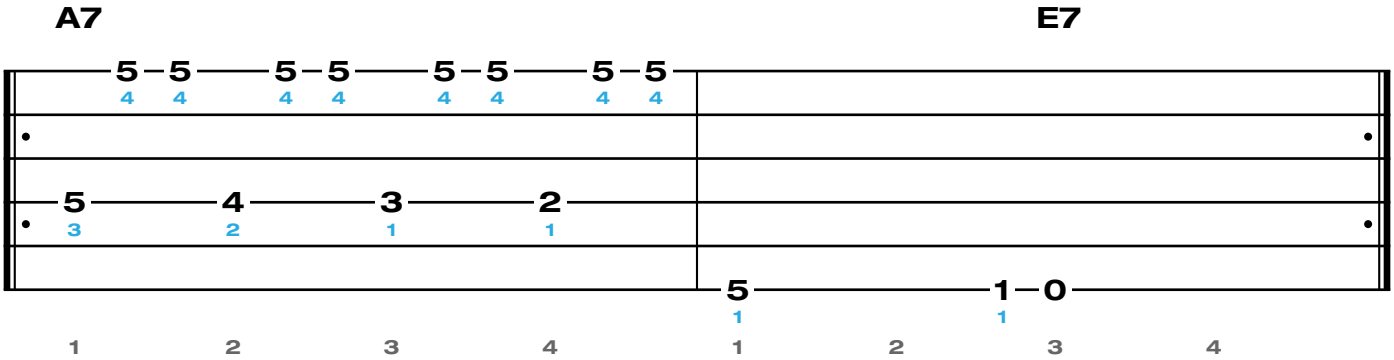
Over A7: add the A major pentatonic (page 39) or the A major blues scale (page 44) for a sweeter sound.

Over D7: go back to the minor shapes. The C♯ of the A major scales clashes with the C in D7.

Over E7: aim for the notes of the chord: E, G♯, B and D.

A classic turnaround for bars 11 and 12

Triplets: three even notes to each beat



The small numbers under the staff are the beats. The line on the D string walks down from the ♭7 (G) to the 5th (E) under a repeated high A. Bar 12 lands on a low A, then the bass drops through F to E, where the E7 arrives on beat 3.

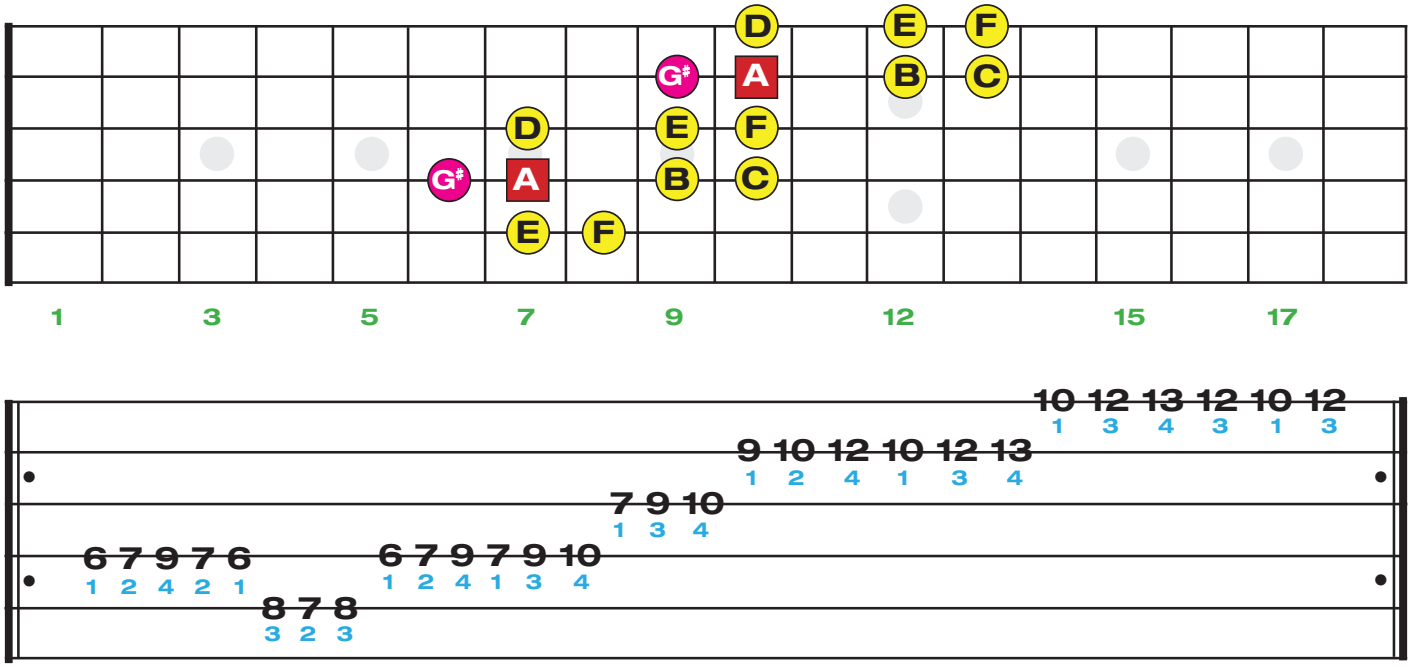
PRACTICE: Strum the form with a steady shuffle until you never lose your place, then record it and solo over your own backing track.

A Harmonic Minor Scale

A Harmonic Minor Notes: A B C D E F G♯ • Scale Formula: 1 2 ♭3 4 5 ♭6 7

"Diagonal Thinking" with the Harmonic Minor Scale

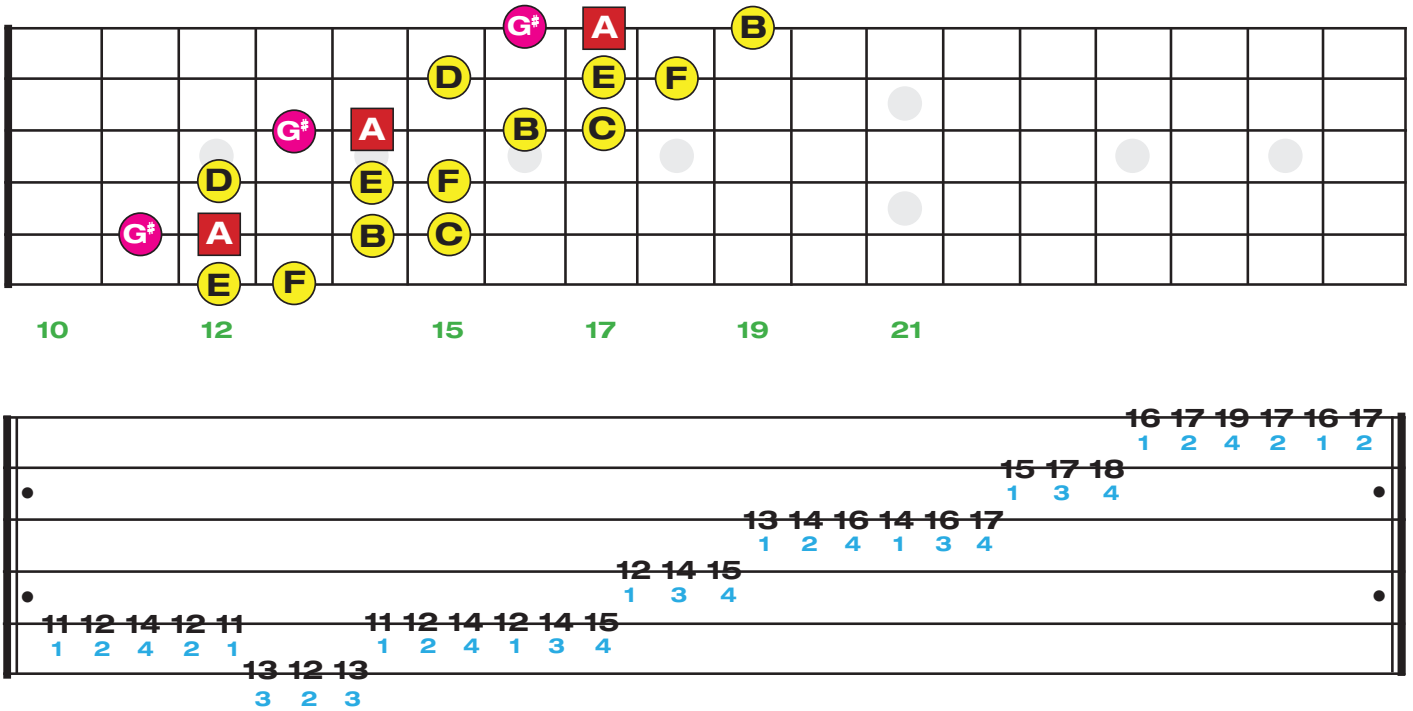
Use this Guitar Tab to expand linear and lateral thinking into *"Diagonal Thinking"*.
The idea is to start diagonally with G♯ Leading Tone as written and progress.



The Red Square boxes indicate the root note of the key.

To transpose to a new key move the Red Square to any new tonic location.

Fingers are the Blue Numbers. Tab is the Black Numbers.



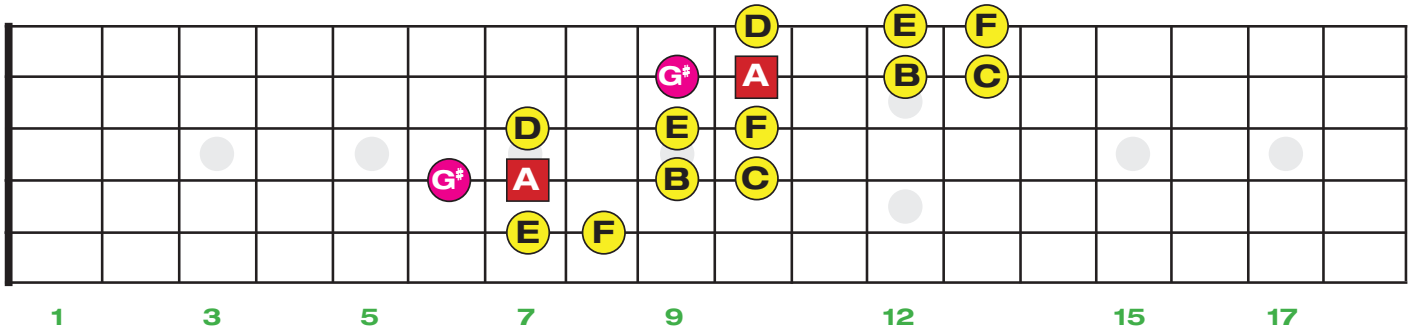
PRACTICE: Play in diagonal groups across the strings, then reverse direction. Aim for smooth, silent position shifts.

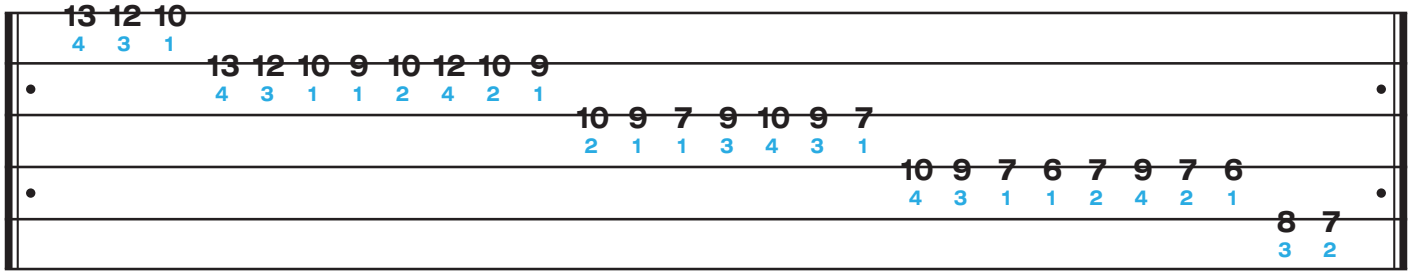
A Harmonic Minor — Descending

A Harmonic Minor Notes: A B C D E F G♯ • Scale Formula: 1 2 ♭3 4 5 ♭6 7

"Diagonal Thinking" in Reverse

The same diagonal pattern, descending from the highest note in a sequence of its own.
Follow the blue numbers closely: the fingerings change on the way down.

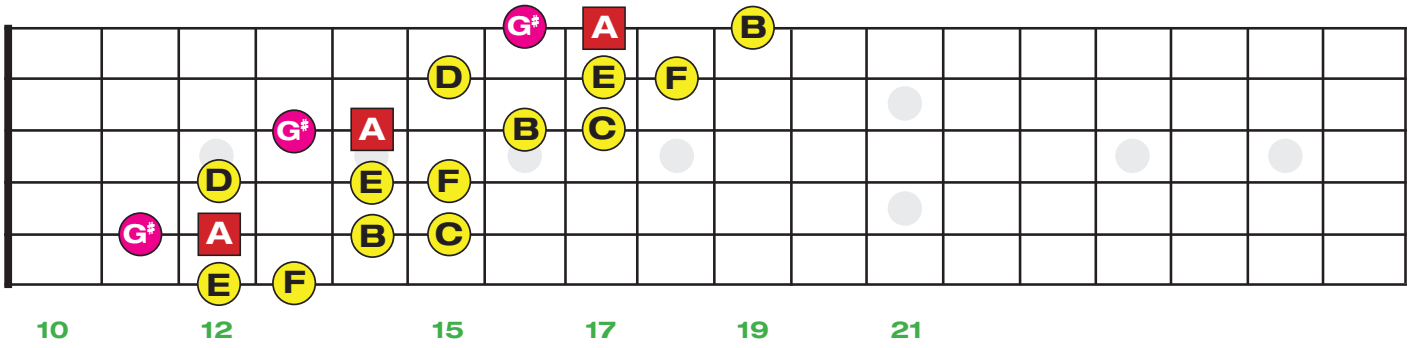


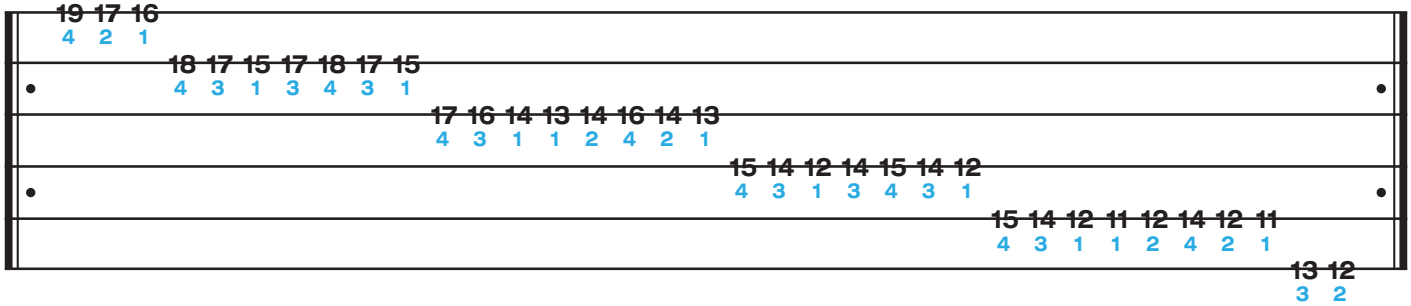


The Red Square boxes indicate the root note of the key.

To transpose to a new key move the Red Square to any new tonic location.

Fingers are the Blue Numbers. Tab is the Black Numbers.





PRACTICE: Play the ascending page straight into this descending page without stopping, keeping every shift smooth and in time.

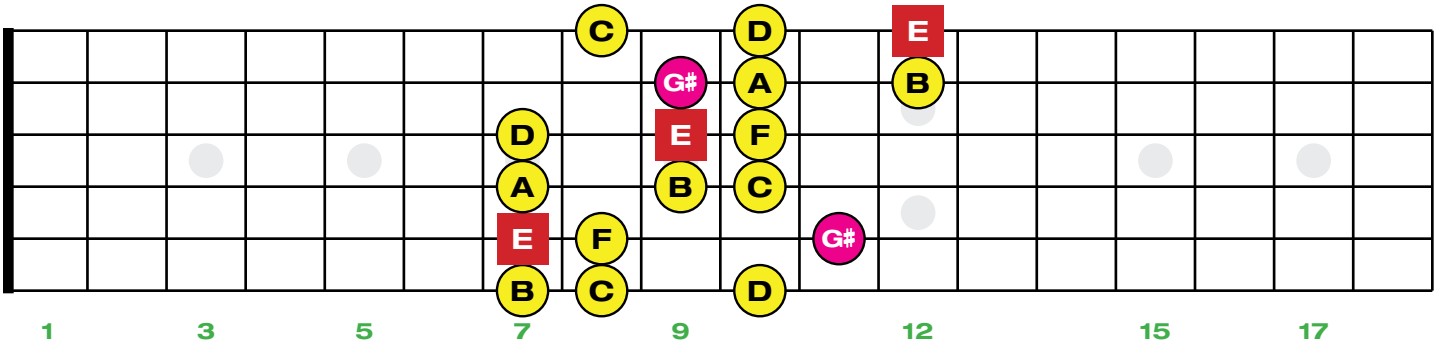
E Phrygian Dominant Scale

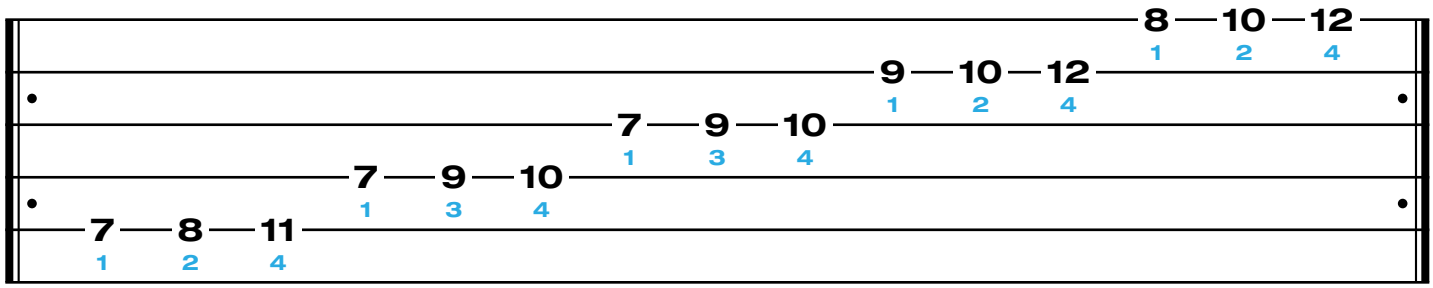
E Phrygian Dominant Notes: E F G♯ A B C D • Scale Formula: 1 ♭2 3 4 5 ♭6 ♭7

The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key • Magenta = G♯, the major 3rd

Pattern 1 • Root on the 5th string

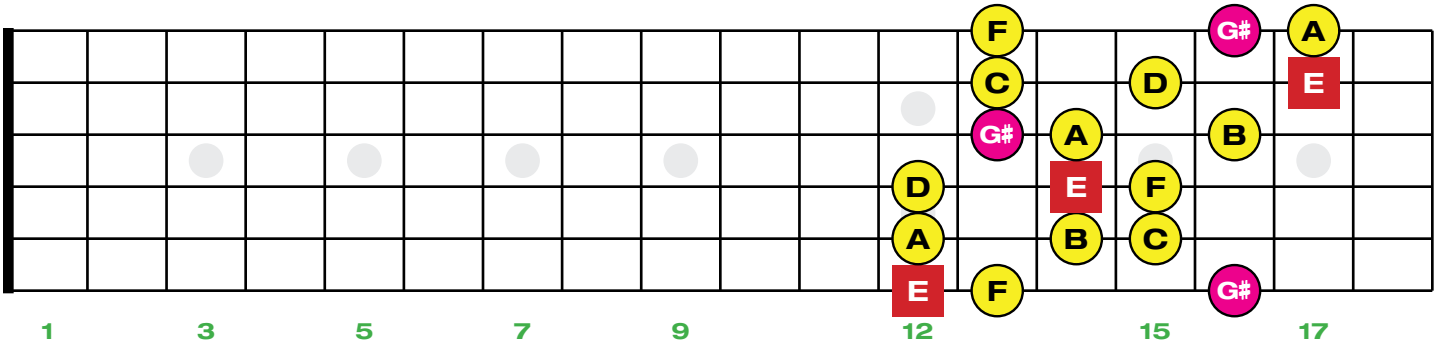
7th position

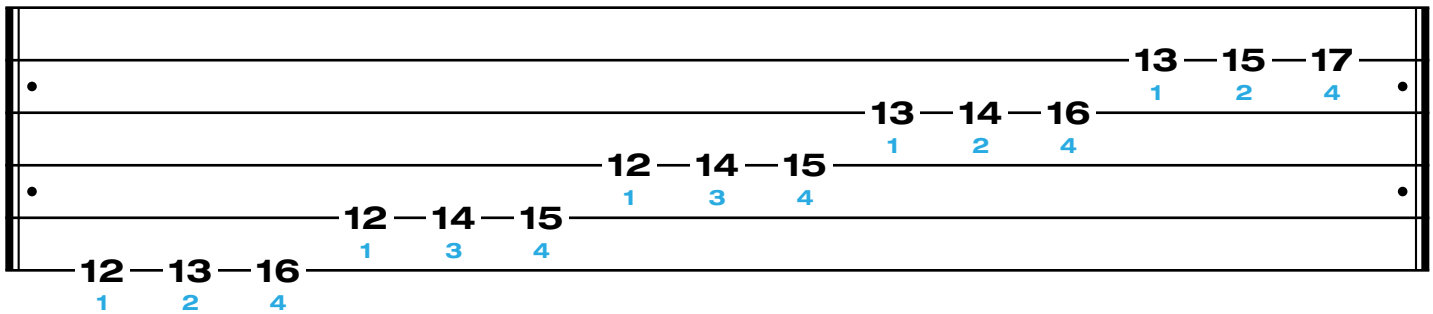




Pattern 2 • Root on the 6th string

12th position





This is the fifth mode of A harmonic minor (pages 46–47): the same seven notes, with E as home. Play it over **E7** or **E7♭9** on its way to A minor, as in the II-V-I on page 30, or over a held E major chord for the Spanish and flamenco sound described on page 114. The wide step from F to G♯ is the heart of the scale.

PRACTICE: Hold an E drone and play the scale slowly. Lean on F and G♯, then resolve the phrase to an A minor chord.

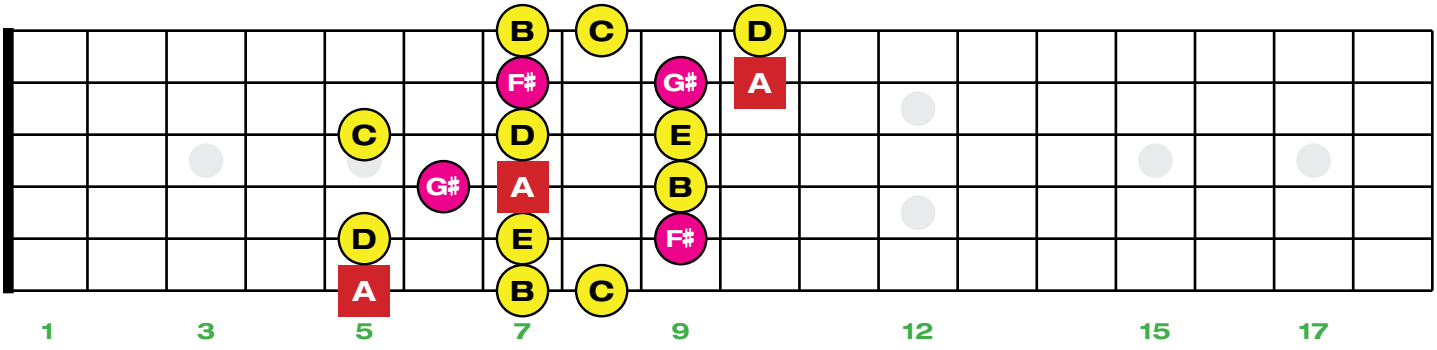
A Melodic Minor Scale

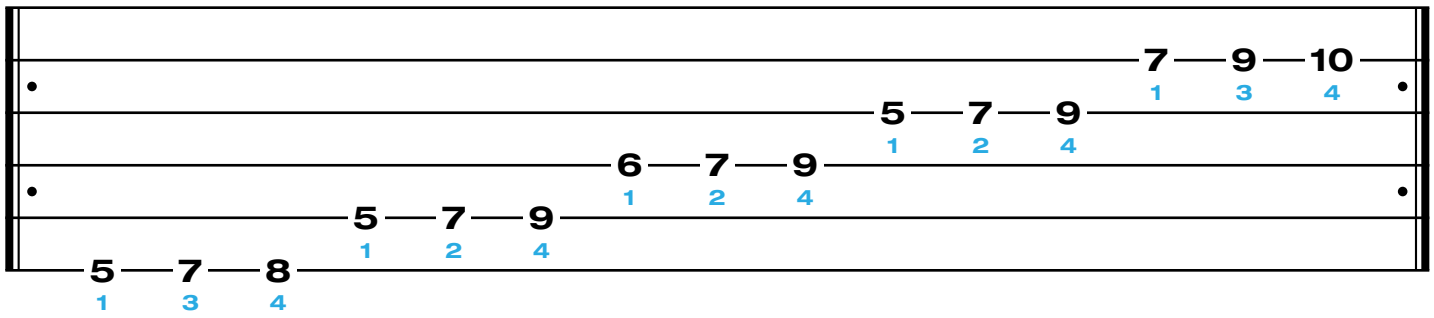
A Melodic Minor Notes: A B C D E F♯ G♯ • Scale Formula: 1 2 ♭3 4 5 6 7

The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key • Magenta = F♯ and G♯, the raised 6th and 7th

Pattern 1 • Root on the 6th string

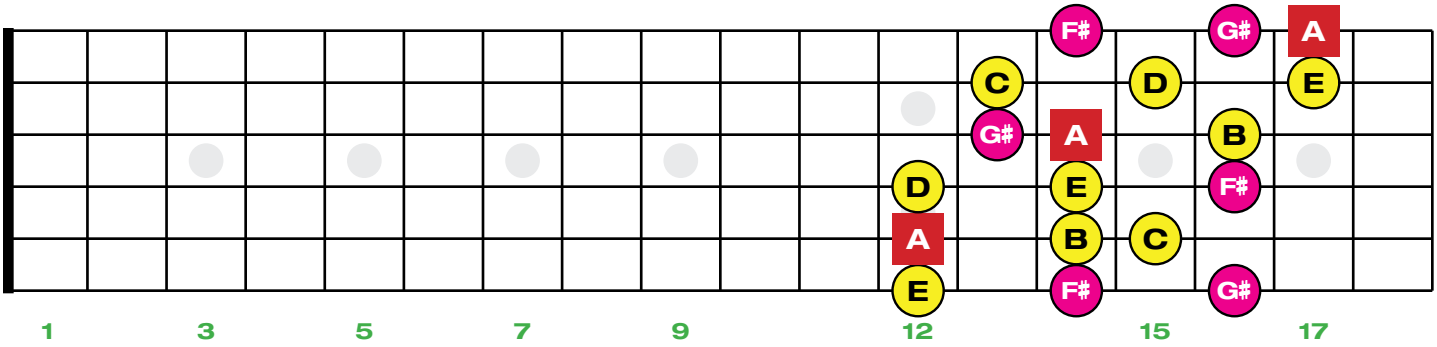
5th position

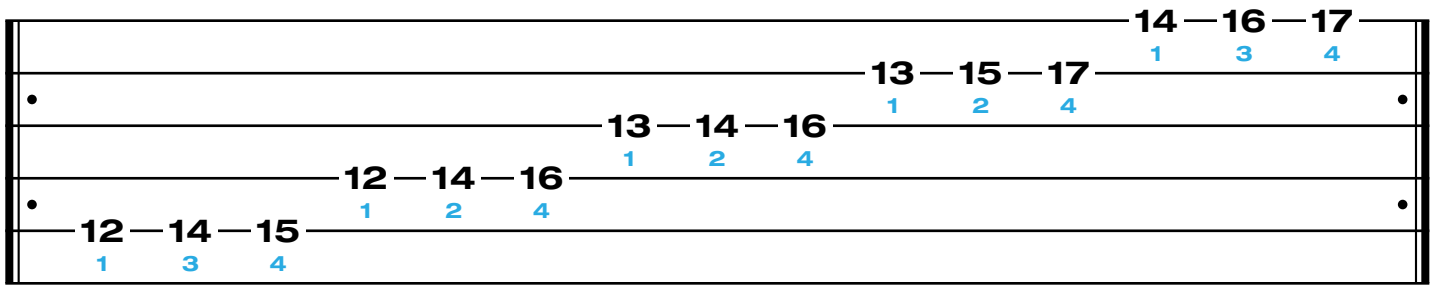




Pattern 2 • Root on the 5th string

12th position





Think of it as a major scale with a minor 3rd, or as natural minor with the 6th and 7th raised. Classical music raises them only on the way up; jazz and rock use this form in both directions, which is why it is also called the **jazz minor**. Play it over a minor chord that feels like home: Am6, Am(maj7), or the Am6 in “I Don’t Mind” on page 120.

PRACTICE: Over an A minor drone, play A natural minor and then A melodic minor. Listen to F♯ and G♯ brighten the top of the scale.

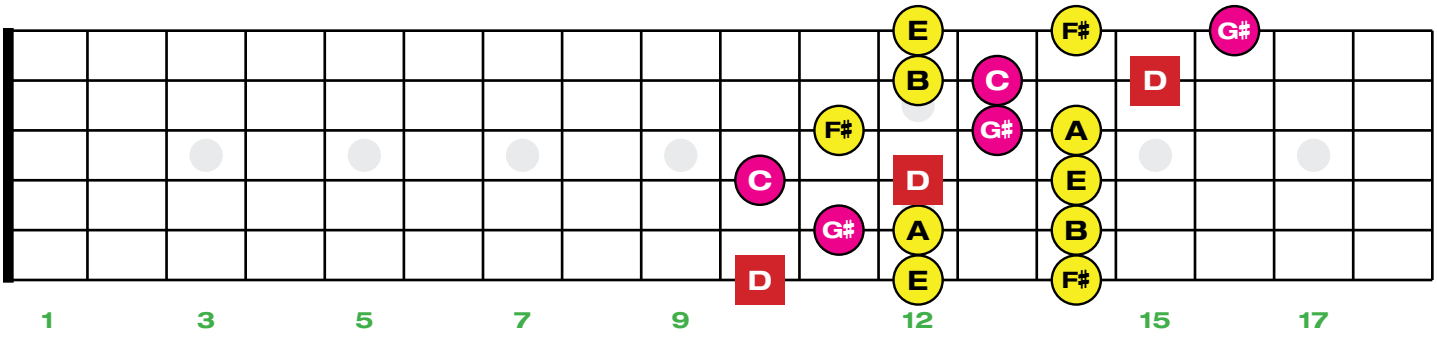
Lydian Dominant & Altered Scales

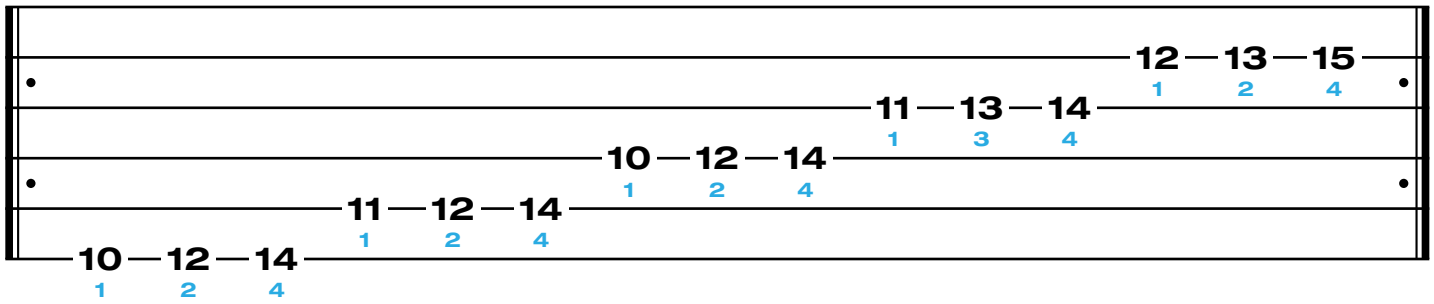
Two modes of A melodic minor: the same seven notes, heard from a new root

D Lydian Dominant

Fits D7, D9 and D7♯11

1 2 3 ♯4 5 6 ♭7 • D E F♯ G♯ A B C

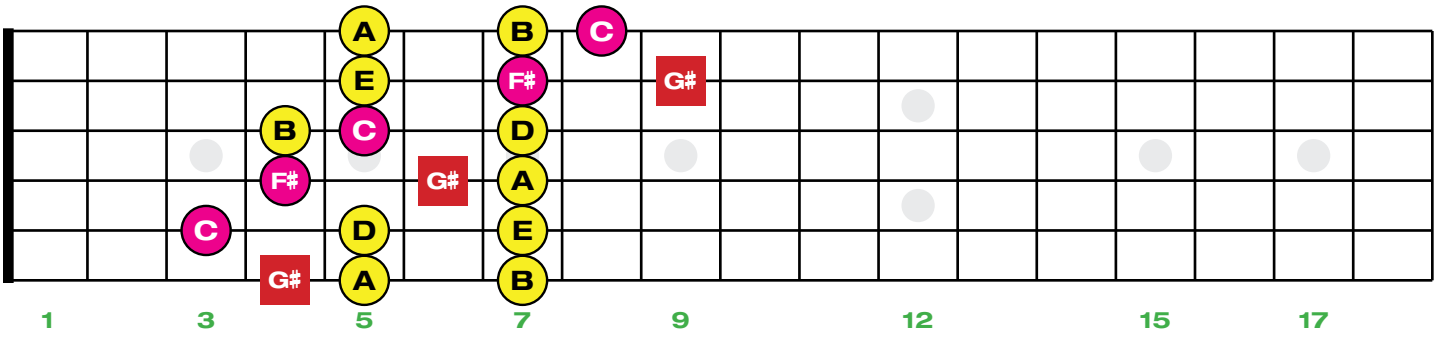


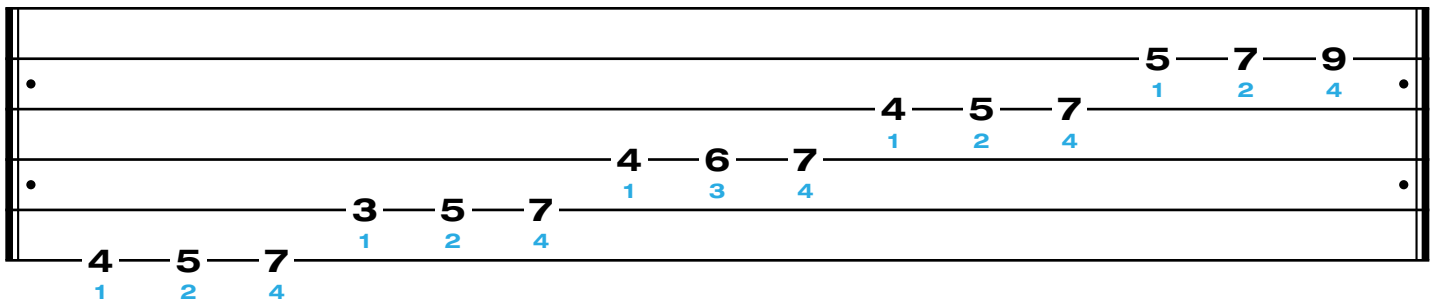


G♯ (A♭) Altered

Fits A♭7♯5, A♭7♯9 and A♭7♭9

1 ♭9 ♯9 3 ♭5 ♯5 ♭7 • G♯ A B C D E F♯





Magenta marks the notes that set each scale apart: the ♯4 and ♭7 of Lydian dominant, and the 3rd and ♭7 that hold the altered scale to its chord while every other note is an altered tension. **Shortcuts:** for Lydian dominant, play melodic minor from the 5th of the chord (D7: A melodic minor). For the altered scale, play melodic minor a half step above the root (A♭7: A melodic minor; E7: F melodic minor).

PRACTICE: Loop two bars of D7 and two bars of A♭7♯5 and play A melodic minor over both: one scale, two very different colors.

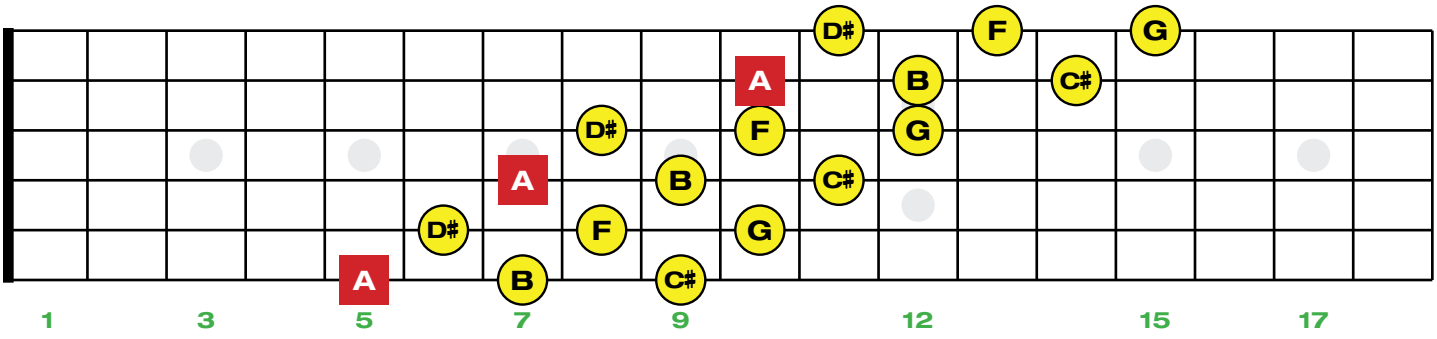
Whole Tone & Diminished Scales

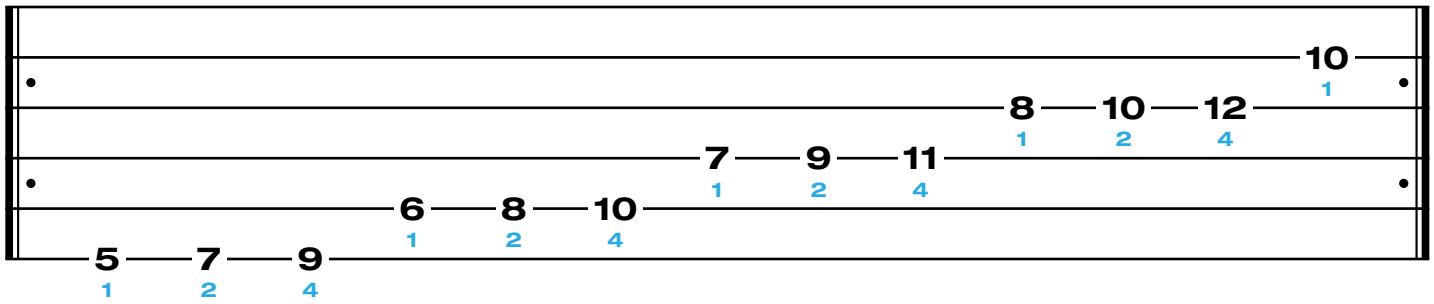
Two symmetrical scales, each built from one repeating pattern of steps

A Whole Tone

Fits A7♯5, A9♯5 and A augmented

1 2 3 ♯4 ♯5 ♭7 • A B C♯ D♯ F G

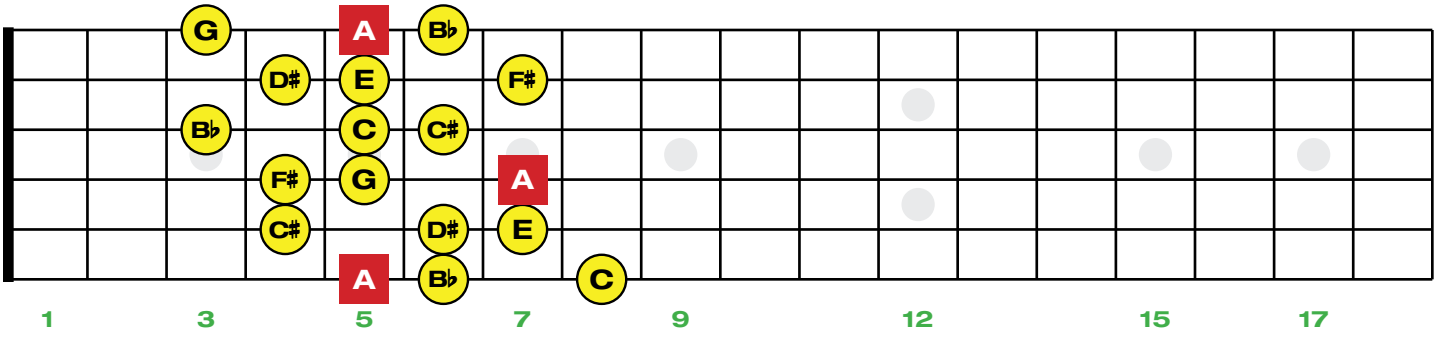


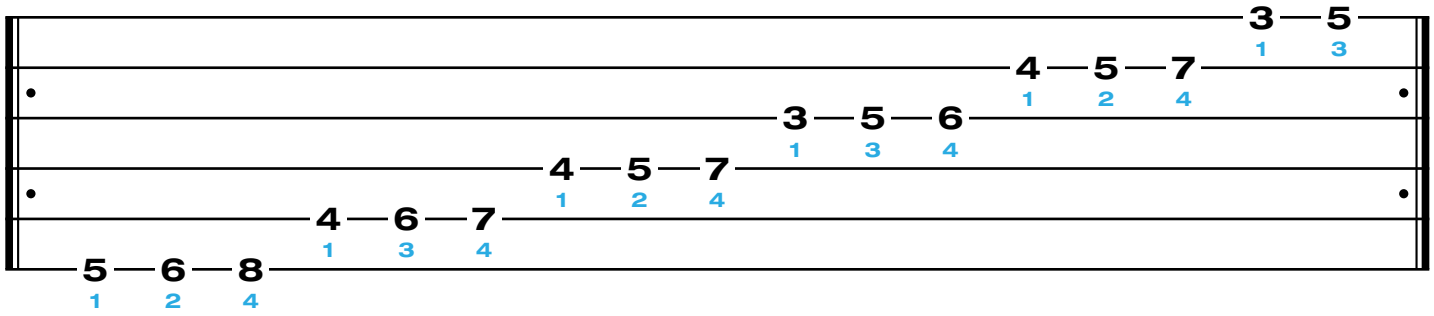


A Half-Whole Diminished

Fits A7♭9, A7♯9 and A13♭9

1 ♭2 ♯2 3 ♯4 5 6 ♭7 • A B♭ C C♯ D♯ E F♯ G





Whole tone: every step is a whole step, so only two whole tone scales exist: this one, and the one a half step higher (A♭ B♭ C D E G♭). The same three-note shape repeats on every string. **Diminished:** half step, whole step, over and over. It repeats every three frets, so this is also C, E♭ and F♯ half-whole diminished. Start from its second note and you have the B♭ whole-half scale, the one to play over a B♭ diminished 7th chord (for the diminished 7th arpeggio, see page 58).

PRACTICE: Over an A7 drone play A Mixolydian, then A whole tone, then A half-whole diminished, and hear the tension rise each time.

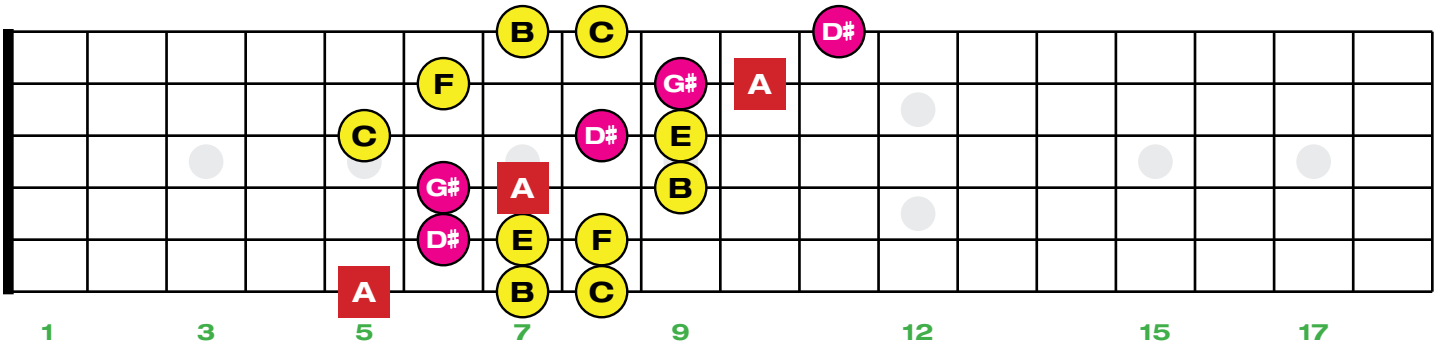
A Hungarian Minor Scale

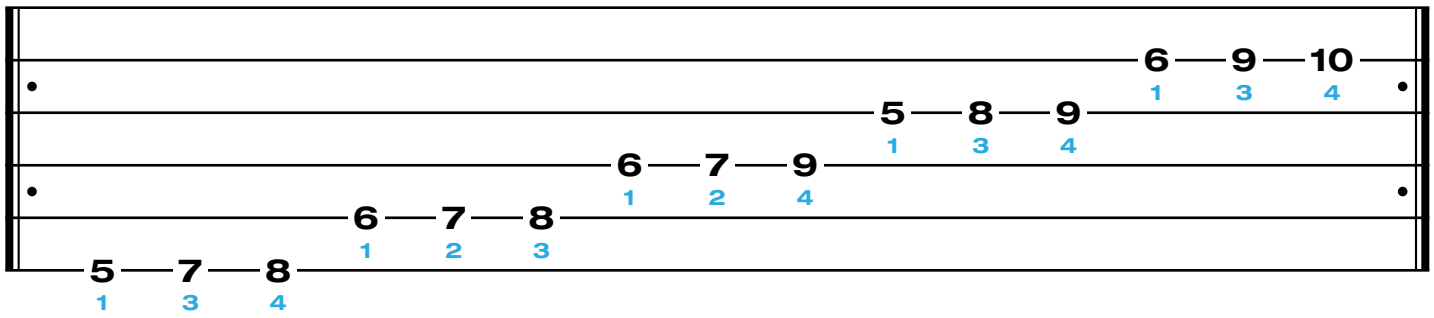
A Hungarian Minor Notes: A B C D♯ E F G♯ • Scale Formula: 1 2 ♭3 ♯4 5 ♭6 7

The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key • Magenta = D♯ and G♯, the raised 4th and 7th

Pattern 1 • Root on the 6th string

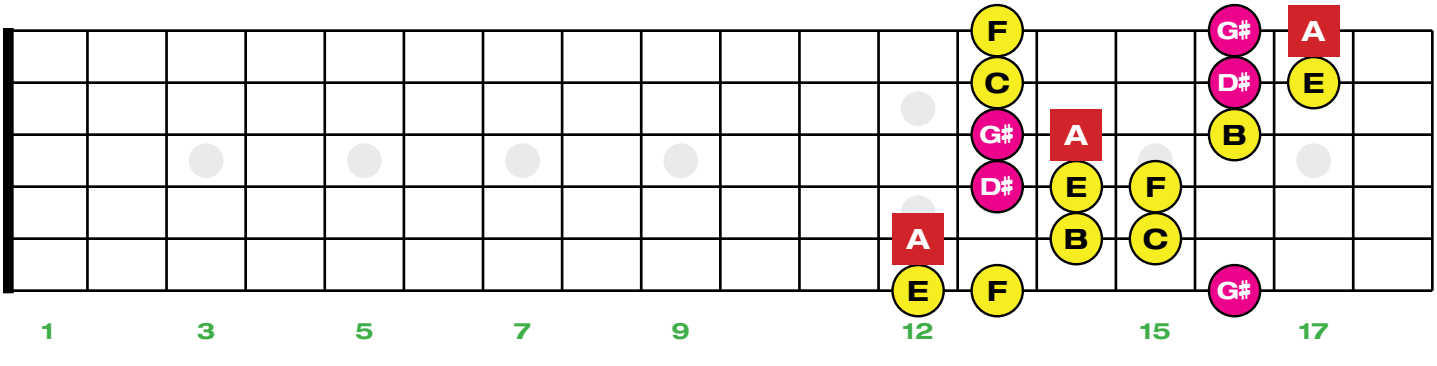
5th position

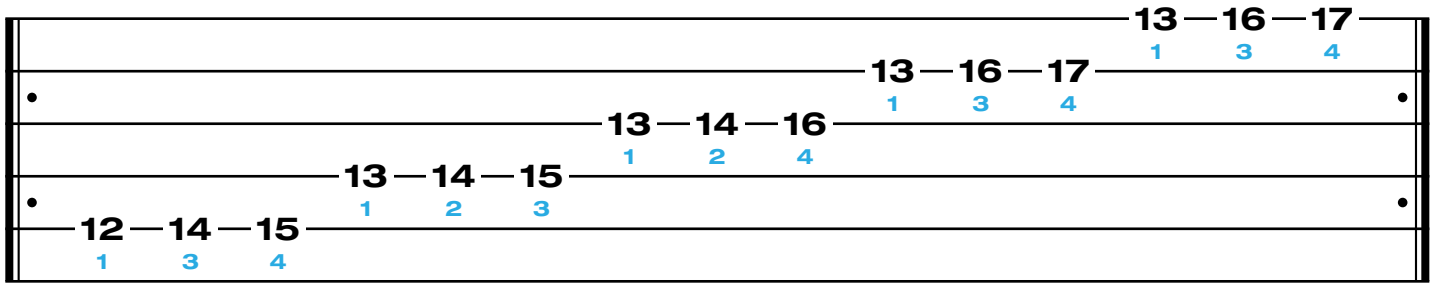




Pattern 2 • Root on the 5th string

12th position





Take the A harmonic minor scale from pages 46–47 and raise the 4th from D to D♯. The scale now has two wide steps, C to D♯ and F to G♯, with half steps packed around them, and that gives it a dark, dramatic sound heard in neoclassical rock, film scores and Eastern European folk music. It is also known as the **double harmonic minor**. Play it over an A minor chord or an A5 power chord.

PRACTICE: Play A harmonic minor, then change every D to D♯. Slide slowly into D♯ and G♯ to bring out the two wide steps.

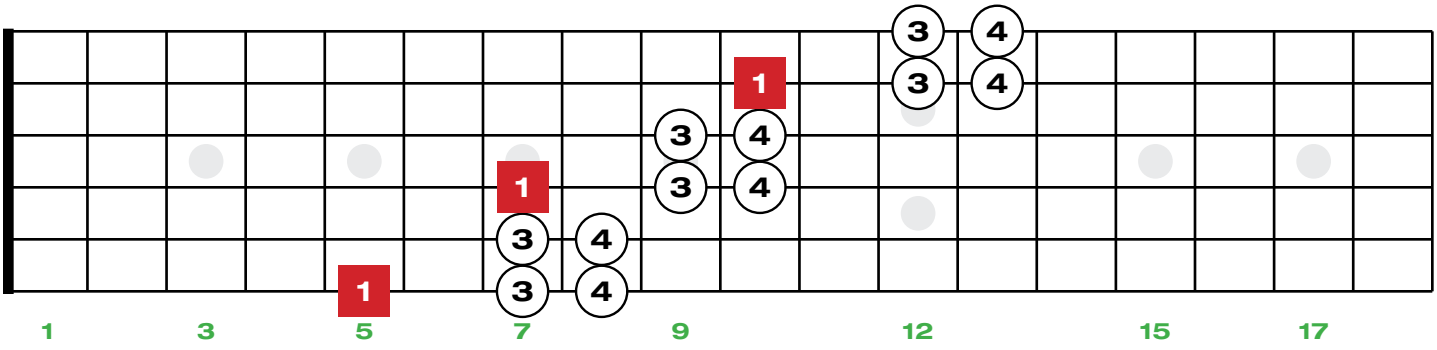
Japanese Pentatonic Scales

Five-note scales with half steps and wide leaps: three exotic colors from one root

The red square boxes are the root note of the key • The numbers show the fretting finger

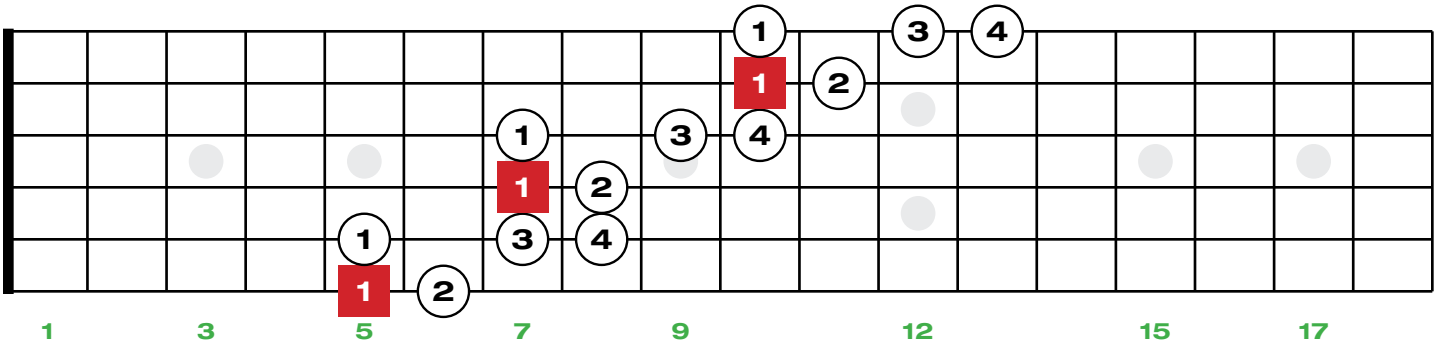
A Hirajoshi 1 2 ♭3 5 ♭6 • A B C E F

dark and haunting



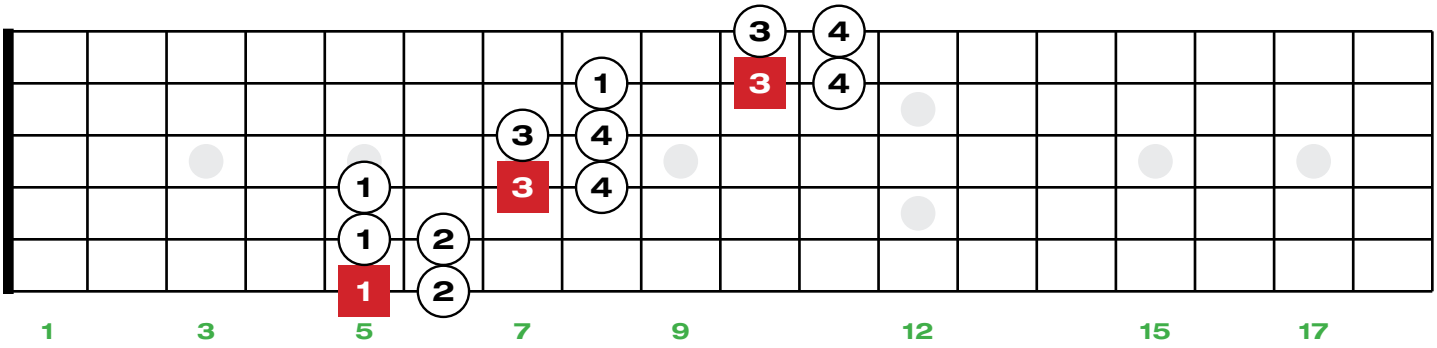
A In (Sakura) 1 ♭2 4 5 ♭6 • A B♭ D E F

tense, delicate



A Iwato 1 ♭2 4 ♭5 ♭7 • A B♭ D E♭ G

unsettled, mysterious



The minor pentatonic has no half steps, which is why it sounds so smooth. These scales do, and the half steps next to wide leaps are what give them their Japanese koto sound. Each pattern climbs two octaves in a repeating shape of two and three notes per string, shifting up the neck as it goes.

The three scales are also modes of one another: the five notes of A Hirajoshi (A B C E F) are the notes of **E In** and of **B Iwato**. Start the same notes from a different home and the mood changes, just as it does with the seven major modes on page 78. Names for these scales differ from book to book, so trust the formulas.

PRACTICE: Play each scale over an A drone or an A5 power chord, slowly, and let every half step ring against the root.


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ESSENTIAL ARPEGGIOS



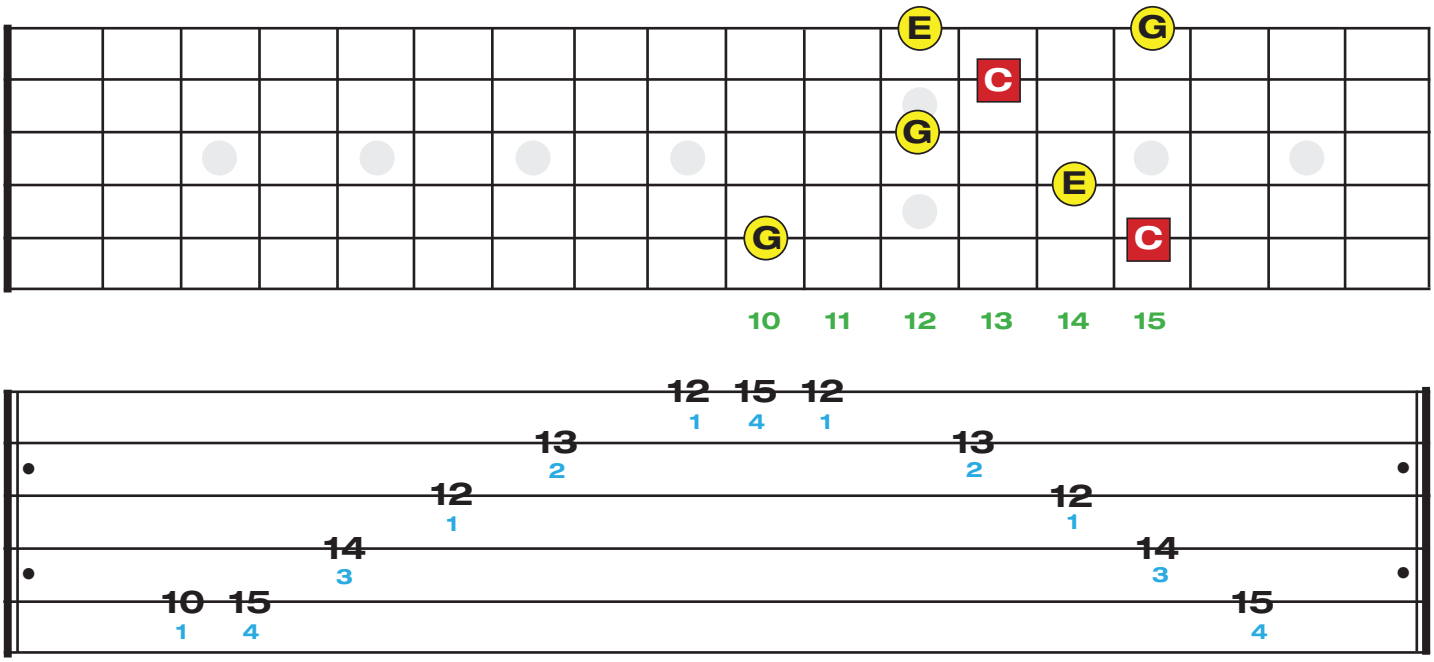
C Major Arpeggio

C Major Arpeggio Notes: C E G • C Major Arpeggio Formula: 1 3 5

To transpose to a new key move the red square to a new tonic location.

The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key

Fingers are the Blue Numbers. Tab is the Black Numbers.



The Major Scale

The Major Scale is the foundation of almost all western music.

The Major Scale Formula:

W W H W W W H

The Major Scale is made up of a series of whole-steps (W) and half-steps (H).
This is the order of whole-steps and half-steps that make up the C Major Scale.

The Notes of the C Major Scale

We apply the Major Scale formula to the musical alphabet.
The rest of the notes are defined by applying the Major Scale formula.

C D E F G A B C

W W H W W W H

The Degrees of the C Major Scale:

1C 2D 3E 4F 5G 6A 7B

PRACTICE: Let every note ring separately, then move the red square to transpose the arpeggio into all 12 keys.

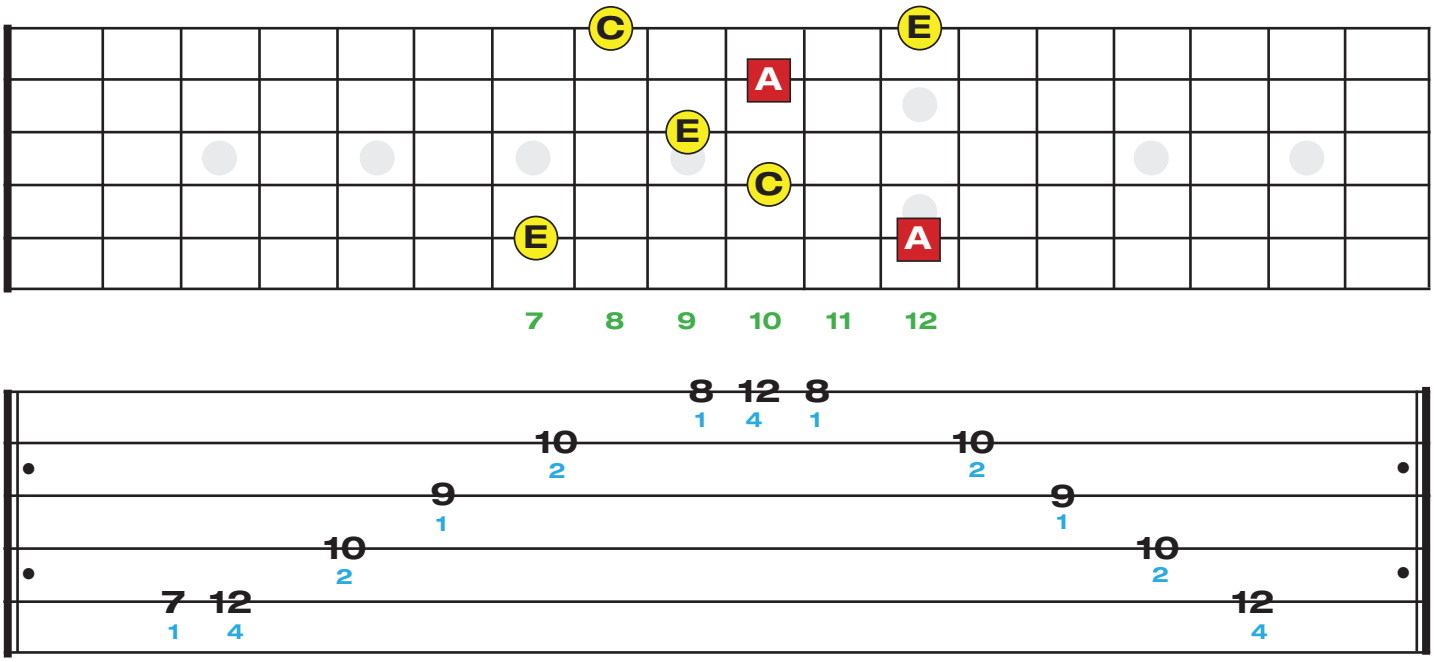
A Minor Arpeggio

A Minor Arpeggio Notes: A C E • A Minor Arpeggio Formula: 1 ♭3 5

To transpose to a new key move the red square to a new tonic location.

The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key

Fingers are the Blue Numbers. Tab is the Black Numbers.



The Minor Scale
The Minor Scale is a seven note scale.

The Minor Scale Formula:

W H W W H W W

The Minor Scale is made up of a series of whole-steps (W) and half-steps (H).
This is the order of whole-steps and half-steps that make up the A Minor Scale.

The Notes of the A Minor Scale
We apply the Minor Scale formula to the musical alphabet.
The rest of the notes are defined by applying the Minor Scale formula.

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	A
W	H	W	W	H	W	W	

The Degrees of the A Minor Scale:

1A 2B 3C 4D 5E 6F 7G

PRACTICE: Let every note ring separately, then move the red square to transpose the arpeggio into all 12 keys.

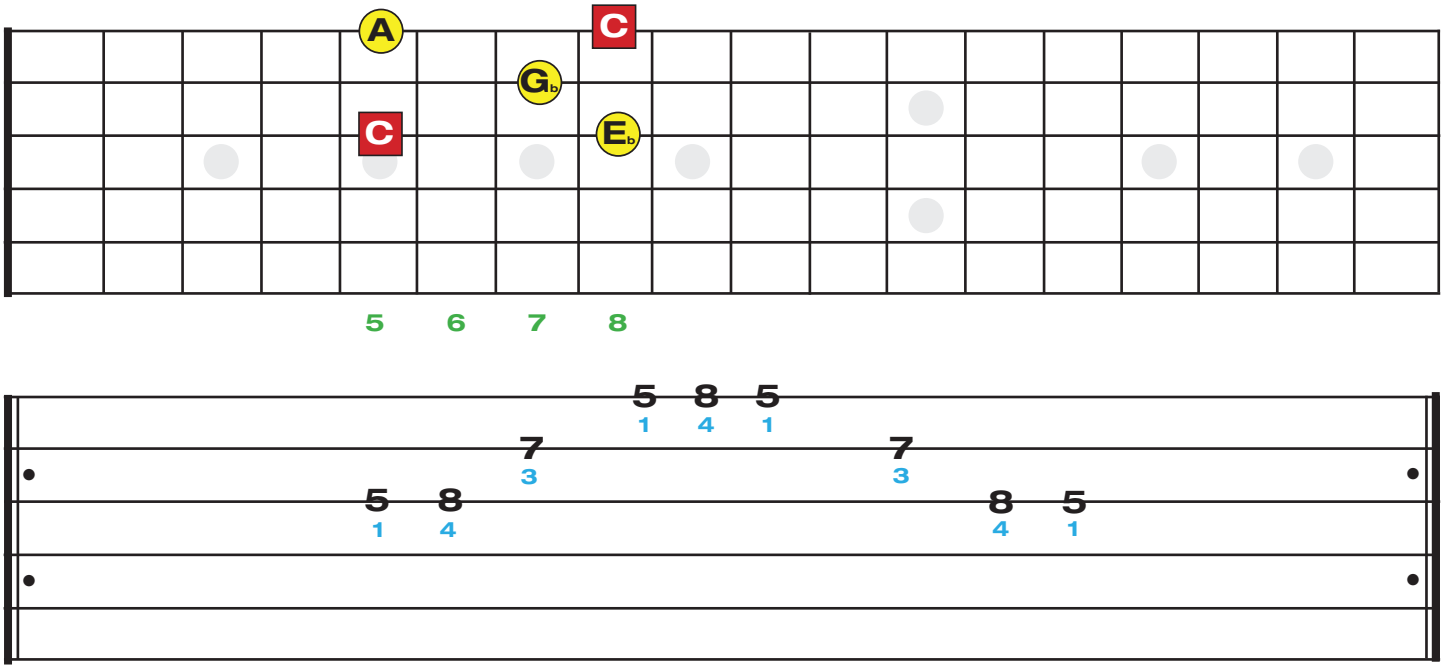
C Diminished Seventh Arpeggio

C Diminished 7th Arpeggio Notes: C E♭ G♭ B♭♭ (A) • Formula: 1 ♭3 ♭5 ♭♭7

To transpose to a new key move the red square to a new tonic location.

The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key

Fingers are the Blue Numbers. Tab is the Black Numbers.



Diminished 7th Arpeggio

Diminished 7th Arpeggio can be considered a diminished triad with a diminished seventh.

The interval formula is:
Root (R), Minor Third (♭ 3), Diminished Fifth (♭ 5), Diminished Seventh (♭♭ 7).

Diminished 7th Arpeggio is basically used to play over diminished 7th chords and dominant ♭ 9 chords a half step below its root (Cdim7 over B7♭9) but can be used creatively over fast heavy metal changes too.

The Perfect Symmetry of Diminished 7th Arpeggio

The Diminished 7th Arpeggio is built with minor third intervals and is symmetrical. A minor third interval is made up of 3 semitones (3 frets on the guitar).

It is advisable to play these shapes starting from the root notes, ascending and descending. Once you are comfortable with the fingerings, try to start from the other tones: (♭ 3, ♭ 5 and ♭♭ 7).

- Practice with a metronome, first very slowly, then gradually increase speed
- Play arpeggio slowly note perfect ascending and then descending
- Concentrate on one arpeggio position, then more positions on the guitar neck
- Focus on even clear tone and accuracy as you play through the arpeggio

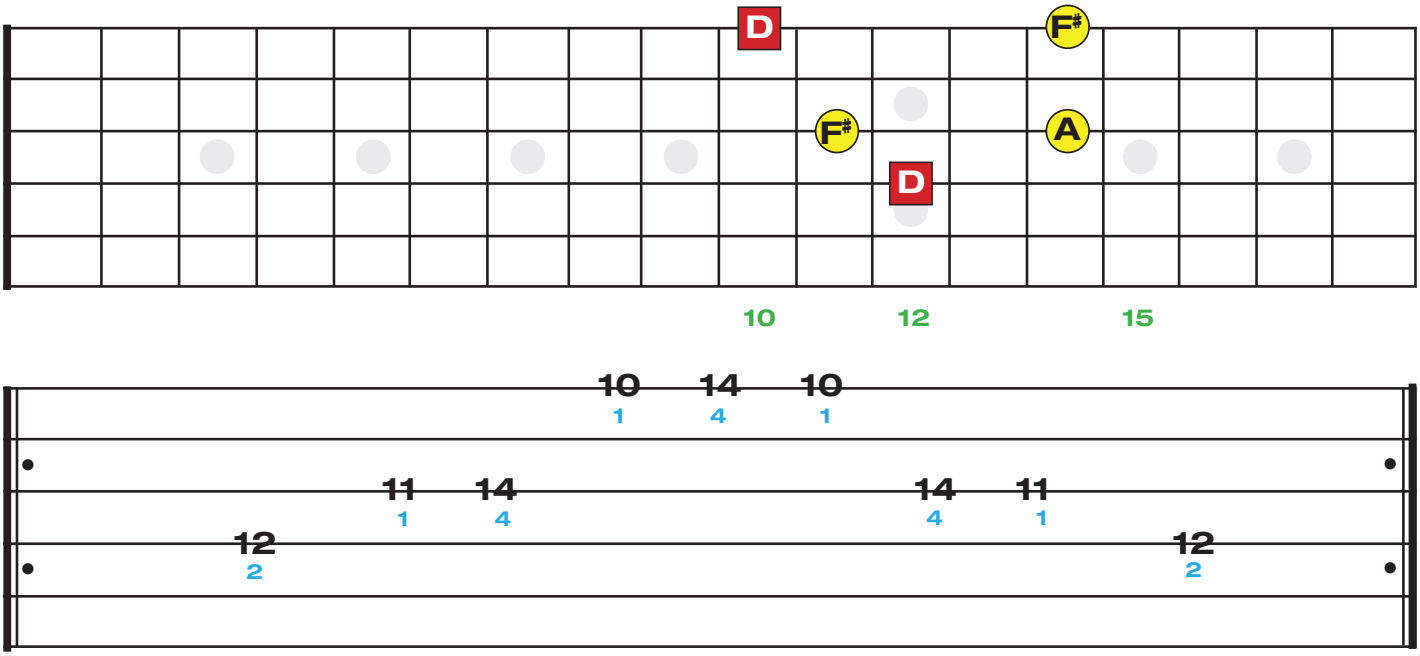
PRACTICE: Slide the shape up three frets at a time. Diminished arpeggios repeat every minor third.

D Major String Skipping Arpeggio

D Major Arpeggio Notes: D F♯ A • D Major Arpeggio Formula: 1 3 5

To transpose to a new key move the Red Square to the new tonic location

Red Square = Key Root Note • Blue Numbers = Fingers • Black Numbers = Tab

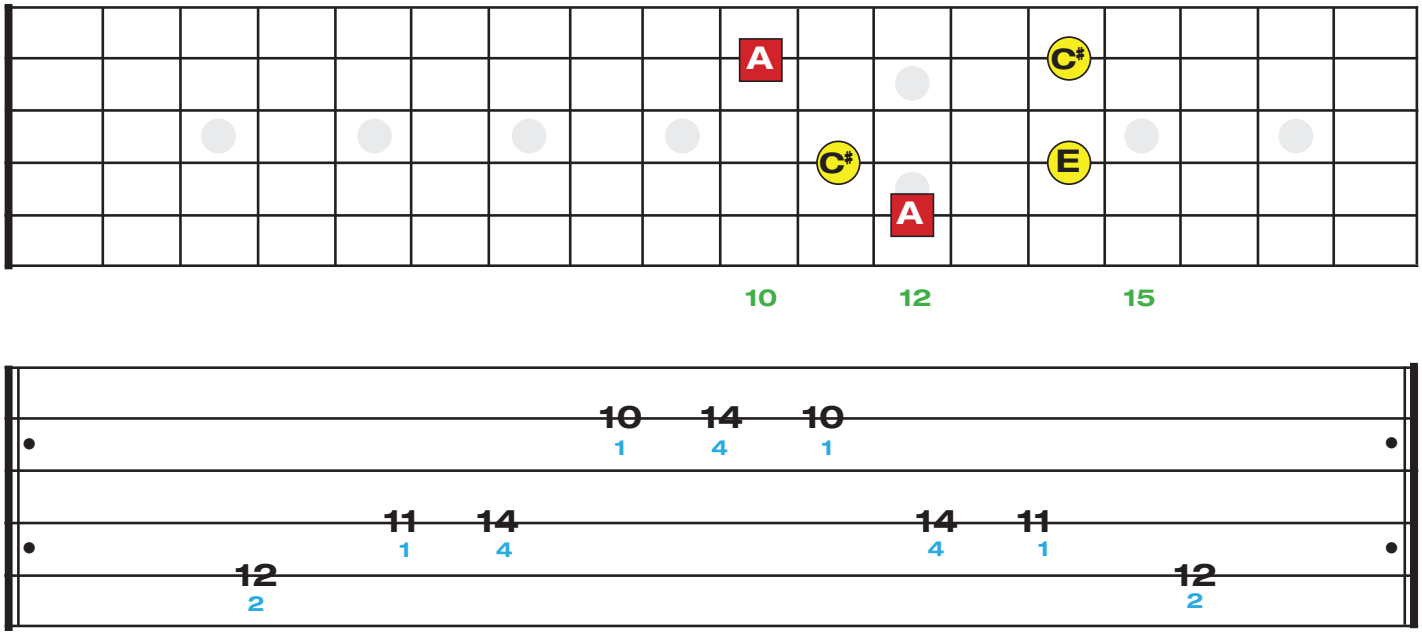


A Major String Skipping Arpeggio

A Major Arpeggio Notes: A C♯ E • A Major Arpeggio Formula: 1 3 5

To transpose to a new key move the Red Square to the new tonic location

Red Square = Key Root Note • Blue Numbers = Fingers • Black Numbers = Tab



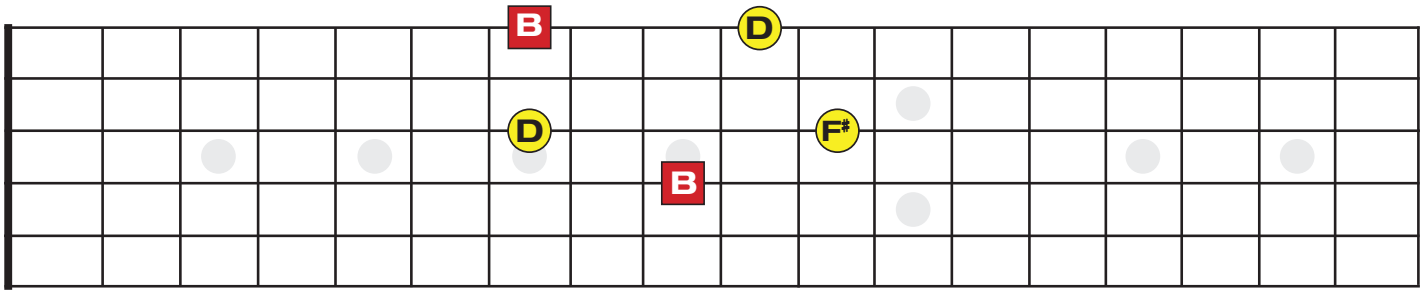
PRACTICE: Keep your picking hand relaxed as you skip strings. Start at 60 BPM with strict alternate picking.

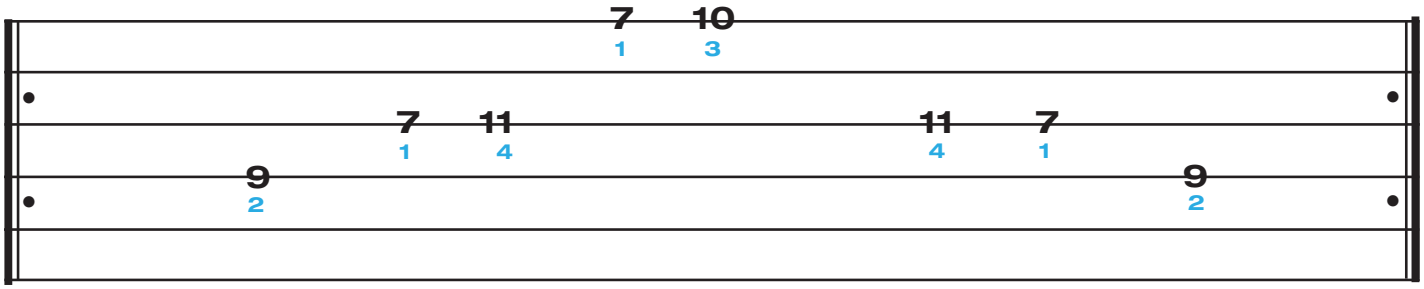
B Minor String Skipping Arpeggio

B Minor Arpeggio Notes: B D F♯ • B Minor Arpeggio Formula: 1 ♭3 5

To transpose to a new key move the Red Square to the new tonic location

Red Square = Key Root Note • Blue Numbers = Fingers • Black Numbers = Tab



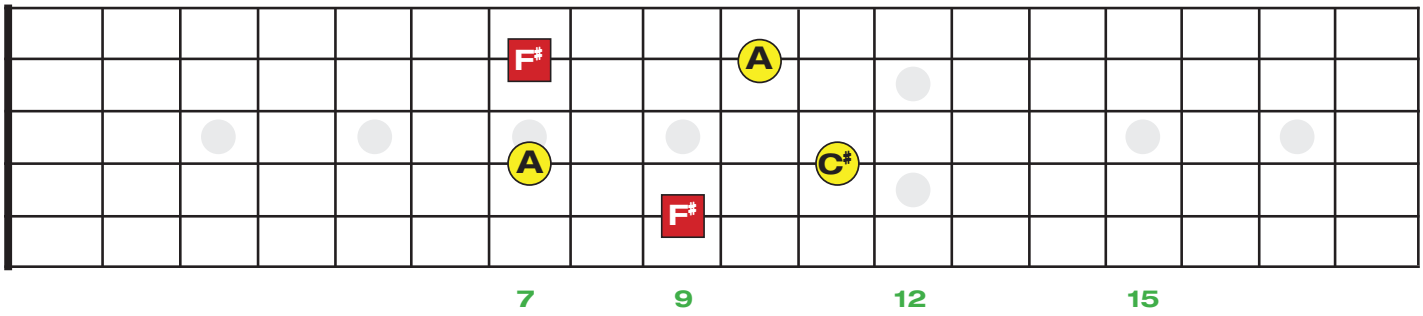


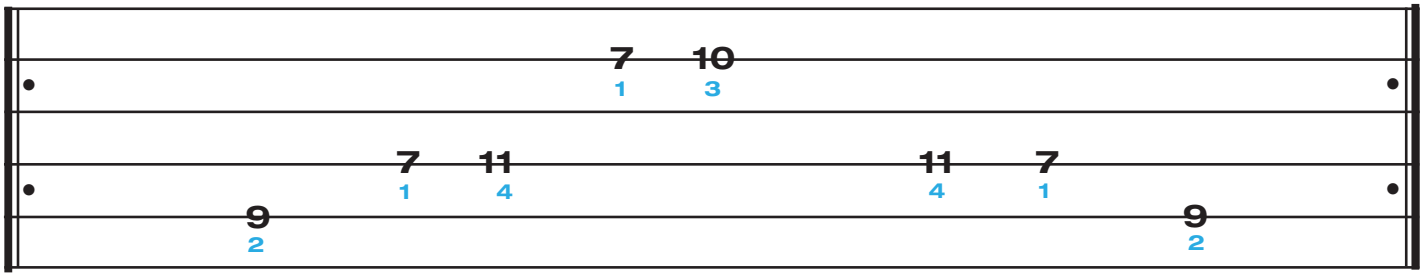
F♯ Minor String Skipping Arpeggio

F♯ Minor Arpeggio Notes: F♯ A C♯ • F♯ Minor Arpeggio Formula: 1 ♭3 5

To transpose to a new key move the Red Square to the new tonic location

Red Square = Key Root Note • Blue Numbers = Fingers • Black Numbers = Tab





PRACTICE: Keep your picking hand relaxed as you skip strings. Start at 60 BPM with strict alternate picking.

Seventh Chord Arpeggios

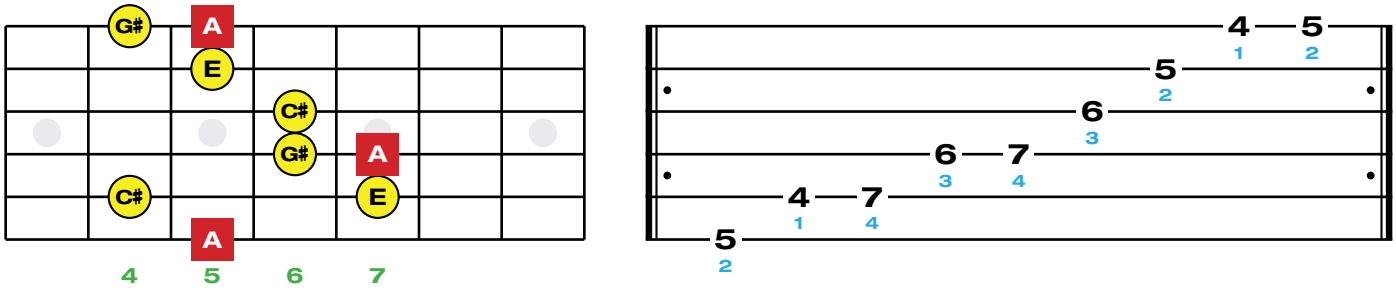
Four chord types from one root, changing one note at a time

A seventh chord arpeggio is a triad with one more note: the 7th. All four shapes start from the same A at the 5th fret, and each one changes a single note of the shape before it. Learn them as a family and you will hear exactly what gives each chord its sound.

Red squares = the root • Blue circle = the note that changed • Blue numbers = fingers • Black numbers = tab

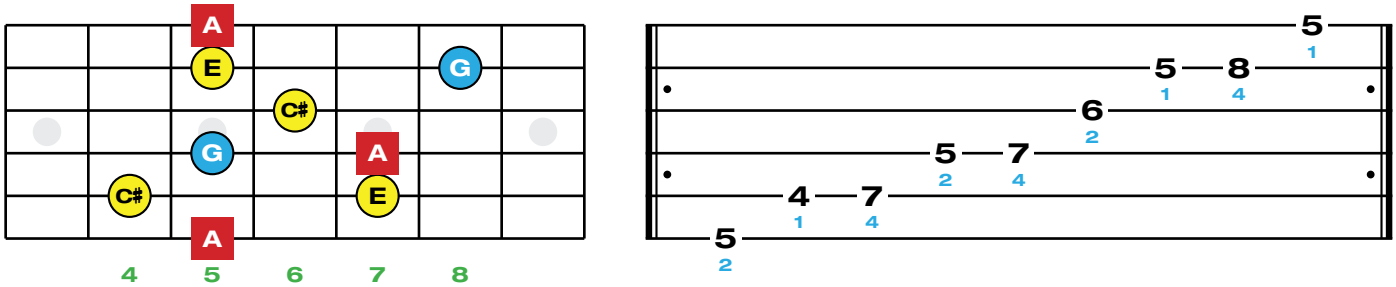
A Major 7 Amaj7 • 1 3 5 7 • A C♯ E G♯

the starting point



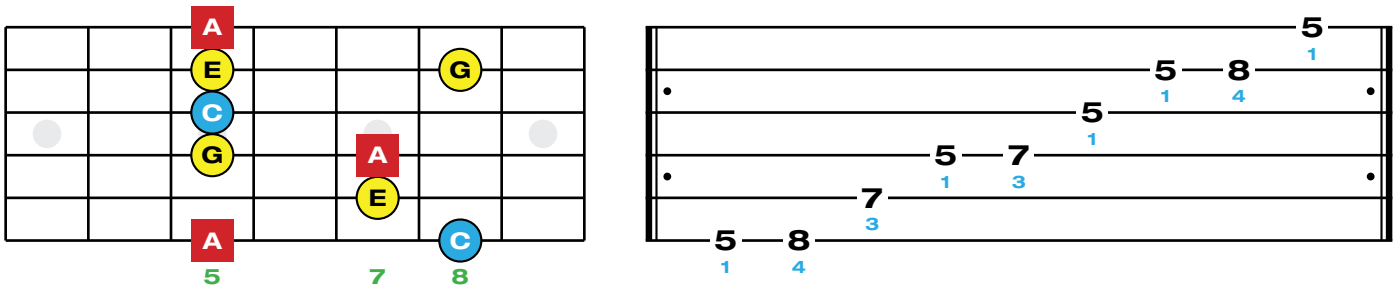
A Dominant 7 A7 • 1 3 5 ♭7 • A C♯ E G

lower the 7th



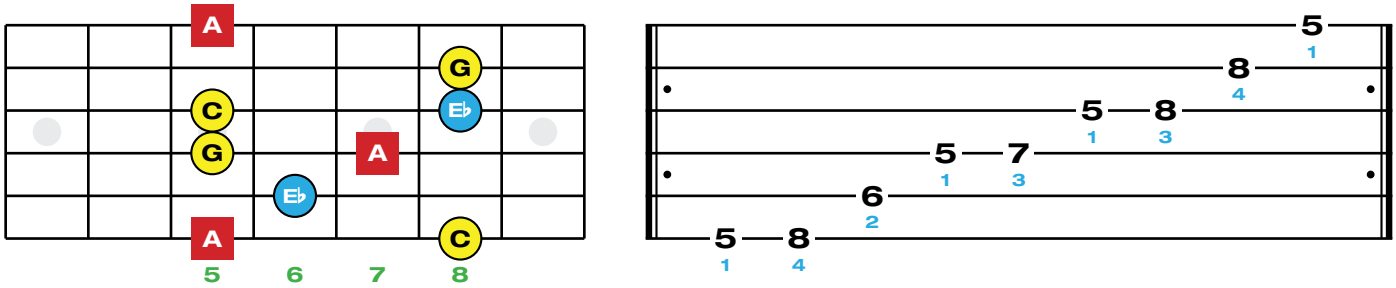
A Minor 7 Am7 • 1 ♭3 5 ♭7 • A C E G

lower the 3rd



A Minor 7♭5 Am7♭5 • 1 ♭3 ♭5 ♭7 • A C E♭ G

lower the 5th



Lower one more note, the ♭7 of Am7♭5, and you arrive at the diminished 7th arpeggio on page 58. To play any of these over another chord, slide the whole shape until the red square sits on the new root.

PRACTICE: Play the four arpeggios back to back from the same A, naming each chord out loud, then repeat from a new root.

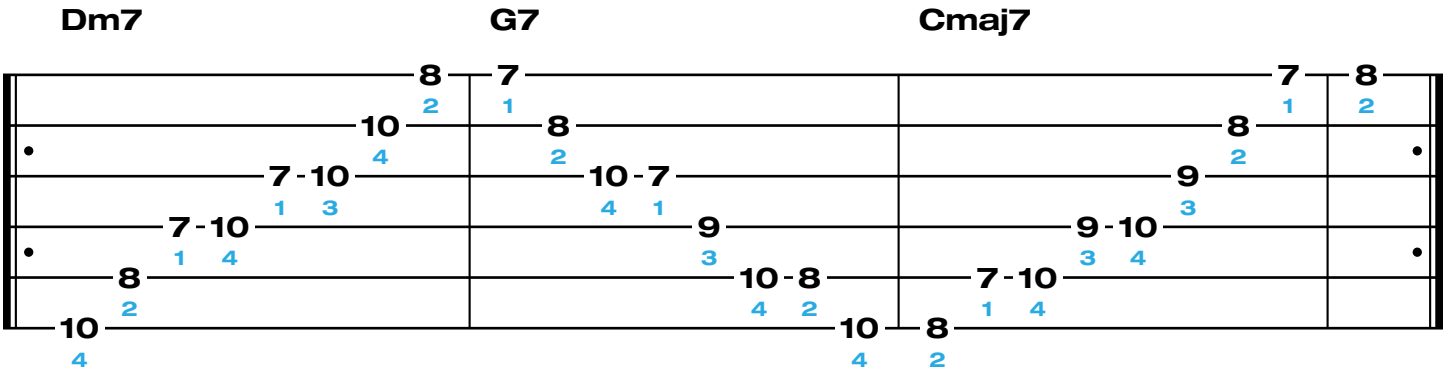
II-V-I Arpeggio Study

Outline the chord changes of pages 30–31 with arpeggios, joined by the nearest note

Soloing over chord changes starts here. Play the arpeggio of each chord, and when the chord changes, step to the closest note of the new arpeggio instead of jumping back to its root. Both studies stay in the 7th position and use even eighth notes, one bar per chord.

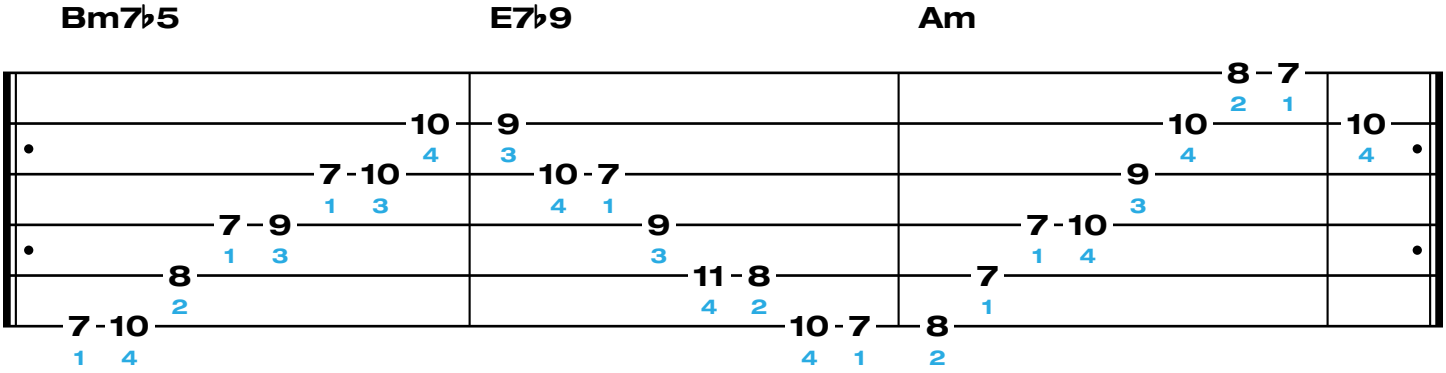
Fingers are the Blue Numbers. Tab is the Black Numbers.

Study 1 • II-V-I in C major



Listen for the joins: the last note of the Dm7 bar (C) falls a half step to B, the 3rd of G7. The last note of the G7 bar (D) steps down to C, and the line ends by rising from B to the root.

Study 2 • II-V-I in A minor



Listen for the joins: A falls a half step to G♯, the 3rd of E7. Over E7♭9 the line plays G♯ B D F, which is a G♯ diminished 7th arpeggio (the shape from page 58). In the last bar, B is a passing note on the way down to the root.

Chord	Formula	Notes	In the study
Dm7	1 ♭3 5 ♭7	D F A C	climbs two octaves
G7	1 3 5 ♭7	G B D F	falls from its 3rd
Cmaj7	1 3 5 7	C E G B	climbs to the root
Bm7♭5	1 ♭3 ♭5 ♭7	B D F A	climbs from its root
E7♭9	1 3 5 ♭7 ♭9	E G♯ B D F	played without its root
Am	1 ♭3 5	A C E	ends on the root

PRACTICE: Start at 60 BPM. Loop each study until the chord changes can be heard in your line with no backing track at all.

Tapping Basics

What to know before you tap your first arpeggio

Tapping lets your picking hand play notes on the fingerboard. Instead of picking the string, you hammer a finger down onto it, just like a fretting-hand hammer-on. Combined with hammer-ons and pull-offs in the fretting hand, tapping lets you play wide, flowing arpeggios that would be hard to pick.

1 Choose your tapping finger

Most players tap with the middle finger of the picking hand, so they can keep holding the pick between the thumb and index finger. Some players tap with the index finger and tuck the pick into the palm. Pick one and stay with it.

2 Tap firmly, just behind the fret

Strike the string with the tip of your finger, quickly and firmly, right behind the fret. A clean, confident tap makes the note ring clearly.

3 Pull off to sound the next note

To release a tapped note, flick the finger slightly off the string, toward the floor or the ceiling. The flick sounds the note your fretting hand is holding underneath it.

4 Let the fretting hand do its part

The fretting hand plays the lower notes with hammer-ons and pull-offs. When you move to a new string, hammer the first note down without picking it: a “hammer-on from nowhere.”

5 Anchor and mute

Rest the heel of your picking hand lightly on the strings for stability. It steadies your tapping finger and keeps unwanted strings quiet. Muting is covered on the following pages.

6 Go slow and stay even

Use a metronome. Aim for every note, tapped or fretted, to sound at the same volume and in perfect time before you add speed.

In the tab on the following pages, a red T marks a tapped note and the small arcs connect notes played legato.

PRACTICE: Practice single taps and pull-offs on one string with a metronome before you try a full arpeggio.

Tapping 7th Chord Arpeggios

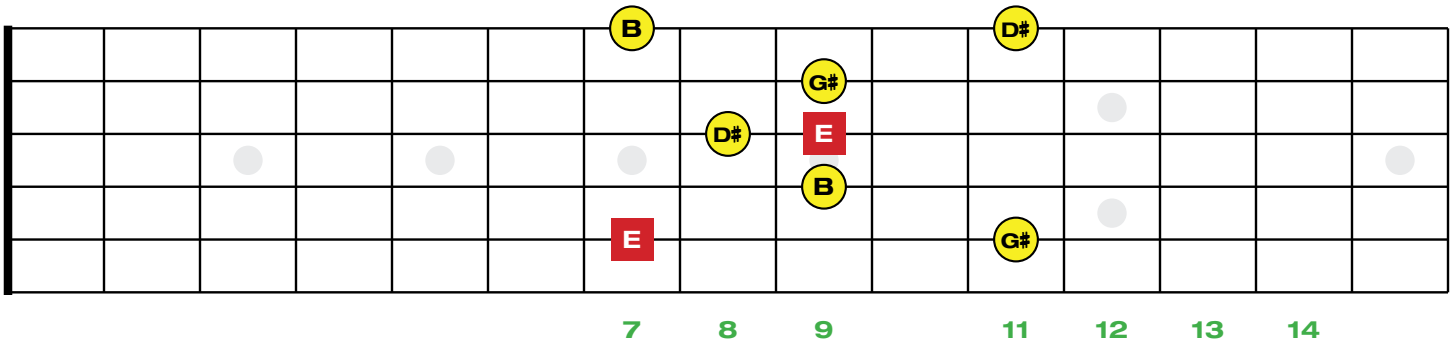
E Major 7 Arpeggio Notes: E G# B D# • E Major 7 Formula: 1 3 5 7

Learn the arpeggio in position first, then turn it into a three-string tapping pattern.

The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key

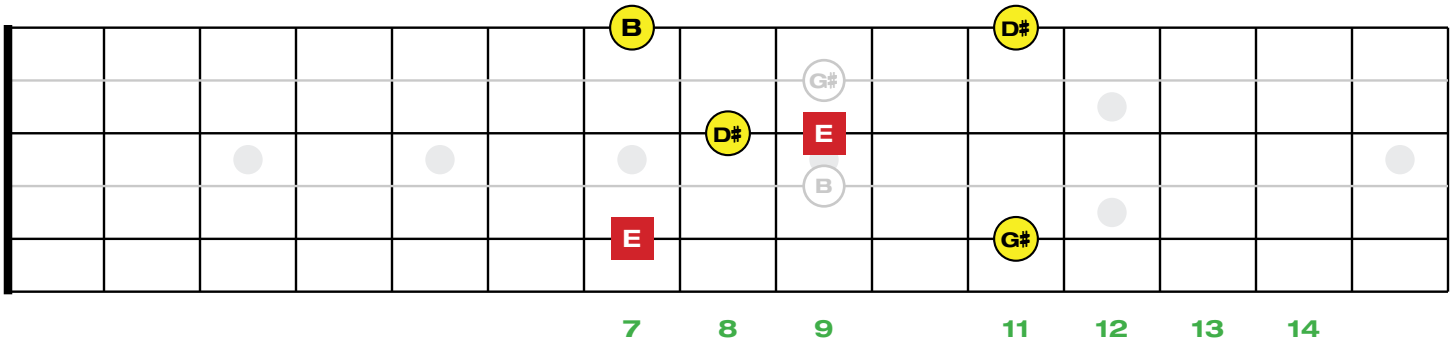
Fingers are the Blue Numbers. Tab is the Black Numbers. **T** = tap with the picking hand.

STEP 1 Learn the E Major 7 arpeggio in position (frets 7 to 11)



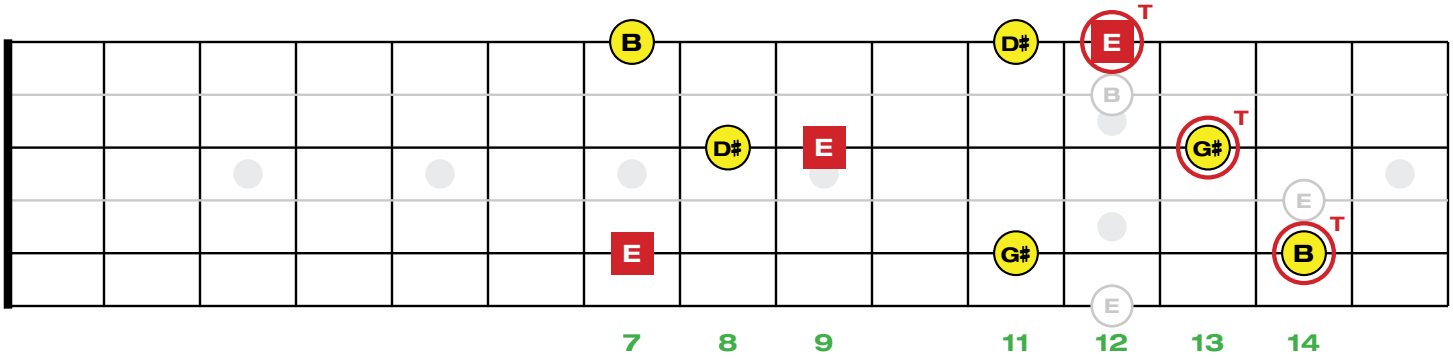
The notes fall 2 – 1 – 2 – 1 – 2 across the A, D, G, B and high E strings: two notes, then one, then two, then one, then two.

STEP 2 Drop the strings that play only one note



Remove the D and B strings. The arpeggio now lives on just three strings (A, G and high E), with two notes on each.

STEP 3 Find the notes to tap



Use an E major barre chord at the 12th fret as your guide (shown in grey). It tells you where to tap: the 14th fret on the A string, the 13th on the G string and the 12th on the high E.

PRACTICE: Get the in-position shape clean first, then add the taps once the two fretted notes on each string sound even.

Tapping 7th Chord Arpeggios

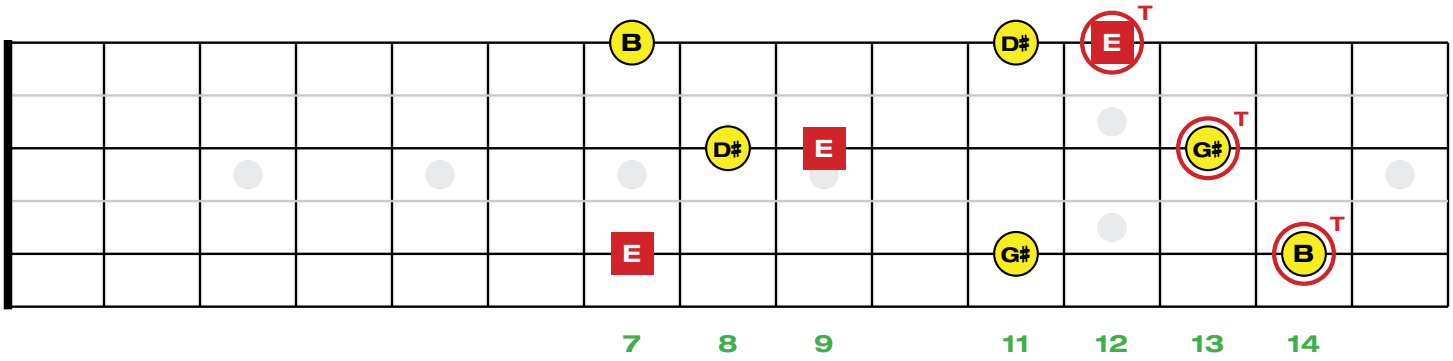
E Major 7 Arpeggio Notes: E G♯ B D♯ • E Major 7 Formula: 1 3 5 7

The complete pattern: three notes per string, the top note of each string tapped.

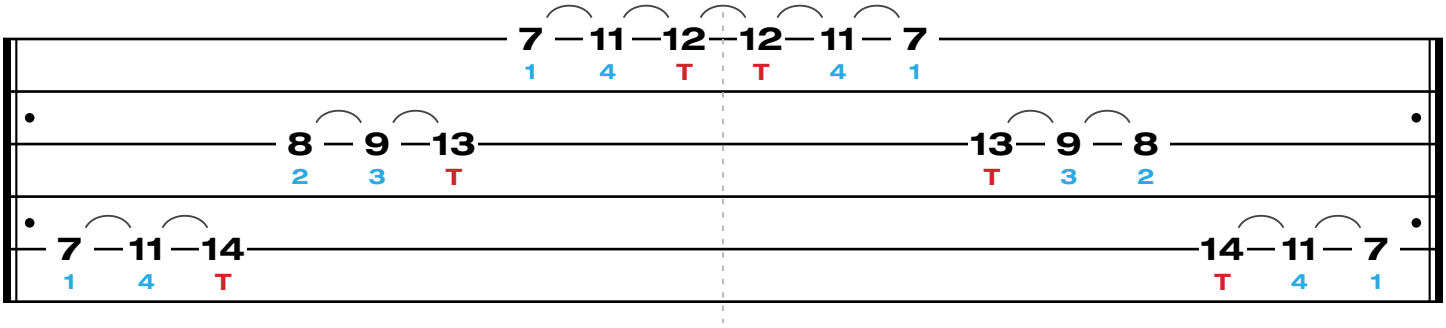
The red square boxes indicate the root note of the key

Fingers are the Blue Numbers. Tab is the Black Numbers. **T** = tap with the picking hand.

The tapping shape



Ascending



Descending

Clean Tapping Is All About Muting

Going up: your picking hand mutes

Rest the palm of your picking hand on the lower strings while you tap. As you climb to the higher strings, rotate the hand so the palm keeps covering the strings you have already played. Only the string you are playing should ring.

Coming down: your fretting hand mutes

Lay your fretting-hand index finger in a light, slightly arched barre across the strings. It does not press the notes down; the flesh simply touches the strings so none of the other notes ring out.

Take it further

Once the E major 7 shape is smooth and quiet, build the same three-string pattern for other 7th chords (dominant 7, minor 7 and minor 7♭5) by changing the notes to match each formula.

PRACTICE: Start at 60 BPM and focus on the muting: only one note should ring at a time, going up and coming down.

Sweep Picking Basics

What to know before you sweep your first arpeggio

Sweep picking plays an arpeggio with one note on each string, using a single continuous pick stroke across the strings instead of a separate stroke for every note. Done well it is a fast, clean ripple of single notes. Done carelessly the notes smear together into a strummed chord. The whole technique is about keeping the notes apart.

1 Let the pick fall through the strings

Going toward the floor, push the pick through one string and let it come to rest on the next, like a strum in slow motion. Coming back, drag it up the same way. Never flick the wrist for each string.

2 Sound one note at a time

Fret each note just before the pick reaches it and relax the finger as soon as it has sounded. The finger stays on the string to keep it quiet, but the note stops. If two notes ring together, slow down.

3 Roll, don't barre

When two notes sit at the same fret on neighboring strings, roll the fingertip from one string to the next so that each note is cut off as the next one begins.

4 Turn around with a hammer-on and pull-off

At the top of the shape the two highest notes are joined by a hammer-on and a pull-off. That gives the picking hand time to change direction.

5 Mute with both hands

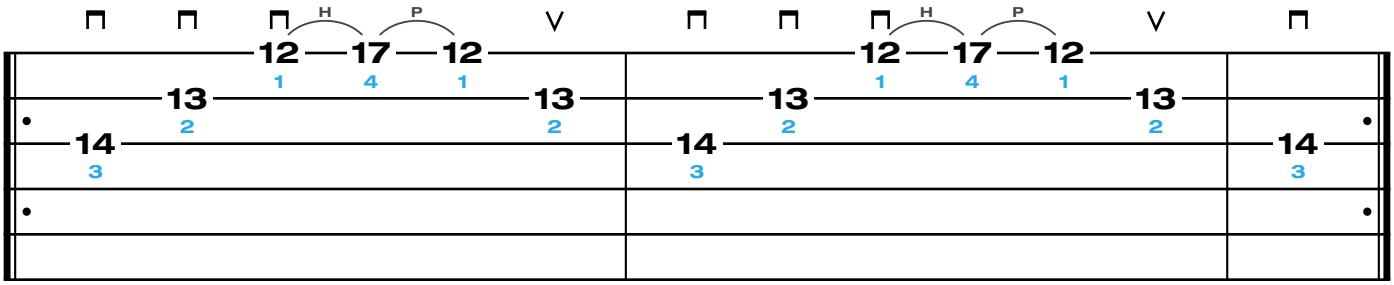
The palm of the picking hand follows the pick and rests on the lower strings. The underside of the fretting fingers lightly touches the higher ones, so the only string free to ring is the one you are playing.

6 Keep every note even

Each note gets the same length and the same volume. Use a metronome and stay slow until all six notes are clear. Speed comes from relaxed, small motions.

First exercise: a three-string A minor arpeggio

⊓ = downstroke ∨ = upstroke H = hammer-on P = pull-off



PRACTICE: Play the six notes as two groups of three at 60 BPM. Every note should be as clear as if you had picked it alone.

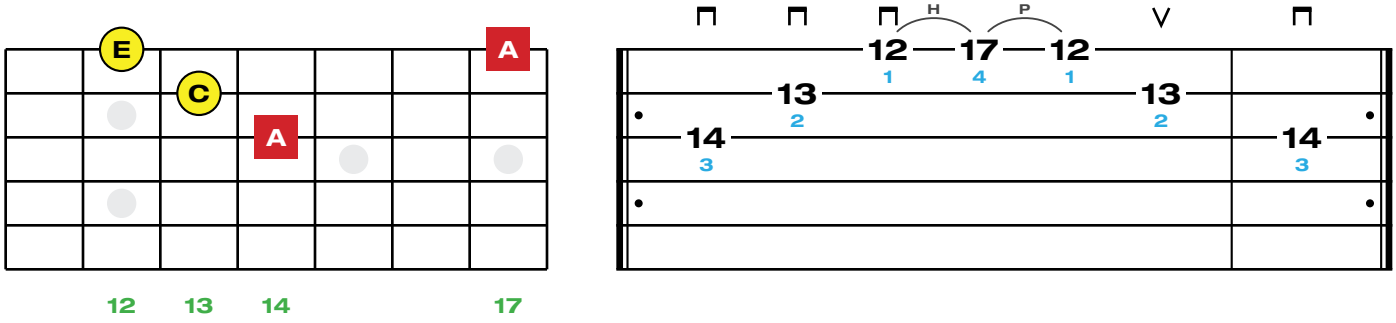
Three-String Sweep Arpeggios

Minor and major triads on the top three strings, and a progression to move them through

⊓ = downstroke ∨ = upstroke H = hammer-on P = pull-off

A Minor 1 ♭3 5 • A C E

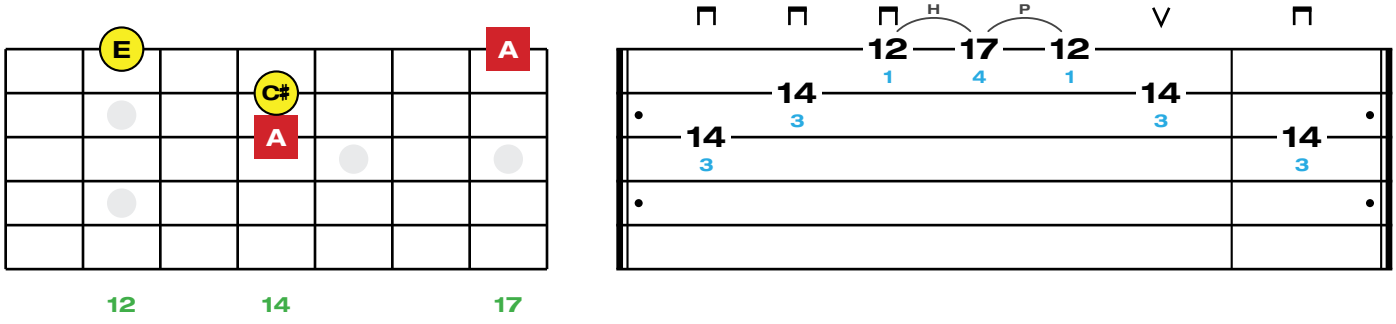
12th position



Three downstrokes in one motion, a hammer-on and a pull-off on the top string, then one upstroke. The first note of the next group is a new downstroke. Count the six notes as two groups of three.

A Major 1 3 5 • A C♯ E

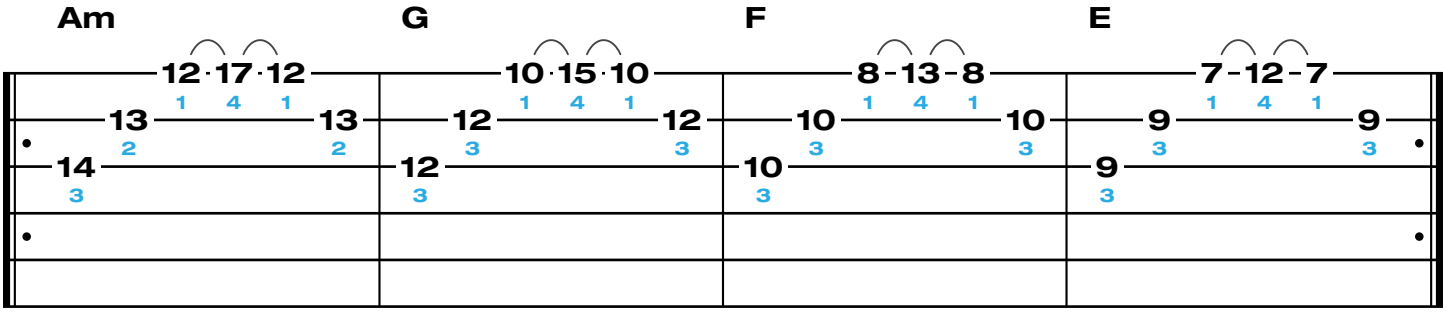
12th position



The G and B strings are both at the 14th fret. Play them with the 3rd finger and roll it from one string to the other, so the two notes never ring together.

Moving the shapes: Am – G – F – E

one minor shape, then three major



The picking is the same in every bar. Am to G to F to E is the **Andalusian cadence**, the chord progression of flamenco: finish on E and you are in the E Phrygian dominant sound of page 48.

PRACTICE: Loop one shape until it is clean at 60 BPM before you move it. Change chords without stopping the sweep.

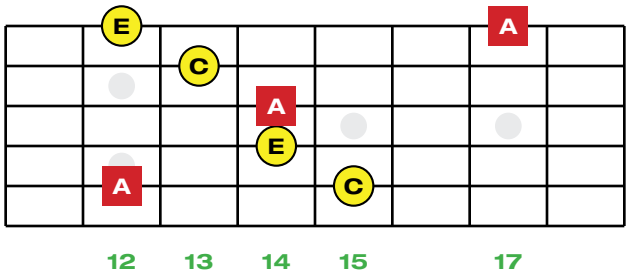
Five-String Sweep Arpeggios

Two octaves in one sweep: the classic A minor and A major shapes

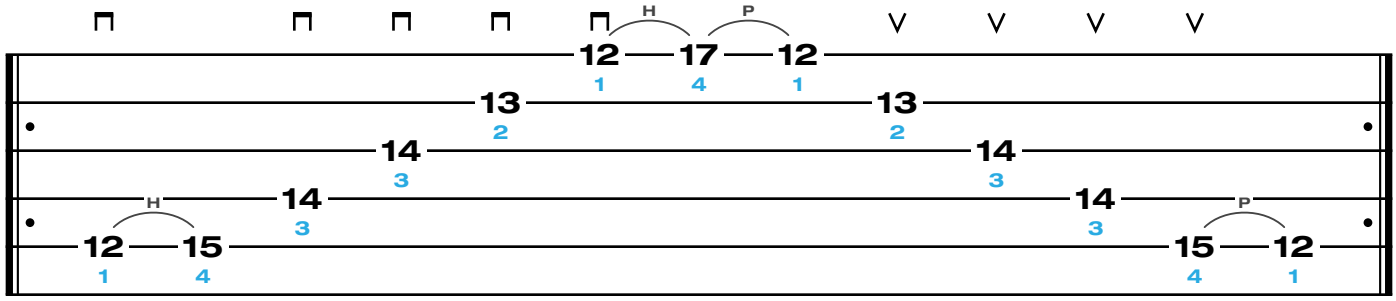
⊓ = downstroke ⋁ = upstroke H = hammer-on P = pull-off

A Minor 1 ♭3 5 • A C E

12th position

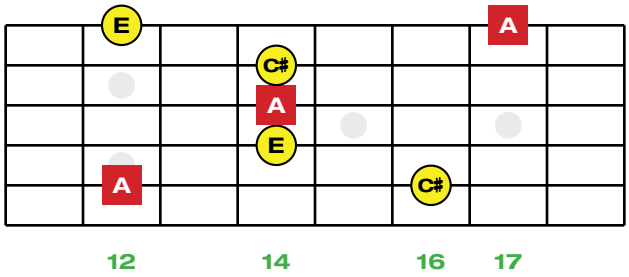


Pick the first note, hammer on to the 15th fret, then sweep down through four strings. At the top, hammer on and pull off, sweep back up, and finish with a pull-off to the root. Roll the 3rd finger across the D and G strings.

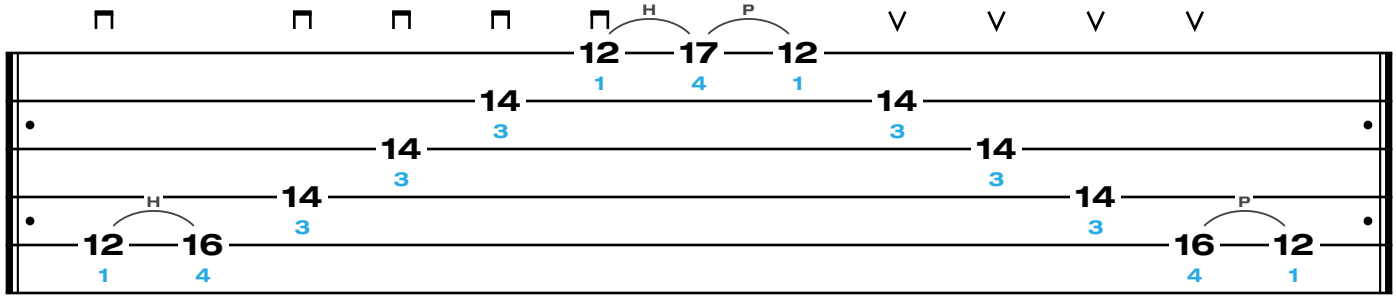


A Major 1 3 5 • A C♯ E

12th position



The D, G and B strings are all at the 14th fret: lay the 3rd finger across them and roll it, pressing only the string being picked. The 5th string stretches from the 12th to the 16th fret, so keep the thumb low behind the neck.



Take it further: these are the A-string root shapes of the major and minor barre chords on page 28, played one note at a time. Slide them to any root, and link them into progressions as you did on the previous page.

PRACTICE: Practice the way down and the way up separately, then join them. Aim for thirteen even notes with no gaps and no ringing.

TECHNIQUE & EXPRESSION



Bending in Tune

Push the string to an exact pitch, every time

A bend raises the pitch of a note by pushing the string across the fretboard. It is how the guitar sings, and it only sounds good when it lands exactly on the note you are aiming for. Know the target before you bend: a half step is the note one fret higher, a whole step is the note two frets higher.

1 Back the bending finger up

Bend with the 3rd finger and place the 1st and 2nd fingers on the same string behind it. All three push together. One finger on its own is weak and hard to control.

2 Turn the wrist

Hook the thumb over the top of the neck and rotate the forearm, as if turning a door knob. The fingers keep their shape and the wrist does the work.

3 Hear the target first

Play the target note where it is fretted, then bend up to it and compare the two. Repeat until your ear, not your eye, tells you when to stop.

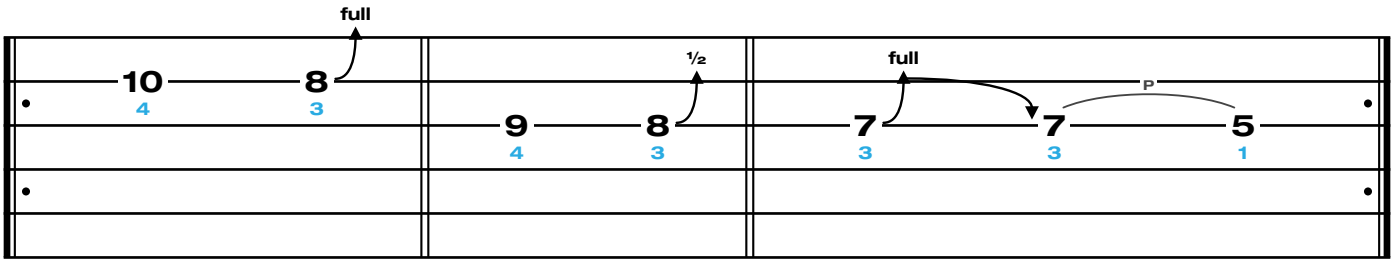
4 Keep the other strings quiet

A rising string pushes into its neighbors. Let the tip of the bending finger and the flat of the 1st finger rest against them so they cannot ring.

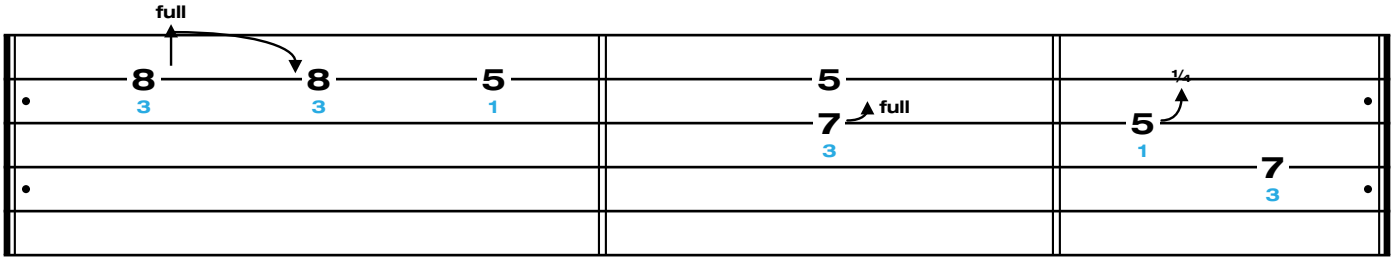
Six bends to practice

full = a whole step **½** = a half step **¼** = a slight push

1. Whole step **2. Half step** **3. Bend and release**



4. Pre-bend and release **5. Unison bend** **6. The blues curl**



1 Play A at the 10th fret, then bend G at the 8th fret until it matches. **2** The blue note E♭ rises a half step to E. **3** Bend, let the string back down while it rings, then pull off. **4** Bend the string before you pick it, then release. **5** Hold E on the B string with the 1st finger and bend D on the G string up to the same pitch. **6** Push C a little sharp, toward C♯, without reaching it. Every bend starts on a note of Block 1 of the A blues scale (page 41).

PRACTICE: Use a tuner: bend, hold the note and check it. Aim to land every whole-step bend exactly in tune ten times in a row.

Vibrato

The signature in your sound

Vibrato is a series of small, even bends and releases that makes a held note sing. Listeners recognize a great player by it within a few notes. It has two controls: how wide the pitch moves, and how fast.

1 Anchor the hand

Hook the thumb over the neck and rest the side of the 1st finger's knuckle against the lower edge of the fingerboard. That contact is the pivot for the whole motion.

2 Rotate, release, repeat

Use the same door-knob turn of the wrist as a bend, but small: the string moves a little, returns, and moves again in a steady rhythm. Push the top three strings up toward the ceiling; pull the bottom three down toward the floor.

3 Come back to pitch every time

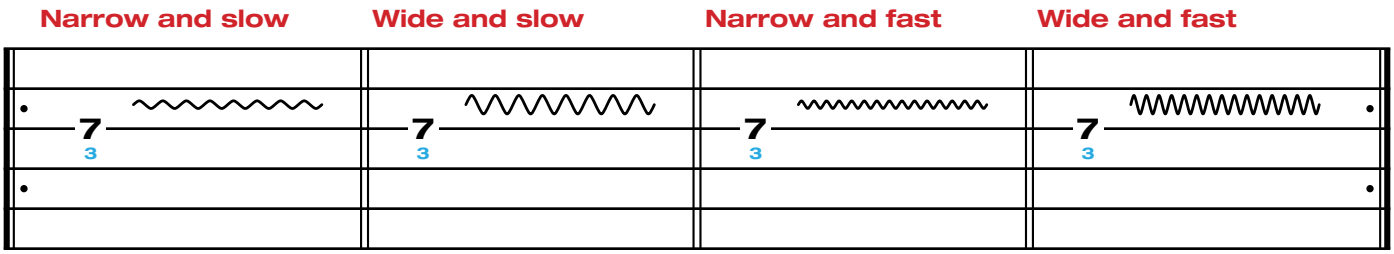
The note must return exactly to where it started on each cycle. If it does not, the vibrato sounds sharp and nervous instead of sweet.

4 Let the note speak first

Hold the note still for a moment, then bring the vibrato in. A long note that blooms into vibrato sounds far more vocal than one that shakes from the start.

Width and speed

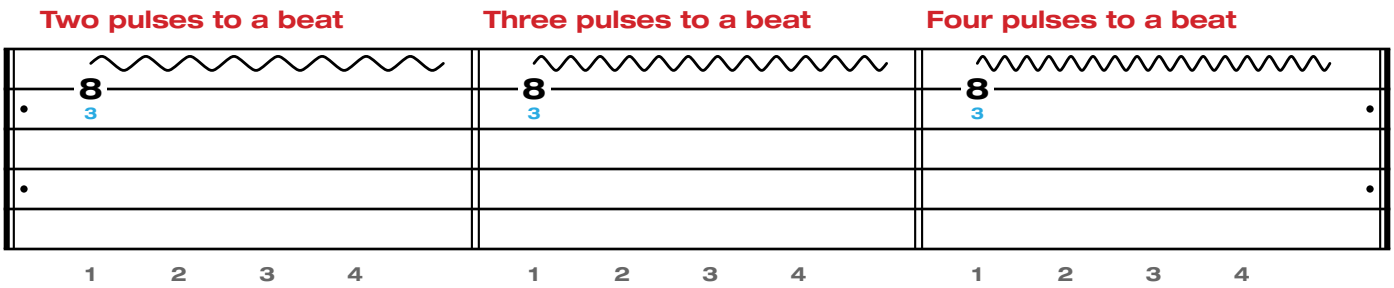
the wavy line after a note means vibrato



ballads, clean tones — *blues, big rock melodies* — *shimmer on a long note* — *intense, aggressive*

Vibrato in time

metronome at 60 BPM: one bar of each



Each wave is one push and return. Lock the pulses to the click and you can choose the speed that suits the song. **On a bent note:** bend to pitch first, then let the string drop slightly and push it back, again and again. The top of each cycle is the note itself.

PRACTICE: Hold one note for four slow beats with even vibrato on every finger in turn. Record it and listen back for a steady pulse.

Legato: Hammer-Ons & Pull-Offs

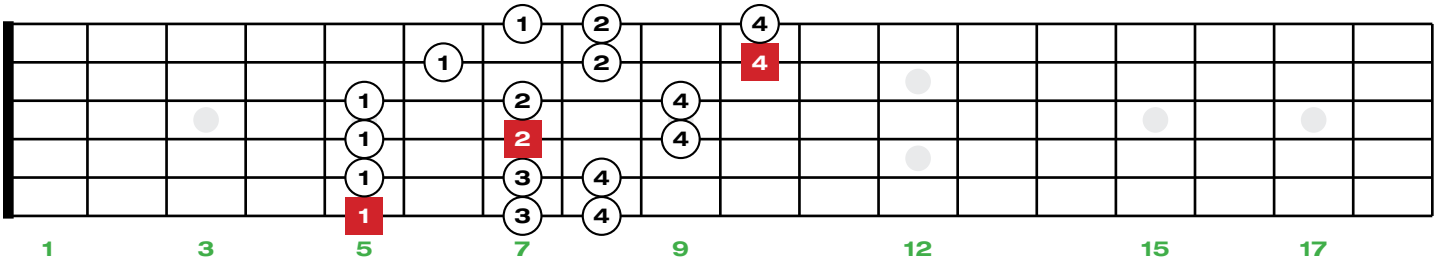
Smooth, connected notes from the fretting hand

Legato means “tied together.” Instead of picking every note, the fretting hand sounds most of them: a hammer-on strikes the string with a fingertip, and a pull-off plucks it sideways as the finger leaves. Pick only the first note on each string and let the fingers do the rest.

- **Hammer from close in.** Speed makes the note, not force. Land on the fingertip, just behind the fret.
- **Pull off with a flick** toward the floor, with the lower finger already holding its note.
- **Match the volume.** Hammered and pulled notes must be as loud as picked ones. Check with a clean tone.
- **Mute the lower strings** with the palm of the picking hand, so only the string you are playing rings.

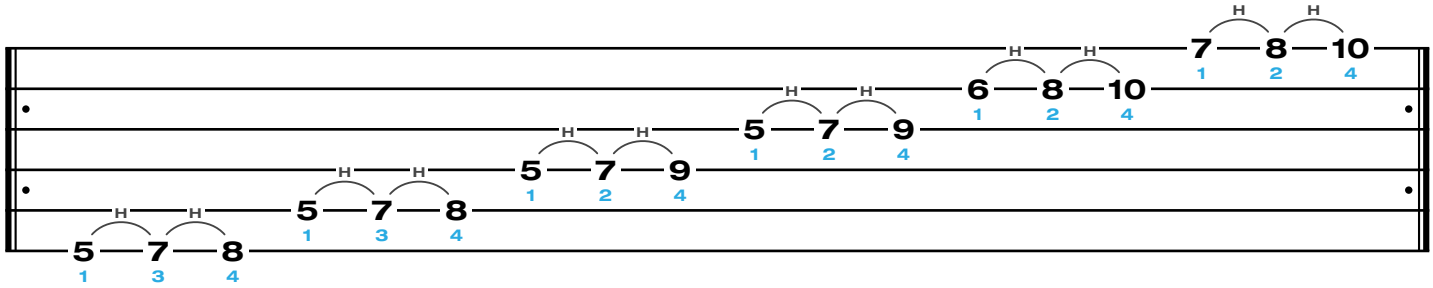
The pattern: A natural minor, three notes per string

numbers = fingers

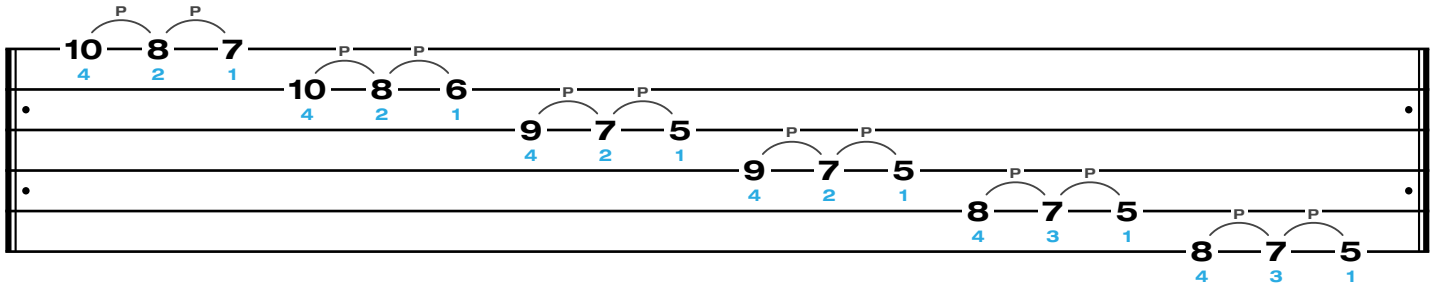


1. Up the pattern with hammer-ons

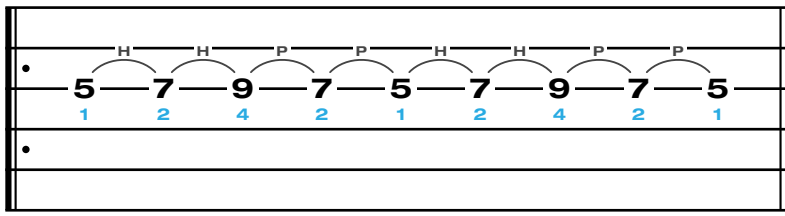
H = hammer-on **P** = pull-off



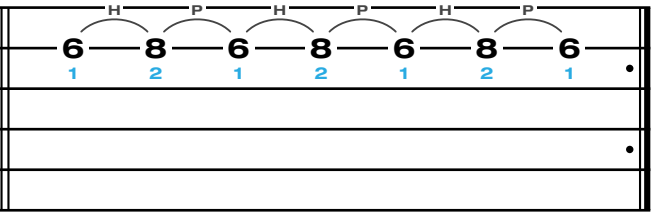
2. Down the pattern with pull-offs



3. The roll: up and back on one string



4. The trill: two notes, evenly



PRACTICE: Pick once per string and keep every note the same length. If a note is quieter than the rest, repeat just that pair of notes.

Picking Sequences

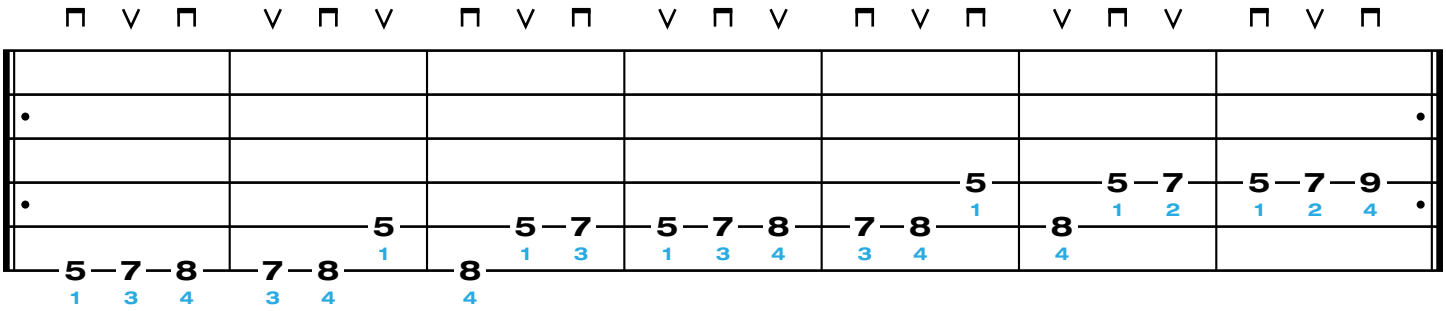
Alternate-picked patterns that turn a scale into a line

A sequence is a short pattern repeated from each note of a scale in turn. Sequences build picking accuracy and give you ready-made lines. These use the A natural minor pattern on the facing page. Play every note with strict alternate picking: down, up, down, up, no matter which string comes next.

⊓ = downstroke ∨ = upstroke

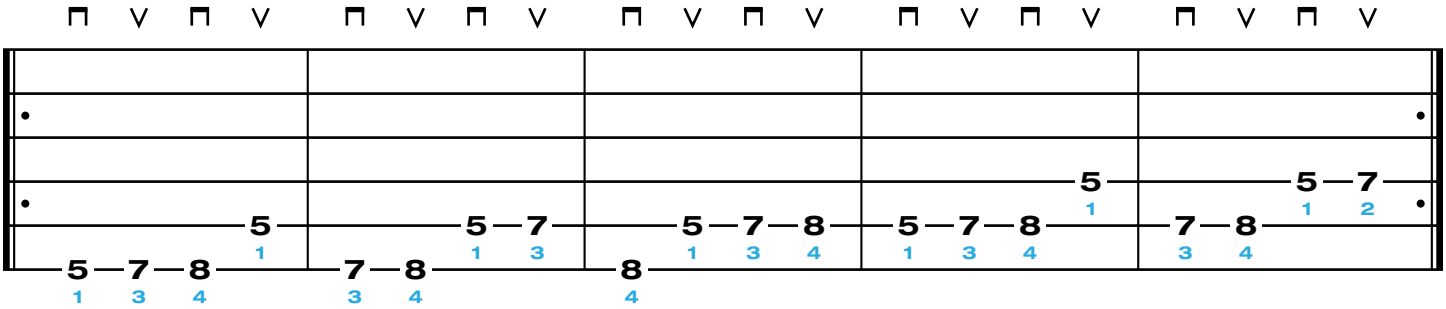
1. Groups of three

three notes up, then start again one note higher



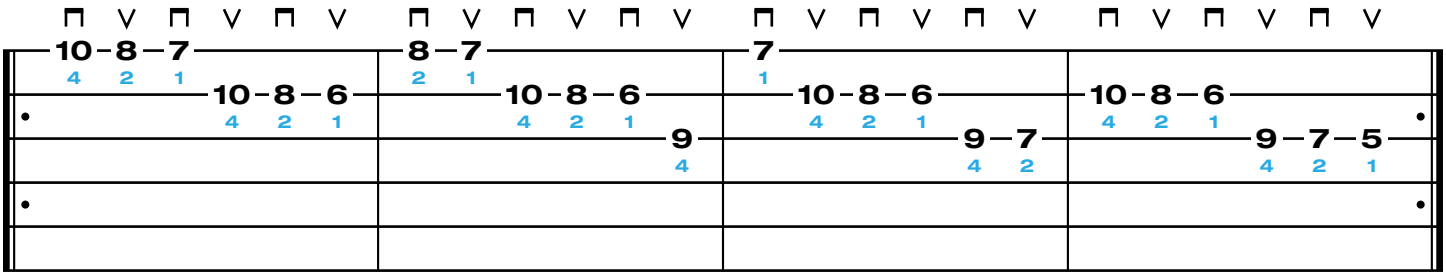
2. Groups of four

four notes up, then start again one note higher



3. Descending sixes

six notes down, then start again one note lower



- **Accent the first note of each group.** The accent is what makes the pattern audible as a pattern.
- **Keep the pick moving the same small distance** for every note, and let the forearm carry the hand from string to string.
- **Use a metronome.** Start at 60 BPM with two notes to a click. Raise it four clicks only when three clean passes in a row say you are ready.

PRACTICE: Carry each sequence through the whole pattern and back down, then try the same three sequences on another scale.

Phrasing

How you say it matters more than how many notes you play

A solo is a conversation, not a list of scale notes. Phrasing is everything that turns notes into sentences: where a phrase starts and stops, which notes it leans on, how it answers the phrase before it, and the silence around it. These six ideas work with every scale in this book.

1 Start with a motif

A short idea of three to five notes with a clear rhythm, simple enough to sing back.

2 Repeat it, then change one thing

A new last note, a new rhythm or a new starting beat. Repetition makes a solo sound composed.

3 Call and response

Ask a question by ending away from the root, then answer it with a phrase that comes home.

4 Leave space

Rest as long as you play. Breathe where a singer would, and let the listener hear what you just said.

5 Land on chord tones

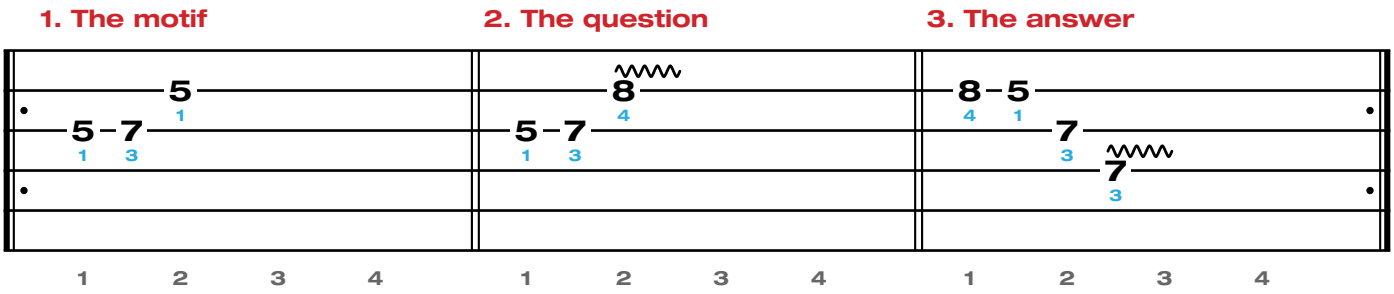
End phrases on the root, 3rd or 5th of the chord of the moment. Other notes are tension that wants to move.

6 Shape the dynamics

Start soft, build, and save the highest note and the widest bend for the peak of the solo.

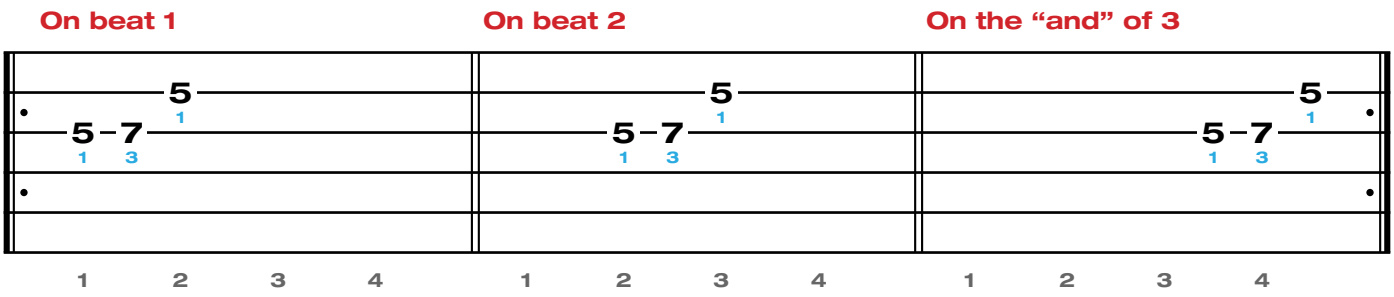
Hear it: a motif, a question and an answer

A minor pentatonic, Block 1



The small numbers are the beats. Each phrase lasts two beats and is followed by two beats of silence. Bars 1 and 2 begin with the same two notes, so the ear hears one idea growing. Bar 2 stops on G and leaves the phrase open; bar 3 walks back down and settles on the root, A.

Move it: the same three notes on a different beat



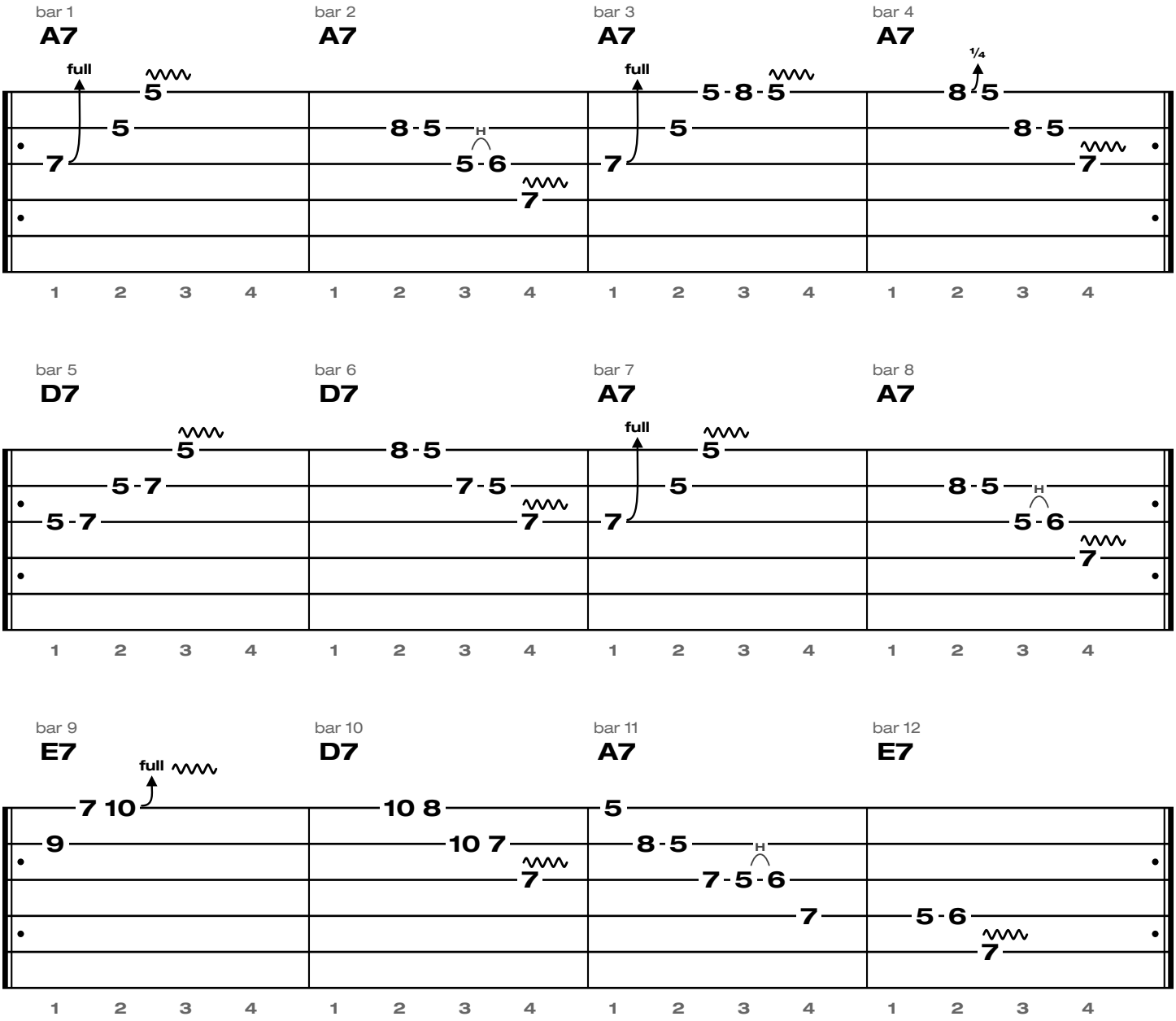
Nothing changes but the starting point, and each version feels different against the beat. Starting late, or just before the bar line, is one of the simplest ways to make a familiar lick sound new.

PRACTICE: Improvise for two minutes using only three notes. With nothing else to change, you will start to shape rhythm, space and tone.

12-Bar Blues Solo Study

One chorus in A that puts bends, vibrato and phrasing to work over the form on page 45

Shuffle feel, 80 to 100 BPM • the small numbers under each staff are the beats



- **Bars 1–2: call and answer.** The bend and the high A ask; the answer falls through G and E and hammers from C to C♯, the major 3rd of A7, before landing on the root.
- **Bars 3–4: the call again, with a longer tail** that ends on D, the root of the chord that is about to arrive.
- **Bars 5–6: the same shape over D7.** C♯ is gone and F♯, the 3rd of D7, takes its place.
- **Bars 9–10: the peak.** G♯ and B spell E7, the highest bend in the solo reaches the root E, and the D7 bar steps down from there.
- **Bars 11–12: the turnaround** runs down the box and ends G, G♯, E: G rises a half step to the 3rd of E7, then falls to its root, pulling back to bar 1.

PRACTICE: Learn it two bars at a time, sing each phrase before you play it, then write your own answer to bars 1, 3 and 7.


Anaheim, CA • House of Blues

SEVEN MAJOR MODES

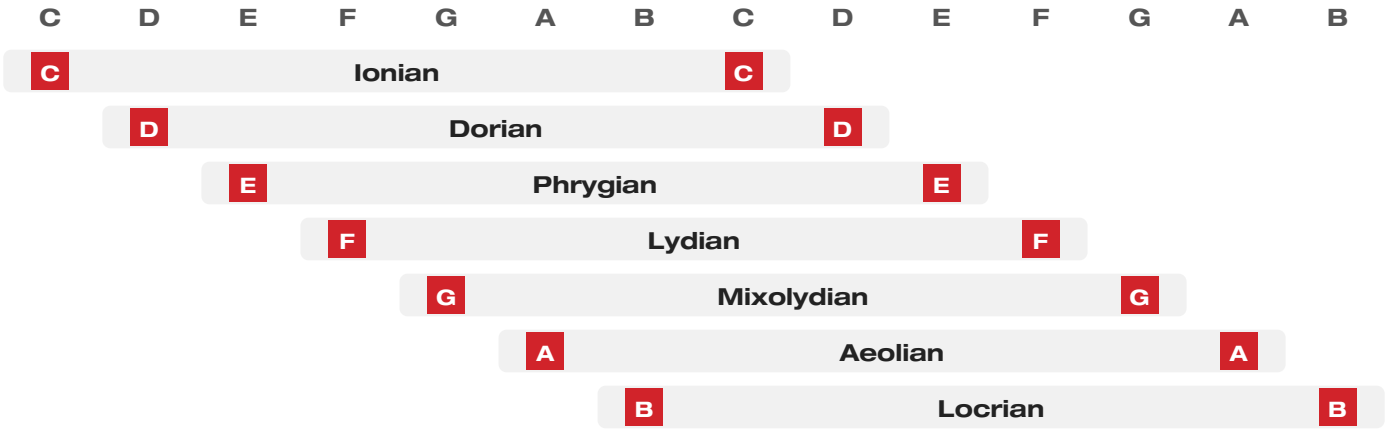


Understanding the Seven Modes

One major scale, seven different moods

What Is a Mode?

A mode is a major scale played from a different starting note. Play C D E F G A B C and you hear the bright, settled sound of the major scale. Play the very same notes from D to D and the music suddenly sounds darker and soulful. Nothing changed except the note that feels like "home," and that new home shifts the whole pattern of whole and half steps. That is all a mode is: the same seven notes, heard from a different center.



Each mode starts and ends on its own home note (red squares) but uses only the notes of C major.

Degree	Mode	In C	Formula	Sound
I	**Ionian**	C to C	1 2 3 4 5 6 7	Bright, resolved
II	**Dorian**	D to D	1 2 ♭3 4 5 6 ♭7	Soulful minor
III	**Phrygian**	E to E	1 ♭2 ♭3 4 5 ♭6 ♭7	Spanish, exotic
IV	**Lydian**	F to F	1 2 3 ♯4 5 6 7	Dreamy, floating
V	**Mixolydian**	G to G	1 2 3 4 5 6 ♭7	Bluesy swagger
VI	**Aeolian**	A to A	1 2 ♭3 4 5 ♭6 ♭7	Melancholy
VII	**Locrian**	B to B	1 ♭2 ♭3 4 ♭5 ♭6 ♭7	Unstable, tense

Hearing the Modes

A mode only reveals its character when your ear hears its home note as the center. Play each mode over a drone or a chord built on its starting note (D Dorian over a D minor chord, G Mixolydian over a G7) and listen for the notes that make it different: the natural 6th in Dorian, the ♭2 in Phrygian, the ♯4 in Lydian, the ♭7 in Mixolydian.

PRACTICE: Play C Ionian and D Dorian back to back over their own drones: the same notes, a different home, a different mood.

Two Ways to Order the Modes

The traditional order and the One-Note Changing Perspective

In the pages that follow you will meet the modes in their traditional order. Later in the book, the One-Note Changing Perspective arranges the very same modes in a different order. Neither order is better or worse. They simply answer two different questions.

The Traditional Order

Which mode lives on each note of a key?

1. **Ionian** starts on the 1st note
2. **Dorian** starts on the 2nd
3. **Phrygian** starts on the 3rd
4. **Lydian** starts on the 4th
5. **Mixolydian** starts on the 5th
6. **Aeolian** starts on the 6th
7. **Locrian** starts on the 7th

Each mode is numbered by the scale degree it starts on. All seven share one key signature, so this order is ideal for finding the modes inside a key and for seeing how they fit chords like the II–V–I.

One-Note Changing Perspective

How bright or dark is each mode?

1. **Lydian** the brightest
2. **Ionian** lower the #4
3. **Mixolydian** lower the 7
4. **Dorian** lower the 3
5. **Aeolian** lower the 6
6. **Phrygian** lower the 2
7. **Locrian** lower the 5: the darkest

Inspired by George Russell and his Lydian Chromatic Concept (1953), built on the Lydian scale, whose notes stack up in perfect 5ths. Every mode shares the same root, and each step lowers exactly one note.

One Note at a Time

C Lydian	1	2	3	#4	5	6	7	*brightest*
C Ionian	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	
C Mixolydian	1	2	3	4	5	6	♭7	
C Dorian	1	2	♭3	4	5	6	♭7	
C Aeolian	1	2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7	
C Phrygian	1	♭2	♭3	4	5	♭6	♭7	
C Locrian	1	♭2	♭3	4	♭5	♭6	♭7	*darkest*

Blue marks the one note that is lowered to create the next, darker mode.

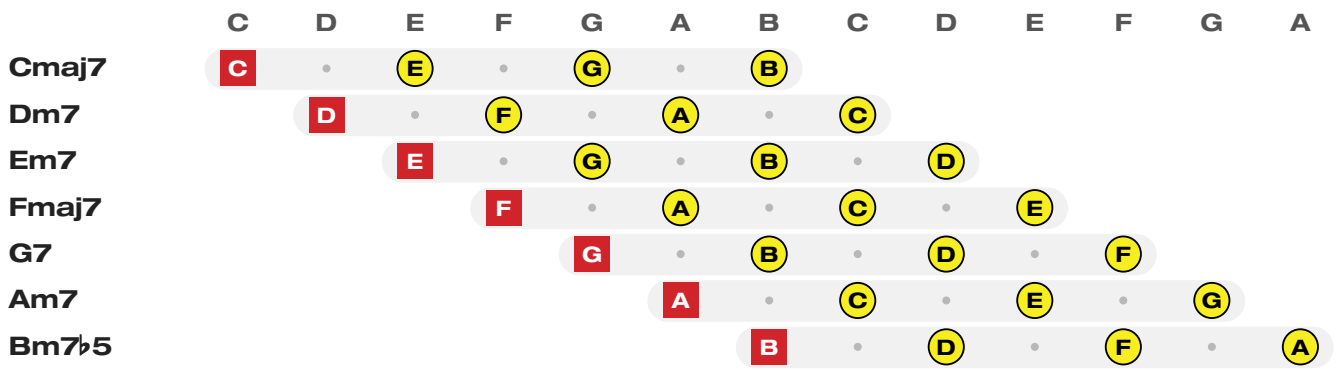
Why they differ: the traditional order compares modes that share the same notes but start on different roots (C Ionian, D Dorian, E Phrygian...). The One-Note Changing Perspective compares modes that share the same root but change one note at a time (C Lydian, C Ionian, C Mixolydian...). One shows you where the modes live; the other shows you how they sound. Together they give you the complete picture.

PRACTICE: Play C Lydian and then C Ionian over the same C drone, and listen to how changing one note changes the whole mood.

The Seven Chords of a Key

Which chord each mode belongs to, and which scale to play over any chord

Stack every other note of the major scale on each of its seven notes and you get seven chords, one for each mode. Play a mode over its own chord and every note fits.



Red = the root. Take a note, skip a note, four times: root, 3rd, 5th and 7th.

Degree	Triad	7th chord	Notes	Mode	Page
I	C	Cmaj7	C E G B	C Ionian	82
ii	Dm	Dm7	D F A C	D Dorian	83
iii	Em	Em7	E G B D	E Phrygian	84
IV	F	Fmaj7	F A C E	F Lydian	85
V	G	G7	G B D F	G Mixolydian	86
vi	Am	Am7	A C E G	A Aeolian	87
vii°	Bdim	Bm7♭5	B D F A	B Locrian	88

The order of chord types is the same in every major key: maj7, m7, m7, maj7, 7, m7, m7♭5.
The mode pages show each pattern from a G root: slide it to the root you need.

A chord-to-scale map

the numbers are the pages where each scale is shown

Over this chord	Start with	Then try
major, 6, maj7	Ionian (82)	Lydian (85), major pentatonic (39)
minor, m7	Dorian (83)	Aeolian (87), minor pentatonic (38), blues (41)
m6	Dorian (83)	melodic minor (49), Coltrane pentatonic (40)
m(maj7)	melodic minor (49)	harmonic minor (46)
7, 9, 13	Mixolydian (86)	blues (41), major blues (44), Lydian dominant (50)
7♭9 going to minor	Phrygian dominant (48)	half-whole diminished (51), altered (50)
7♯9, 7alt	altered (50)	half-whole diminished (51), blues (41)
7♯5	whole tone (51)	altered (50)
m7♭5	Locrian (88)	the m7♭5 arpeggio (61)
dim7	whole-half diminished (51)	the dim7 arpeggio (58)

One key, many chords: the II-V-I in C on page 30 (Dm7, G7, Cmaj7) takes D Dorian, G Mixolydian and C Ionian, the same seven notes each time. The scale does not change; the note you aim for does.
One chord, many colors: when a chord lasts a long time, choose the mode by its sound, as the next page shows.

PRACTICE: Play the seven 7th chords of C major in order, then play each mode over a recording of its own chord.

A Vamp for Every Mode

Seven short chord loops over an open A string, one for each mode

A mode only sounds like itself when the music keeps telling your ear where home is. Each vamp keeps the open A string ringing in the bass and adds a chord that contains the mode's characteristic note. Record two bars of each chord, loop them and solo with the mode. All seven share the root A, so you hear exactly what each mode changes.

The red square is the open A string: home for every vamp • Numbers are fingers • x = don't play

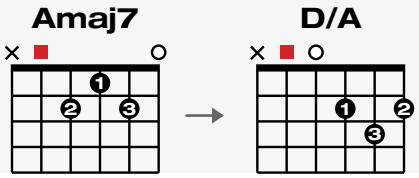
The patterns on pages 82–88 are drawn from a G root: play them two frets higher and the red squares land on A.

A Ionian *bright, resolved*

1 2 3 **4** 5 6 **7**

Listen for D (the 4th) and G♯ (the 7th)

Notes of A major • patterns on page 82

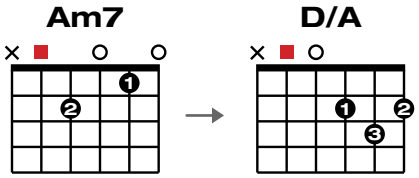


A Dorian *soulful minor*

1 2 ♭3 4 5 **6** ♭7

Listen for F♯ (the natural 6th)

Notes of G major • patterns on page 83

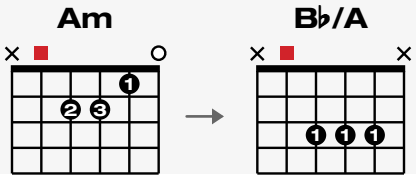


A Phrygian *Spanish, exotic*

1 **♭2** ♭3 4 5 ♭6 ♭7

Listen for B♭ (the ♭2)

Notes of F major • patterns on page 84

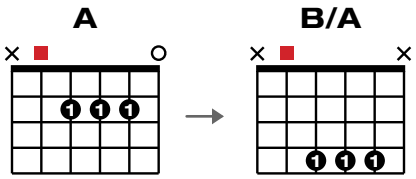


A Lydian *dreamy, floating*

1 2 3 **♯4** 5 6 7

Listen for D♯ (the ♯4)

Notes of E major • patterns on page 85

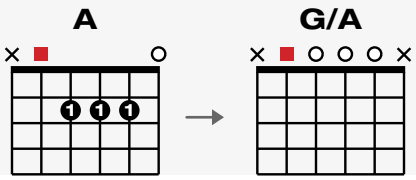


A Mixolydian *bluesy swagger*

1 2 3 4 5 6 **♭7**

Listen for G (the ♭7)

Notes of D major • patterns on page 86

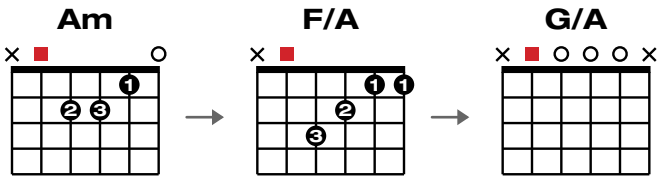


A Aeolian *melancholy*

1 2 ♭3 4 5 **♭6** ♭7

Listen for F (the ♭6)

Notes of C major • patterns on page 87

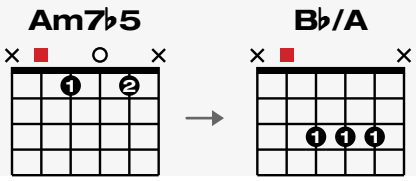


A Locrian *unstable, tense*

1 ♭2 ♭3 4 **♭5** ♭6 ♭7

Listen for E♭ (the ♭5)

Notes of B♭ major • patterns on page 88

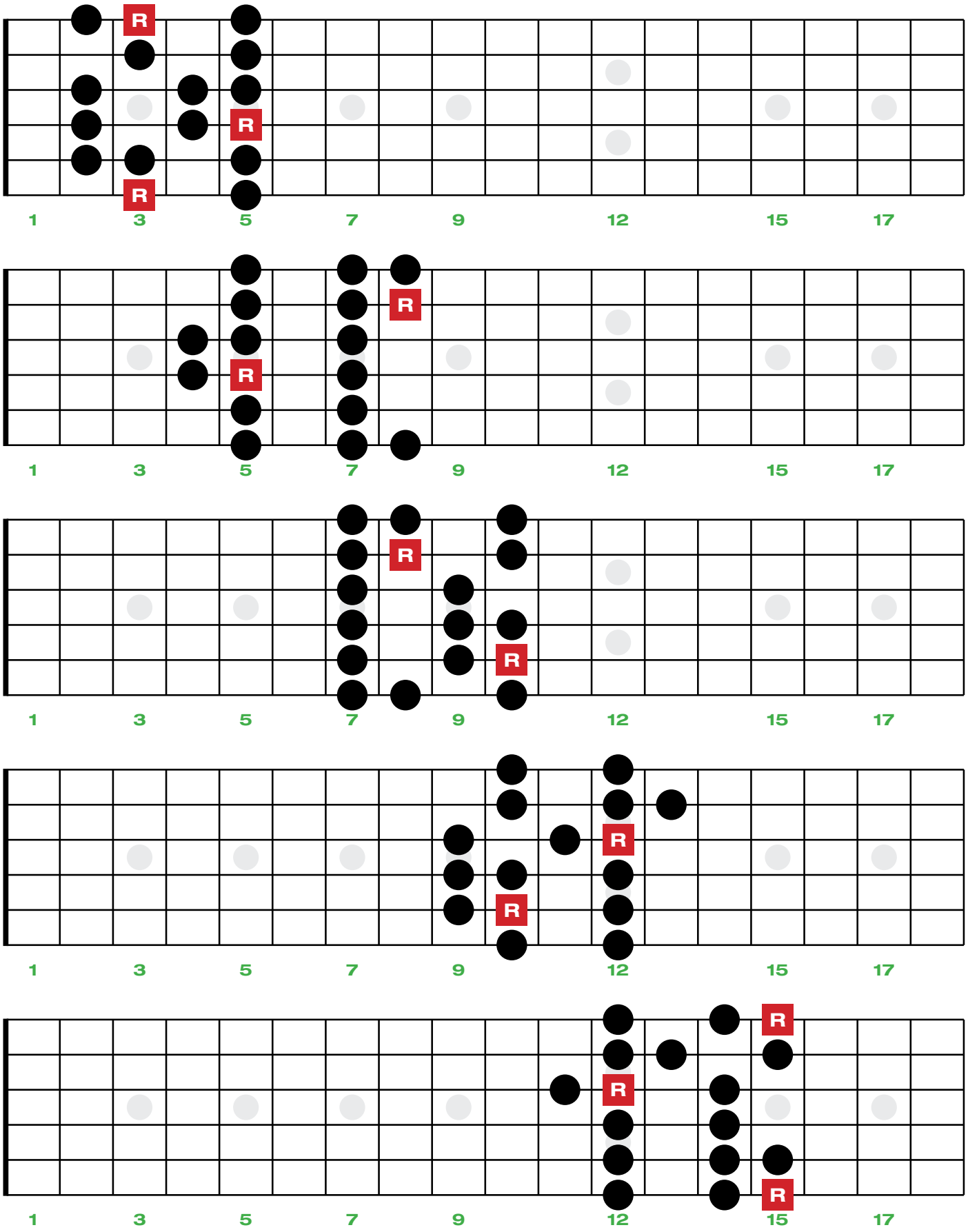


PRACTICE: Loop one vamp for five minutes. Start every phrase from A, then end every phrase on the note the page tells you to listen for.

Ionian Mode • Major Scale

Traditional order of the Seven Major Modes

The red square indicates the root note of the key • Play these patterns in all 12 keys.

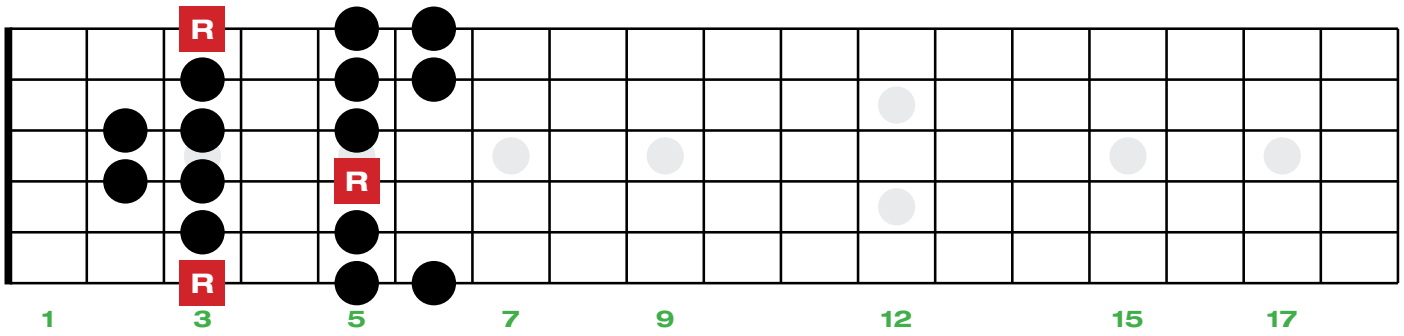


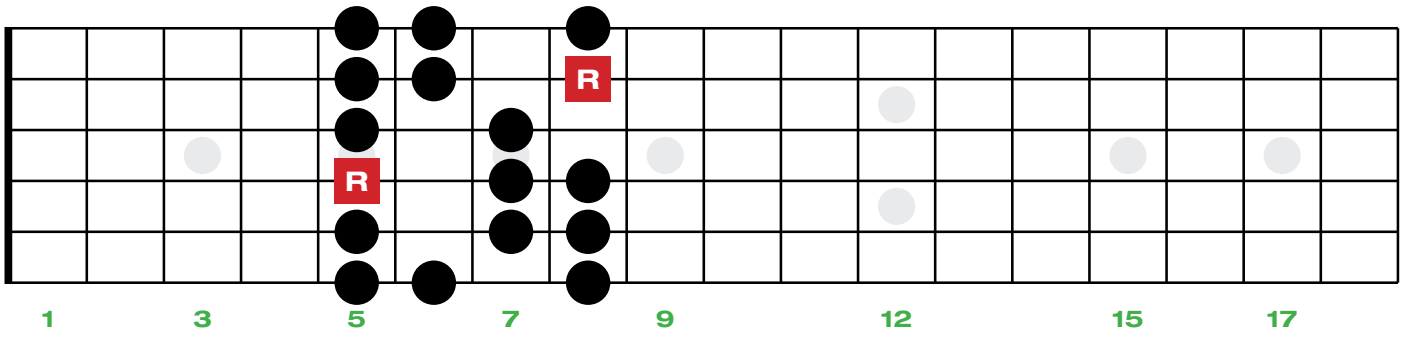
PRACTICE: Play each pattern over a root-note drone and listen for the bright, resolved sound of the major scale.

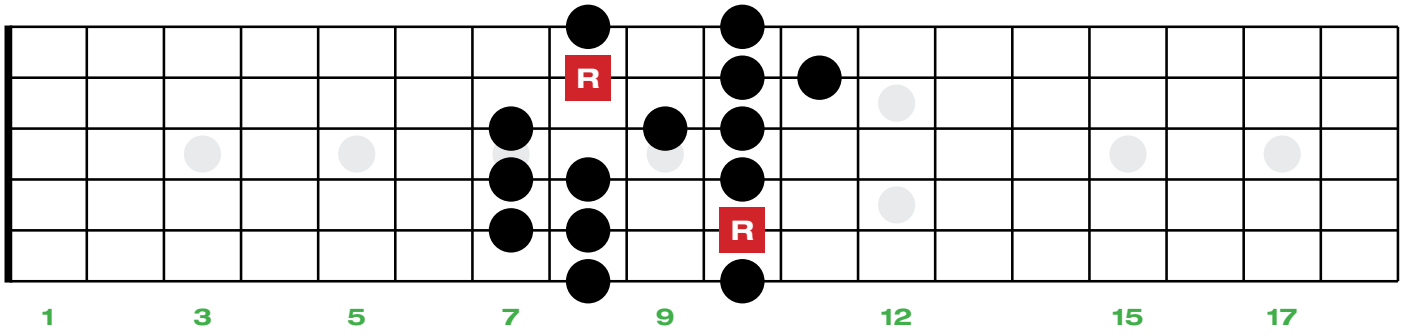
Dorian Mode

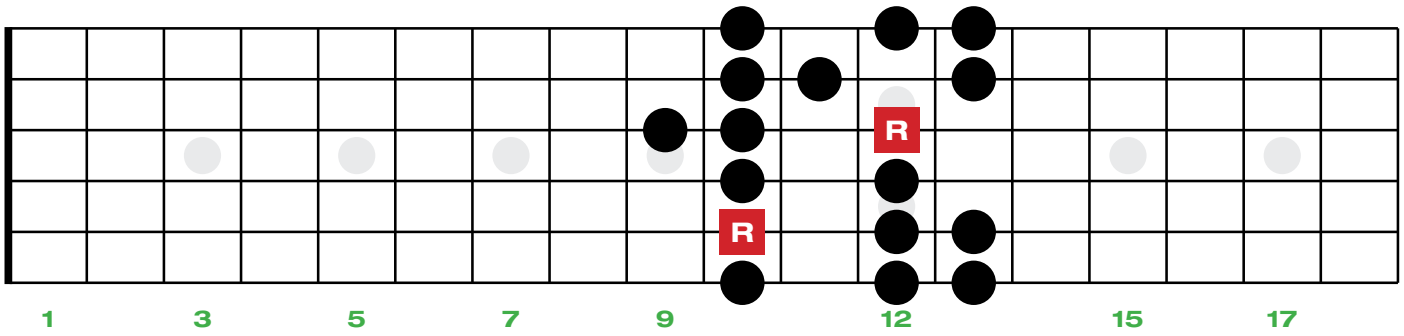
Traditional order of the Seven Major Modes

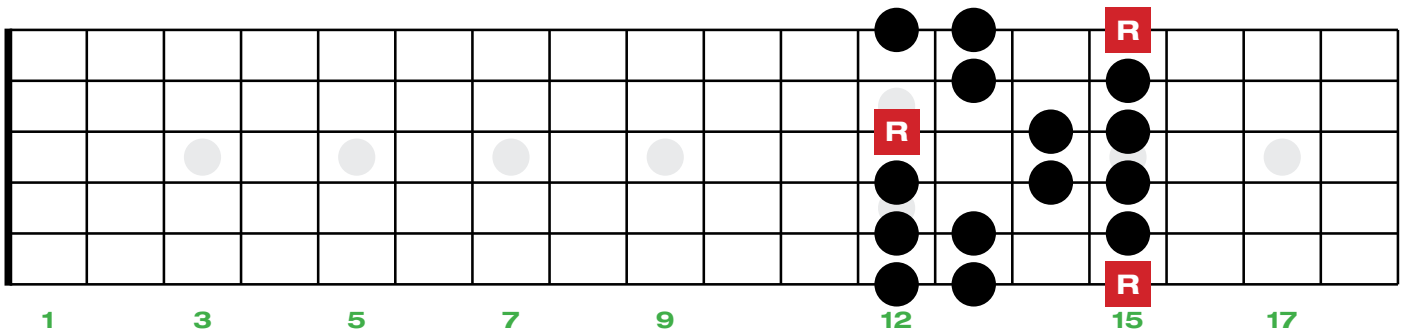
The red square indicates the root note of the key • Play these patterns in all 12 keys.









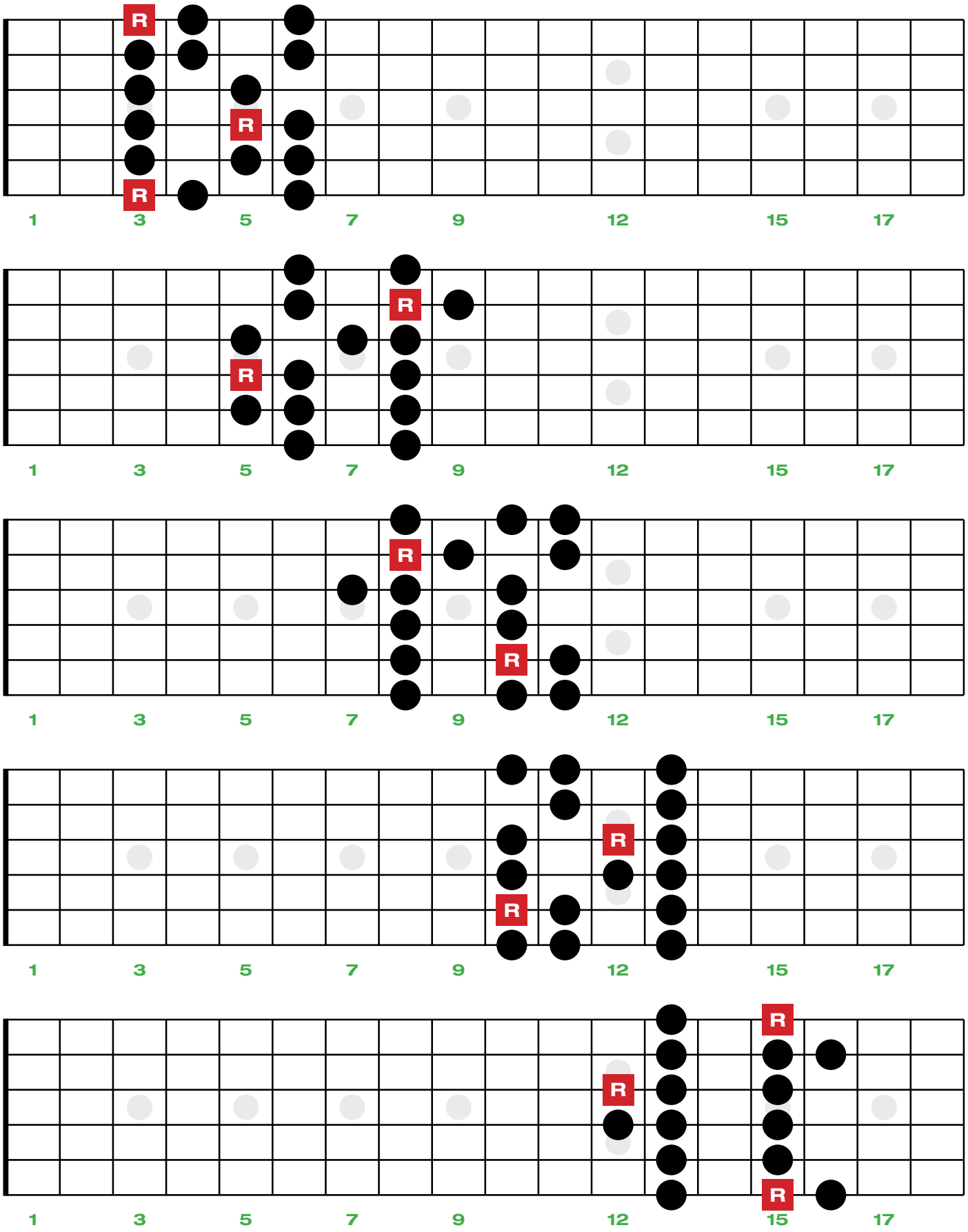


PRACTICE: Play over a minor 7 vamp and emphasize the natural 6th to hear Dorian's soulful color.

Phrygian Mode

Traditional order of the Seven Major Modes

The red square indicates the root note of the key • Play these patterns in all 12 keys.

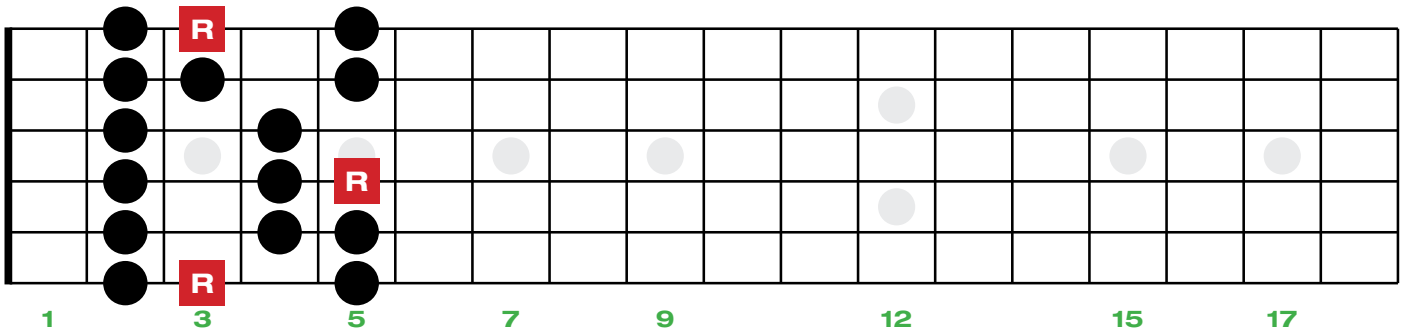


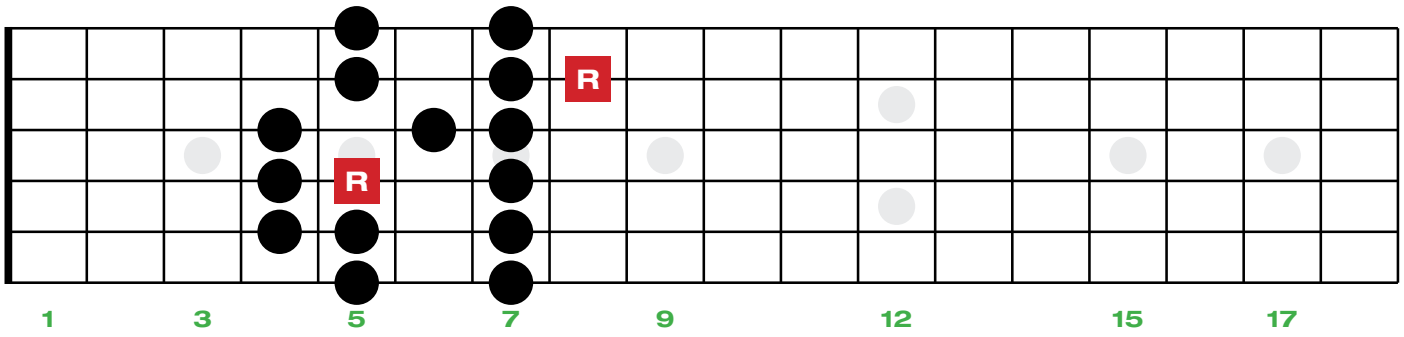
PRACTICE: Play over a root-note drone and lean on the ♭2 to hear Phrygian's Spanish flavor.

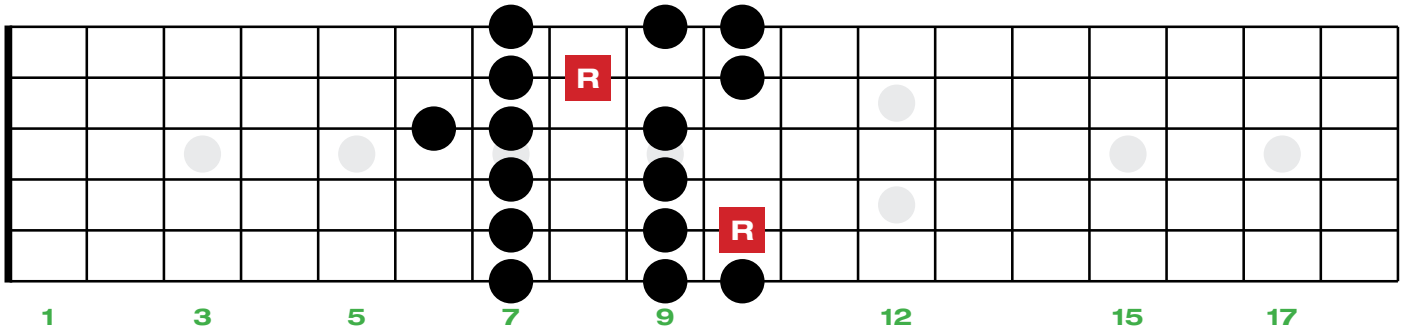
Lydian Mode

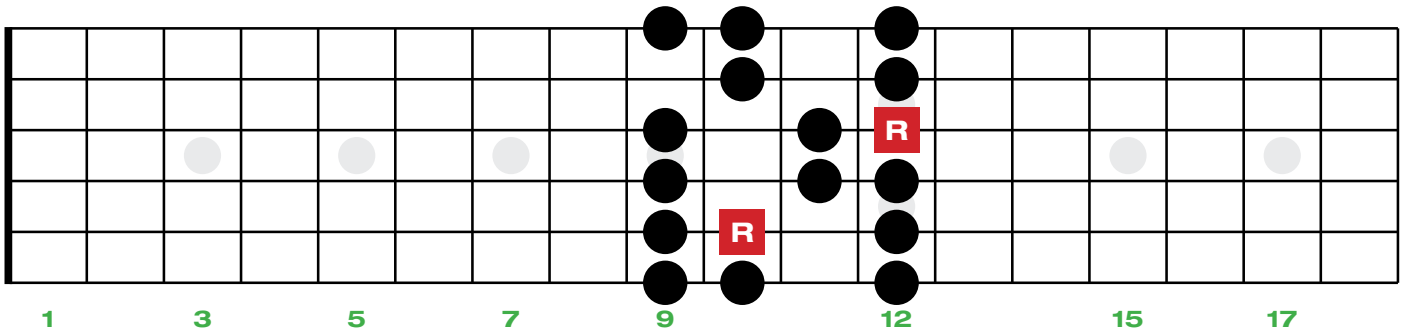
Traditional order of the Seven Major Modes

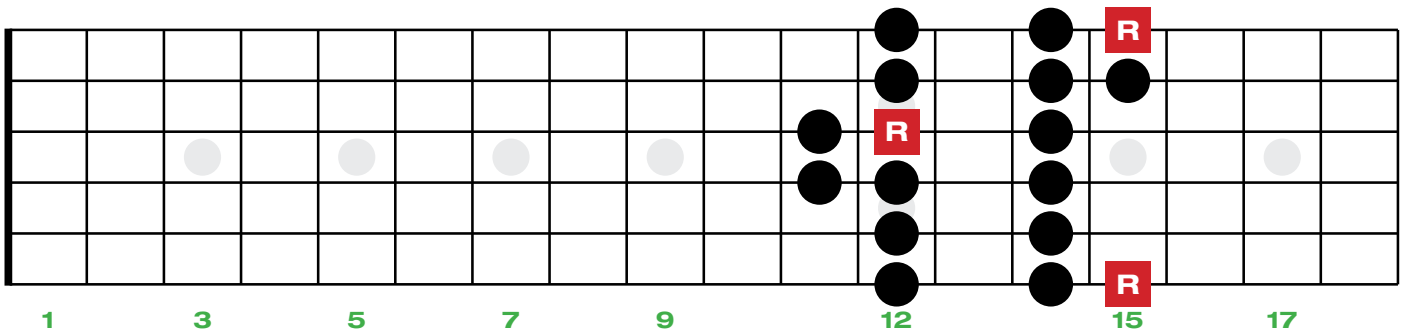
The red square indicates the root note of the key • Play these patterns in all 12 keys.









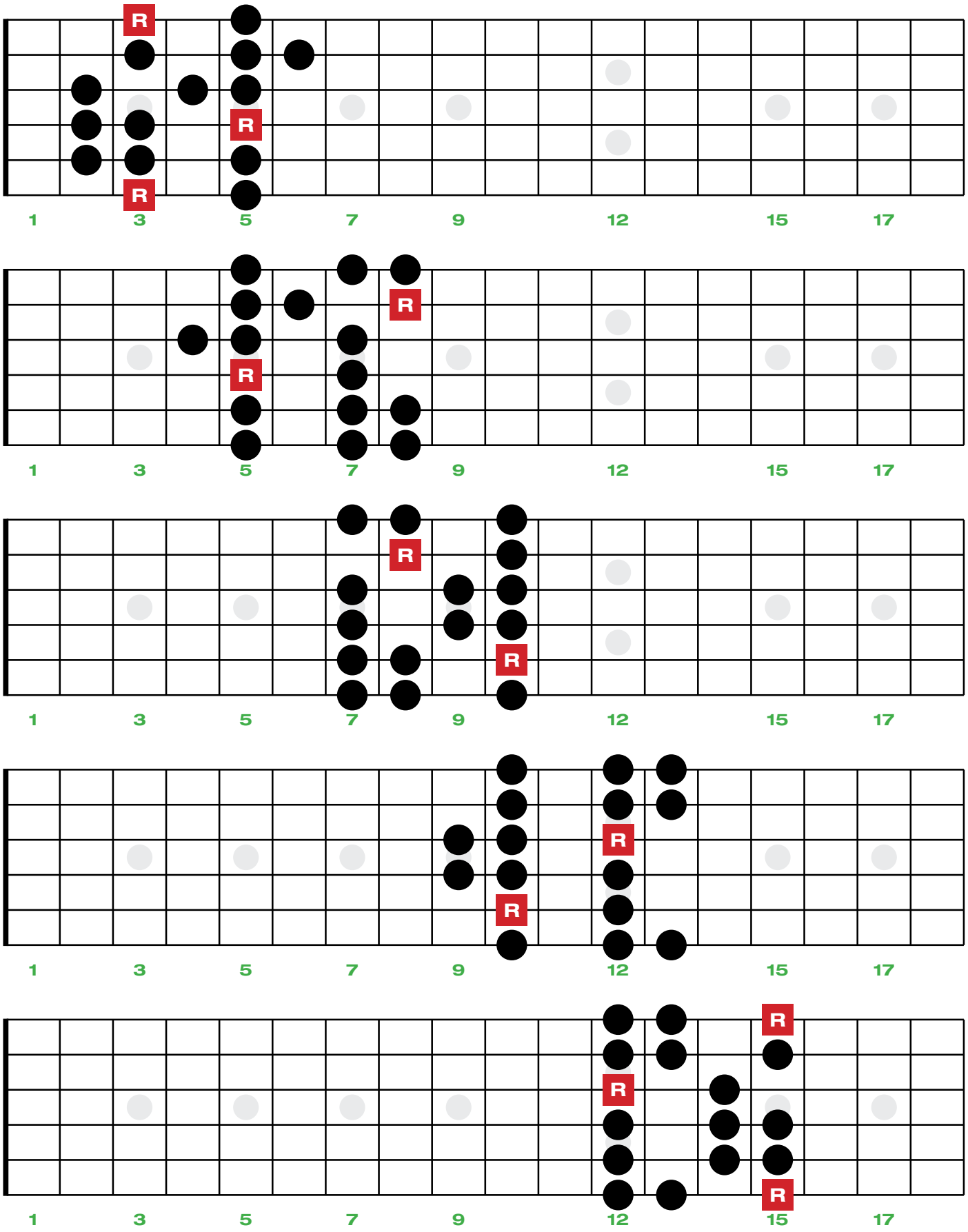


PRACTICE: Play over a sustained major chord and let the #4 hang in the air for Lydian's dreamy sound.

Mixolydian Mode

Traditional order of the Seven Major Modes

The red square indicates the root note of the key • Play these patterns in all 12 keys.

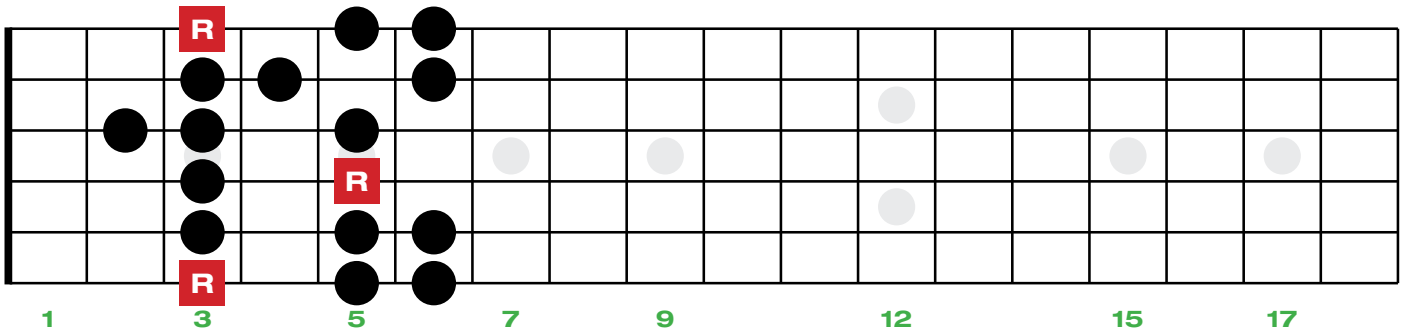


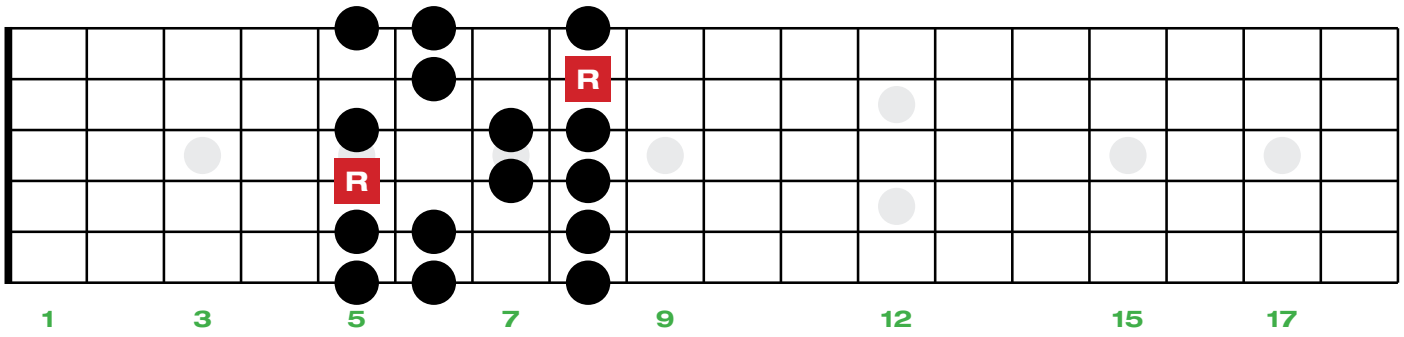
PRACTICE: Play over a dominant 7 groove and emphasize the ♭7 for Mixolydian's bluesy swagger.

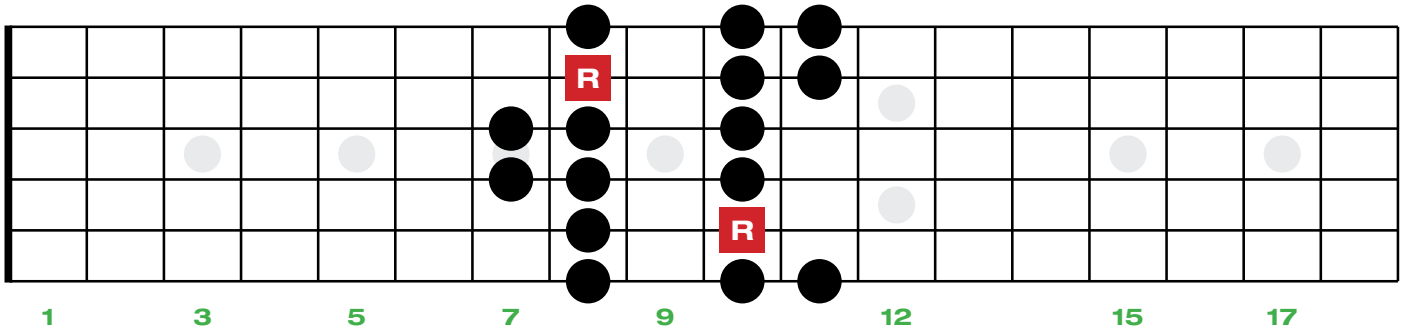
Aeolian Mode • Minor Scale

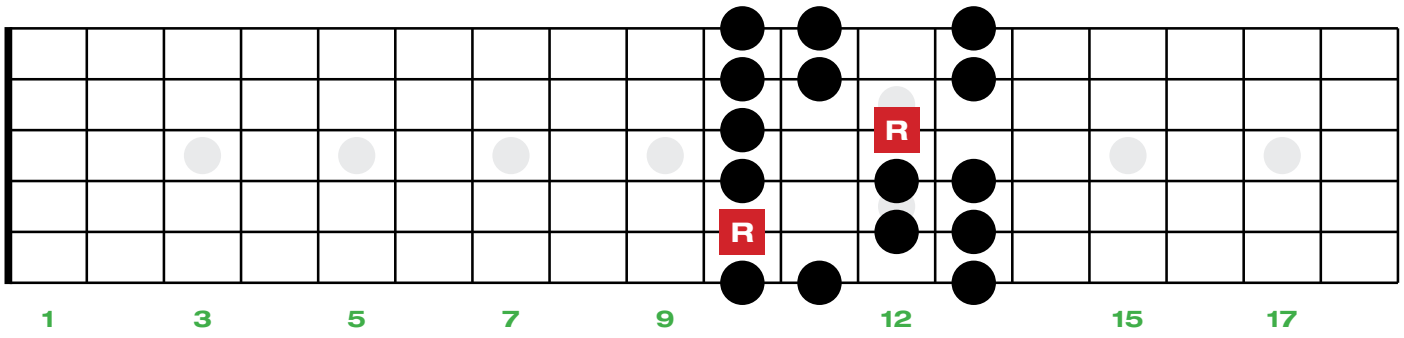
Traditional order of the Seven Major Modes

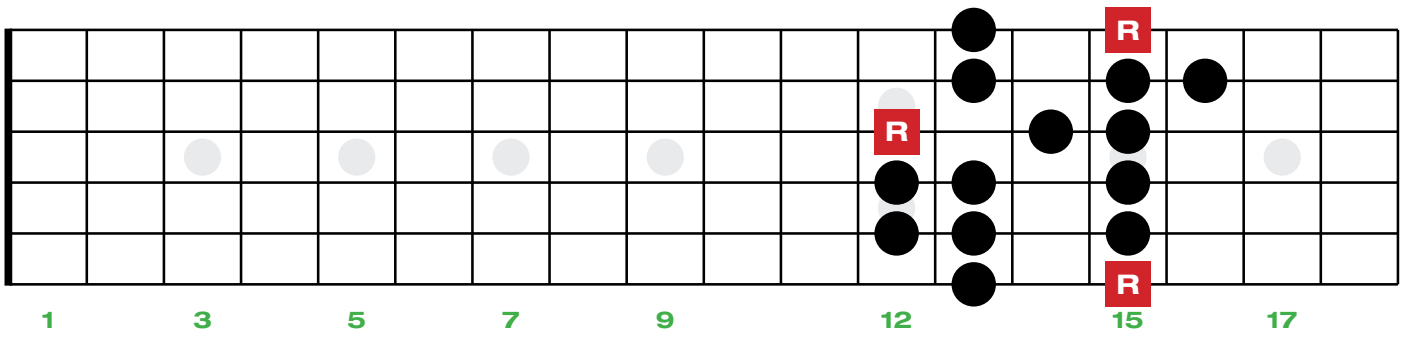
The red square indicates the root note of the key • Play these patterns in all 12 keys.









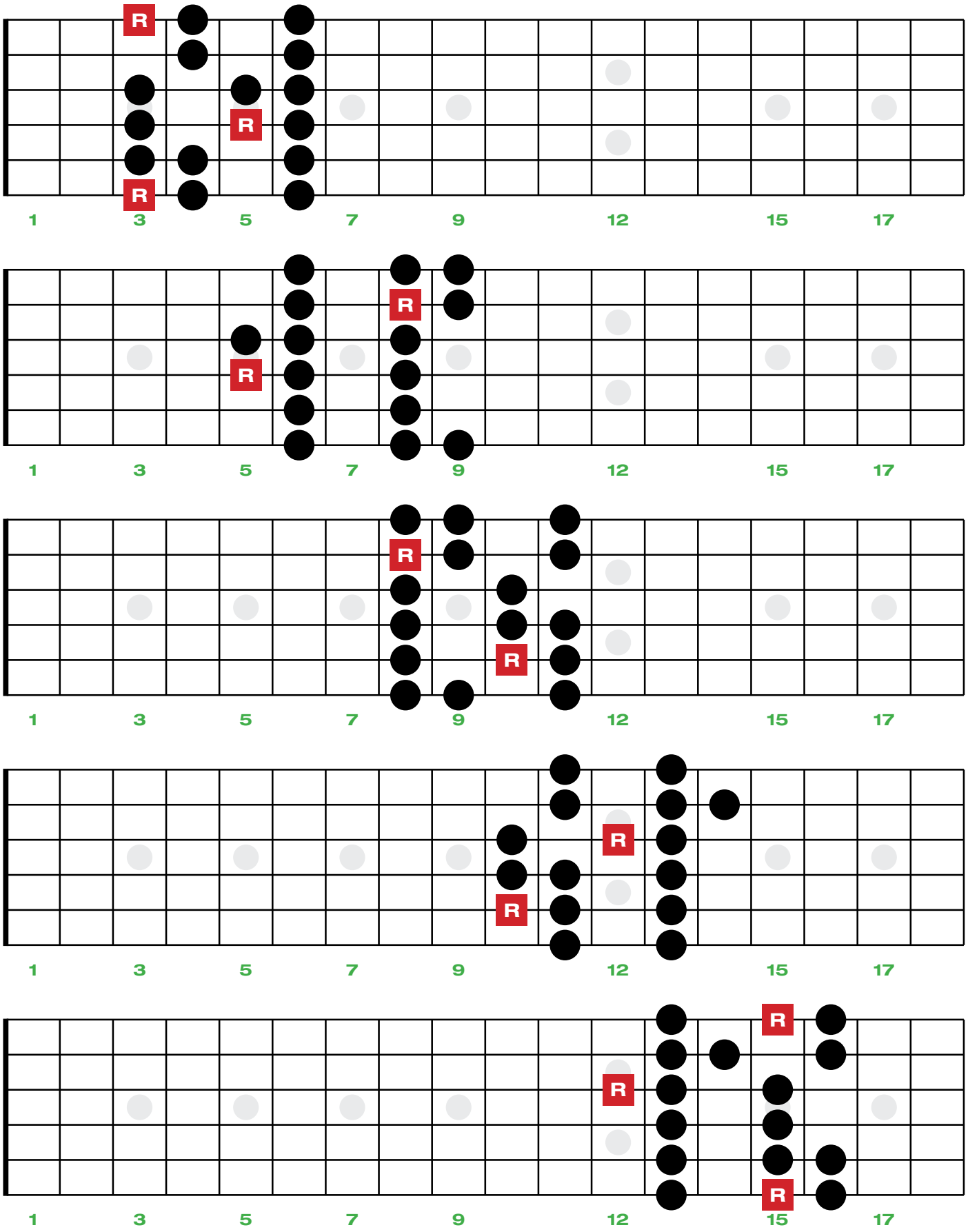


PRACTICE: Play over a minor drone and linger on the ♭6 to hear Aeolian's melancholy.

Locrian Mode

Traditional order of the Seven Major Modes

The red square indicates the root note of the key • Play these patterns in all 12 keys.



PRACTICE: Play over a m7♭5 chord and lean into the ♭5 to hear Locrian's unresolved tension.

MODAL PENTATONICS



What Are Modal Pentatonics?

Five-Note Portraits of the Seven Modes

The Seven Major Modes each have seven notes. That's a lot of information to carry into a solo. A modal pentatonic keeps only five of them: the notes that define the mode's character. You get the easy, two-notes-per-string feel of the pentatonic scale with the unmistakable color of the mode.

The recipe: keep the root, the 3rd and the 5th so the chord quality is clear. Then keep the notes that give the mode its color. For Ionian, Lydian, Mixolydian and Locrian, that means the 4th and the 7th. Dorian, Phrygian and Aeolian all share the same 4th and 7th, so for them we swap in each mode's signature note instead (Dorian's natural 6th, Phrygian's ♭2 and Aeolian's ♭6).

Mode	Formula	Notes in C	Mood	Sounds like
Ionian	R Δ3 p4 p5 Δ7	C E F G B	Sweet	Neal Schon, Brian May
Dorian	R ♭3 p5 Δ6 ♭7	C E♭ G A B♭	Soulful	Carlos Santana
Phrygian	R ♭2 ♭3 p5 ♭7	C D♭ E♭ G B♭	Exotic menace	Al Di Meola
Lydian	R Δ3 ♯4 p5 Δ7	C E F♯ G B	Dreamy	Joe Satriani, Eric Johnson
Mixolydian	R Δ3 p4 p5 ♭7	C E F G B♭	Southern swagger	Allman Brothers
Aeolian	R ♭3 p5 ♭6 ♭7	C E♭ G A♭ B♭	Melancholy	Gary Moore
Locrian	R ♭3 p4 ♭5 ♭7	C E♭ F G♭ B♭	Evil	Tony Iommi, Slayer

How to use the pages that follow

1. Start with the full-neck map on the left. It shows every note of the scale from the open strings to the 24th fret, and the colored brackets show where each of the five blocks lives.
2. Learn one block at a time from the diagrams on the right. Each uses two notes per string. Some blocks need a wide stretch: play those slowly, or shift your hand rather than strain.
3. Connect the blocks. The top notes of one block are the bottom notes of the next, so you can travel the whole neck without a break. After Block 5 the cycle repeats 12 frets higher.
4. Hear the mood. Play each scale over a C drone or a matching vamp and let the character notes (the ones that aren't R, 3 or 5) do the talking.
5. Transpose. Every page is in C, but the shapes are movable. Slide the red roots to any key.

Moods from brightest to darkest: Lydian, Ionian, Mixolydian, Dorian, Aeolian, Phrygian, Locrian.

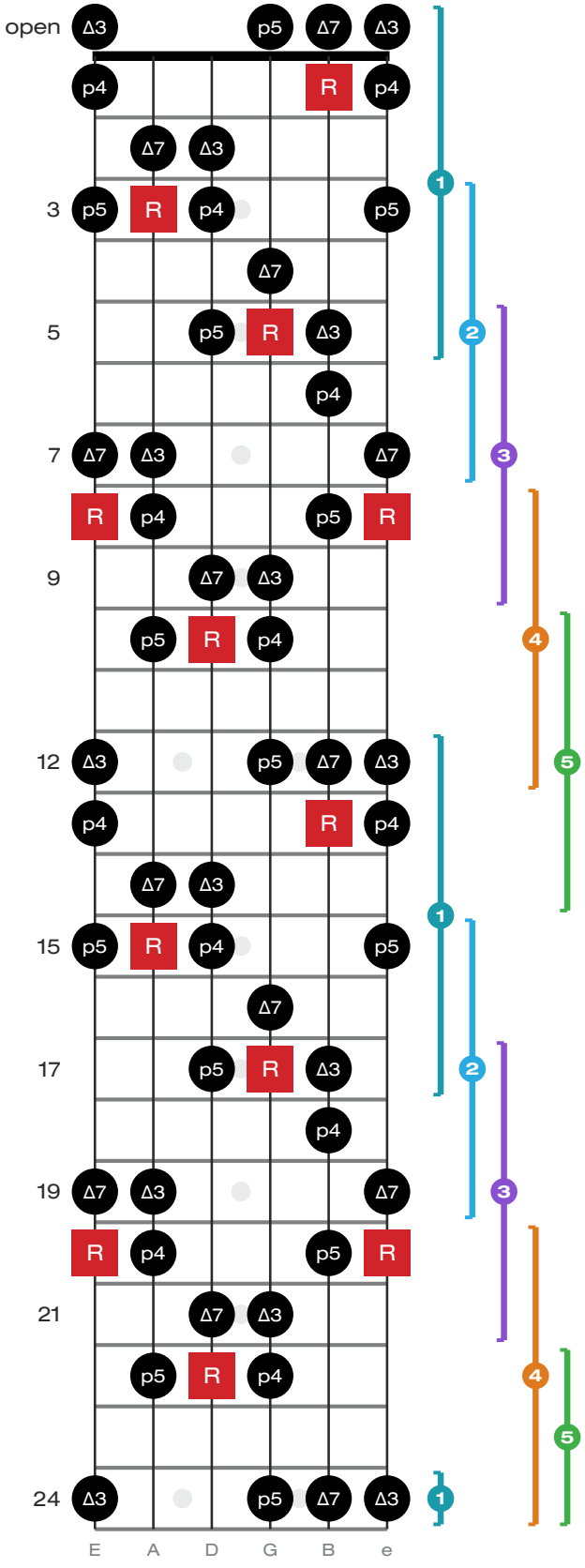
C Ionian Pentatonic

Full Neck Map · Five Blocks

Mood: Sweet · Sounds like: Neal Schon, Brian May, Andy Timmons

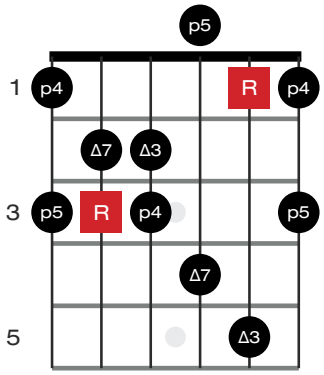
C · E · F · G · B (R · Δ3 · p4 · p5 · Δ7)

FULL NECK



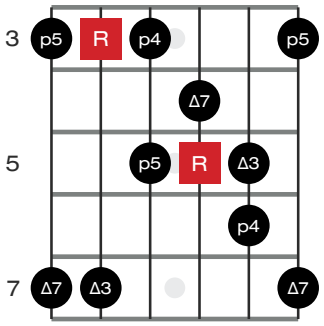
BLOCK 1

Frets 0–5 (also 12–17)



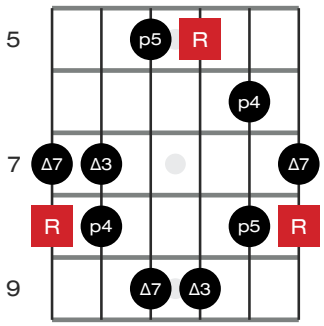
BLOCK 2

Frets 3–7 (also 15–19)



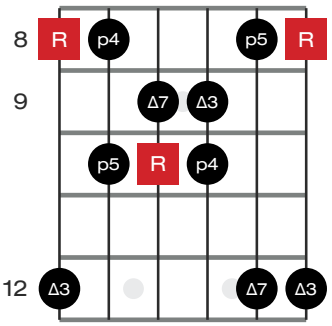
BLOCK 3

Frets 5–9 (also 17–21)



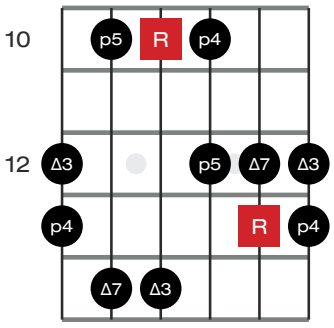
BLOCK 4

Frets 8–12 (also 20–24)



BLOCK 5

Frets 10–14



KEY

- R — C root
- Δ3 — E major 3rd
- p4 — F perfect 4th
- p5 — G perfect 5th
- Δ7 — B major 7th

Blocks link end to end: the top notes of one block are the bottom notes of the next.

After Block 5 the cycle repeats 12 frets higher, starting again with Block 1.

PRACTICE: Play each block over a C drone. Resolve phrases to the root and let the Δ7 ring sweetly.

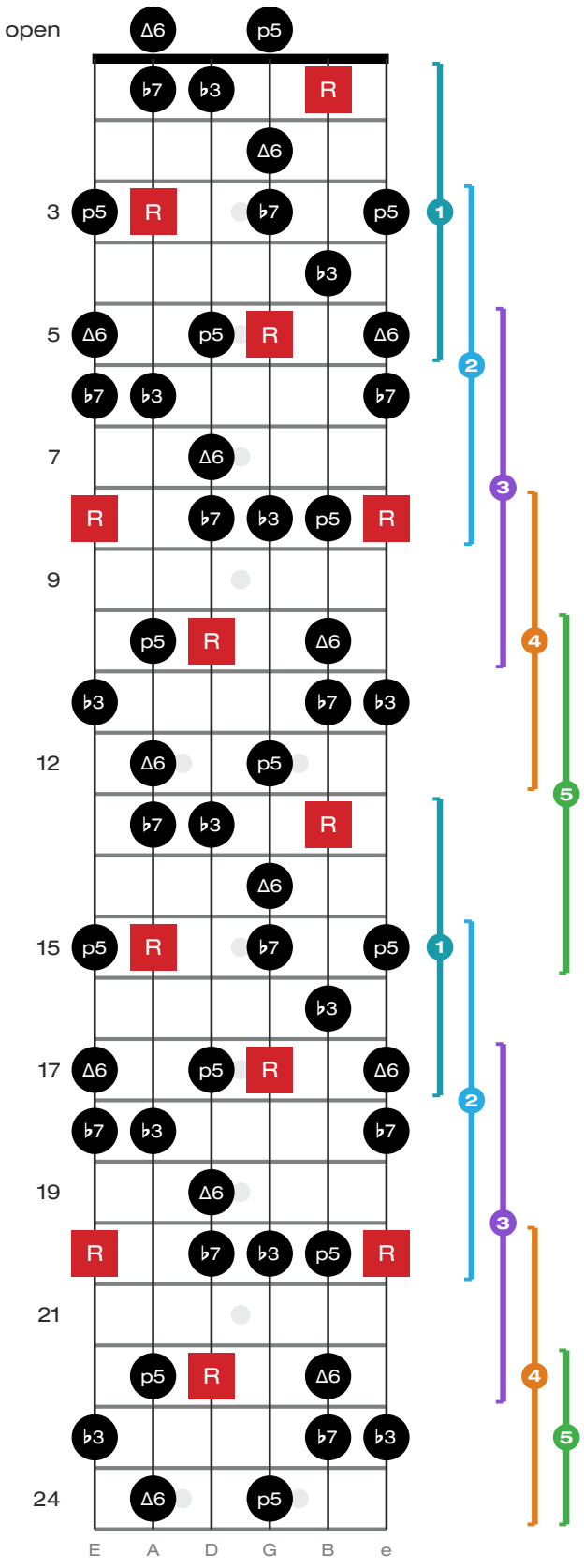
C Dorian Pentatonic

Full Neck Map · Five Blocks

Mood: Soulful · Sounds like: Carlos Santana, David Gilmour

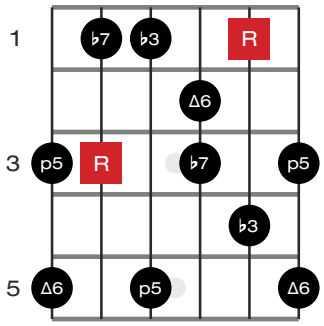
C · E♭ · G · A · B♭ (R · ♭3 · p5 · Δ6 · ♭7)

FULL NECK



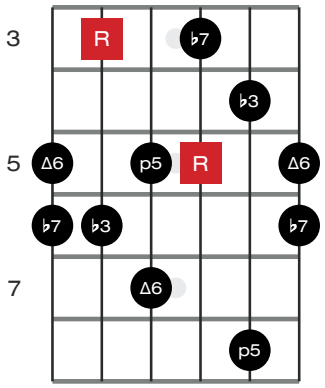
BLOCK 1

Frets 1–5 (also 13–17)



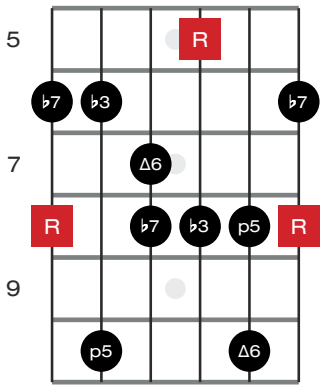
BLOCK 2

Frets 3–8 (also 15–20)



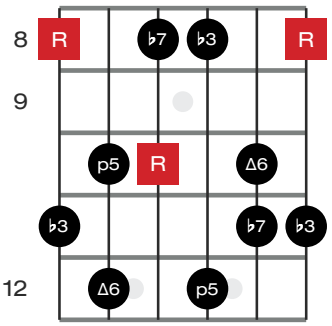
BLOCK 3

Frets 5–10 (also 17–22)



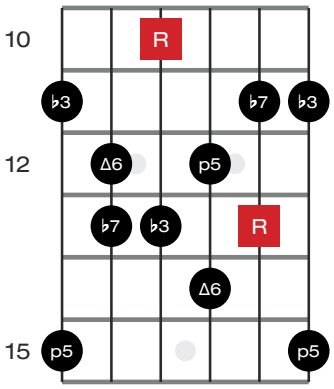
BLOCK 4

Frets 8–12 (also 20–24)



BLOCK 5

Frets 10–15



KEY

- R — C root
- ♭3 — E♭ minor 3rd
- p5 — G perfect 5th
- Δ6 — A major 6th
- ♭7 — B♭ minor 7th

Blocks link end to end: the top notes of one block are the bottom notes of the next.

After Block 5 the cycle repeats 12 frets higher, starting again with Block 1.

PRACTICE: Loop a Cm7 vamp and target the Δ6 (A). That one note makes Dorian sound soulful.

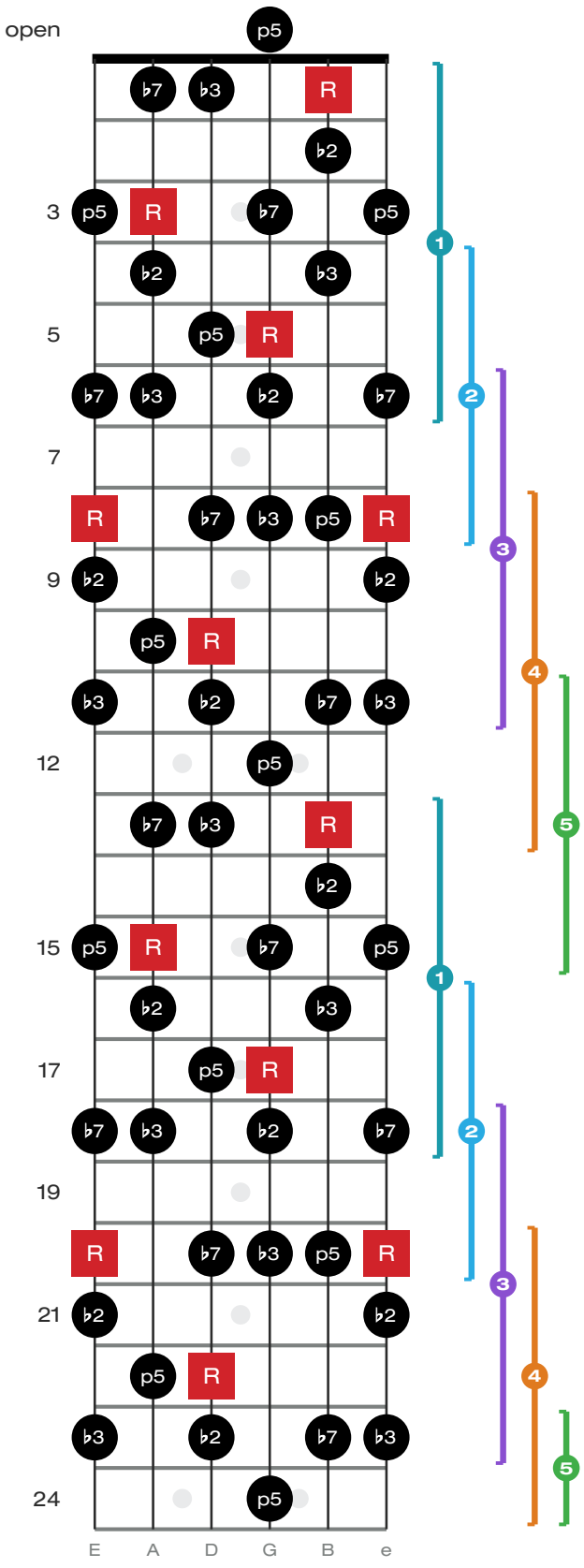
C Phrygian Pentatonic

Full Neck Map · Five Blocks

Mood: Exotic menace · Sounds like: Al Di Meola, Metallica

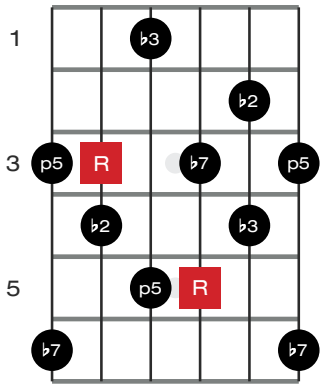
C · D♭ · E♭ · G · B♭ (R · ♭2 · ♭3 · p5 · ♭7)

FULL NECK



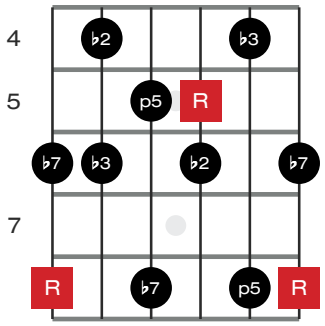
BLOCK 1

Frets 1–6 (also 13–18)



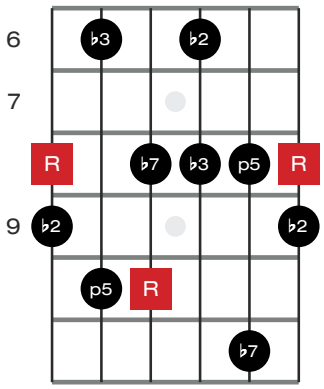
BLOCK 2

Frets 4–8 (also 16–20)



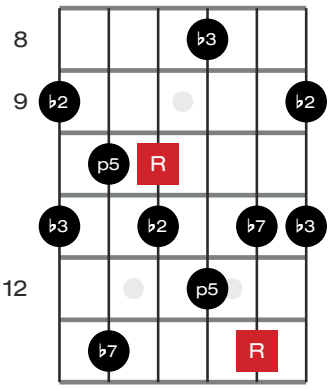
BLOCK 3

Frets 6–11 (also 18–23)



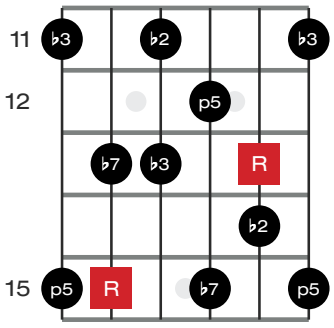
BLOCK 4

Frets 8–13



BLOCK 5

Frets 11–15



KEY

- R C root
- ♭2 D♭ minor 2nd
- ♭3 E♭ minor 3rd
- p5 G perfect 5th
- ♭7 B♭ minor 7th

Blocks link end to end: the top notes of one block are the bottom notes of the next.

After Block 5 the cycle repeats 12 frets higher, starting again with Block 1.

PRACTICE: Hold a low C drone and move from the ♭2 (D♭) back to the root for that Spanish tension.

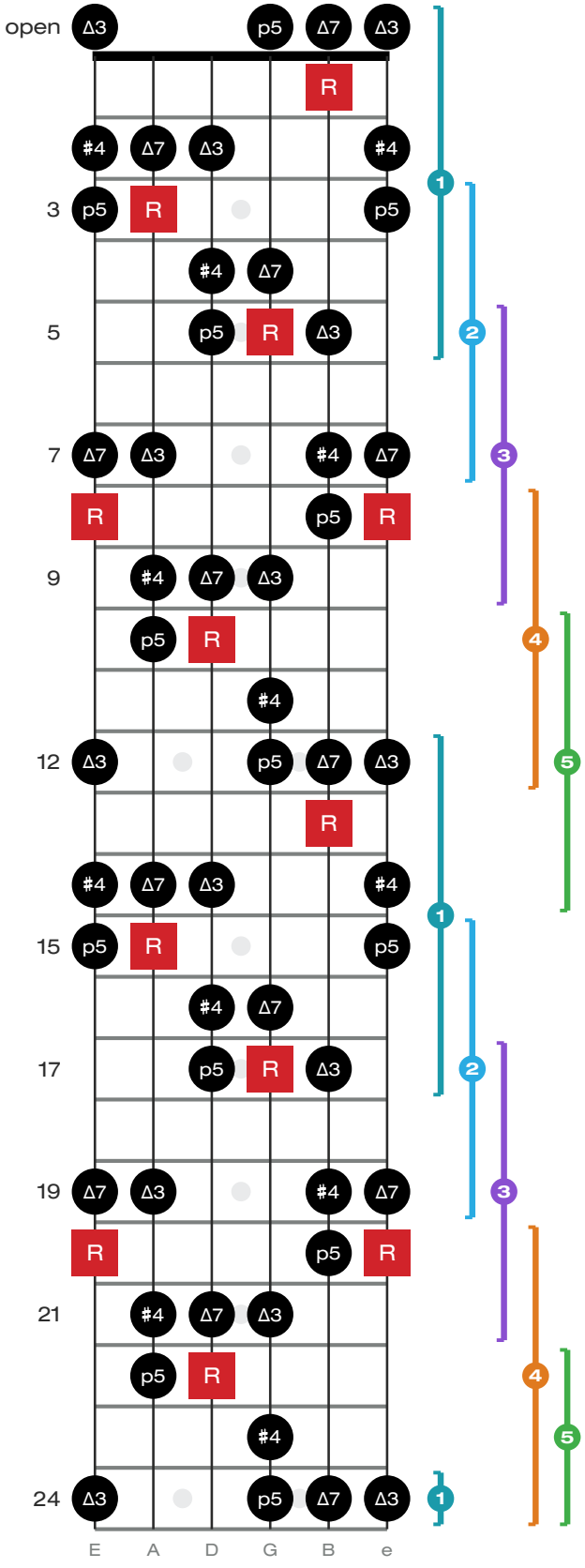
C Lydian Pentatonic

Full Neck Map · Five Blocks

Mood: Dreamy · Sounds like: Joe Satriani, Eric Johnson

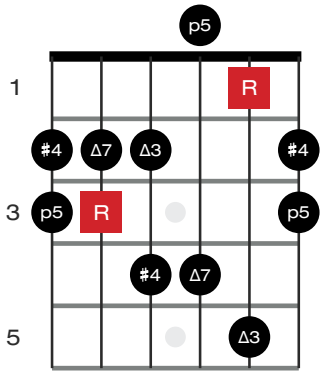
C · E · F♯ · G · B (R · Δ3 · ♯4 · p5 · Δ7)

FULL NECK



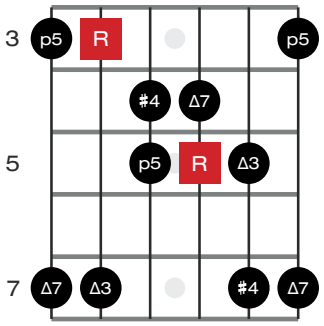
BLOCK 1

Frets 0–5 (also 12–17)



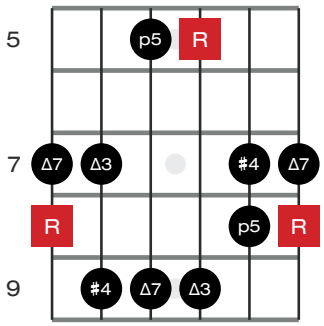
BLOCK 2

Frets 3–7 (also 15–19)



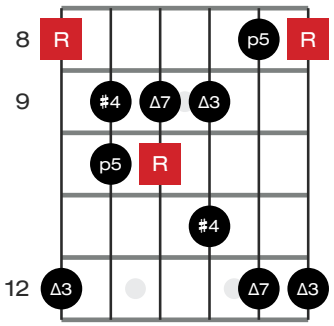
BLOCK 3

Frets 5–9 (also 17–21)



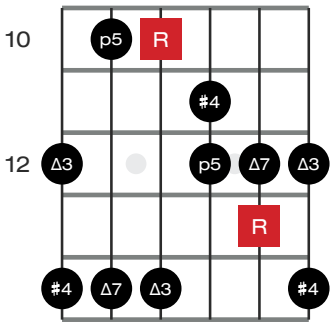
BLOCK 4

Frets 8–12 (also 20–24)



BLOCK 5

Frets 10–14



KEY

- R — C root
- Δ3 — E major 3rd
- ♯4 — F♯ raised 4th
- p5 — G perfect 5th
- Δ7 — B major 7th

Blocks link end to end: the top notes of one block are the bottom notes of the next.

After Block 5 the cycle repeats 12 frets higher, starting again with Block 1.

PRACTICE: Play over a sustained C major chord and let the ♯4 (F♯) hang in the air for the dreamy sound.

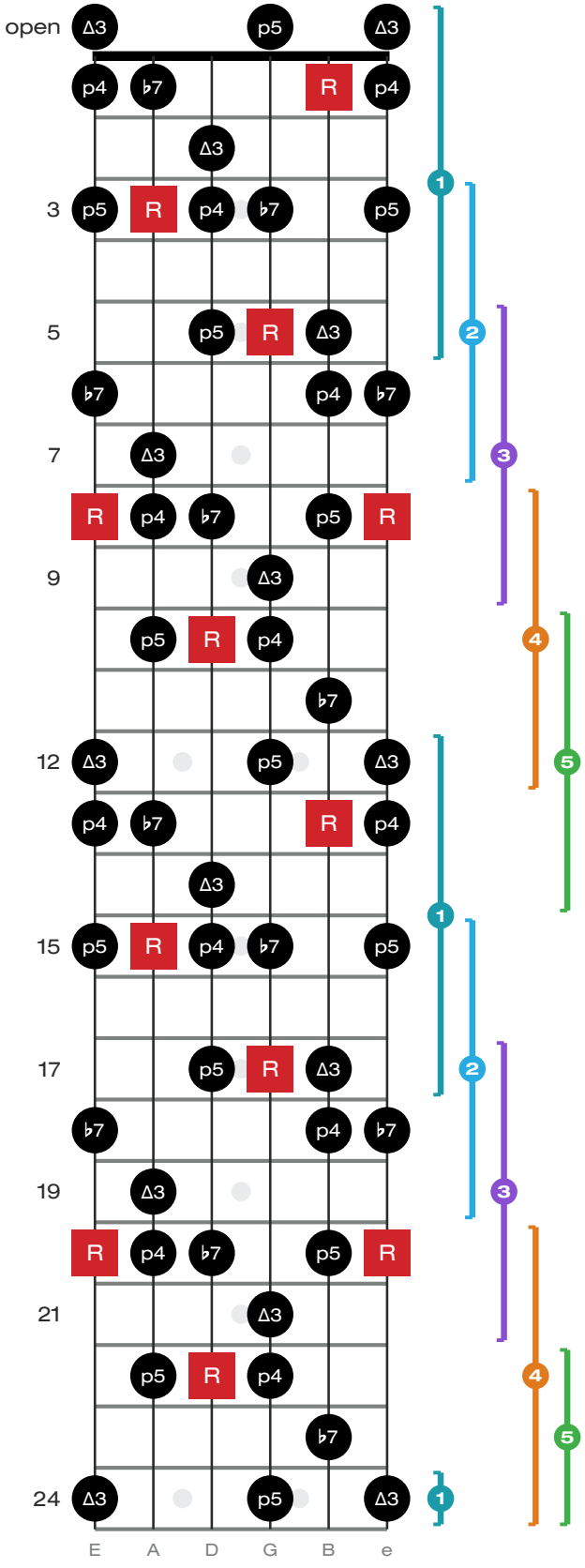
C Mixolydian Pentatonic

Full Neck Map · Five Blocks

Mood: Southern swagger · Sounds like: Allman Brothers, Lynyrd Skynyrd

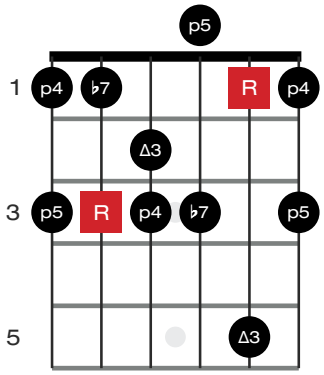
C · E · F · G · B♭ (R · Δ3 · p4 · p5 · ♭7)

FULL NECK



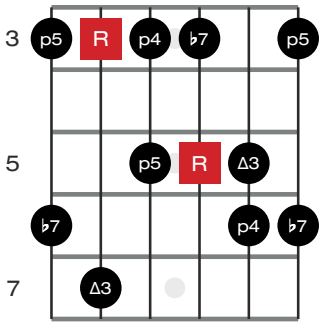
BLOCK 1

Frets 0–5 (also 12–17)



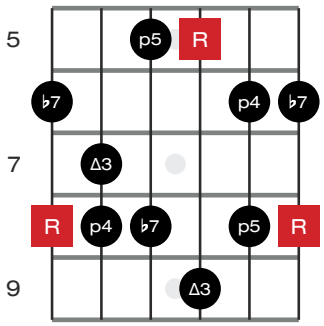
BLOCK 2

Frets 3–7 (also 15–19)



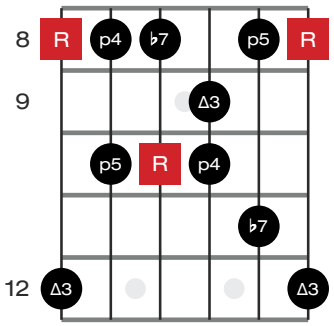
BLOCK 3

Frets 5–9 (also 17–21)



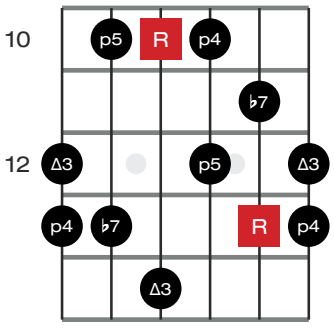
BLOCK 4

Frets 8–12 (also 20–24)



BLOCK 5

Frets 10–14



KEY

- R C root
- Δ3 E major 3rd
- p4 F perfect 4th
- p5 G perfect 5th
- ♭7 B♭ minor 7th

Blocks link end to end: the top notes of one block are the bottom notes of the next.

After Block 5 the cycle repeats 12 frets higher, starting again with Block 1.

PRACTICE: Jam over a C7 groove, sliding into the Δ3 and landing on the ♭7 for Southern swagger.

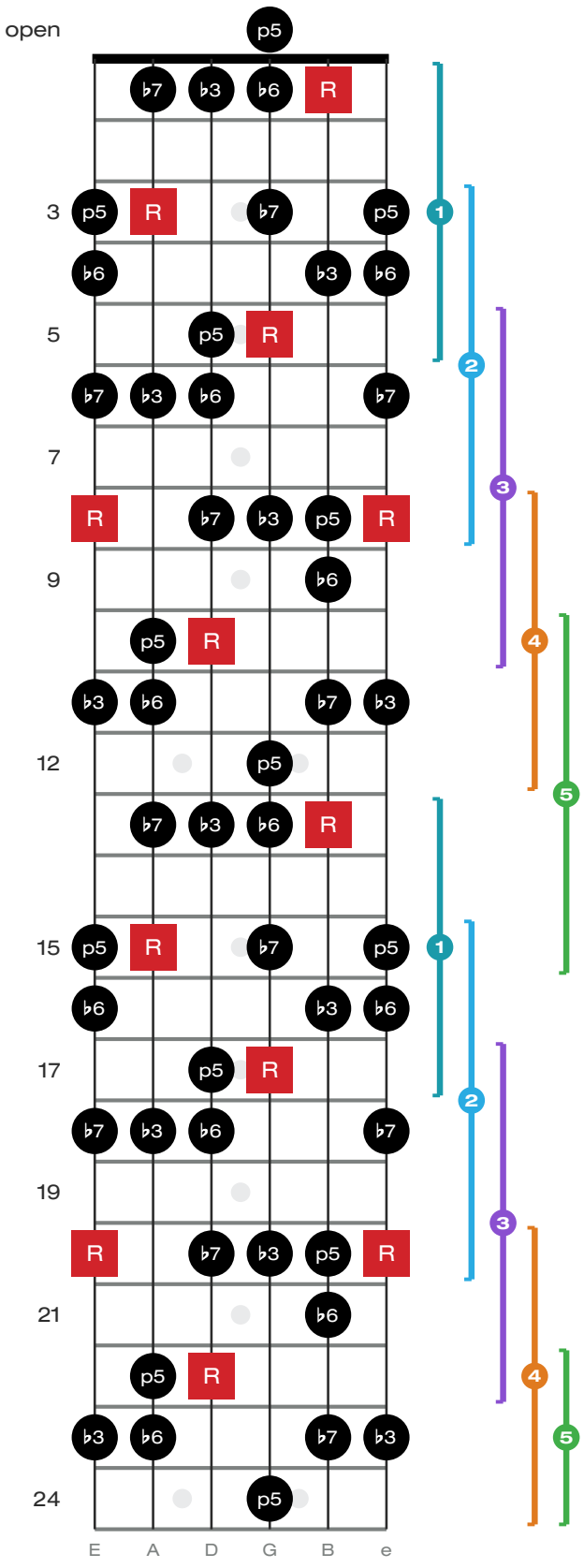
C Aeolian Pentatonic

Full Neck Map · Five Blocks

Mood: Melancholy · Sounds like: Gary Moore, Michael Schenker, Randy Rhoads

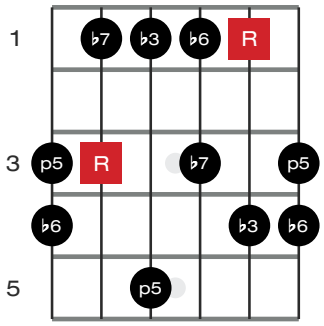
C · E♭ · G · A♭ · B♭ (R · ♭3 · p5 · ♭6 · ♭7)

FULL NECK



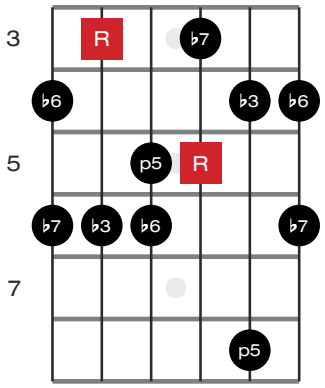
BLOCK 1

Frets 1–5 (also 13–17)



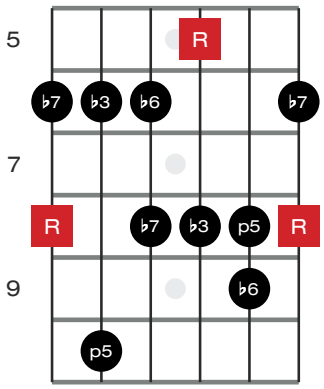
BLOCK 2

Frets 3–8 (also 15–20)



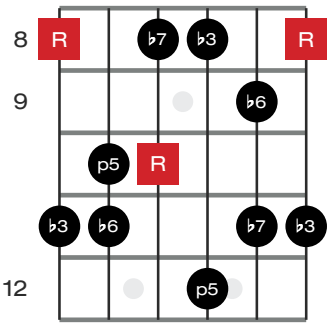
BLOCK 3

Frets 5–10 (also 17–22)



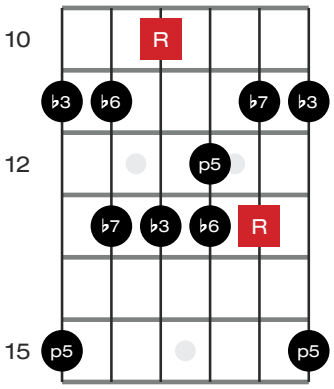
BLOCK 4

Frets 8–12 (also 20–24)



BLOCK 5

Frets 10–15



KEY

- R C root
- ♭3 E♭ minor 3rd
- p5 G perfect 5th
- ♭6 A♭ minor 6th
- ♭7 B♭ minor 7th

Blocks link end to end: the top notes of one block are the bottom notes of the next.

After Block 5 the cycle repeats 12 frets higher, starting again with Block 1.

PRACTICE: Over a Cm drone, linger on the ♭6 (A♭). It's the note that aches.

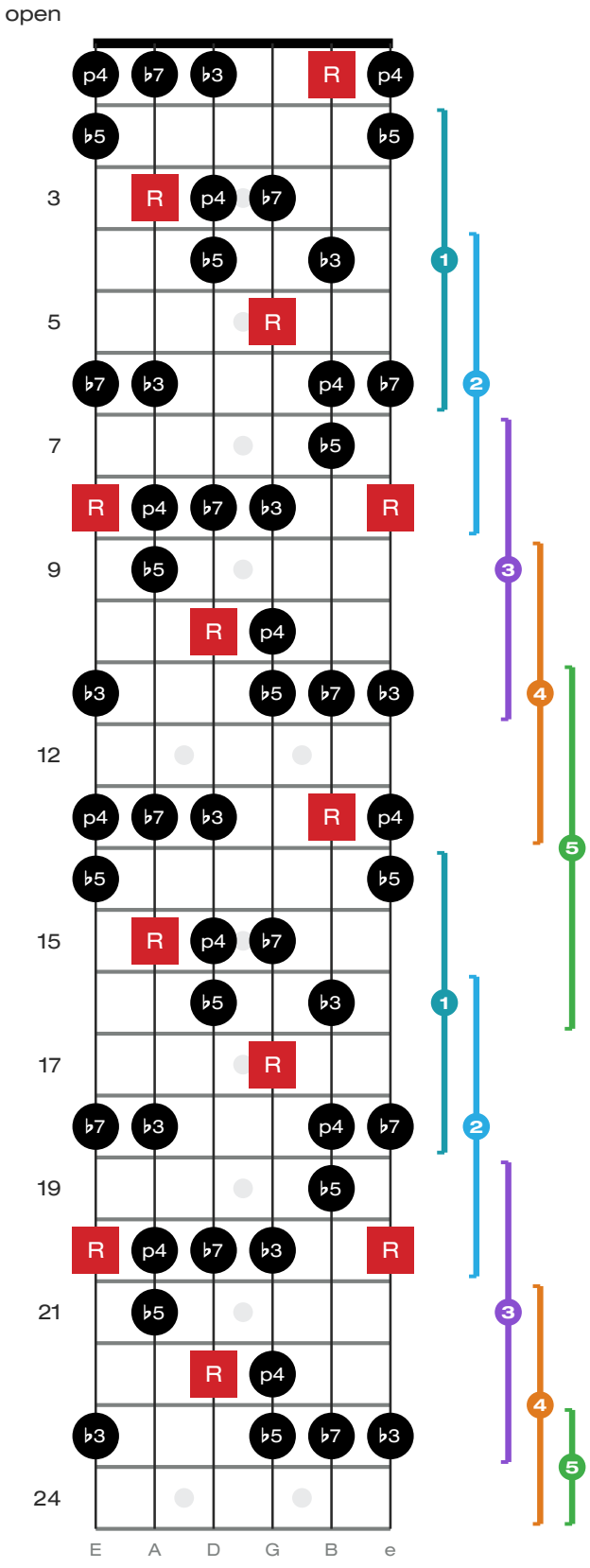
C Locrian Pentatonic

Full Neck Map · Five Blocks

Mood: Evil · Sounds like: Tony Iommi, Slayer

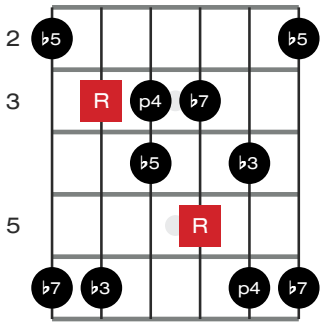
C · E♭ · F · G♭ · B♭ (R · ♭3 · p4 · ♭5 · ♭7)

FULL NECK



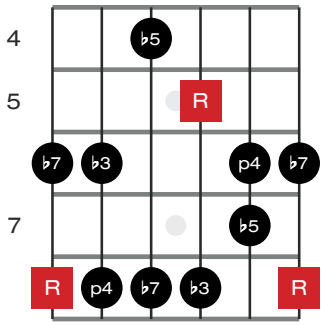
BLOCK 1

Frets 2–6 (also 14–18)



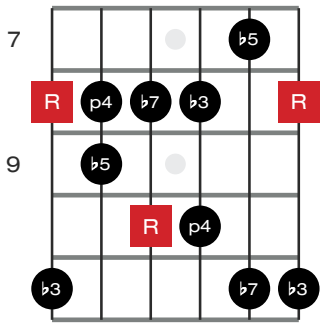
BLOCK 2

Frets 4–8 (also 16–20)



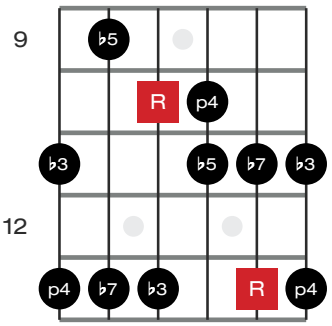
BLOCK 3

Frets 7–11 (also 19–23)



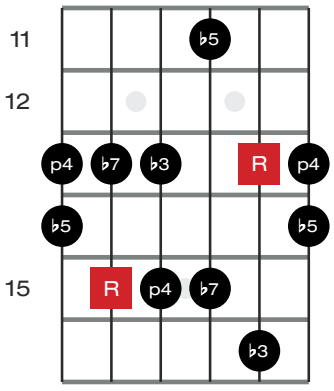
BLOCK 4

Frets 9–13



BLOCK 5

Frets 11–16



KEY

- R — C root
- ♭3 — E♭ minor 3rd
- p4 — F perfect 4th
- ♭5 — G♭ diminished 5th
- ♭7 — B♭ minor 7th

Blocks link end to end: the top notes of one block are the bottom notes of the next.

After Block 5 the cycle repeats 12 frets higher, starting again with Block 1.

PRACTICE: Over a Cm7♭5 chord, lean into the ♭5 (G♭) and let the tension hang unresolved.


Nashville, TN
Jackson

COLOR ASSOCIATION OF THE SEVEN MODES

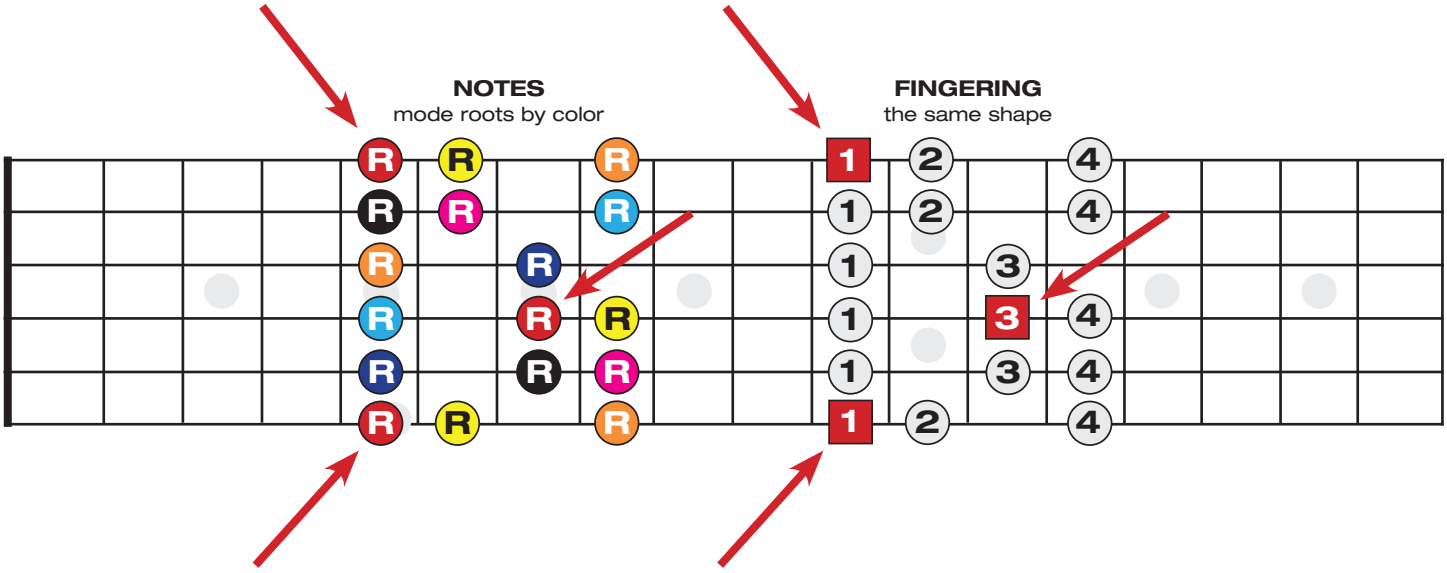


Color Association of the Root (R) Note with any of the Seven Modes

Select preferred mode by associating it with the color linked to its Root (R) note

Example — The Phrygian Mode

The Phrygian Mode, celebrated for its mysterious and exotic tonal quality, can be deeply understood by associating its Root Note (R) with the color Red. In the case of A Phrygian mode below, the note A becomes the tonal anchor, and visualizing it as Red helps solidify its identity on the fretboard. This creative connection makes the mode more intuitive & memorable for beginning guitarists exploring modal concepts.



IONIAN MODE (MAJOR SCALE) • MAGENTA
A "happy" sound used in bright and cheerful upbeat music styles and types.

DORIAN MODE • SKY BLUE
A darker "melancholy yet optimistic" feel with a lowered 3rd and 7th degree.

PHRYGIAN MODE • RED
A feeling of tension, mystery and sometimes even a sense of "thrilling exoticism".

LYDIAN MODE • YELLOW
A bright and "high celestial" sound that evokes a sense of expansive happiness.

MIXOLYDIAN MODE • ORANGE
A relaxed, bluesy touch and feel of smooth "coolness" with a lowered 7th degree.

AEOLIAN MODE (MINOR SCALE) • NAVY BLUE
A melancholic "introspective" feel conveying real depth and emotion.

LOCRIAN MODE • BLACK
An unstable feel which creates a sense of unresolved tension and "mystery".

Steps to using Color Association with the Seven Diatonic Modes

1. Choose Your Mode and Root Note by Color
Begin by selecting a mode you wish to explore (e.g., Dorian, Phrygian, etc.) and associate it with the **specific color** for visualization and memorization. The color serves as a creative tool to strengthen your connection to the mode and where to start it on the tonic **Root (R) note**.

2. Select a Backing Track in the Desired Key
Use an online backing track in the same exact key corresponding to your chosen mode. For example, if you are studying the A Dorian Mode, ensure the online backing track you choose is in A Dorian; if you are studying the G Aeolian Mode, choose the online backing track in G Aeolian, etc.

3. Emphasize the Root Note (R)
Begin your solo by emphasizing the root note of the mode (e.g., A for A Dorian) prominently at the outset. This root note serves as the tonal anchor, providing a strong foundation for your phrases and aligning them seamlessly with the harmonic framework and progression of the backing track.

4. Understand the Diagram and Grey Dots
Refer to the modal diagram provided, where the grey dots indicate the extended notes of the chosen mode within the specified key. These notes expand the modal palette, helping you craft melodic lines that complement the harmony.

5. Utilize the Three-Notes-Per-String and Modal Block Patterns
Employ the three-notes-per-string system and the modal block patterns to navigate the fretboard efficiently. This combination offers a structured approach, allowing for smooth transitions across positions while maintaining the integrity of the mode.

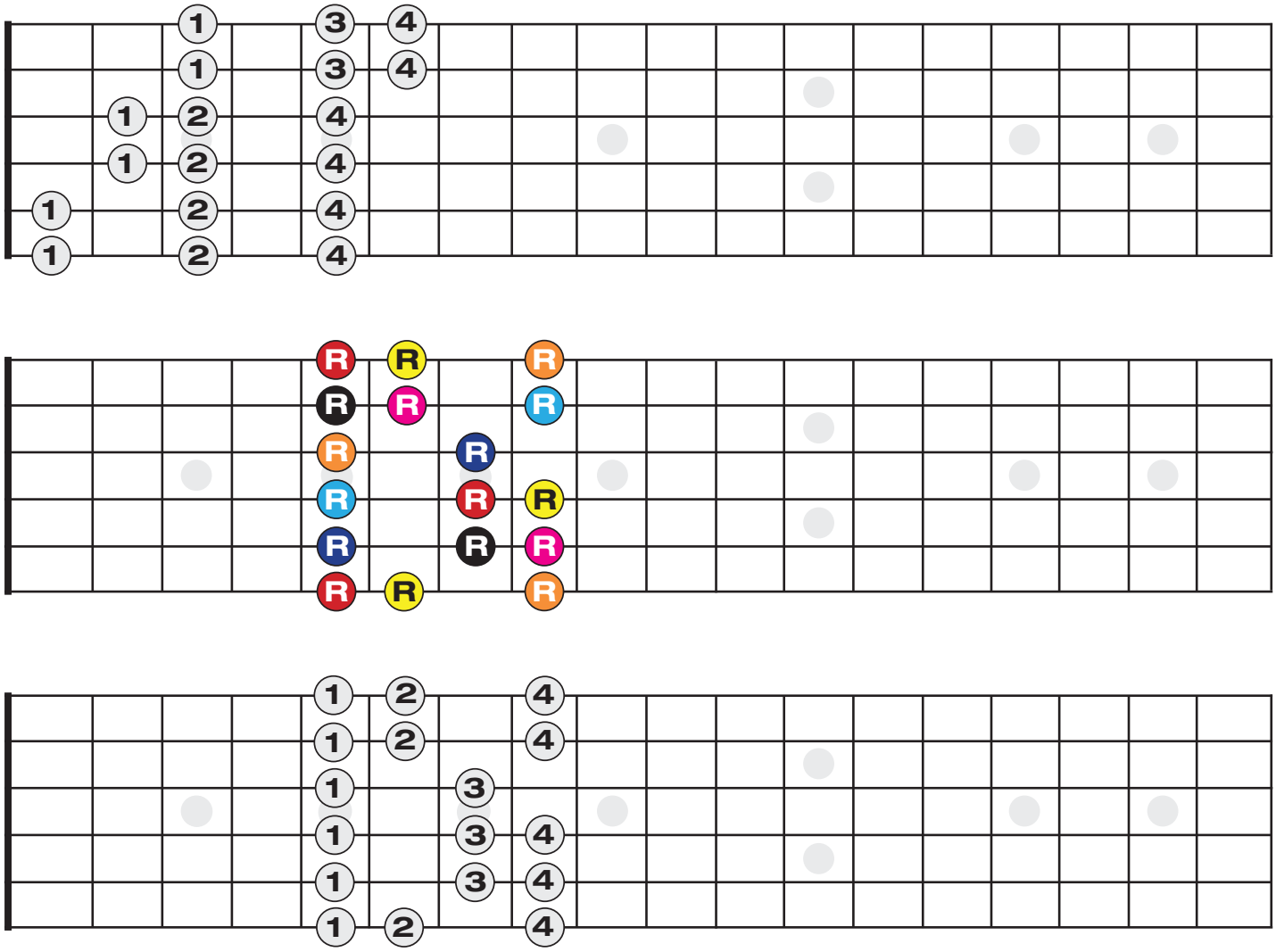
6. Expressive Soloing Through Visualization
By associating the **Root (R) note** with a color, you develop a visual and theoretical framework. This enhances your ability to create expressive solos that remain fully cohesive and musically engaging. This approach integrates color association, modal theory, and fretboard techniques to make learning modes intuitive and enjoyable.

7. Extending Across All Seven Modes
This method of associating modes with colors can be extended across all seven modes, with each assigned a distinct color to reflect its unique musical identity. For example, the Dorian Mode, known for its smooth and jazzy quality, is linked to Sky Blue, while the Lydian Mode, with its bright and uplifting sound, is linked to Yellow.

This color-coding approach makes navigating the fretboard more engaging and simplifies the process of identifying and exploring each mode. By visualizing the **Root (R) note** in its corresponding color, guitarists can unlock creative potential, turning complex modal theory into a tangible and expressive tool for soloing.

Color Association of the Root (R) Note with any of the 7 Modes

Select preferred mode by associating it with the color linked to its Root (R) note



Select an online backing track in the key that corresponds to the Mode you wish to explore. Begin your solo by emphasizing the **Root (R) Note** which serves as the tonal anchor that aligns your phrasing with the harmony of the backing track. The choice of the Mode is defined by the color of the **Root (R) Note.**

The grey dots indicate the extended notes of the chosen Mode within the specified key. Using the 3 notes-per-string approach in conjunction with the classic modal block patterns facilitates smooth and seamless navigation across the fretboard enabling expressive, cohesive and intentional soloing.

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PHRYGIAN MODE • RED — A feeling of tension, mystery and sometimes even a sense of “thrilling exoticism”.

LYDIAN MODE • YELLOW — A bright and “celestial” sound that evokes a sense of expansive happiness.

MIXOLYDIAN MODE • ORANGE — A relaxed, bluesy touch of “coolness” feel with a lowered 7th degree.

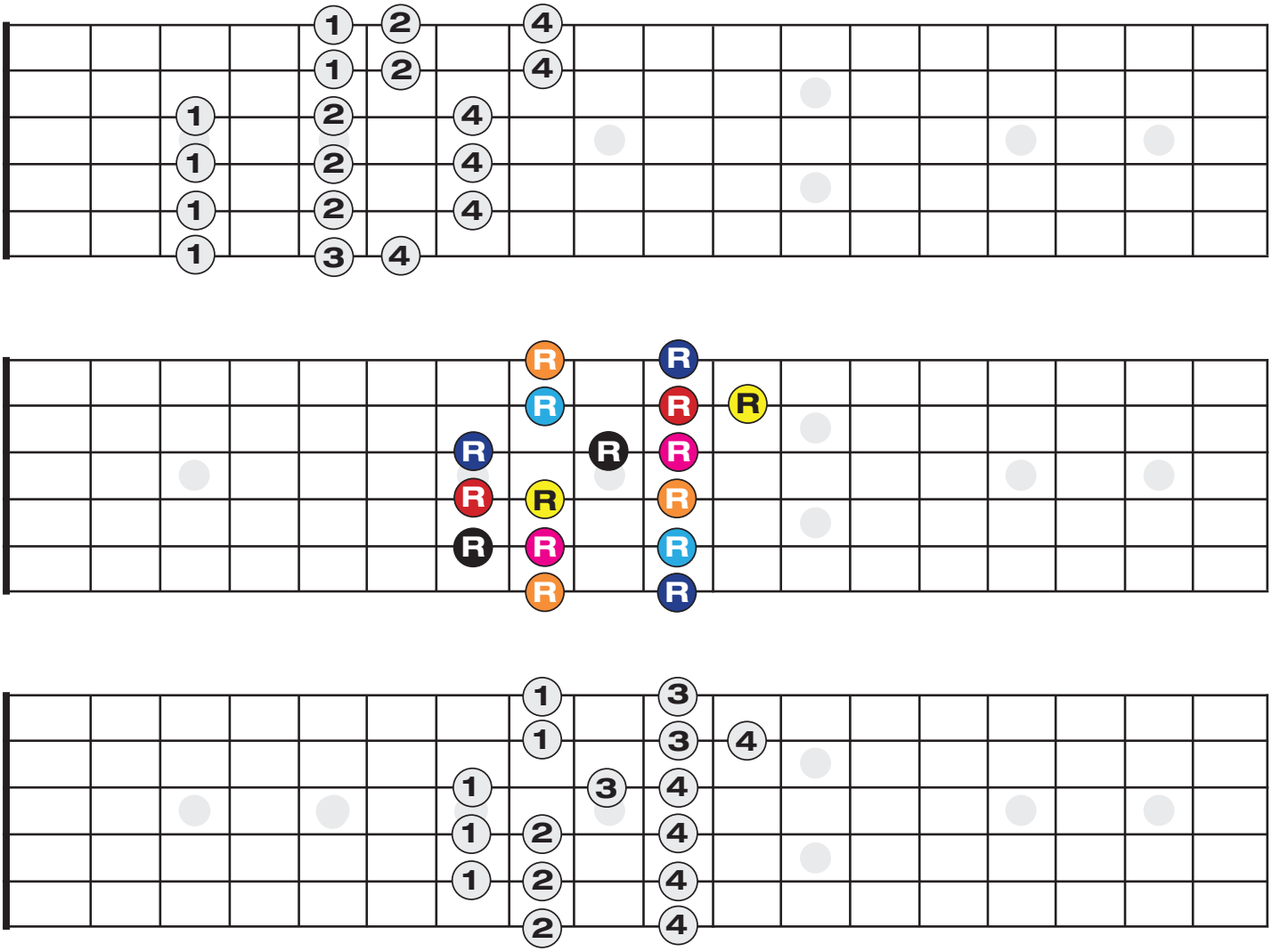
AEOLIAN MODE (MINOR SCALE) • NAVY BLUE — A melancholic “introspective” feel conveying real depth.

LOCRIAN MODE • BLACK — An unstable feel which creates a sense of unresolved tension and “mystery”.

PRACTICE: Say the mode's color out loud as you play each pattern to link sound, shape and color in your memory.

Color Association of the Root (R) Note with any of the 7 Modes

Select preferred mode by associating it with the color linked to its Root (R) note



Select an online backing track in the key that corresponds to the Mode you wish to explore. Begin your solo by emphasizing the **Root (R) Note** which serves as the tonal anchor that aligns your phrasing with the harmony of the backing track. The choice of the Mode is defined by the color of the **Root (R) Note.**

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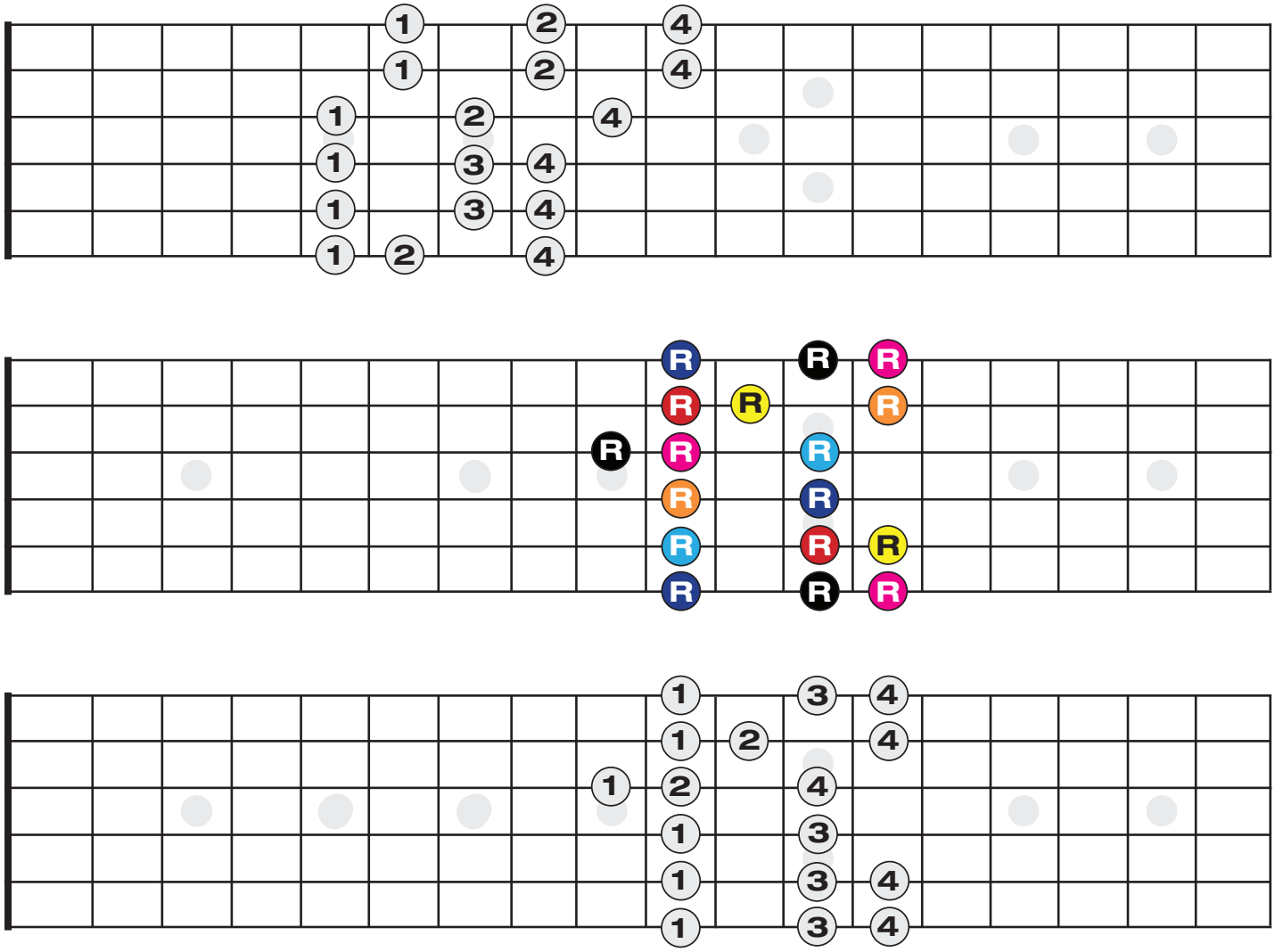
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Color Association of the Root (R) Note with any of the 7 Modes

Select preferred mode by associating it with the color linked to its Root (R) note



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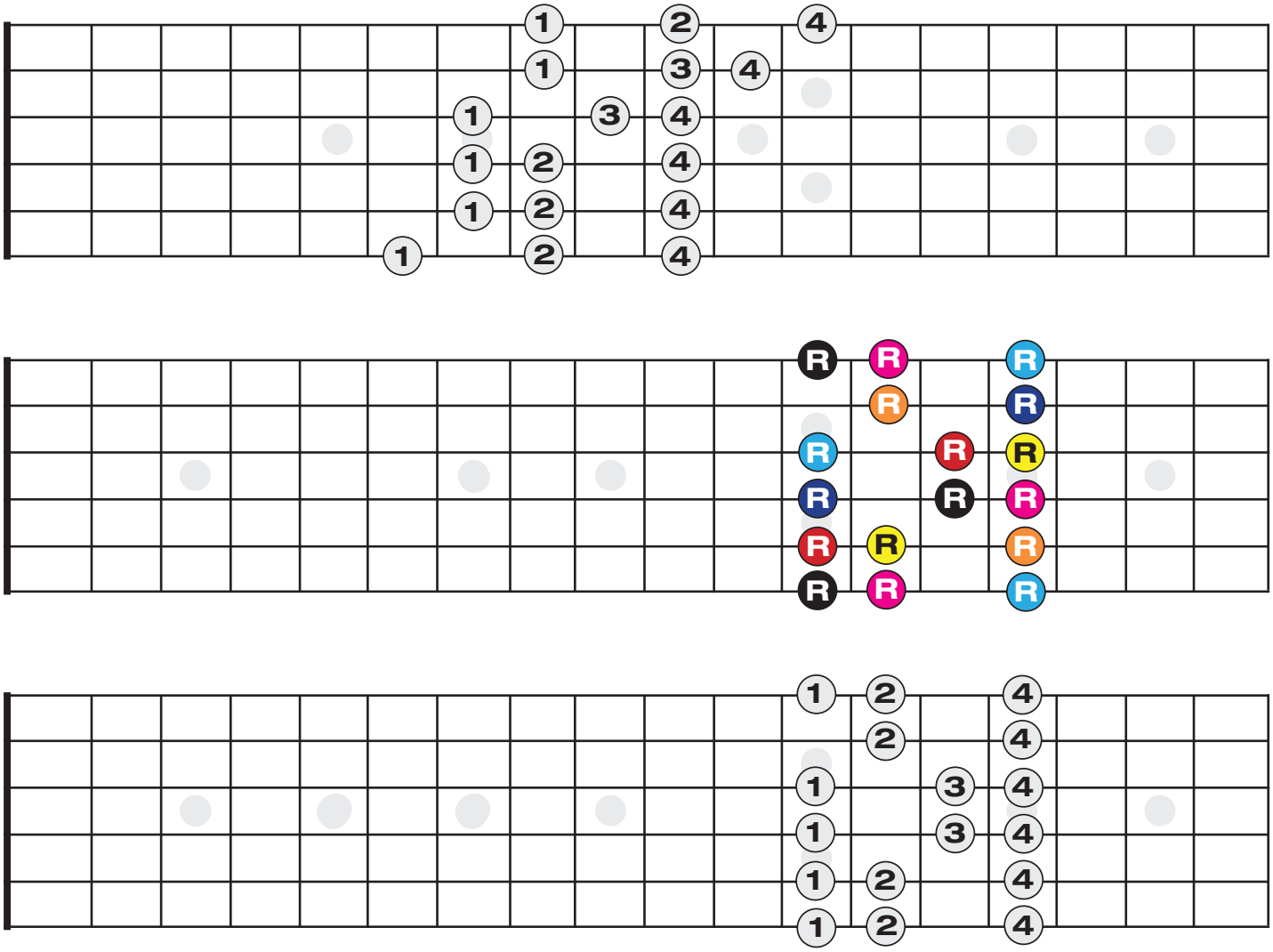
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PRACTICE: Say the mode's color out loud as you play each pattern to link sound, shape and color in your memory.

Color Association of the Root (R) Note with any of the 7 Modes

Select preferred mode by associating it with the color linked to its Root (R) note



Select an online backing track in the key that corresponds to the Mode you wish to explore. Begin your solo by emphasizing the **Root (R) Note** which serves as the tonal anchor that aligns your phrasing with the harmony of the backing track. The choice of the Mode is defined by the color of the **Root (R) Note.**

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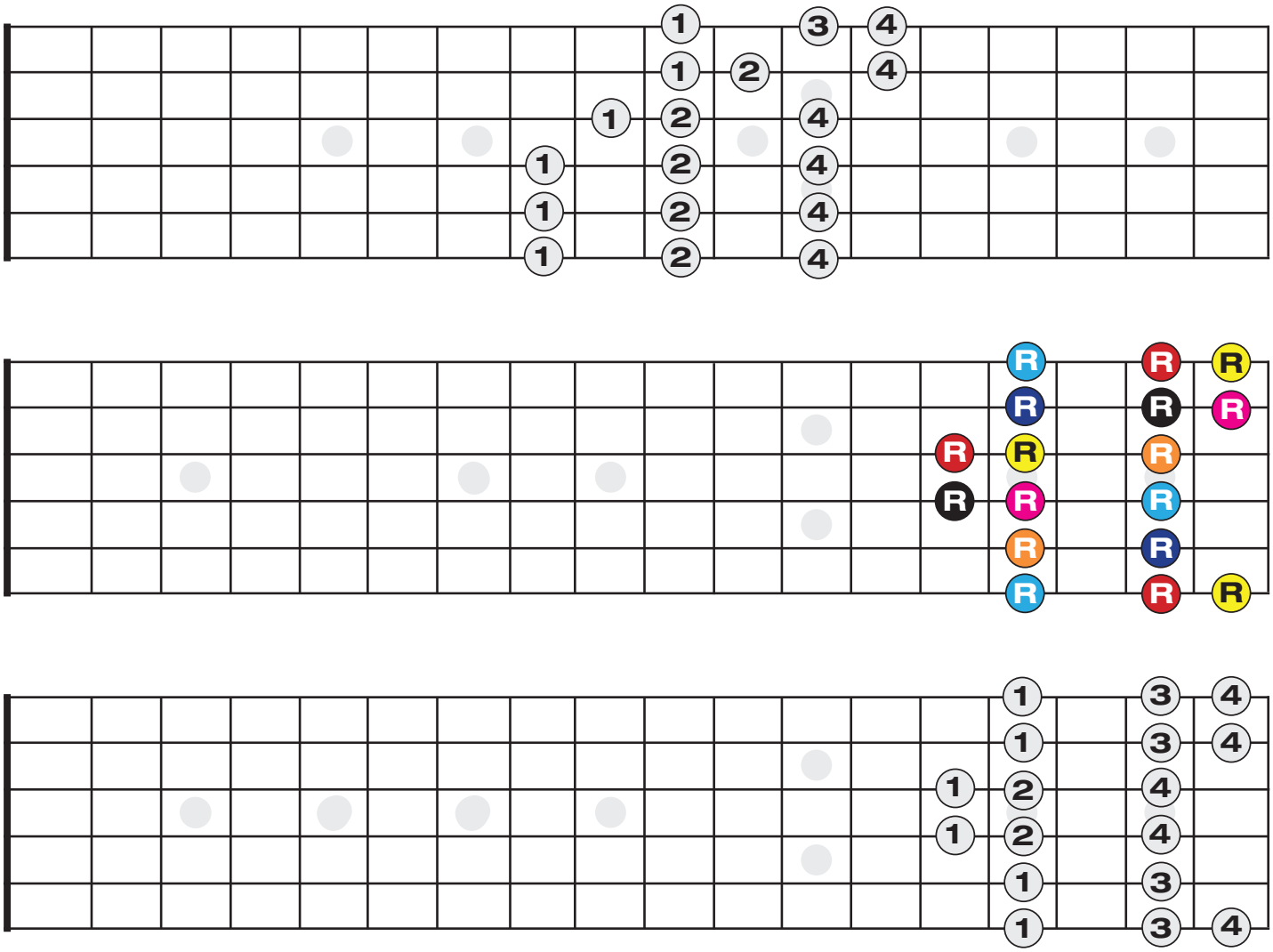
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Color Association of the Root (R) Note with any of the 7 Modes

Select preferred mode by associating it with the color linked to its Root (R) note



Select an online backing track in the key that corresponds to the Mode you wish to explore. Begin your solo by emphasizing the **Root (R) Note** which serves as the tonal anchor that aligns your phrasing with the harmony of the backing track. The choice of the Mode is defined by the color of the **Root (R) Note.**

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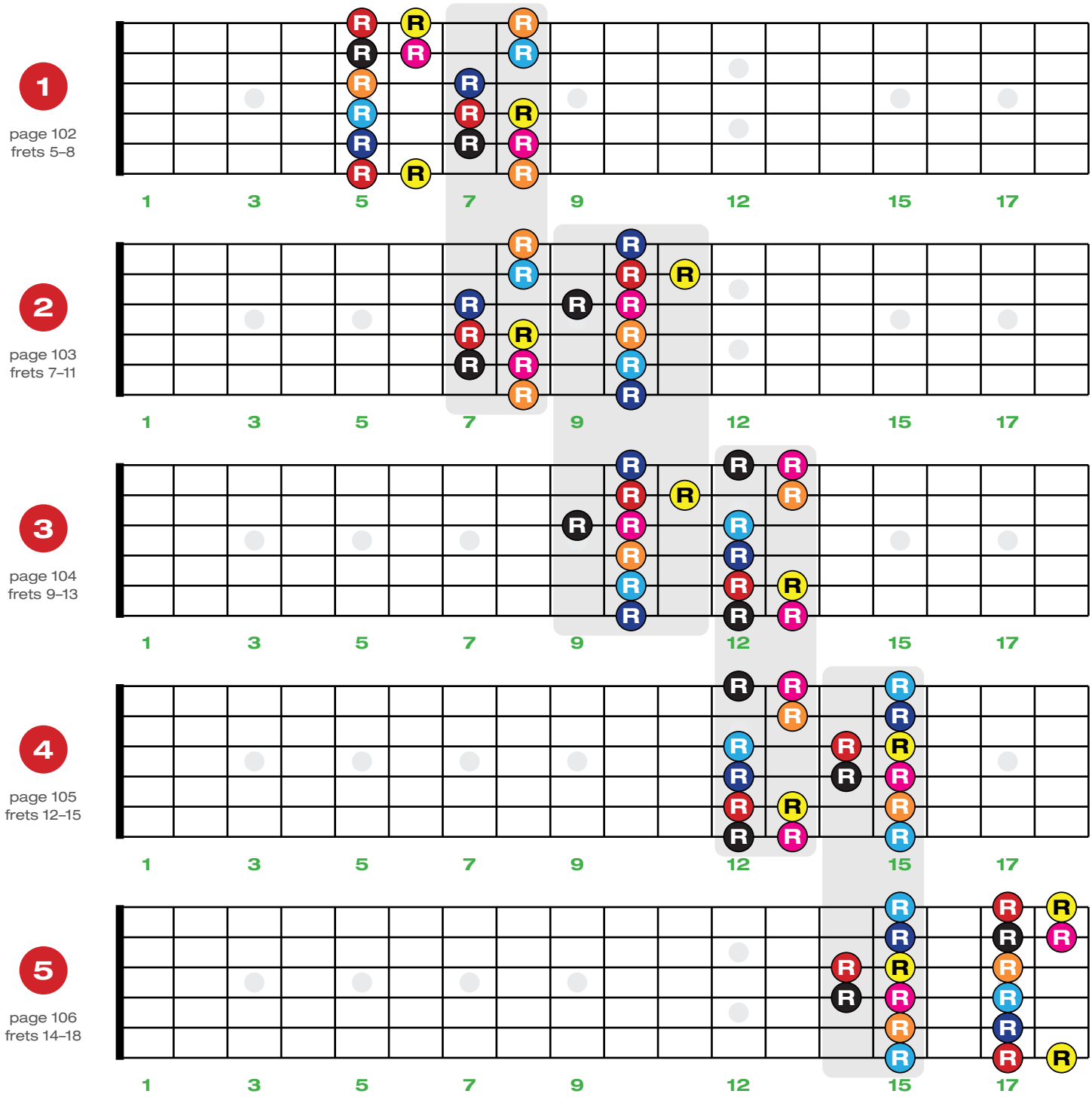
PRACTICE: Say the mode's color out loud as you play each pattern to link sound, shape and color in your memory.

Color Association Overview

The five shapes of pages 102–106 in order, each in its own place on the neck

F Ionian · G Dorian · A Phrygian · B♭ Lydian · C Mixolydian · D Aeolian · E Locrian

Shaded frets hold the notes that two neighboring shapes share: that is where one shape hands over to the next.

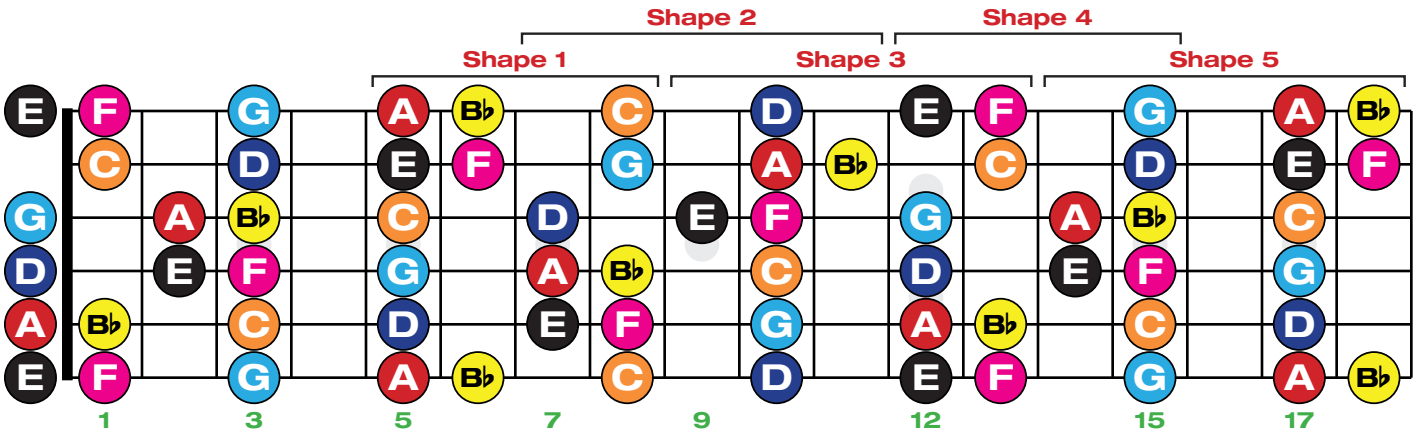


One scale, five hand positions. All five shapes hold the same seven notes, F G A B♭ C D E. Each shape begins where the one above it ends: the shaded notes belong to both, so you can climb from Shape 1 to Shape 5 without a gap, and after Shape 5 the first shape begins again twelve frets higher. A note keeps its color in every shape, so once you choose a mode, its color shows you the root (R) wherever your hand is on the neck.

PRACTICE: Play the five shapes in order up the neck and back, crossing each shaded zone without stopping, and name the color you land on.

The Whole Neck in Color

All five shapes joined: every note of F major from the open strings to the 18th fret



Seven colors, seven modes

in F major

Color	Mode	Root	Scale step	Sound
Magenta	Ionian (major scale)	F	1st	happy, bright, upbeat
Sky blue	Dorian	G	2nd	melancholy yet optimistic
Red	Phrygian	A	3rd	tension, mystery, exotic
Yellow	Lydian	B♭	4th	bright, celestial
Orange	Mixolydian	C	5th	relaxed, bluesy, cool
Navy blue	Aeolian (minor scale)	D	6th	melancholic, introspective
Black	Locrian	E	7th	unstable, unresolved

Find any mode on the whole neck

1 Choose a mode and its color

Dorian is sky blue. In F major every sky-blue note is a G, so the sky-blue notes are the roots of G Dorian.

2 Find that color under your hand

Whichever shape you are in, the nearest sky-blue note is a root. Start your phrases there and come back to it to end them.

3 Keep the same seven notes

Only the home note changes. Over a G Dorian backing track the sky-blue notes sound like home, and every other color still fits.

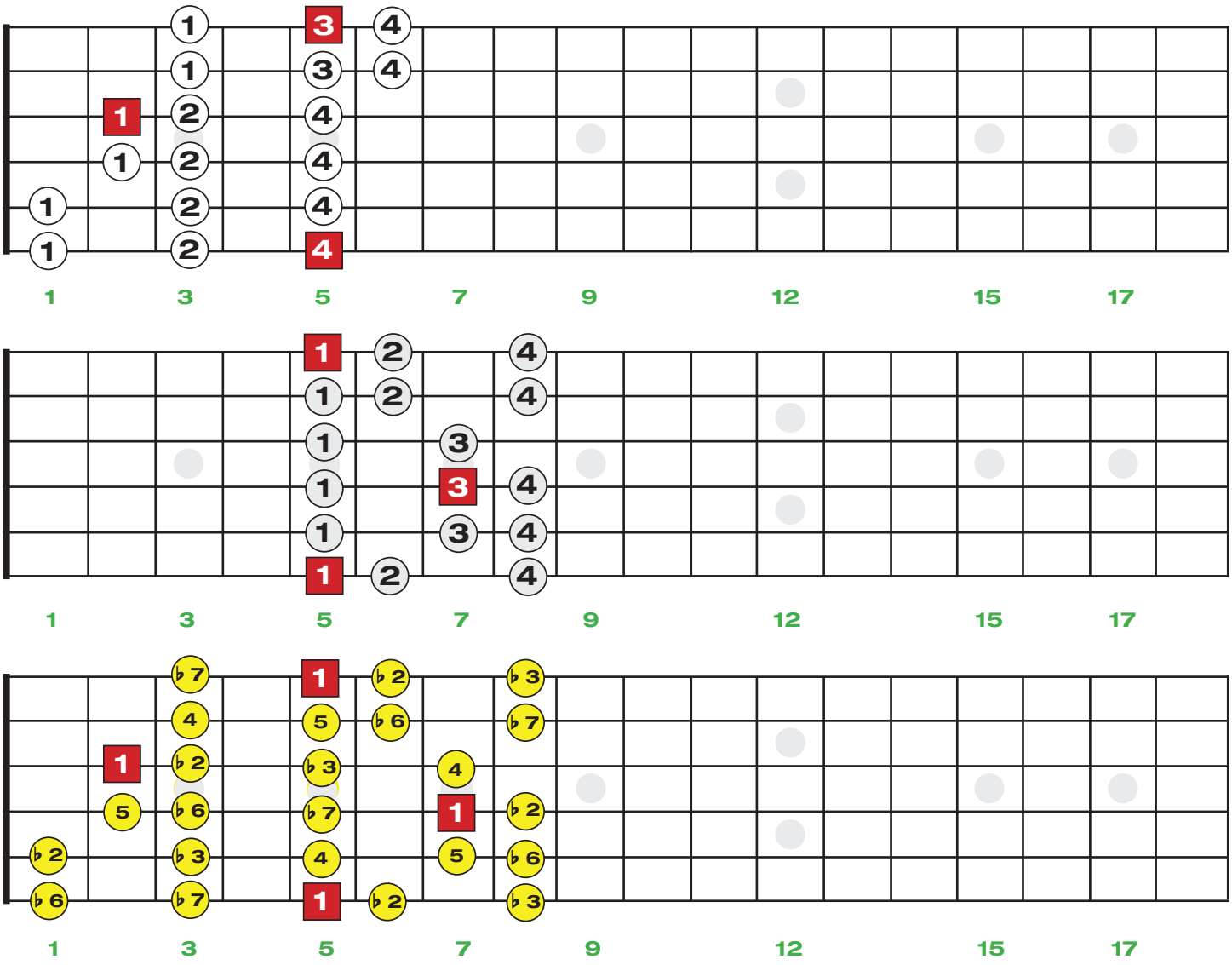
In any other key the colors follow the steps of the major scale: the 1st note is always magenta, the 2nd sky blue, the 3rd red, the 4th yellow, the 5th orange, the 6th navy blue and the 7th black. In G major red falls on B, so B Phrygian is the red mode. The pages that follow work through the red mode of F major, A Phrygian.

PRACTICE: Pick one color, find every note of that color on the whole neck, then improvise over a drone of that note with these notes.

A Phrygian Mode Example

The Red Color association is in the Tonic (The Red Squares)

Red Squares = Phrygian Tonic • Grey Circles = Phrygian Mode • Yellow Circles = Scale Formula



A Phrygian is the third mode of the F Major Scale

A Phrygian Scale Notes: A B♭ C D E F G

Phrygian Scale Formula: 1 ♭2 ♭3 4 5 ♭6 ♭7

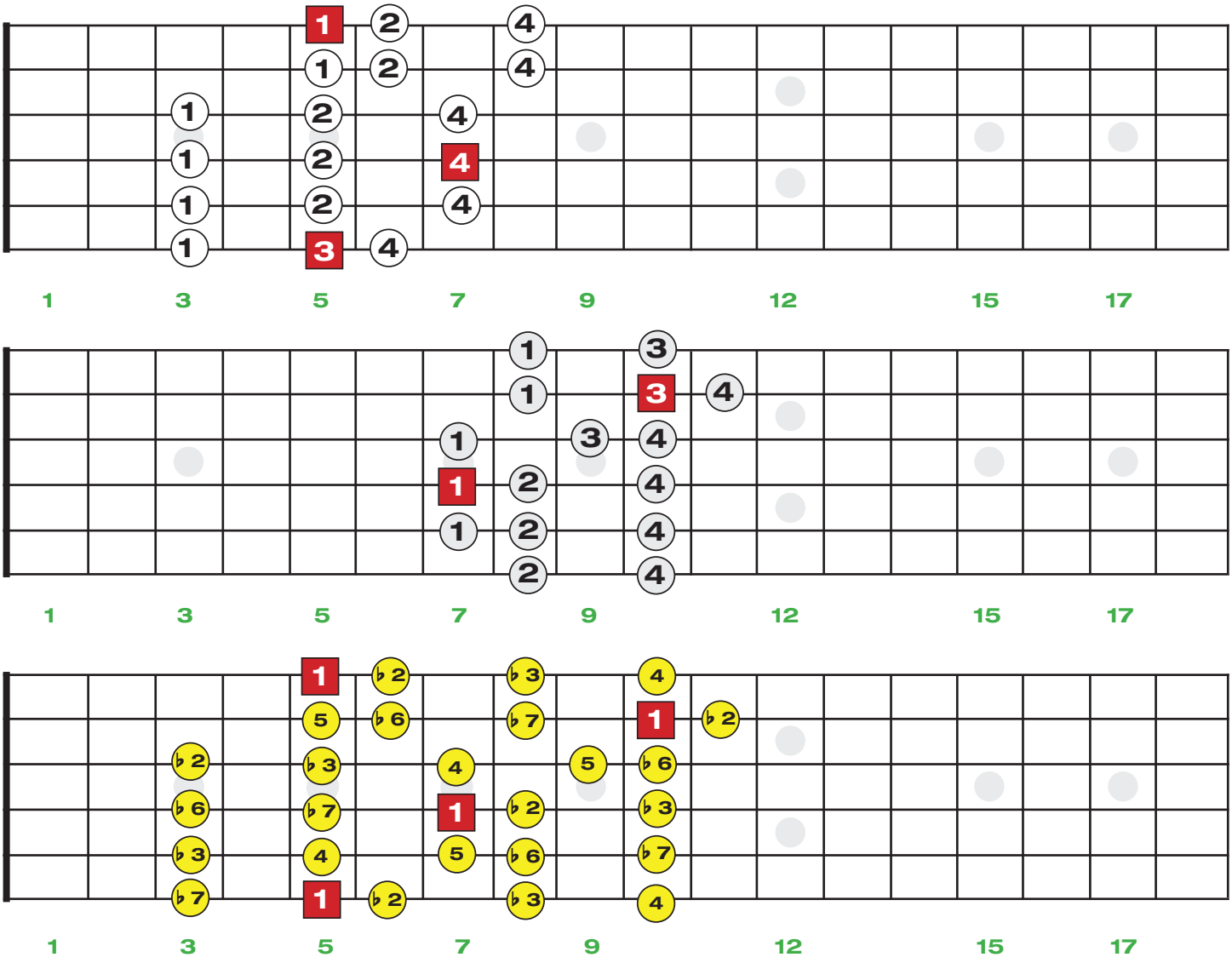
Phrygian Scale Intervals: H W W W H W W

PRACTICE: Play the full mode (grey circles and red squares), then again while naming each yellow scale degree.

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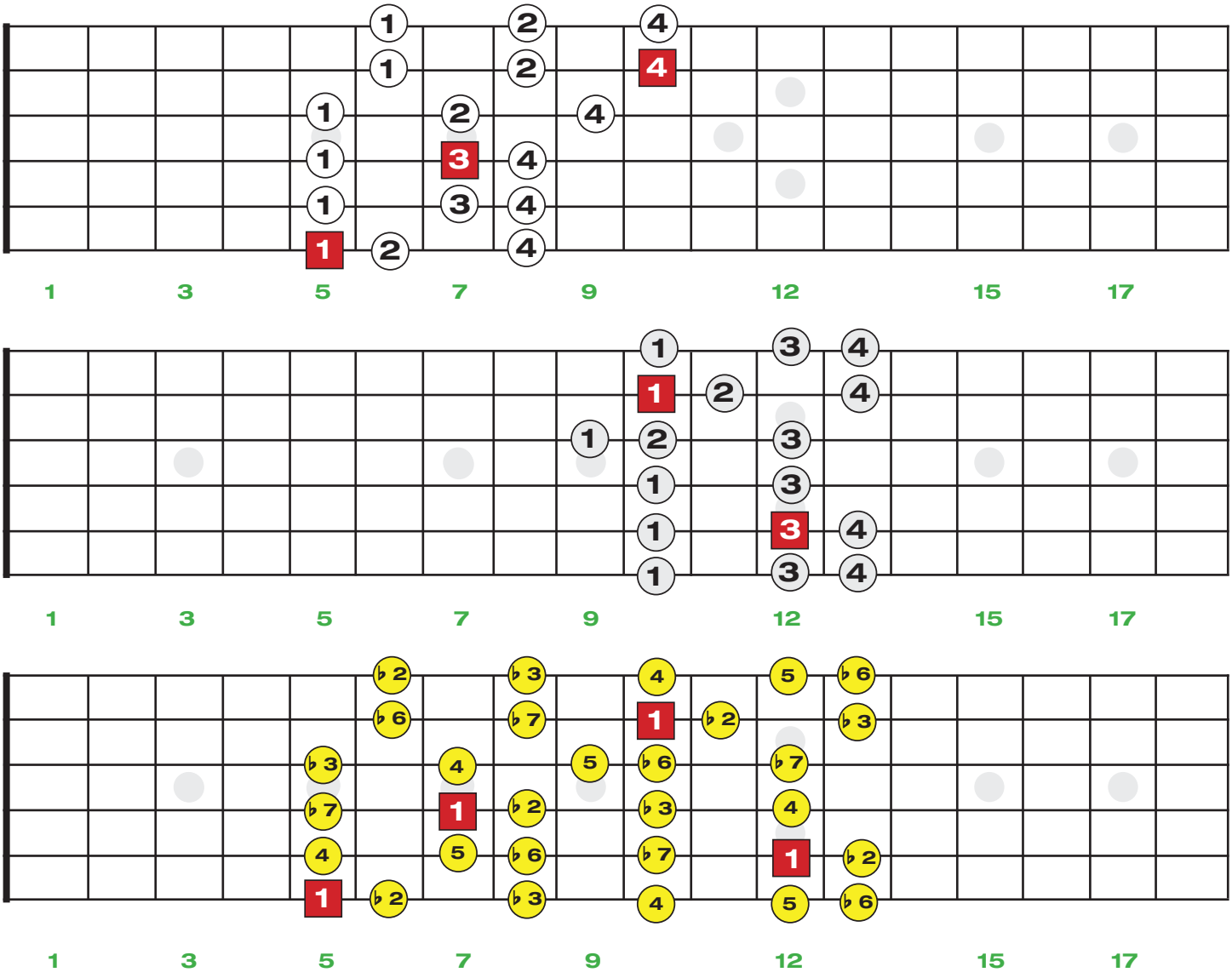
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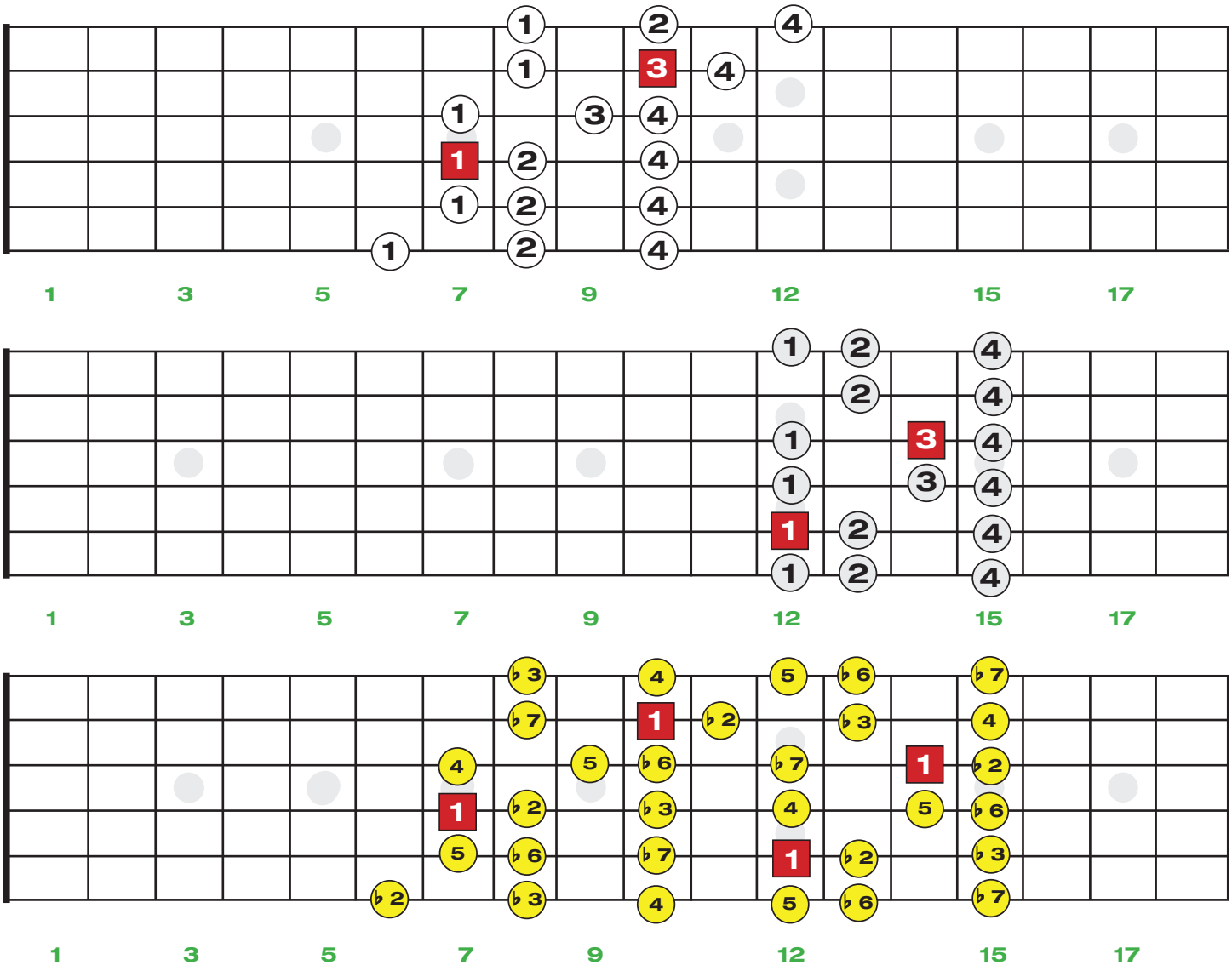
Phrygian Scale Intervals: H W W W H W W

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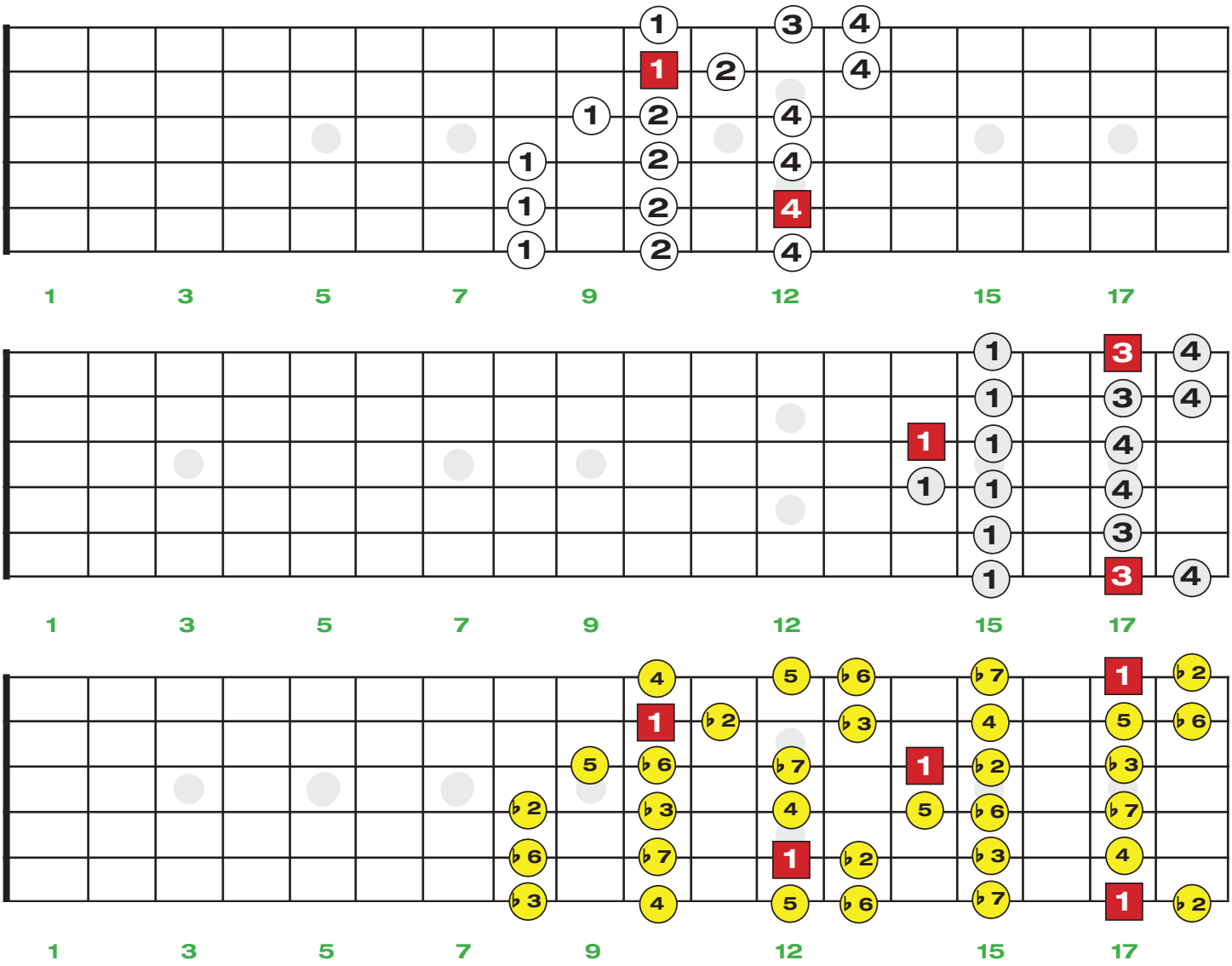
Phrygian Scale Intervals: H W W W H W W

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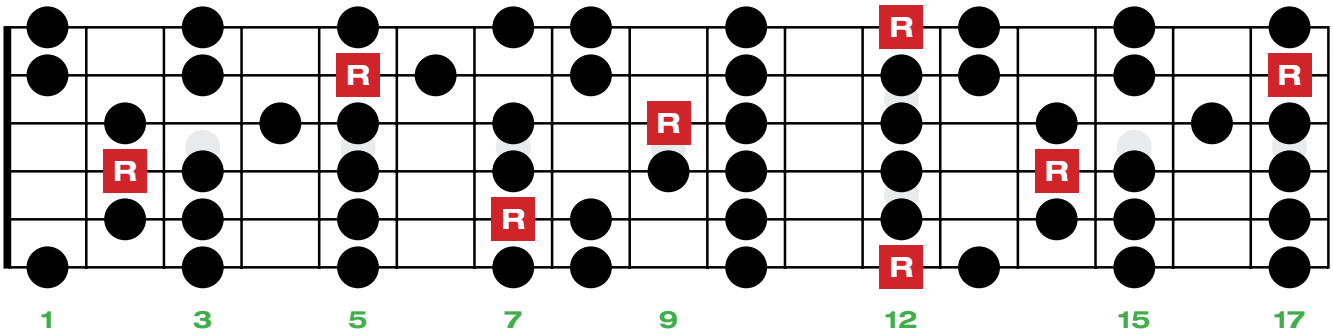
The Exotic & Mysterious Phrygian Mode

"The Spanish Minor"

Phrygian Mode, the third mode of the major scale, exudes a dark, exotic, and mysterious character, often found in metal, hard rock, jazz, and film scores. It's also a cornerstone of Flamenco music, where it's affectionately dubbed the **'Flamenco Mode.'** However, Flamenco often raises the third scale degree, transforming it into something beyond the traditional Phrygian framework.

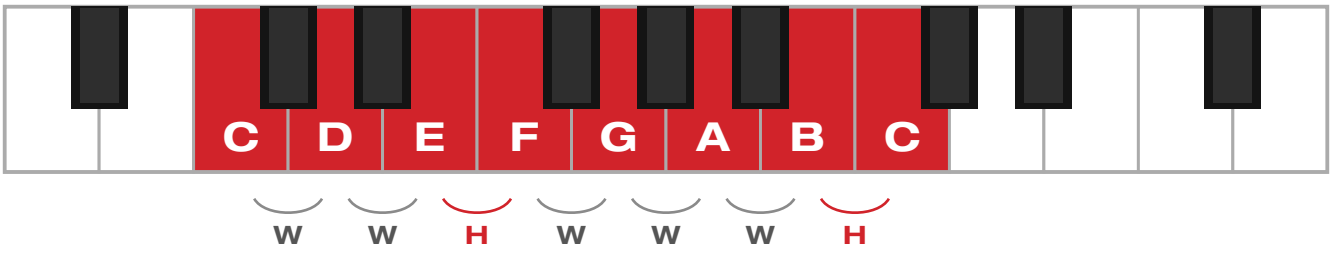
This modification, known as the **'Phrygian Dominant'** or **'Spanish Gypsy'** scale, adds another layer of exoticism, creating an alluring tonal palette. The hallmark of the Phrygian scale is its flattened second interval, a distinctive note that lends an unmistakable **'Egyptian'** or **'Spanish'** essence. The semitone leap from the tonic to the second interval creates immediate tension, setting the scale apart with its striking sonic signature.

As a result, the Phrygian Mode crafts an eerie, dark, and mysteriously exotic soundscape, producing a unique tension that captivates listeners. Its sonic flavor is both haunting and instantly recognizable. In the preceding pages, you explored the 3-Note-Per-String method, blending ascending three-note patterns with descending traditional blocks for a comprehensive approach to this evocative mode.



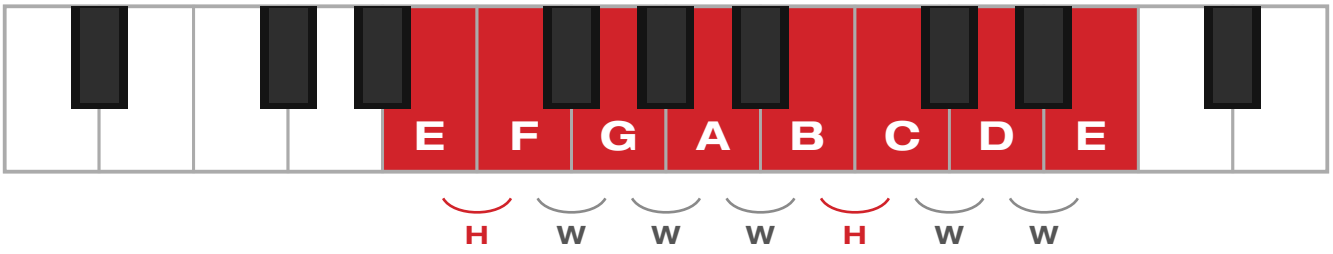
C MAJOR SCALE (IONIAN)

C D E F G A B C • Steps: W W H W W W H



E PHRYGIAN MODE

E F G A B C D E • Steps: H W W W H W W • The ♭2 (F) gives it the Spanish sound



In the Key of C Major, the E Phrygian Mode would be the 3rd mode and played E to E

THE LYDIAN CHROMATIC CONCEPT OF TONAL ORGANIZATION



The Lydian Chromatic Concept of Tonal Organization

One-Note Changing Perspective

Credit to George Russell who in 1953 first published The Lydian Chromatic Concept of Tonal Organization. It was the first theoretical contribution to come from Jazz and was responsible for introducing modal improvisation which resulted in Miles Davis's "Kind of Blue."

Inspired by his work, below is my own One-Note Changing Perspective for your guitar study.

Formula	Notes	Intervals	Degrees
1	G	Unison	Tonic
2	A	Major Second	Supertonic
3	B	Major Third	Mediant
♯4	C♯	Augmented Fourth	Subdominant
5	D	Perfect Fifth	Dominant
6	E	Major Sixth	Submediant
7	F♯	Major Seventh	Leading Tone

MAJOR MODES

Lydian Mode
The Lydian mode contains one raised note **(♯ 4)**. This is the base mode for all seven shapes so get this shape totally down before moving on to the next mode in the system.

Ionian Mode
Take the Lydian mode and alter one note to create the Ionian mode.
You lower the 4th note of Lydian to form the Ionian mode.

Mixolydian Mode
Take the Ionian mode and alter by one note to create the Mixolydian mode.
You lower the 7th note of Ionian to form the Mixolydian mode.

MINOR MODES

Dorian Mode
Take the Mixolydian mode and alter by one note to create the Dorian mode.
Lower the 3rd of Mixolydian to form the Dorian mode.

Aeolian Mode
Take the Dorian mode and alter by one note to create the Aeolian mode.
Lower the 6th of Dorian mode to form the Aeolian mode.

Phrygian Mode
Take the Aeolian mode and alter by one note to create the Phrygian mode.
Lower the 2nd of Aeolian mode to form the Phrygian mode.

Locrian Mode
Take the Phrygian mode and alter by one note to create the Locrian mode.
Lower the 5th note of Phrygian mode to form the Locrian mode.

The Lydian Chromatic Concept of Tonal Organization

One-Note Changing Perspective

Traditional guitar learning of the seven major modes begins with the Ionian mode.

When using The Lydian Chromatic Concept of Tonal Organization with the One-Note Changing Perspective you start with the Lydian Mode and lower one note at a time until you play all seven modes.

The one note change between each subsequent mode will play them out of normal order.

Traditional order of the seven major modes for review.
• Ionian • Dorian • Phrygian • Lydian • Mixolydian • Aeolian • Locrian

One-Note Changing Perspective order of the seven modes.
• Lydian • Ionian • Mixolydian • Dorian • Aeolian • Phrygian • Locrian

Memorize this new order to use the One-Note Changing Perspective method. From there you can go back and play them in the original order when putting them together in one key on the fretboard.

By doing this One-Note Changing Perspective method it will allow you to learn the seven modes and then bring them back into normal order rather than learning them as seven distinct fingerings in normal order from the beginning.

There are three colors on the guitar fingerboards

Red: Mode Root Note.

Black: Static notes between the last mode and new mode.

Blue: The one note that's moved from previous mode to form new mode.

Playing Exercises

1. Play through all three Major Modes:
Lydian-Ionian-Mixolydian from one root note and repeat in all 12 keys.

2. Play through all four Minor Modes:
Dorian-Aeolian-Phrygian-Locrian from one root note and repeat in all 12 keys.

3. Play all seven Modes in the order presented:
Play from one root note and repeat in all 12 keys.

4. Play over a G Major Chord backing-track:
Solo over Lydian, Ionian and Mixolydian to hear these modes color a Major Chord situation.

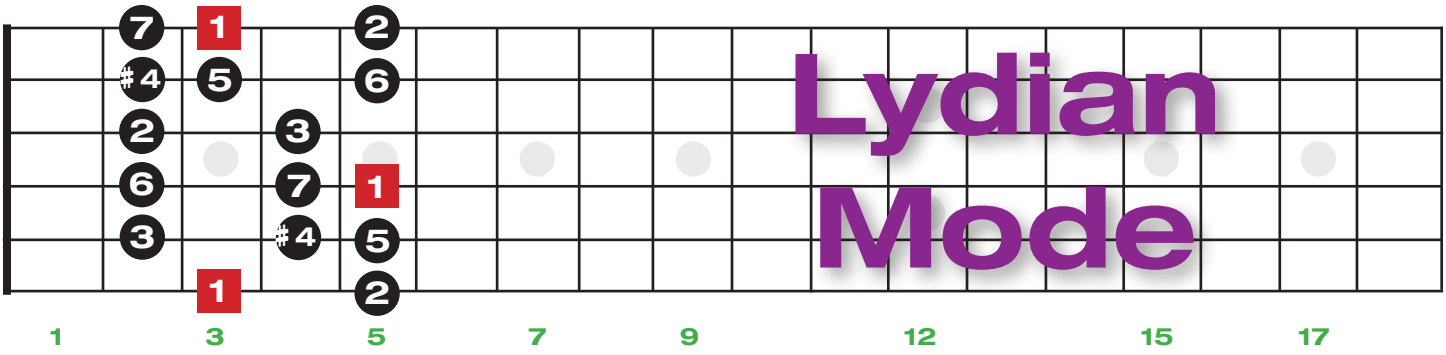
5. Play over an A Minor Chord backing-track:
Solo over Dorian, Aeolian, and Phrygian to hear these modes color a Minor Chord situation.

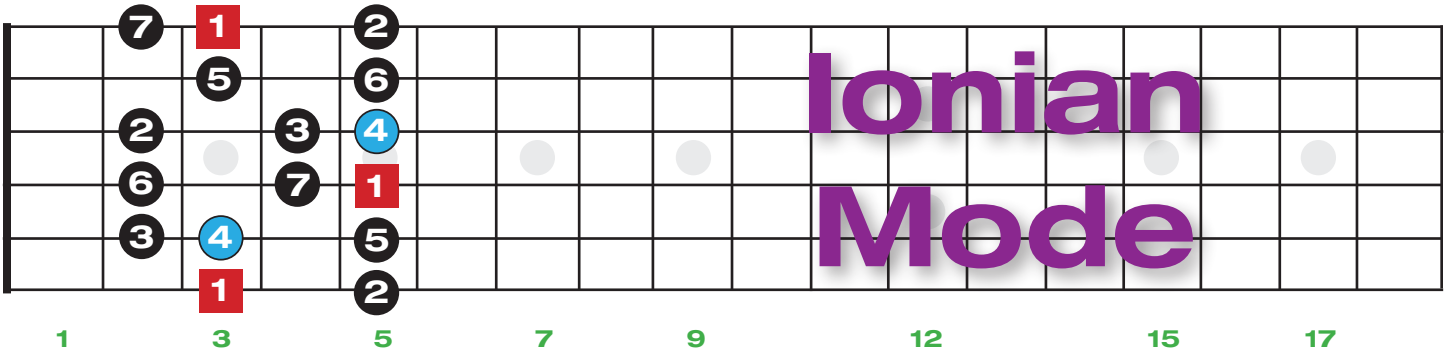
The Lydian Chromatic Concept of Tonal Organization

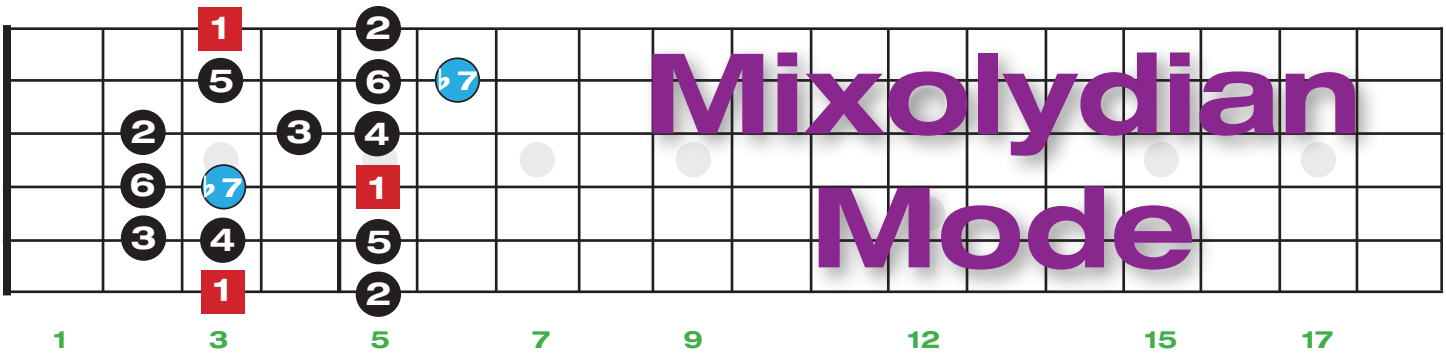
MAJOR MODES

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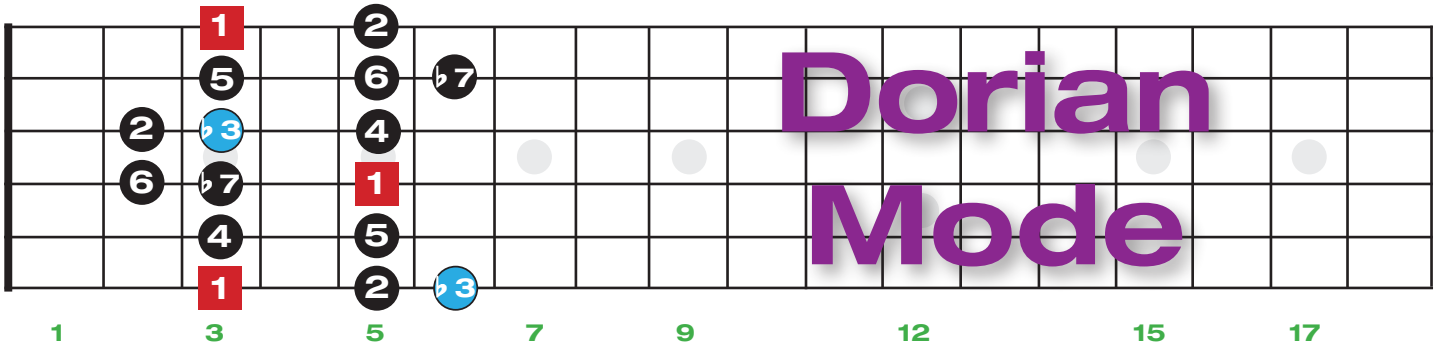
PRACTICE: Play each mode in order, changing only the blue note, and hear how one note transforms the whole mood.

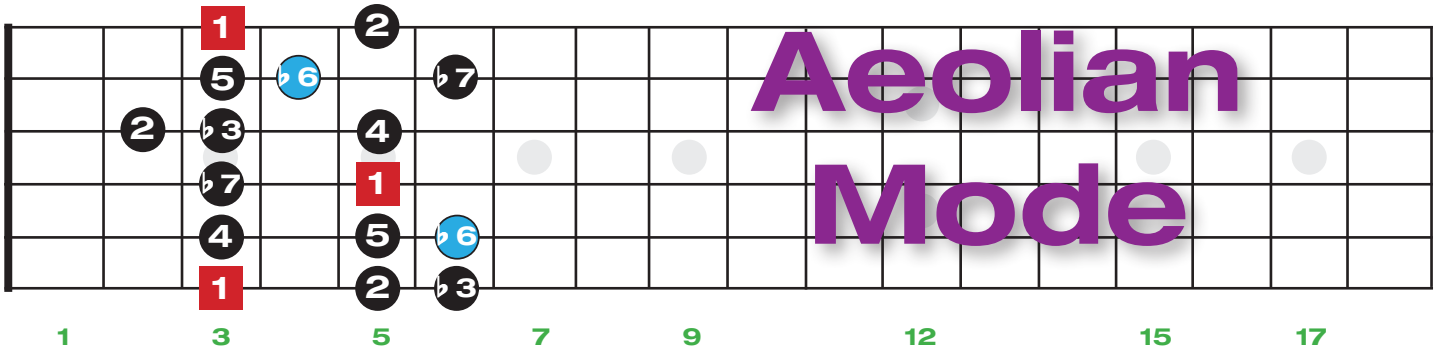
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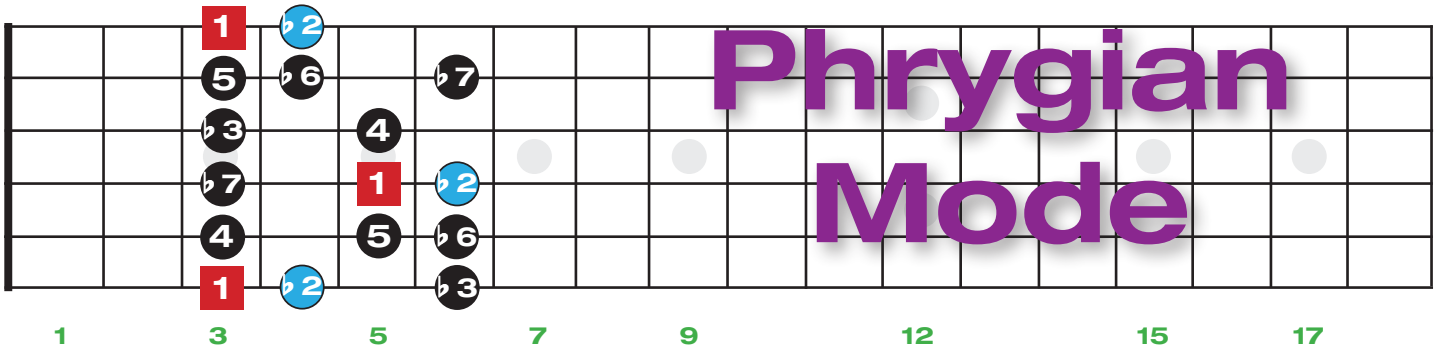
MINOR MODES

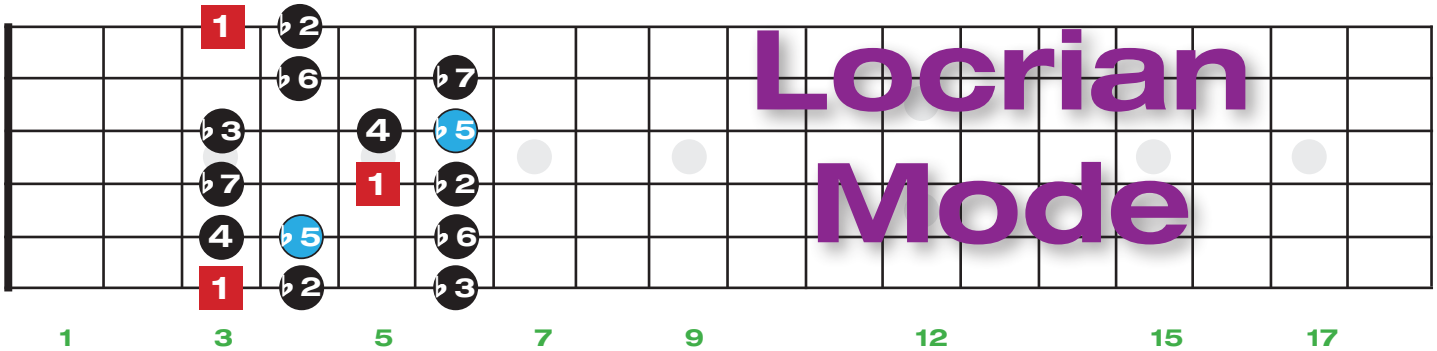
Red: Mode Root Note. **Black:** Static notes between the last mode and new mode.

Blue: The one note that's moved from previous mode to form new mode.









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I Don’t Mind

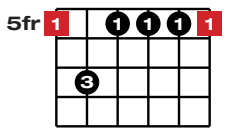
LISTEN ON YOUTUBE MUSIC

Music by Byron Nemeth • 85 BPM

Red squares mark the chord’s root · Numbers are fingers · x = don’t play · 5fr = starting fret

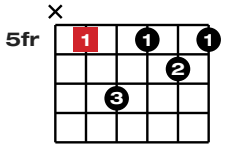
1

Am7



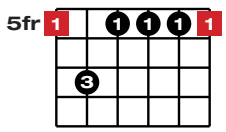
2

Dm7



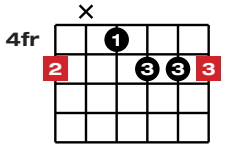
3

Am7



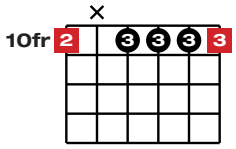
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Am6



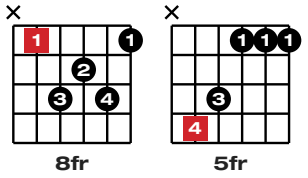
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Dm7



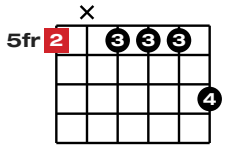
6

Fmaj7 **Fmaj7**



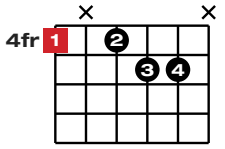
7

Am9



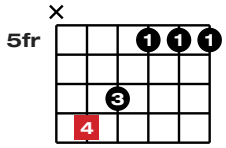
8

A♭7♯5



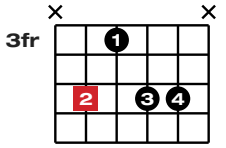
9

Fmaj7



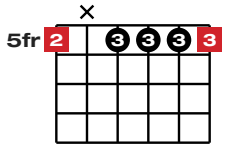
10

Dm9



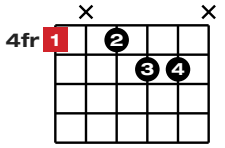
11

Am7



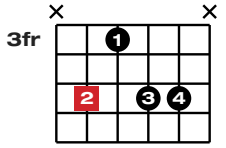
12

A♭7♯5



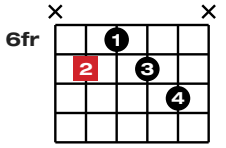
13

Dm9



14

E7♯9



I Don’t Mind has emotive chords that evoke the intimacy of jazz and the raw, expressive power of blues. Each chord paints its own vivid emotional landscape, creating a journey that’s both compelling and harmonically sophisticated. Turn the page to see how these chords interact to craft a soulful musical narrative.

PRACTICE: Learn the chord changes first at a slow tempo, then work up to 85 BPM and play along with the recording.

I Don’t Mind: Inside the Chords

How each chord shapes the story of the song

The Opening Gesture: Am7 to Dm7

The piece begins with Am7, a quintessential jazz chord known for its mellow, introspective quality. It sets the stage with a sense of mystery and melancholy, inviting the listener into a reflective soundscape. The transition to Dm7, a warm and somewhat plaintive chord, feels like a natural conversation between kindred spirits. This movement suggests a subtle shift in emotional perspective, introducing the listener to the duality of longing and resolution that defines the blues idiom. The interplay between these two chords creates a harmonic relationship that is both smooth and impactful. The i-iv undertone of this progression resonates with jazz tradition, offering a sense of forward motion while staying rooted in emotional depth.

Introducing Nuance: Am6 and Fmaj7

The shift to Am6 adds a touch of sophistication to the progression. The addition of the sixth interval subtly brightens the minor tonality, hinting at optimism amidst the introspection. This chord, often used in both jazz and blues, invites melodic exploration, especially on guitar. The interplay between the sixth and seventh degrees creates opportunities for melodic embellishments that can be delicately expressive or strikingly bold.

The movement to Fmaj7 is an inspired choice, injecting a dreamy, ethereal quality. This chord opens a new chapter in the narrative, providing a moment of reprieve and reflection. Its lush, open sound contrasts with the denser qualities of the minor chords, giving the listener a sense of light breaking through the clouds. This contrast invites dynamic phrasing and the possibility for soaring, lyrical improvisation.

Deepening the Texture: Am9 and A♭7♯5

Returning to Am9, the progression deepens its emotive palette. The ninth interval introduces a sophisticated tension that enriches the storytelling. This chord provides fertile ground for improvisation, especially in jazz-blues, where extended voicings are a hallmark of the genre. The Am9 bridges the introspective mood of the earlier minor chords with the bold drama that follows.

A♭7♯5 is a striking and adventurous inclusion, injecting an unexpected twist. Its altered tone brings a sense of urgency and complexity, marking a pivotal moment in the progression. This chord, with its sharp fifth, is a favorite in jazz for its tension and chromatic pull, offering a chance to infuse a dramatic, almost cinematic flair. The introduction of this altered dominant chord teases the resolution that lies ahead, setting the stage for expressive improvisational lines filled with anticipation.

The Climactic Release: Dm9 and E7♯9

As the progression returns to Dm9, the mood shifts again to one of sophistication and elegance. The addition of the ninth adds a delicate layer of harmonic richness, offering a lyrical, melodic anchor. This chord provides a sense of familiarity while maintaining the textural complexity of the overall piece.

Finally, the arrival of E7♯9, the iconic Hendrix chord, serves as the climactic moment. This altered dominant chord is the epitome of blues-infused jazz, with its sharp ninth creating an unmistakable edge. The tension it introduces is simultaneously jarring and exhilarating, demanding resolution while standing as a powerful statement in its own right. Its role as the dominant chord in the progression firmly grounds the piece in the blues tradition, signaling both an ending and an invitation to begin the cycle anew.

PRACTICE: Play each chord slowly as you read about it, and listen for the color and mood the text describes.

I Don’t Mind: Soloing Over the Chords

A scale for every chord of the song on page 120

The song is in A minor, and most of it can be played with one scale. Two chords step outside the key, and they are the moments that lift a solo above running a scale. Work through the three levels in order, and stay on each one until it feels like music.

1 Level 1: One scale

Play the A minor pentatonic or the A blues scale (pages 38 and 41) over the whole song. It always works. When A♭7♯5 arrives, hold C or E; when E7♯9 arrives, hold E, G or D. Those notes belong to both the scale and the chord.

2 Level 2: Follow the chords

Use A natural minor (the pattern on page 72) and end each phrase on a note of the chord you are over. The table shows the notes to aim for. Over Am6 raise F to F♯, and you are playing A Dorian.

3 Level 3: Change scale on the two outside chords

Over A♭7♯5 play the A♭ whole tone scale or A melodic minor. Over E7♯9 play E Phrygian dominant, the E altered scale or E half-whole diminished. The facing page shows how.

The chord map

bar numbers as on the chord page

Bars	Chord	Chord tones	Scale	Aim for
1, 3, 11	**Am7**	A C E G	A natural minor (72)	**C, E**
7	**Am9**	A C E G B	A natural minor	**B, C**
4	**Am6**	A C E F♯	A Dorian, or the Coltrane pentatonic (40)	**F♯**
2, 5	**Dm7**	D F A C	A natural minor	**F, A**
10, 13	**Dm9**	D F A C E	A natural minor	**F, E**
6, 9	**Fmaj7**	F A C E	A natural minor	**A, E**
8, 12	**A♭7♯5**	A♭ C E G♭	A♭ whole tone or A melodic minor (49)	**C, E, G♭**
14	**E7♯9**	E G♯ D G	E Phrygian dominant (48) or E altered	**G♯, then A**

Two notes that hold the song together: C is a chord tone of every chord except E7♯9, and E is a chord tone of every chord except Dm7. Build your phrases around them and let the notes in between change with the harmony.

The road map

the shaded bars are the two chords from outside the key

1 **Am7** A natural minor	2 **Dm7** A natural minor	3 **Am7** A natural minor	4 **Am6** A Dorian
5 **Dm7** A natural minor	6 **Fmaj7** A natural minor	7 **Am9** A natural minor	8 **A♭7♯5** A♭ whole tone
9 **Fmaj7** A natural minor	10 **Dm9** A natural minor	11 **Am7** A natural minor	12 **A♭7♯5** A♭ whole tone
13 **Dm9** A natural minor	14 **E7♯9** E altered		

PRACTICE: Record the chords at 60 BPM, two bars each. Play Level 1 for a week before you try Level 2, and Level 2 before Level 3.

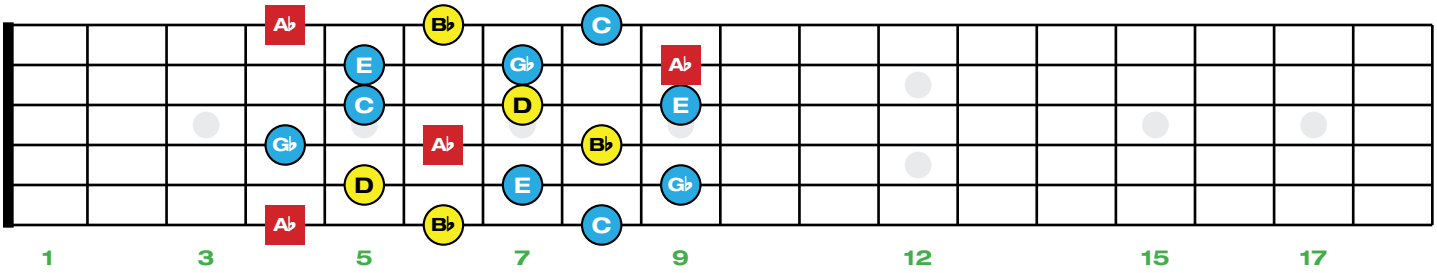
I Don't Mind: The Altered Chords

Scales and lines for A♭7♯5 and E7♯9, the two chords from outside the key

Red squares = the root of the chord • Blue numbers = fingers • Black numbers = tab

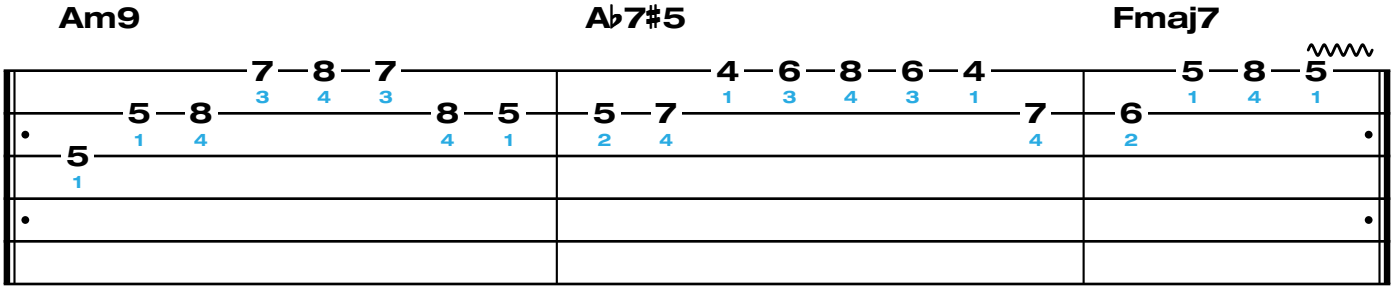
A♭7♯5: the A♭ whole tone scale

1 2 3 ♯4 ♯5 ♭7 • A♭ B♭ C D E G♭



Line 1: bars 7 to 9

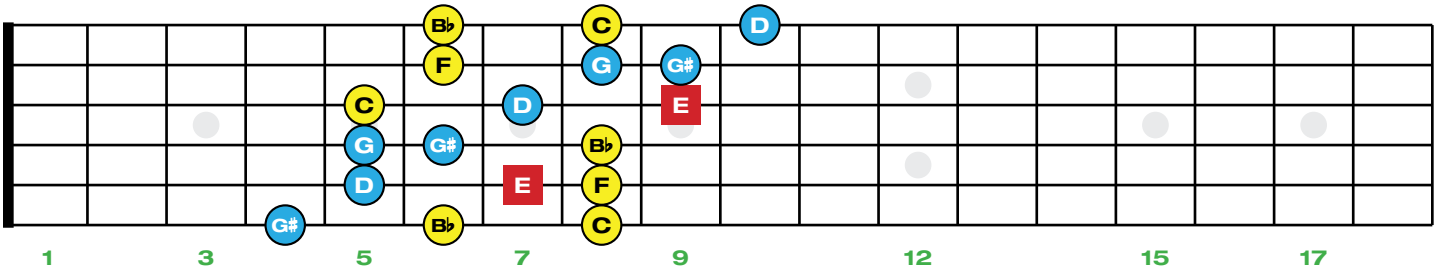
even eighth notes



The blue circles are C, E and G♭: the 3rd, ♯5 and ♭7 of the chord. C and E are also in A minor, so the scale changes around two notes that stay. The line climbs the Am9 arpeggio, runs the whole tone scale from E, and lets G♭ fall a half step to F as the chord changes.

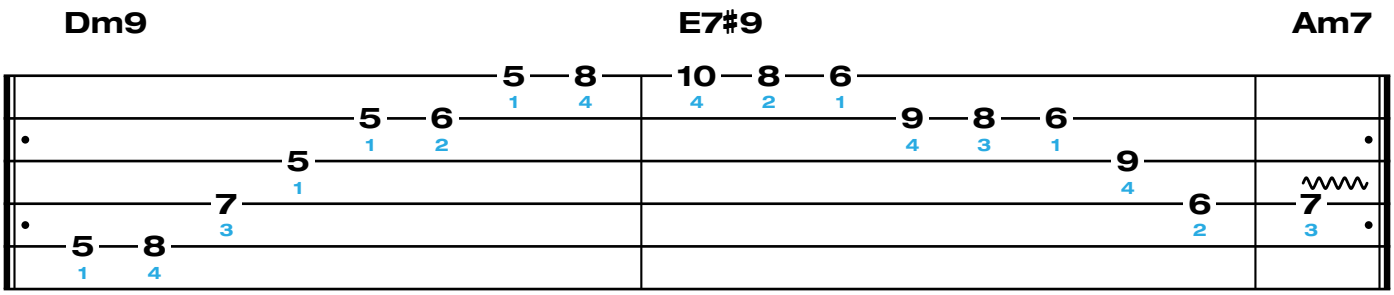
E7♯9: the E altered scale

1 ♭9 ♯9 3 ♭5 ♯5 ♭7 • E F G G♯ B♭ C D



Line 2: bars 13 and 14, back to bar 1

even eighth notes



The blue circles are G♯, D and G: the 3rd, ♭7 and ♯9 of the chord. The E altered scale has the same notes as F melodic minor (see page 50). The line ends on G♯, the note that pulls hardest back to A. For a simpler sound play E Phrygian dominant (page 48); for a sharper one, the diminished pattern on page 51, played one fret higher, is E half-whole diminished.

PRACTICE: Loop each three-bar passage on its own. Play the line as written, then make up your own line that ends on the same note.

VIDEOGRAPHY



Videography

Watch the music: every card on these pages is a live link

This book ends where it all leads: real songs, played with real musicians. Each of the videos on the following pages puts the ideas in this book to work, from the riffs and rhythm parts to the scales, arpeggios and phrasing behind every solo. In the digital edition, click or tap anywhere on a card to open the video on YouTube. Watch, listen closely, and then pick up your guitar and play along.



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Hell To Pay

2023 · Byron Nemeth Group
The Tone Factory, Las Vegas

Hell To Pay is a hard-driving rock anthem built on razor-sharp guitar work and the explosive energy of the Byron Nemeth Group. It was recorded at The Tone Factory in Las Vegas on October 23, 2023 with producer Vinnie Castaldo. Johnny Gibson recorded the audio, and Dylan Dyce mixed and produced the final track on October 30, 2023.

The video was filmed and edited by Alyssa Gibson on December 4, 2023, on location at The Jackpot bar in Las Vegas and at The Tone Factory. Released on Christmas Day 2023, Hell To Pay announced the return of the Byron Nemeth Group with full force.



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

You Know It’s True

2021 · Blackbird Studios, Nashville

Recording began on July 12, 2021 in Studio A at the legendary Blackbird Studios in Nashville, one of the premier recording facilities in the world. The song was tracked live, old-school style, with all four musicians playing at the same time: Byron on guitar, Steve Braun on lead vocals, Luis Espaillat on bass and Zach Ballard on drums. Tim Dolbear produced the session and Lowell Reynolds engineered it.

The video was directed by Mark Allee, with artwork by Timo Wuerz. Released on September 29, 2021, You Know It’s True became one of Byron’s most-watched music videos.

The Video Chronicles

A four-song studio video release (2014)

The Video Chronicles features two members of the Steve Vai Band, Jeremy Colson on drums and Philip Bynoe on bass, alongside vocalist Mark Boals, who sang on Yngwie Malmsteen's Trilogy album, with special guest pianist David Kole. Each of the four songs was recorded as both an audio track and a full studio video.



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

A New Freedom

2014 · The Video Chronicles
The Mothership, Los Angeles

A New Freedom was recorded over three days, June 10th to 12th, 2013, at "The Mothership," Steve Vai's recording studio in Los Angeles. Byron wrote the music and lyrics and Mark Boals wrote the vocal melodies, with Jeremy Colson on drums and Philip Bynoe on bass.

Greg Wurth produced, engineered and mixed the session with assistant engineers Shane Fitzgibbon and Ryan Staples, and Maor Appelbaum mastered the track. The video was filmed and edited by Echostar Cinema's Steven Esparza.



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Everybody Knows

2014 · The Video Chronicles

The second song of The Video Chronicles is a heavy, hard-driving rocker built on a syncopated, riff-driven guitar part, with Mark Boals' melodic vocals soaring over the powerhouse rhythm section of Jeremy Colson and Philip Bynoe.

Watch how the guitar and drums lock together in the verses. It is a great lesson in how a rhythm part drives a whole band.

The Video Chronicles

The band



Byron Nemeth
Guitars



Mark Boals
Vocals



Jeremy Colson
Drums



Philip Bynoe
Bass



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Riding On The Flames

2014 · The Video Chronicles

Riding On The Flames slows the tempo and turns up the drama: a powerful, epic hard-rock song built around Mark Boals' soaring vocals, with Jeremy Colson and Philip Bynoe laying down a heavy, patient groove underneath.

The track was remastered in 2024, giving one of the standout songs of The Video Chronicles a fresh, modern sound.



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Fight

2014 · The Video Chronicles

Fight is the closing song of The Video Chronicles, bringing the release to a hard-hitting finish with the full band of Mark Boals, Jeremy Colson and Philip Bynoe firing on all cylinders.

The songs of The Video Chronicles were later revisited on The Video Chronicles Reimagined in 2018.

Videography

Instrumentals and classics



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Engines Of Thunder

2021 · Instrumental

Engines Of Thunder is a pure instrumental that pays homage to the early Joe Satriani and Jimi Hendrix sound, where strong composition and lyrical soloing let the guitar speak without words. Byron composed and performed every element of the track.

The performance video was filmed in Phoenix on November 16, 2020, capturing the raw energy and technical precision of Byron's playing. Watch it alongside the instrumental lessons in this book: every phrase is built from the scales and arpeggios you have been practicing.



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

I Am The Walrus

Byron Nemeth Group · The Force Within

Byron's love of music began at the age of five, when he first heard The Beatles. His instrumental take on the Lennon–McCartney classic closes The Force Within, an album mastered at Abbey Road Studios in London by Nick Webb on December 11, 2006, the very studio where The Beatles recorded the original.

The video was released to celebrate the re-release of The Force within, and was filmed at 98 KUPD, Arizona's Real Rock station, in Scottsdale.

Cinematic Works

Music for the screen

These last two videos are Byron's foray into film soundtrack work. Season's Of May — Symphonic Reimagined and Digital God were each conceived as a short film rather than just a song, and together they launch his move into film composition and cinematic music production. More releases are planned as mini-movies, some animated and some with Byron on screen.



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Season's Of May
Symphonic Reimagined

2026 · Official cinematic animated music video

Season's Of May began as a composition Byron wrote in the 1990s. In 2026 he rebuilt it as a sweeping symphonic piece, designed as a miniature motion picture rather than just a song.

Byron recorded and mixed the track in Avid Pro Tools, playing his Charvel Jake E. Lee guitar through the Fractal AM4 and VP4. The orchestral arrangements were developed with SUNO and the animated film was created with Freebeat. It was released on May 24, 2026.

IN THE PRESS · Hollywood Press Corps

Byron Nemeth Announces Season's Of May — Symphonic Reimagined

READ THE ARTICLE →



▶ WATCH ON YOUTUBE

Digital God

2026 · A three-act cinematic rock film

Digital God is an original three-act cinematic rock film: an instrumental in which progressive guitar meets a dark, high-concept visual narrative told in three movements.

Released in July 2026, it follows Season's Of May and takes Byron's film soundtrack work a step further: three acts, no vocals, and a story told by guitar and picture together.

IN THE PRESS · Hollywood Press Corps

When Music Directs the Lens: Byron Nemeth Unveils Instrumental DIGITAL GOD

READ THE ARTICLE →

About the Author



Byron Nemeth

GUITARIST · AUTHOR · AI ENTREPRENEUR

Byron Nemeth is a guitarist, composer, author and educator based in Las Vegas, Nevada. A multi-instrumentalist who knew at a young age that music was his true calling, he turned to the guitar after hearing Elvis and The Beatles, and was inspired by Randy Rhoads, Michael Schenker, Jimmy Page, Joe Satriani and Steve Vai, as well as jazz and classical music.

Byron studied jazz and classical music at Cleveland State University and performed as first guitar in Ozone Hour, a 90-minute symphonic rock ballet with the Cleveland Chamber Orchestra. He has opened for Dream Theater, Yes, Zakk Wylde's Black Label Society, RATT, Winger and many others, and has toured as lead guitarist with Kill Ritual and Images of Eden. Since his debut album, 2000, he has released 100 Worlds and The Force Within, both mastered at Abbey Road Studios in London, and The Video Chronicles, recorded with members of the Steve Vai Band. He leads the Byron Nemeth Group, which performed at the 2026 NAMM Show in Anaheim.

In 2023 he launched The Guitar Academy, his private lessons platform, and in 2025 he published Volume Three of The Zen of Guitar; this book is Volume Four. In 2026 Byron moved into film composition with Season's Of May — Symphonic Reimagined and Digital God. Alongside his music, he is an entrepreneur in AI technology.

Thank you for playing along. Keep listening, keep exploring, and let the guitar take you somewhere new.

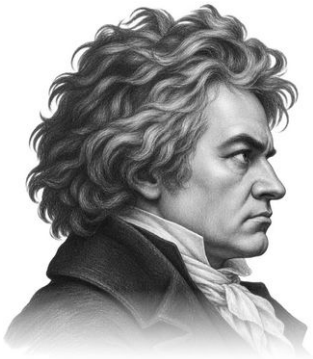
BYRONNEMETH.COM · READ THE HOLLYWOOD PRESS CORPS INTERVIEW


Anaheim, CA • House of Blues



"IT IS A MISTAKE TO THINK THAT THE PRACTICE OF MY ART HAS BECOME EASY TO ME. I ASSURE YOU, DEAR FRIEND, NO ONE HAS GIVEN SO MUCH CARE TO THE STUDY OF COMPOSITION AS I."

— WOLFGANG AMADEUS MOZART



"MUSIC IS A HIGHER REVELATION THAN ALL WISDOM AND PHILOSOPHY."

— LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN



"DO NOT FEAR MISTAKES. THERE ARE NONE."

— MILES DAVIS



"I DON'T SEE MUSIC AS DOTS ON A PAGE."

— PAUL MCCARTNEY · THE BEATLES

THE ZEN OF GUITAR

UNDERSTANDING GUITAR THRU DIRECT INTUITION

VOLUME FOUR



ART DIRECTION & BOOK DESIGN
DIGITAL GOD DESIGNS • BEVERLY HILLS

LOGO DESIGN
TIMO WUERZ • GERMANY

PHOTOGRAPHY
DAVID MECEY • LAS VEGAS | NASHVILLE
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THE ZEN OF GUITAR

UNDERSTANDING GUITAR THRU DIRECT INTUITION

VOLUME FOUR

Unlock the fretboard. Trust your ear. Play with intuition.

In Volume Four of The Zen of Guitar, Byron Nemeth takes you deeper into the language of the guitar with a visual system you can see, hear and feel. Every idea is mapped across the fretboard in clear, color-coded diagrams, so your hands learn what your ears already know.

Whether you are just finding your way around the neck or you are a seasoned player looking for fresh inspiration, this book will change the way you see and hear the guitar.

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- Modal Pentatonics for all seven modes
- Blues connection sequences across the neck
- 7th chord tapping arpeggios
- The Magic Chord Accompaniment Guide
- Color Association & the Lydian Chromatic Concept
- Fretboard notes, chords, scales & notation

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

BYRON NEMETH

Byron Nemeth is an instrumental rock guitarist, recording artist and guitar educator based in Las Vegas. Through his teaching practice and The Zen of Guitar series, he helps players of every level build a natural, intuitive and expressive relationship with music.

BYRONNEMETH.COM

GUITAR INSTRUCTION · MUSIC THEORY